The Queen's Gambit Accepted

Chess Theory and Practice Series

3



Konstantin Sakaev
Semko Semkov


Chess Stars
Openings

Current Theory and Practice Series

The Queen's Gambit Accepted (Third Revised Edition – 2008)

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The Queen's Gambit Accepted
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4

Third Revised Edition

Konstantin Sakaev
Semko Semkov

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Preface

I often see in chess forums people asking: "What is the current status of that line?" It is a good and reasonable question, but who could claim that he knows the answer?!

The contemporary information flood replaced the previous "bibles" like The Encyclopedia of Chess Openings written by famous top players, with huge megabases, compiled without much filtering. If you try to learn a new opening or reassess your old knowledge with the help of some specialised book, you'll quickly discover that it would be a mission impossible. Most opening studies nowadays just reproduce some excerpts from databases, quoting piles of games, but wisely omitting straight recommendations. Naturally, it is much easier to hide in the shadow of someone else's authority, but such an approach is of little use to the unfortunate reader, since it says what has been played, but not what should be. The other ("starting out") approach is equally unproductive – the author chooses a couple of games of renowned experts, pretending that there are no other branches or new ideas around. When the reader starts playing the system, he suddenly discovers the existence of a whole universe of other lines and it turns out that the book answers no crucial questions at all.

Accordingly, I decided to produce a book with one main objective in mind – to give as much answers as possible, reassessing the outdated evaluations. The concept is simple – to digest all available material on the Queen's Gambit Accepted, to separate it into branches, and offer a move-by-move presentation of the main ideas according to the latest tournament trends. The great experience of GM Konstantin Sakaev – two times junior world champion and two times Olympic champion with the Russian team in 1998 and 2000, helped me a lot for the first editions in 2003 and 2005. The third edition, however, has been prepared entirely by me, so you'll often meet the usage of "I" instead of "us", or the note (S.S.). I went through all the pages and replaced everything I felt obsolete. At the same time I left the structure of the book intact, in order to help readers of the old editions to quickly compare information and see what is new.

If you expect to learn how to win against the QGA, I should disappoint you right away. Black is holding firmly against all attempts and I cannot single out any system as most promising for White. Your weapon of choice will have to be selected among a wide range of systems of equal merit, depending mostly on your style of playing chess. I hope that the present book will become your secret trump in the battles.

Semko Semkov, January 2008

Pros:
The Queen's Gambit Accepted is a solid, positionally sound opening. That makes it good for a long-term repertoire. It is also suitable for beginners, for it leads to open piece play and helps improving calculation. Endgames with symmetrical pawn structure are also frequently seen. They are perfect for polishing one's technique.

The QGA involves little learning overhead. Its concepts are clear and logical. There are only a few forced variations which must be memorised, and the evaluations do not vary much as the arising positions are strategically balanced.

Black's play is easy. His pieces have good, natural places, with sufficient manoeuvering space.

Cons:
In symmetrical pawn structures White has some initiative. Practice has shown that it is usually not dangerous, but Black must defend patiently. Jerky moves or counter-attacking attempts could only aggravate his problems.

In some variations, especially with early dxc5, it is difficult to beat even a weaker opponent. (although it is amazing to watch how easily White loses this endgame sometimes, without making any particular blunders) For cases when you must win at all cost, I propose the system with ♗g4 (Chapter 26), especially the line D1. Recent practice often sees White struggling there right from the opening. White often neglects that system and can pay for that.

Tricky Move Orders
White often chooses 3.e3 to sidestep the ♗g4 system as 3...♘f6 4.♗c4 ♗g4? does not work due to 5.♕b3. Such an approach seems strange to me as Black could answer 3...e5 with fair chances to equalise.

Black typically employs particular move orders to avoid the gambit 3...♘f6 4.♘c3. (although Black is in fine theoretical shape there) For instance:

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 e6, when 4.e3 c5 5.♗c4 a6. The flip side is that you have to study the Vienna variation which arises after 4.♘c3 ♘f6 5.e4 ♗b4 6.♗g5.

Perhaps 3...a6 is a better idea, as 4.e4 b5 looks good for Black lately.

You can also transpose to the QGA from the Reti or Meran:

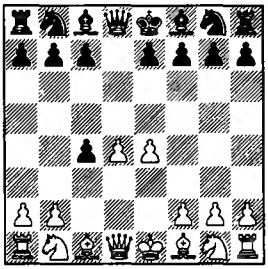
1.♘f3 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3 ♘f6 4.♗c4 e6 5.0–0 c5 6.d4 or:

1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.c4 c6 3.d4 d5 4.e3 e6 5.♗d3 dc4 6.♗c4 c5.

Topical lines
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4, when Rublevsky plays for equalisation with 5...♗b4, while 5...♘c6 6.0–0 ♗e6 is considered more challenging, though risky.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♗b3, when 7...b5 is most interesting and fashionable.

Part 1 — 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4



(D20)

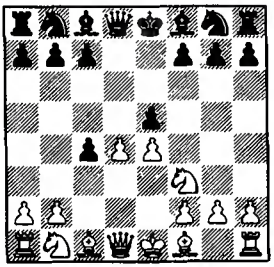
Any chess player who wants to master the Queen's Gambit Accepted (QGA) must start his preparation with the 3.e4 system. It is hardly better than the classical 3.♘f3, but it is certainly the most straightforward and challenging answer. The open character of play imposes on opponents heavy responsibilities and increases the cost of every move. There are not so many subtleties in move orders, like in the other QGA lines. White's strategy is clear and consistent. Arising positions are easy to evaluate and comply with the common sense in chess.

Black has tried four main systems against 3.e4: 3...c5, 3...e5, 3...♘c6 and 3...♘f6. The first two are based on a pawn counter-attack against the opponent's centre. Only 3...e5 is positionally correct though, and ensures Black normal play. It has always been the most popular choice. Its only downside from Black's point of view is that White can easily lead the game to a meagre ending, but, then, the old saying ascertains that the simplest way to beat a patzer is to swap queens...

Nowadays Black has invested some effort in 3...♘f6 and 3...♘c6. Only recently the latter move has been rehabilitated with several amazing Black ideas. They practically limited the scope of research to 3.e4 ♘c6 4.♘f3 ♗g4 5.d5.

3...♘f6 leads to very complex positions with lasting space advantage of White. Currently second players seem to be in control, but in our opinion life is easier with a strong pawn centre. At least, mistakes are seldom fatal which cannot be said for the cramped side.

The 3.e4-system is mostly played at higher level, because it is more demanding. Internet fans usually prefer to regain quickly the gambit pawn by 3.♘f3, 4.e3, 5.♗c4. We can only advise them to spend a few days with Part One of this book. They will discover that it could be refreshing to forget about systems like 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 ♗g4, or 3.♘f3 a6 or 3.♘f3 c5, not to mention about the IQP positions which could be much more insidious than they look on the surface.



(D20)

Sometimes White tries also:

4.♗c4 ♕d4 (4...ed4) 5.♕b3 ♕e4 6.♗e3, when 6...♕g6 proved to be good: 7.♘f3 ♗d6 8.♘c3 ♘f6 9.0–0–0 0–0∓.

After 4.♘f3, Black's options are:

A. 4...♗b4

B. 4...ed4

4...♘f6 5.♘e5! ♘e4 6.♗c4 ♘d6 7.♗b3 ♗e7 8.♘c3± is seldom seen.

A. 4...♗b4

Black will take on d4 anyway, but he wants to exploit the still living c4-pawn. For instance, 5.♘bd2 will be met by 5...c3.

White has three major responses:

A1. 5.♘bd2

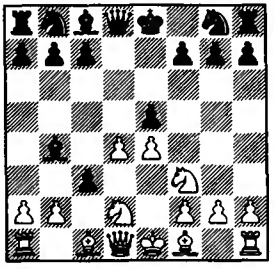
A2. 5.♗d2

A3. 5.♘c3

The first one is reported to be outright bad though practical evidence is not too convincing. The second option leads directly to an equal ending. Here again we often meet with some discrepancies between assessments and practical results. The last one allows White to keep the queens on, and is the main choice recently.

A1. 5.♘bd2 faces the opponent with some practical problems.

5...c3



6.bc3

6.♕a4?! should probably be buried for good: 6...♘c6 7.d5 cd2 8.♘d2 ♘ge7! 9.dc6 ♘c6 10.♗b5 ♗d7 11.♗c6 (11.0–0 does not help much: 11...♗d2 12.♗d2 ♘d4 13.♗d7 ♕d7 14.♕a5 0–0 15.♗e3 ♕e7∓) 11...♗d2 12.♗d2 ♗c6 13.♕a3 ♗e4 14.♖d1 ♕d3 15.♗c3 ♕b5 16.f3 ♗d5 17.♗e5 Lautier – Dlugy, Palma de Mallorca 1989, when 17...0–0–0∓ (instead of 17...♗f3?? 18.gf3+–) would have been in Black's favour.

6...♗c3 7.♖b1 ed4

7...♗d4 is also hazy – 8.♗c4 ♘f6

(The game Velimirovic – Susic, Titograd 1965 saw 8...♘d7 9.♘d4 ed4 10.♘f3 c5 11.0–0 ♘h6 12.♗g5 ♕c7 13.♕c1+–) 9.♗a3∞.

8.♗c4 ♘h6!?

This novelty has been introduced in the game Shabalov – Granda Zuniga, Willemstad 2003. The old move 8...♘c6 may also be good enough: 9.0-0 ♕f6 10.♖b5?! ♘ge7, Ushenina – Zsuzsa Polgar, Dresden 2006.

9.0-0 0-0 10.e5 (10.♘b3 ♘c6 11.♗h6 gh6∓) **10...♗f5 11.♖b7∞** Things are unclear, but Black seems to be OK.

A2. 5.♗d2 ♗d2 6.♕d2

6.♘d2!? ed4 transposes to Chapter 2.

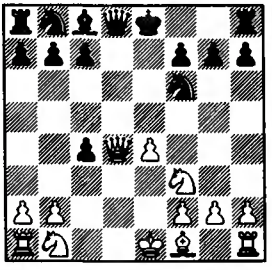
6...ed4

Main options are:

A2a. 7.♕d4 and A2b. 7.♘d4.

A2a. 7.♕d4 ♘f6!

Black is against any concessions! 7...♕d4 8.♘d4 ♗d7 9.♗c4 ♘c6 10.♘c6 ♗c6 11.♘c3 ♖d8 12.♔e2 ♘f6 13.f3 ♔e7 14.♖hd1±, Karpov – Seirawan, Skelleftea 1989 gave White some space advantage.



8.♕d8 ♔d8 9.♘c3 ♗e6 10.♘e5

To similar structures leads 10.♘d4 ♘c6 (10...♖e8? 11.0–0–0 ♘bd7 12.♘e6 ♖e6 13.♗c4 ♖e7 14.f4 ♘e4 15.♘e4 ♖e4 16.♗f7± Andersson – Nikolic, Tilburg 1990. 10...♘bd7!? intending to cover the d5-square by c6, is a good alternative e.g. 11.♘e6 fe6 12.♗c4 e5 13.f3 c6 14.♔f2 ♔c7 15.♖hd1 ♖hd8 16.♔e3 b5= Miles – Rachels,USA 1989) 11.♘e6 fe6 12.♗c4 ♔e7 13.♖d1 ♖ad8 14.f3 ♖d1 15.♔d1 e5 16.♔d2 ♖d8 17.♔e3 ♘d4= Browne – Seirawan, Jacksonville 1990.

10...♘c6

Black manoeuvres his knight straight to d4.

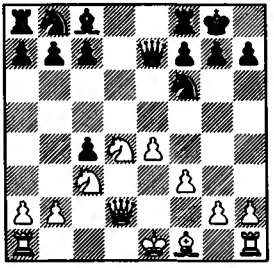
11.♘c4 (11.♘c6 bc6=) **11...♔e7 12.♘e3 ♖hd8 13.f4 ♔f8! 14.♗e2 ♘d4=** V. Salov – P. Nikolic, Reykjavik 1991.

Salov assumes that instead of 15.f5? ♗d7 16.♗f3 c5!∓, **15.♔f2** ♘e2 16.♔e2 ♖d4 17.e5= would have maintained equality.

A2b. 7.♘d4 ♘f6 8.♘c3 ♕e7

8...♗d7 9.♗c4 ♘c6 looks too passive.

9.f3



9...0–0

White dominates in the centre. Apart from entrenching himself and waiting, Black can look for counterplay on the queenside by c5. In such case the d5-square would be of primary concern. With that in mind, 9...♗e6 looks out of context, e.g. 10.♘e6 ♕e6 11.♕d4 ♘c6 12.♕c4±.

10.♗c4 ♘bd7

The straightforward alternative 10...c5 does not bring Black full equality:

11.♘de2 ♖d8 12.♕e3 ♗e6 13.♗e6 fe6 14.0–0 ♘c6 15.♖ad1 b6 16.e5 ♘d5 17.♕e4 ♕f7 18.f4 ♘c3 19.bc3 (19.♘c3 ♘d4⇄) 19...♘e7 20.♘g3±. The d6 square is excellent for White's rook and Black can not cover it. The swap of knights failed to bring relief either – 20...♘f5 21.♘f5 ef5 22.♕e2 h6 23.♖d2 ♖d2 24.♕d2 ♖e8 25.h3 ♕c4 26.♖f3! ♖e7 27.♖d3 ♔h7 28.♖d6 b5? (28...♕e4±) 29.♖c6!+–, Andersson – Seirawan, Tilburg 1990.

11.0–0

Or 11.♘f5 ♕c5 12.♕g5? g6∓.

11...♖d8

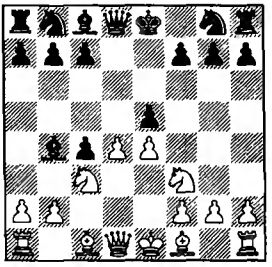
11...♕c5 12.♗e2 ♖d8 13.♕e3 ♘e5 14.♖ad1±.

12.♗e2!

Intending to meet 12...♘e5 with 13.♕e3± and 12...♘b6 with 13.♖ad1. In the latter line 13...♗d7 completes development, minimising White's advantage.

Less accurate is 12.♕e3?! ♘b6! 13.♗b3 (13.♗e2 ♘fd5) 13...c5! 14.♘de2 c4 15.♗c2 ♘bd5 16.♕f2 ♘b4 17.♘g3 b5!∓ Groszpeter – Zsuzsa Polgar, HUN-ch 1991.

A3. 5.♘c3



5...ed4

The experiment of Ivanchuk 5...♘f6 6.♘e5 (6.♕a4 ♘c6 7.d5 ♘e4 8.dc6 ♘c3 9.bc3 ♗c3 10.♗d2 b5 11.♕d1 ♗a1 12.♕a1 f6 13.a4 ♕d5∓) 6...b5 failed to attract adherents, probably in view of 7.f3.

Bareev chose against Ivanchuk 7.♗e2 when 7...♘e4 (instead of 7...♗b7?! 8.0–0±) would have led to a complicated game after 8.0–0 ♗c3 9.♗f3 ♕d4 10.♕d4 ♗d4 11.♗e4 ♗e5 12.♗a8 ♗e6∞.

7...c5 8.dc5 ♕d1 9.♔d1 a6 10.a4±

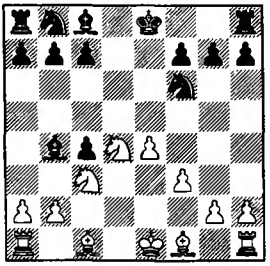
Let's return to the position after 5...ed4. White is at crossroads. He can opt to trade queens with A3a. 6.♕d4, assuming that Black would have nothing better than make a second step with an already developed piece, e.g. ♗b4-c5. However, in the long run this tempo loss proves to be rather insignificant.

The acid test for the whole line with 4...♗b4 is A3b. 6.♘d4!.

A3a. 6.♕d4 ♕d4 7.♘d4 ♘f6

Excessively passive is 7...♗d7 8.♗c4 ♘c6 9.♘db5 0–0–0 10.a3 ♗a5 11.b4 ♗b6 12.♘d5± Dzindzichasvilli – Bagirov, URSS, 1966.

8.f3



a) 8...♗d7?! 9.♗c4 ♘c6 10.♘c6 ♗c6 Black has accepted a cramped position, relying on the fact that he has no weaknesses. In modern times such an approach does not bring success. White's plan is to find a good place for his bishop (on e3 or f4), the king goes to f2 to protect the f3-pawn, and both g and h-pawns move as far as possible. It is also good to trade off a pair of rooks.

11.♗e3

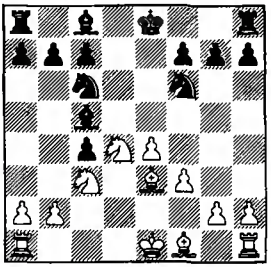
Or 11.♗f4 ♘d7 12.♖c1 f6 13.a3 ♗c3 14.♖c3 ♘e5 15.♗e2 0–0–0 16.b4 ♗a4 17.♔f2 ♖he8 18.♖hc1 ♖e7 19.h4 ♔b8 20.b5± Bagirov – Barua, Frunze 1983;

11...♗c3 12.bc3 ♘d7 13.♔f2 a6 14.♖ad1 f6 15.♖d4 ♘e5 16.♗b3 ♗d7 17.♖hd1 0–0–0 18.g4 h6 19.♔g3 ♖he8 20.h4± Brenninkmeijer-Arlandi, Lugano 1989;

b) 8...♗c5 9.♗e3

9.♘db5 would have left White a pawn down without clear compensation: 9...♘a6 10.♗f4 c6! (10...♗e6 11.♗c7 0–0 12.♗d6 ♖fc8 13.0–0–0 ♘e8 14.♗g3 ♘b4 15.♘d4 ♘d3 16.♗d3 ♗d4 17.♗e2 ♗c5∞ Begovac – Rueetschi, 1993) 11.♘d6 ♗d6 12.♗d6 ♗e6 13.e5 ♘d7 14.0–0–0 ♘ac5 15.♗e2 0–0–0∓.

9...♘c6



10.♘c2

10.♘cb5 ♘d4 11.♗d4 ♗d4 12.♘d4 ♗e6 13.♘e6 fe6 14.♗c4 ♔e7 15.♔f2 ♖ad8 16.♖hd1 g5 17.♔e3= Lobron – Dlugy, New York 1992, when the obvious manoeuvre ♘f6-d7-e5 would have balanced the game;

10.♖d1 ♗d4 11.♗d4 ♗e6 12.♗f6 gf6 13.f4 ♖d8! (13...f5 14.ef5 ♗f5 15.♗c4∞ Karpov – Dlugy, Mexico) 14.♖d8 ♔d8 15.f5 ♗d7 16.♗c4 ♘e5 17.♗e2 c5! (17...c6? 18.♔f2±) 18.♔f2 ♗c6 19.♖d1 Svensson – L. Santos, corr Wch–13 1992. Here 19...♔e7∓! would have led to Black's edge.

10...♗e3 11.♘e3 ♗e6 12.0-0-0!?

After 12.♗c4 ♗c4 13.♘c4 0–0–0= Black solves his last problem – where to hide his king.

12...0–0

Perhaps simplest for Black is to castle long: 12...♘d7 13.♘cd5 0–0–0 14.♗c4 ♖he8 15.♔b1 ♘e7=, Volkov – Rublevsky, Kazan 2005.

In case of 12...♘e5 13.♘b5 ♖c8 14.♘a7 ♖a8 15.♘b5 ♖c8 16.a3 ♔e7 17.♘d4 g5 18.h4 h6 19.♘ef5 ♗f5 20.♘f5 ♔e6 21.♔c2 ♘fd7 22.b3!∞ Black's king is vulnerable on the h3-

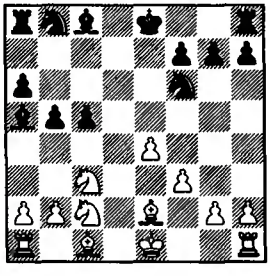
c8 diagonal, Seirawan – Ivanchuk, Monaco 1992.

13.♗c4 ♖ad8 14.♗d5 ♗d5 15.♘ed5 ♘d5 16.♘d5 ♘e5 17.♖d2 c6 18.♘e7 ♔h8 19.♘f5 ♖d2 20.♔d2 ♖d8= Alburt – Leverett, Chicago 1989.

c) 8...a6 9.♗c4 b5 10.♗e2 c5 11.♘c2

In the rapid game Karpov – Zs. Polgar, Monaco 1993, the ex-champion decided to provoke the move c5-c4 and achieved some advantage after 11.♘b3 ♗e6 12.♗e3 ♘bd7 13.♔f2 ♖c8 14.♖hd1 ♘b6 15.♖ac1 ♔e7 16.g4 h6 17.h4 ♘c4 18.♗c4 ♗c4 19.e5 ♘d7 20.♘d5 ♗d5 21.♖d5 c4 22.♘d4 g6, when 23.♖d1 ♘b6 24.♘f5 gf5 25.♗b6 fg4 26.fg4± would have emphasized White's initiative.

11...♗a5



12.0–0

An important moment. White should castle only if he is planning to push e5 on the next move. Otherwise the best place for the king is on f2, e.g. 12.♔f2 ♗e6 13.♗e3 ♘bd7 14.♖hd1 0–0 15.g4±!? Azmaiparashvili – Lerner, URSS 1981. Another possible way to prepare e5 is 12.♗d2 ♗e6 13.e5±! Rashkovski – Lerner, Lvov, 1981.

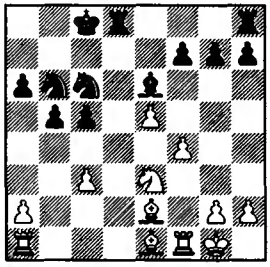
12...♗e6 13.e5!

Or 13.♗e3 ♘bd7 14.g4 h6 15.h4 ♗c7 16.♔g2 (It is becoming clear that White's set-up was not designed for pawn marches on the kingside. Still 16.g5 hg5 17.hg5 ♘h5 18.f4 ♘g3 19.♖f2 ♘e2 20.♖e2 was to be preferred) 16...g5! 17.♖h1 ♖g8 18.hg5 hg5 19.♘e1 ♗e5=, Semkov – Donchev, BUL-ch 1983.

13...♗c3

Or 13...♘fd7 14.f4 ♘c6 15.♗f3 ♖c8 16.♘e4 0–0 17.♘d6±, Skembris – Grivas, 1983.

14.bc3 ♘d5 15.♗d2 ♘b6 16.♘e3 ♘c6 17.f4 0–0–0 18.♗e1± Skembris – Bourios, 1984.



White's pieces look randomly piled along the e-file, but their potential should not be underestimated. Here are some variations: **18...h6** (18...g5 could be met by 19.fg5 ♘e5 20.a4!? ♘a4 21.c4 ♘d3 22.♗a5! ♖d4 23.♖a3 ♘f4 24.♖f4 ♖f4 25.cb5 ♔b8 26.g3 ♖e4 27.ba6; or 18...♖he8 19.♗h4 ♖d2 20.♗f3 ♔c7 21.♖fd1 ♖d1 22.♖d1 ♗a2 23.♖a1 ♗e6 24.♖a6 b4 25.cb4 cb4 26.♗f2 b3 27.♘d1 ♖b8 28.♗c5±). **19.f5** ♗c4 20.♘c4 ♘c4 21.e6 fe6 22.fe6±, intending to undermine Black's pawn fortress on the queenside with a4.

A3b. 6.♘d4!

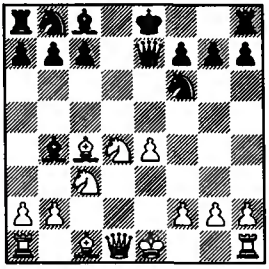
In this line White maintains a small edge. In most endgames his pieces are more active, but Black should be able to hold with precise defence.

6...♘e7

6...♕e7 is considered to be extremely risky. (if not just bad) We would say it is White who should look for improvements here as practice does not prove his edge:

7.♗c4 ♘f6

7...♕e4? goes too far: 8.♔f1! (8.♗e3 is unnecessarily timid, e.g. 8...♗c3 9.bc3 ♘f6!?±) 8...♗c3 9.bc3 ♗e6 10.♕a4! (10.♗e2 ♕d5! 11.♗f3 ♕c4 12.♔g1 ♘c6 13.♘c6 bc6∓, Van Wely – P. Nikolic, Wijk aan Zee 1994) 10...♘d7 (10...♘c6 is also met with 11.♗g5±) 11.♗g5! (11.♘e6⩲ fe6 12.♗d2 0-0-0∞) 11...♗c4 12.♕c4 ♘b6 13.♕c7 ♖c8 14.♕g3 ♕d5 15.♖e1 ♔f8 16.♘f5 g6 17.♘d6 ♖c6 18.♕h4!±.



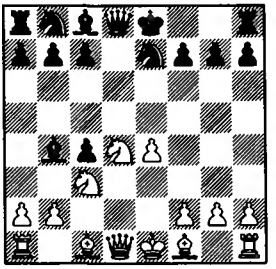
The pressure on the e4-pawn is only a "side-effect" of the queen's move to e7. More important are the threats of ...♖d8, (after castling) or the triple(!) attack ...♕c5 in case of ♗g5. White can follow the game Hertneck – Westerinen, Manila (ol) 1992:

8.0–0 0–0 9.♗g5 ♗c3 10.bc3 (10.♗f6 ♕f6 11.bc3 ♘c6 12.f4 ♖d8 13.e5 ♕e7 14.♘c6 ♕c5 15.♘d4 ♕c4 16.♕b3, Tyomkin-Krush, Montreal 2005, 16...♕d5! 17.♖fe1 b6=.)

10...♕c5 11.♗f6 ♕c4= 12.♕h5 An ambitious, but not very reasonable move. 12.♗g5 would have maintained the balance. 12...gf6 13.♕h6 ♕a6!∓ Intending f6-f5. Westerinen went astray with 13...♘c6 14.♖ae1 ♘d4 15.cd4 ♗g4 16.♖e3 ♖fe8 17.h3 ♖ad8 18.hg4 ♖d4 19.g5 fg5 20.♕g5 ♔f8 21.♕h6 ♔e7 22.♖b3⩱.

Perhaps in the position on the last diagram White can achieve some tiny advantage after taking a few urgent consolidating measures like 8.f3!?, followed by 9.♕b3 or ♗e3. Anyway, it has not been tested yet.

Now let's come back to the most popular move – **6...♘e7.**



7.♗c4

7.♗f4!? is a very interesting alternative. The source game Epishin – Godena, Reggio Emilia 1996 saw further 7...♘g6 8.♗g3 ♕e7 9.♗c4 ♕e4 10.♔f1 ♗c3 11.bc3 0–0 12.♕e1!! ♕e1 13.♖e1 ♗d7 14.h4⩱. Godena quickly lost following 14...♘c6 15.♘c6 ♗c6 16.h5 ♘h8 17.♖h4±. Epishin sug-

gests 14...♖e8! 15.♖e8 ♗e8 16.h5 ♘e7 17.♗c7 ♘bc6 18.♘c6 ♗c6 19.♖h4 ♗d5!=.

In Bareev – Rublevsky, Khanty Mansyisk 2005 White attempted 11.♕e2!? ♕e2 12.♗e2 0–0 13.♗c7 ♗d7, when 14.♖b1!? would have given White a slight initiative, for instance, 14...♘c6 15.0–0 ♘d4 16.cd4 ♗c6 17.♗b5 ♖ac8 18.♗c6 bc6 19.♖b7 ♖fe8 20.♖fb1 (Huzman). As a whole, White has some initiative in that line, but gradually Black should neutralise it.

7...♘bc6

The best move order if Black wants to prevent White's bishop from reaching f4, which would have been possible after 7...0–0?! 8.♗f4.

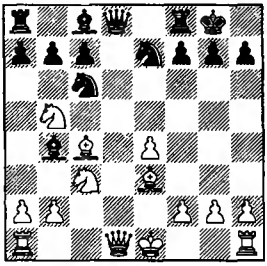
8.♗e3

White cannot avoid the exchange of a knight pair by 8.♘db5 since 8...♕d1 9.♔d1 ♗g4! 10.f3 (10.♔c2 ♗a5) 10...0–0–0 11.♔e2 ♗e6 12.♗e6 fe6 13.♗e3 a6 leads to an equal ending, Alburt – Rachels, USA-ch 1989.

a) 8...0–0 This move adds to White's list two more pleasant options besides 9.0–0, which would transpose to positions from b). At the same time Black avoids 8...♘d4 9.♗d4 0–0 10.a3 when 10...♗c3 11.♗c3 keeps White's pawns on the queenside connected.

9.♘db5!?

9.a3 ♗c3 10.bc3 ♘a5 11.♗e2 is also pleasant for White due to his bishop pair. The text is however more consistent, since White attacks the c7-pawn. Black can defend it by 9...♗d7?!, 9...♗a5 or even ignore the threat – 9...♗e6!?



9...♗a5

9...♗d7?! allows White to seize the initiative with 10.a3 ♗a5 11.b4 ♗b6 12.♗b6 ab6 13.f4!, Bacrot – Lautier, Val d'Isere 1992.

Very interesting is the pawn sac 9...♗e6 10.♗e6 fe6 11.♕d8 ♖ad8 12.♘c7 ♔f7! This quiet move unveils Black's idea – to entrap the wandering white knight. 13.♘7b5 a6 14.a3 (The source-game saw 14.♘a3? b5 15.♘c2 ♗c3 16.bc3 ♖d3 17.♗d2 ♖fd8 18.0–0–0 ♖c8∓, Azmaiparashvili – Nogueiras, Yerevan ol 1996) 14...♗a5 15.b4 ♘b4 16.ab4 ♗b4 17.♔e2 ab5 18.♘b5 ♘c6 with a drawish endgame. Perhaps White should decline the gift with 11.♕b3.

10.♕h5

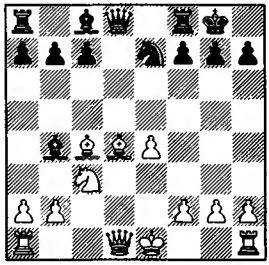
10.0–0 a6 11.♘d4 ♘d4 12.♗d4 ♕d6 13.♗e3 ♗e6 is fairly equal.

10...♗e6 11.♗e6 fe6 12.♖d1 ♕e8 13.♕e8 ♖ae8 14.♔e2 ♘e5 15.♘a4±, Bologan – Rublevsky, Tomsk 2006.

b) 8...♘d4 9.♗d4

9.♕d4 ♕d4 10.♗d4 0–0 11.a3 gave White an edge in Topalov – Kharlov, Tripoli 2004. However, White can try to get a better version of that endgame.

9...0–0



10.a3!

White takes control of c5 in order to meet ...♘c6 with ♗c5. 10.0–0 ♘c6 11.♗e3 is about equal after 11...♕d1 (Or 11...♗c3 12.bc3 ♕e7 13.♕a4 ♘e5 14.♗e2 b6 15.♖fd1 ♗d7 16.♕c2 ♖ad8 17.a4 ♗e6 18.c4 ♘g4=, Van Wely – Huebner, Wijk aan Zee 1996) 12.♖fd1 ♗c3 13.bc3 ♗e6 14.♗e2 (or 14.♗e6 fe6 15.♖d7 ♖f7 16.♖ad1 ♖af8=) 14...♖fd8 15.c4 ♘e5 16.♖dc1 b6, with a comfortable endgame, Van Wely – Azmaiparashvili, EU-ch Ohrid, 2001.

10...♗a5 11.0–0

White had an edge in Van Wely – Romanishin, Moscow 2004:

11...♗b6

11...♘g6 12.♗c5 ♖e8 13.♕a4 ♗h3 14.♕a5 ♕g5 15.g3 turned well for White in H. Gruenberg – Penrose, corr 1988.

12.♗b6 ab6 13.f4±.

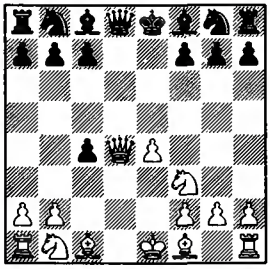
Black's queenside pawns are very weak without queens.

B. 4...ed4 5.♕d4

The other main option 5.♗c4 is the subject of Chapters 2 and 3.

We'll mention the alternative 5.♘d4 for completeness sake only:

5.♘d4 ♗c5 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♘c3 ♘g4 8.♗c4 ♘e3 9.fe3 ♕h4 10.g3 ♕g5 11.♕f3 0–0 12.0–0 Novak – M. Schmitz, Porz 1993 when 12...♘c6 would have offered Black good play.



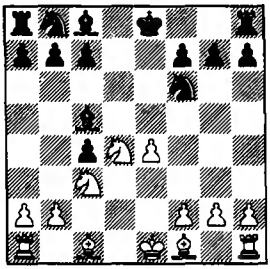
The swap of queens leads to an endgame which is supposed to be quite dull for White. In fact things are not so simple and, moreover, Black has to be familiar with it since sometimes play transposes to this line after the move order 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 e5 5.♘f3 ed4 6.♕d4.

5...♕d4 6.♘d4 ♘f6 7.♘c3

7.f3 is not topical anymore. Black takes over the initiative by 7...♗c5 8.♘b5 ♘a6 9.♗c4 (Or 9.♗f4 ♗e6 10.♘d2 0–0–0 11.♗c4 c6 12.♘c3 ♘b4 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♔e2 ♘d3∓, K. Arkell – Kumaran, Dublin 1993) 9...c6 10.♘5a3 ♘b4 11.♔e2 ♘d7 (Spectacular, but not entirely correct, is 11...b5 12.♗b3 ♘e4?! 13.fe4 ♗g4 14.♔f1 0–0–0 15.♘c3 f5 16.h3? fe4! 17.hg4 ♖hf8 18.♔e1 ♘d3∓, Lindsay – R. Livshits, North Bay 1995. Instead 16.♗e6! followed by 17.h3± would have tamed Black's outburst).

12.♗e3 b5 13.♗b3 ♗e3 14.♔e3 ♘c5 15.♘d2 ♔e7↑, Polovodin – Batsanin RUS-Cup Nizhnij Novgorod 1999.

7...♗c5



We examine here:
B1. 8.♘db5?!
B2. 8.♗e3

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4 ♘f6 7.♘c3 ♗c5)

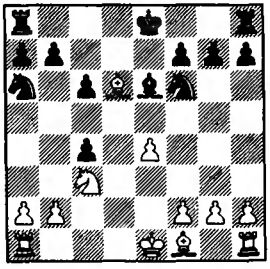
B1. 8.♘db5

Practical results are rather unfavourable to White in this line.

8...♘a6 9.♗f4 c6

Another good option for Black is 9...♗e6 10.♗c7 ♔e7 11.♗e2 ♘c7 12.♘c7 ♖ac8 13.♘e6 fe6 14.0–0 ♗d4 15.♗f3 b5 16.♖ad1 e5∓, J. Candela Perez – Damaso, Mancha Real 1999.

10.♘d6 ♗d6 11.♗d6 ♗e6



12.e5

Or Black will castle, obtaining the e8-square fot the knight to attack White's bishop: 12.b3 0–0–0 13.e5 ♘e8 14.♗a3 b5∓; 12.0–0–0 0–0–0 13.♗e2 b5 14.f3 ♘e8 15.♗e7 ♖d1 16.♖d1 ♘ec7 17.f4 ♖e8 18.♗d6 f5∓.

12...♘d7 13.f4

White is underdeveloped for a successful play on the queenside: 13.b4 f6 14.f4 fe5 15.fe5 0–0–0 16.b5 ♘ac5 17.bc6 bc6 18.0–0–0 ♘b7 19.♗e2 ♘dc5∓, Epishin –Dorfman, Belgrade 1988; 13.b3 0–0–0 14.bc4 f6 15.f4 ♖he8 16.♔f2 g5 17.g3 fe5 18.fe5 ♗f5 19.♖e1 ♖e6 20.g4 ♗g6∓, Borges Mateos – Yakovich, Santa Clara 1990.

13.♗e2 is more reasonable, when in Beliavsky – Ponomariov, Enghien les Bains 1999 Black blocked the centre with 13...f5!? thus securing a place for his king on f7. This way he could push safely his pawn majority on the queenside, 14.0–0 ♘ac5 15.♖ad1 ♔f7∓.

13...♘ac5 14.♗e2

Now, in the recent game Miladinovic – Stojanovic, Vrsac 2007, Black chose 14...b5?! 15.0–0 with compensation. Instead he should have broken through the centre with 14...f6, or 14...f5.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4 ♘f6 7.♘c3 ♗c5)

B2. 8.♗e3 ♘g4

8...c6 9.♗c4!? ♘g4 10.0–0 transposes to the main line, while 9.f3 b5 10.a4 b4 11.♘d1 c3 12.bc3 a5 13.♘c6 ♗e3 14.♘b8 ♖b8 15.♘e3 bc3 offers Black a small plus, Seirawan

– Huebner, 1993.

9.♗c4

The superficial 9.♘db5 ♘e3 10.fe3 ♘a6 11.♘d5 ♔d8 12.0–0–0 ♗d7 13.♘d4 c6 14.♘c3 ♗d4 15.ed4 b5 16.d5 cd5 17.♖d5 ♘c7 18.♖d4 ♔e7∓ led White to difficulties in the game Lahlum – Rausis, Hamburg 2002.

9...c6

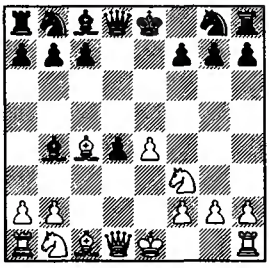
After 9...♘e3 10.fe3 ♘d7 11.♘d5 ♔d8 12.b4 ♗f8 13.b5 ♘e5 14.♗b3 c6 15.♘f4 ♗b4 16.♔f2 ♔e7 17.bc6 bc6 18.♖ac1 ♗d7 19.♖hd1 Cifuentes Parada – D. Bronstein, Oviedo 1993 White enjoyed some initiative.

10.0-0 ♘d7 11.♖ad1 ♘e3 12.fe3 ♘e5 13.♗b3 ♗g4 14.♖d2 ♖d8 15.♘a4 ♗d6 16.h3 ♗c8 17.♘f5 ♗f5 18.ef5 f6 19.♖fd1 ♔e7=, Cifuentes Parada – Magem Badals, Terrassa 1994.

Conclusion

In this chapter we devoted a considerable amount of pages to the continuation 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ♗b4. It is aimed against the popular plan of White, linked with ♘bd2-b3-d4. After the check White is practically forced to play 5.♘c3 since 5.♘d2 c3! loses a couple of pawns with unclear consequences. Then 5...ed4 6.♘d4! is the only way to fight for the edge. At this point Black is at crossroads. The frequently seen 6...♘e7 7.♗c4 ♘bc6 looks acceptable, but 8.♗e3 ♘d4 9.♗d4 0-0 10.a3 or 8...0-0 9.♘db5!? ♗a5 10.♕h5 gives White a small edge. Black could try to fish in muddy waters in the considered as dubious line 6...♕e7 7.♗c4 and now 7...♘f6! We would like to see more of this line in practice.

Chapter 2



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♗b4

(D20)

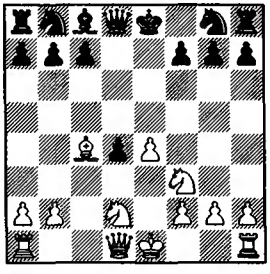
Note also 5...c5 6.♘e5±.

6.♗d2

6.♘bd2 is the subject of Chapter 3.

The game Epishin – Bezgodov, Krasnoyarsk 2003 introduced a dubious novelty: 6.♘fd2?! ♘c6 7.0-0 ♘f6 8.e5 ♘d5 9.♕f3 ♗e6 10.♕g3 ♕d7 11.a3 ♗e7 12.♘f3 ♘c3 13.♗d3 ♗f5 14.bc3 ♗d3∓. White definitely needs some patching for his idea to reach a presentable state.

6...♗d2 7.♘bd2



Now major options are:

A. 7...♕f6

B. 7...♘h6

C. 7...♘c6

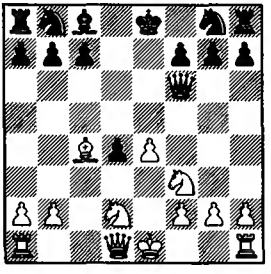
Practice has also seen some overambitious rare lines, such as:

7...c5 Here 8.♖c1 regains the pawn as 8...♘d7 (8...♘c6 9.0–0; 8...♘h6 9.♗b5) 9.0–0 ♘e7 10.e5 would be awfull for Black;

7...♘f6 8.e5 ♘d5 9.♕b3 c6 10.0–0 0–0 11.♗d5 ♕d5 12.♕d5 cd5 13.♘d4 ♗d7 14.f4± Gyimesi – Kucera, Pardubice 1998.

A. 7...♕f6

Usually Black inserts 7...♘c6 8.0–0 and only then 8...♕f6 (see A3c). The text looks more flexible as Black could delay development of the knight for a better time. However, White can also use the move order by castling queenside.



A1. 8.♘b3

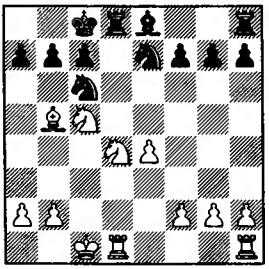
A2. 8.0–0

A1. 8.♘b3 ♘c6 9.♗b5

The game A. Kuzmin – Sorokin, Dubai 2000 saw 9.♘fd4 ♘d4 10.♕d4

♕d4 11.♘d4 ♗d7 12.0–0–0! Black was struggling after 12...♘e7 13.♘f3 f6 14.♗f7 ♔f7 15.♖d7 ♖ac8 16.♖hd1 ♔e8 17.♘g1 ♖g8 18.♘e2 ♘c6 19.f4 ♘b8 20.♖7d5 ♔f7 21.g4 ♖ge8 22.♘g3±. Black can improve with 9...♗d7, intending to castle long.

9...♘ge7 10.♕d4 ♕d4 11.♘fd4 ♗d7 12.♘c5 0-0-0 13.0-0-0 ♗e8



White's pieces are much more active, but Rublevsky stubbornly defends this position as Black, relying on the fact that he has no weaknesses. In any case White's game is easier, but with little chances to convert the initiative:

14.♘e2 14...b6 15.♗a6 ♔b8 16.♖d8 ♘d8 17.♖d1±, Ivanchuk – Rublevsky, Moscow 2002.

14.♘c2 f5 15.ef5 ♘f5 16.♗c4, Onischuk – Rublevsky, Poikovsky 2003, 16...♖d1!? 17.♖d1 ♘d6 18.♗e6 ♔b8=. (Onishuk)

14.♘f3?! b6 15.♗a6 ♔b8 16.♖d8 ♘d8 17.♖d1 ♗c6 18.♘d7 ♔a8 19.♘de5 ♗e4 20.♖d7 ♖e8 21.♖c7 ♘e6∓ Kasimdzhanov – Rublevsky, Antalya 08.10.2007.

A2. 8.0-0 ♘e7

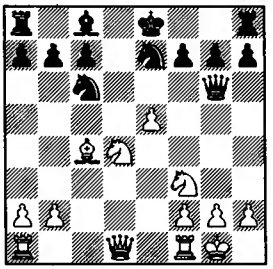
8...♘c6!? transposes to line C3.

9.e5

9.♘b3 ♘bc6 10.♘fd4 0–0 is rather balanced.

9...♕g6 10.♘d4 ♘bc6 11.♘2f3

Or 11.♘c6 ♘c6 12.f4 0–0 13.♘f3 ♗g4 14.♗d3 ♕h6=, Aronian – Kramnik, Dortmund 2006.



11...♗g4!?

In this line, if Black finds a tempo to lead out his bishop to g4, the opening problems would be behind him. Previously Black had played 11...0–0 and gradually equalised after 12.e6 fe6 (or 12...♗e6 13.♘e6 fe6 14.♖e1 ♔h8 15.♖e6 ♕g4 16.♕e2 ♘g6 17.h3 ♕f5 18.♗d3 ♘f4 19.♗f5 ♘e2 20.♖e2 ♖f5 21.♖d1 ♔g8 22.♖d7 ♖c8!=, Komarov – Rublevsky, Vrnjacka Banja 1999.) 13.♖e1 ♘d4 14.♘e5 (14.♘d4 ♖d8 15.♘e6=, Sakaev – Rublevsky, Herceg Novi 2000.) 14...♘f3 15.♘f3 ♘d5 16.♗d5 ed5 17.♕d5 ♕f7. Typically for the 3...e5 variation, White has more active pieces, but Black has no weaknesses, for instance, 18.♕f7 (18.♕d4 ♗f5 19.♖ac1 c6 20.a3 ♕f6 21.♕b4 ♖f7 22.♘e5 ♖e7 23.♘c4 ♖ae8 24.♖e7 ♖e7 25.♘d6 ♖e2 26.♕c4 ♕e6 27.♕e6 ♗e6 28.♘b7 ♖b2=, Rublevsky) 18...♖f7 19.♘g5 ♖f8 20.♖ac1 h6 21.♘e4 ♖f7 22.♖cd1 ♗f5= Dreev – Rudolph,

Frankfurt 2000.

12.♕b3 ♖d8 13.♘c6 ♘c6∞

It turns out that the b7-pawn is poisoned as 14.♘h4 ♕h5 15.♕b7 ♘d4 16.♕e4 0–0 17.h3 ♗e6 18.♖fc1 c5⩱ would be fine for Black. So in the source game Volkov – Zhou Jianchao, Moscow 2007, White chose 14.♖ae1 0–0 15.e6 fe6 16.♘h4 to become a bit worse following 16...♕g5↑.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♗b4 6.♗d2 ♗d2 7.♘bd2)

B. 7...♘h6

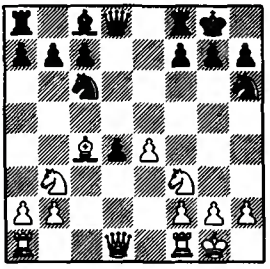
This line is out of fashion.

8.0–0 0–0

8...c5 is dubious due to 9.♘b3 ♕e7 10.♖c1 b6 11.♗d5♗b7 12.♘c5 bc5 13.♕a4 ♔f8 14.♖c5 ♘a6 15.♖a5±.

8...♘c6 could prove to be more flexible since after 9.♘b3 Black has also 9...♗g4. Then 10.♘bd4 ♘d4 11.♕d4 ♕d4 12.♘d4 0–0–0 13.♘b3 ♖he8 14.♖ac1 ♗e6 15.h3 led to a draw in Tisdall – Westerinen, Gausdal 1995. Probably White would have been better off with 10.♗b5 0–0 11.♗c6 bc6 12.h3 ♗f3 13.♕f3 ♖b8 14.♖ac1 ♕d6 15.♖fd1 c5 16.e5 ♕e5 17.♖c5±.

9.♘b3 ♘c6



10.♘bd4 ♘d4 11.♕d4 ♗g4

11...♕d4 12.♘d4 leads to a better endgame for White:

12...♘g4 (After 12...♖d8 13.♖ad1 ♗d7 14.♖d2 ♔f8 15.♖fd1 ♔e7 16.h3±!) 13.♘b5 ♗d7 14.♘c7 ♖ac8 15.♖ac1! ♖c7 16.♗f7 ♖f7 17.♖c7 ♗c6 18.♖c8 ♖f8 19.♖f8 ♔f8 20.♖d1 ♔e7 21.f3 ♘e5 22.♔f2±, Epishin – Westerinen, Parnu 1996.

12.♕c3!

(12.♕d8 ♖ad8 13.♘e5 ♖d2!=)

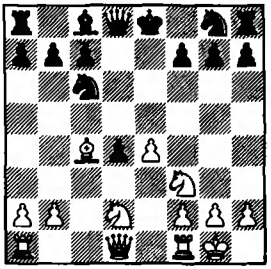
12...♗f3 13.♕f3 ♕d4

White has a space advantage, but it is not so easy to find targets. Therefore he should try to overrun the opponent on the kingside:

14.b3 ♖ad8 15.♖ad1 ♕e5 16.h3 c6 17.♕e3 b6 18.a4 ♖fe8 19.g4 ♔f8 20.f4±, Volkov – Raetsky, Smolensk 2000.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♗b4 6.♗d2 ♗d2 7.♘bd2)

C. 7...♘c6 8.0–0



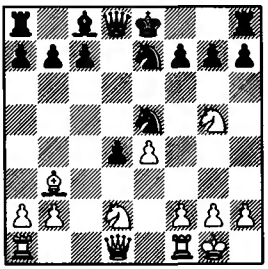
A very popular position.

C1. 8...♘ge7
C2. 8...♘f6
C3. 8...♕f6

C1. 8...♘ge7 9.♘g5

What was good against a knight on the rim, (h6) is harmless here. 9.♘b3 0–0 (Matulovic suggests 9...d3 10.♖c1!? 0–0 11.♖c3 ♗g4!=) 10.♘fd4 ♘d4 11.♕d4 ♕d4 12.♘d4 ♖d8 13.♖fd1 ♗d7 14.f3 ♔f8=, Taimanov – Polugaevsky, Leningrad 1963.

9...♘e5 10.♗b3



10...♗g4

The critical test of White's set-up is 10...h6 11.f4 ♗g4! when 12.fe5?! ♗d1 13.♗f7 ♔d7 14.♘e6 ♕b8 15.♘c5 ♔d8 16.♖ad1 b6 17.♘e6 ♔c8 18.♘d4 could be fun, but objectively Black should be able to survive.

More reasonable is 12.♕e1! hg5 13.fe5 ♗h5 14.♕g3 (14.♖c1 ♘c6 15.♗a4⩱) 14...d3 15.♔h1⩲. Rybka may claim that Black is OK here, but probably he is not.

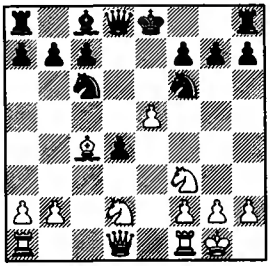
11.f3!?

By 11.♗f7 ♘f7 12.♕g4 White regains the pawn, but loses the initiative.

11...♗h5 12.g4 h6 13.♘h3 ♗g6 14.f4 ♘d7 15.♖c1!↑.

Having taken control of the c5-square, White is ready for a pawn storm on the kingside.

C2. 8...♘f6 9.e5



9...♘d5

9...♘g4 10.h3 ♘h6 11.♘b3 ♘f5 is also playable. We suppose that White should acquiesce to a small edge after 12.♗b5 ♕d5 13.♘bd4 ♘fd4 14.♘d4 ♗d7 15.♗c6 ♗c6 16.♘c6 ♕c6 17.♖c1 ♕b6 18.♕a4 c6 19.♕a3 0–0–0 20.b4!

10.♕b3

Or 10.♘b3 0-0 11.♘bd4 ♘d4 12.♕d4 ♘b6=, Karpov – Anand, Linares 1992.

10...♘a5

10...♘ce7 leves Black struggling in a cramped position: 11.♘d4 (Also good is 11.♘e4 0–0 12.♖ad1 ♘b6 13.♖d4± Averkin – Izvozchikov, Grozny 1969) 11...0–0 12.♖ad1 ♘b6 13.♘e4 ♘c4 14.♕c4 ♘d5 15.♕b3 c6 16.♕g3±, as in Bagirov – Petrushin, Baku 1977.

11.♕b5 c6 12.♕c5 ♕b6

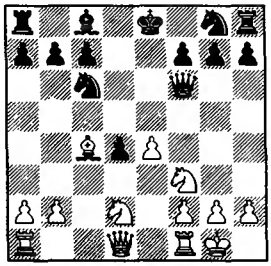
12...♗g4 13.♗d5±; 12...b6 13.♕d4±

13.♕d4 ♕d4

Or 15...♘c4 (with inserted 11.♕a4 ♘c6 12.♕b3 ♘a5) 16.♕c4 ♗d7 17.♘d4 ♖c8 18.♘e4 0–0 19.♘d6±, Karpov – Huebner, 1994.

14.♘d4 ♘c4 15.♘c4 ♔e7 16.♘d6 ♖d8 17.♖ac1±.

C3. 8...♕f6



9.b4!?

The thematic 9.e5 ♕g6 10.♘b3 or 10.♖e1 ♘ge7 11.♘b3 are neutralised by ...♗g4!

9...a6

Alternatives:

9...♘b4? gives White a decisive tempo: 10.e5 ♕g6 11.e6 ♗e6 12.♕a4 ♘c6 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♘e5+–, Epishin – Schmitz, Bad Woerishofen, 1999.

9...♘ge7 10.b5 ♘d8 (White had the better endgame following 10...♘e5 11.♘e5 ♕e5 12.♘f3 ♕d6 13.♕d4 ♕d4 14.♘d4±, S. Popov – Paunovic, Zlatibor 2006) 11.e5 ♕g6 12.♘d4 ♘e6 13.♘2b3 ♘d4 14.♘d4 ♗g4 15.♕b3 ♖d8 16.♘e2 0–0, Volkov – Rublevsky, St. Petersburg 1999. White is obviously better due to his b5-pawn which binds Black's queenside pawns. A normal move like 17.♖ad1!?± would have fixed his edge. In that case 17...♗e2 18.♗e2 ♕e4 19.♗c4 ♕e5 would fail to 20.♗f7 ♔h8 21.♖d8 ♖d8 22.♕e3! ♕e3 23.fe3 h6 24.♗b3± so he should look for other moves.

9...♗g4 10.♕a4 ♗d7 11.b5 ♘d8 gives White a bunch of good options, e.g.12.e5 ♕b6 13.♗d3±, Rausis – Westerinen, Reykjavik 1998.

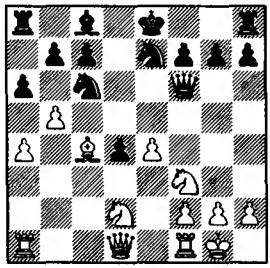
10.a4

The most consistent move. White not only gains space on the queenside, but enables a rook lift along the third rank. 10.e5 ♕g6 11.♖e1 ♘ge7 12.e6 ♗e6 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♕b3 0–0 is fine for Black. 11.♘b3 ♘ge7 12.♘bd4 0–0 13.♖e1 is a better try, but the text is clearly more challenging.

10...♘ge7

Perhaps critical here is 10...♘b4 11.e5 ♕g6 12.♘d4 ♘e7. It seems that White has a good compensation for the pawn. All his pieces are powerfully concentrated in the centre, while the a1-rook will quickly join in the attack via a3, after 13.♖e1! ♘ed5 14.♘e4 0–0 15.♖a3→.

11.b5



11...♘a5

11...♘d8 12.e5 ♕g6 13.♘d4 0–0 was too passive in M. Gurevich – Lane, Brussels 1995.

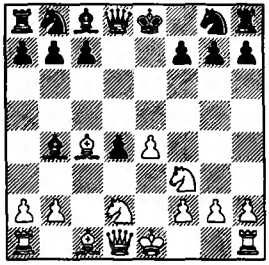
12.♗d3 0-0

The game A. Goldin – Z. Polgar, Moscow 1993 saw 12...c5, when 13.e5! would have favoured White.

13.♕c2 ♕b6 14.♖fc1 c6 15.ba6 ba6 16.♖ab1 ♕a7 17.e5 h6 18.♗h7 ♔h8 19.♗e4⩱

I'd take White here!

Chapter 3

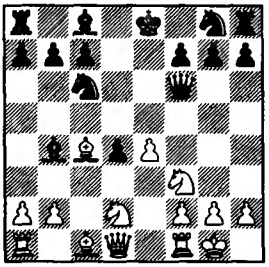


6.♘bd2 is the sternest test of the check on move 5. Rublevsky used to successfully defend Black's position, but in line C we'll see that White has at least two different ways to aspire to the edge. His big spatial advantage could be transformed into a better pawn structure or a strong attack. This conclusion of mine is not supported by many games, but mostly by analysis. It should be tested in practice more thoroughly.

6...♘c6 7.0–0

A. 7...♕f6
B. 7...♗e6
C. 7...♘f6

A. 7...♕f6



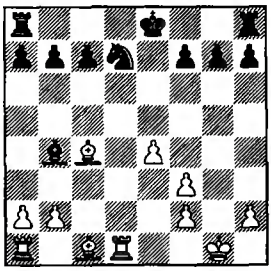
8.e5!?

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♗b4 6.♘bd2

(D20)

White is trying to punish the enemy for breaking the "rules" – first giving up the centre, and then lifting the queen in front of pawns. Supposedly the remaining on board ♗c1 would play the role of the last nail in Black's coffin. In fact, the brave queen proves to be amazingly light-heeled and shuttles all over the board, provoking chaos amongst White's pieces. The final diagnosis is perhaps a small edge for White.

Alternatively, 8.♘b3 ♗g4 9.♘bd4 ♘d4 10.♕d4 ♗f3 11.♕f6 ♘f6 12.gf3 ♘d7 13.♖d1



13...♘e5 (13...f6 14.♗e3 ♗d6, as in Mikhalchishin–Chekhov, Lvov 1984, does not change the pattern, so White could follow the same path: 15.f4 0–0–0 16.♖ac1 ♔b8 17.♗b3 ♖he8

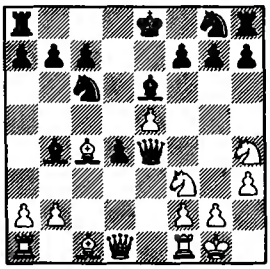
18.f3±.)

14.♗b5 c6 15.♗e2 f6 16.♗e3 ♔e7 17.f4 ♘g6 18.♔g2 ♗d6 19.♔f3±, planning a pressure along the g-file after ♖g1,♖g4, h4, Beliavsky – Chekhov, Lvov 1984.

8...♕g6 9.♘h4

Or 9.a3 ♗e7 10.♖e1 ♘h6!?

9...♕g4 10.♘df3 ♗e6 11.h3 ♕e4



12.♗e6

Further queen-hunting only centralises the strongest Black piece: 12.♗d3 ♕d5 13.♘g5 ♘ge7 But not 13...♕e5?! 14.♘hf3 ♕d5 15.♗e4 ♕d7 16.♗c6 bc6 17.♘e6 fe6 18.♘d4! 0–0–0? (18...♘f6 19.♗e3 U. Boensch) 19.♕a4!!→ Boensch, – Chekhov, Halle 1987.

14.a3 It is unwise to weaken the kingside and the e3-square with 14.f4 0–0–0 15.a3 ♗c5 16.b4 ♗b6 17.♗d2 ♕b3∓, Boensch – Meins, Germany 1997.

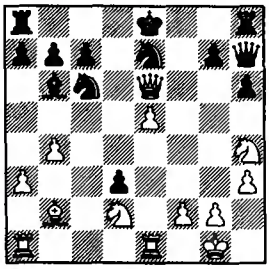
14...♗a5! 15.♗f4 0–0–0∞.

White has probably enough compensation for the pawn, but his knights went astray on the kingside and they will need time for returning to play.

12...fe6 13.♕b3 ♘ge7

Or 13...♕d5 14.♕d5 ed5 15.♘f5↑.

14.♕e6 h6 15.a3 ♗a5 16.b4 ♗b6 17.♖e1 ♕h7 18.♘d2 d3 19.♗b2



This position is critical for the evaluation of the 7...♕f6 line. White controls more space and should be somewhat better. In an endgame, the d3-pawn will prove to be overextended. The source game Jussupow – Mikhalchishin, Frunze 1981 went on with:

19...♗d4

Here, Huzman proposes 20.♕b3!? ♗b2 21.♕b2 0–0–0 22.♘hf3 ♘f5 23.♘b3±. On the other hand, in the stem game White got a convincing advantage after 20.♖ab1!? ♗b2 21.♖b2 ♘d4 22.♕g4 ♘e2 (22...♖d8 23.♕h5 g6 24.♕g4 0–0 25.♘e4±) 23.♔h2 h5 (23...0–0 24.♕c4 ♔h8 25.♕c7±) 24.♕g5 ♕h6 25.♘e4 ♕g5 26.♘g5±.

Note that Huzman's suggestion 20.♗d4 is dubious, due to 20...♘d4 21.♕g4 ♖d8 22.♖ac1 h5!∓

B. 7...♗e6 8.♗e6 fe6 9.♕b3 ♕d7

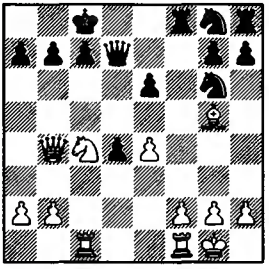
In the case of 9...♗d2 10.♗d2 ♕d7 White would be better after 11.♕b7

♖b8 12.♕a6±.

10.♘c4 0–0–0

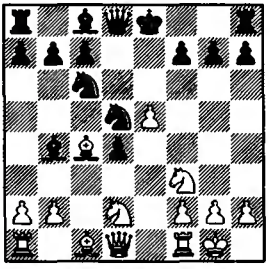
Or 10...♘f6 11.♘ce5 ♘e5 12.♘e5 ♕e7 13.♘d3 c5 14.a3±.

11.♗g5 ♖f8 12.♘fe5 ♘e5 13.♕b4 ♘g6 14.♖ac1±



Black is helpless against the threat of 15.♘d6 or 15.♘e5.

C. 7...♘f6 8.e5 ♘d5



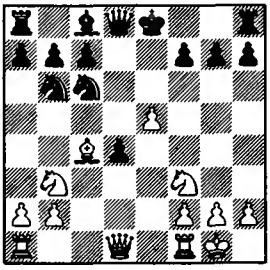
C1. 9.a3
C2. 9.♘b3

C1. 9.a3 ♗e7 10.♕b3 ♘a5 11.♕a4 ♘c6 12.♘d4 ♘b6 13.♘c6 ♘a4 14.♘d8 ♗d8 15.f4

Analysing the games of Rublevsky, we can conclude that the ending does not pose Black any serious problems. An example is Jobava – Rublevsky, Moscow 2002: 15.♘e4 ♗e7 16.b4 ♘b6 17.♗e2, when simplest would have been 17...♗e6=.

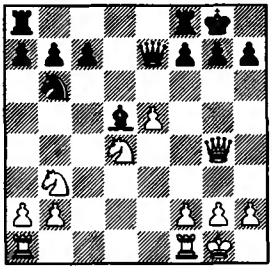
15...♘b6 16.♗b3 g6 17.♘e4 ♗e7 18.♗e3 ♗e6 19.♗e6 fe6=, Azmaiparashvili – Rublevsky, Hyderabad 2002.

C2. 9.♘b3 ♘b6



C2a. 10.♗g5; C2b. 10.♗b5!?

C2a. 10.♗g5 ♗e7 11.♗e7 ♕e7 12.♗b5 ♗d7 13.♗c6 ♗c6 14.♘fd4 ♗d5 15.♕g4 0-0



A critical position. White's initiative looks very threatening, but Rublevsky proved that Black is able to hold. 15...g6 is less precise due to 16.♖fe1! (the threat is e5-e6) 0–0 17.♘f5 ♕d7 18.♘h6 ♔g7 19.♕g5!±, Kasparov – Huebner, Skelleftea 1989.

16.f4 g6

This situation compares favourably for Black to the line with 15...g6 16.♖fe1 0-0 where White has saved the move f4.

17.♘f5

17.♖ae1 has been parried in the game Goldin – Rublevsky, Niksic 1997, with 17...f5 (an improvement on 17...♗c4? 18.f5! ♗f1 19.f6 ♕b4 20.♕h4 ♖fe8 21.a3 ♕f8 22.e6 ♗c4 23.e7 ♖e7 24.fe7 ♕e8 25.♘c5±, Sakaev – Rublevsky, Vrnjacka Banja 1999) 18.ef6 ♕f6 19.f5 ♗c4 20.♖f3 ♗d5 21.♖ff1 ♗c4 22.♖f3 ♗d5 23.♖ff1 ½–½, Sherbakov – Rublevsky, Ekaterinburg 2002.

17...♕d7 (17...♕d8?! 18.♖ad1) **18 ♘e3!**

This move allowed White to get some edge in Onischuk-Dominguez, Foros 25.06.2007, after 18...♕xg4 19.♘g4 ♖fd8 20.♘f6 ♔g7 21.♖fd1 a5 22.♖d4 ♗b3 23.♖d8 ♖d8 24.ab3 ♖d4±. I (S.S.) suppose that Black should fight for equality with:

18...♗b3!? 19.♕d7

Or 19.ab3 ♕d4 20.♕f3 ♘d5=.

19...♘d7 20.ab3 ♘c5 21.♖ac1

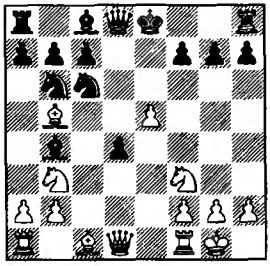
21.b4 ♘e6 22.g3 a6 and Black is not worse.

21...♘e6 22.♘d5 c6 23.♘f6 ♔g7 24.g4 ♘d4

Black has enough counterplay, for example, 25.♔g2 ♘b3 26.♖c3 ♘d4 27.h4 ♖ad8 28.h5 h6 29.hg6 fg6 30.f5 a5.

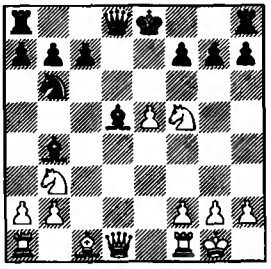
C2b. 10.♗b5!?

Currently this move poses problems to Black.



10...♕d5

In 2007 Black switched to 10...♗d7, but it may be even more risky. White's best answer seems to be 11.♗c6 (Alternatively, 11.♘bd4 ♘d4 12.♘d4 0–0 H. Knuth – Putzbach, Germany 1992, 13.♗d3!? ♖e8 14.♗f4±.) 11...♗c6 12.♘fd4 ♗d5 13.♘f5



13...♗f8!

13...g6 is more natural, but White has 14.♕g4! (14.♘g7 ♔f8 15.♗h6 ♔g8 is roughly equal) 14...gf5 15.♕b4 ♖g8 16.g3! with a better game, for example, 16...♗c4 17.♖e1 ♕d5 18.♗e3 0–0–0 19.♖ac1 ♗b3 20.ab3±.

14.♗e3. Here, Granda Zuniga-Matsuura, Callao, 13.08.2007 went on with 14...g6? 17.♘d6±. Instead, the only move is:

14...c6, when White has a lot of interesting ways, but I could not see

anything decisive:

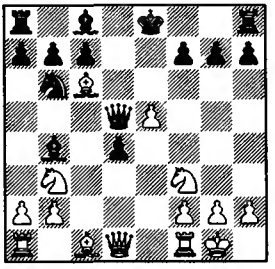
a) 15.♘c5 ♘c4 16.♕d4 (16.♘b7 ♕d7 17.♘bd6 ♘d6 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.ed6 ♕d6 20.♕c2 ♕g6=; 16.♕g4 g6 17.♘d6 ♗d6 18.ed6 ♘d6) 16...f6 (16...b6 17.♘b7 ♕d7 18.b3±) 17.e6 g6 18.♘b7 ♕c7 19.♕f6 ♖g8 20.e7 gf5 21.ef8♕ ♖f8 22.♗f4 ♖f6 23.♗c7 ♘b2 24.♘c5±. White retains the initiative, but the mighty bishop on d5 will probably save Black from big trouble.

15.♕g4 g6 16.♘h6 ♕d7=.

11.♗c6!

Rublevsky showed that the endgame after 11.♘bd4 0–0 12.♗c6 bc6 13.♕c2 c5 14.♘f5 ♕e6 15.♘g3 ♕g6 16.♕g6 hg6 is comfortable for Black. The c-pawn is more of an asset, than a weakness. That was confirmed by the game Adianto-Sasikiran, rapid Doha 2006: 17.a3 ♗a5 18.♗d2 ♗d2 19.♘d2 c4 20.♖fd1 ♖e8 21.♖ac1 ♗a6=.

Another option is 11.♘fd4 0-0=.



This exchange faces Black with a difficult choice.

11...bc6 12.♕d4 ♕d4 13.♘fd4 ♗d7 14.♗d2± leaves him with a split pawn structure, whereas

11...♕c6 12.♗g5! proved to be awkward for him in the game Chetverik – Remete, Szombathely 2005: 12...♗g4 13.♕d4. The onus is on Black in that line.

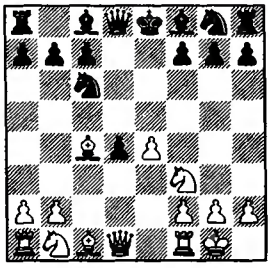
Conclusion

The old variation 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♗b4 is in crisis, in my opinion although Rublevsky is successfully defending Black's position after the allegedly best continuation of White 6.♘bd2 ♘c6 7.0–0. He prefers 7...♘f6!? 8.e5 ♘d5 9.♘b3 ♘b6 and neither 10.♗b5, nor 10.♗g5 look too dangerous. Still, in the latter variation Black might suffer in the endgame.

Chapter 4

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♘c6 6.0-0

(D20)



We see on the diagram the most fashionable position in the 3.e4 e5 system. This line is not so solid as the check on b4, but it leaves more chances for win, to both players. Recently White came up with new ideas in both major branches, but Black is still holding his own.

Most topical are lines A4 and B2. You should be watching them for new developments.

6...♗e6

6...a6 is unexplored. Then 7.♗d5 will be met by 7...♗c5! (7...♘ge7 8.♕b3! ♘d5 9.ed5±) 8.♗c6 bc6. Perhaps better is 7.♗f4, developing.

We cannot believe that **6...♘f6** could be completely sound, but White should certainly act energetically.

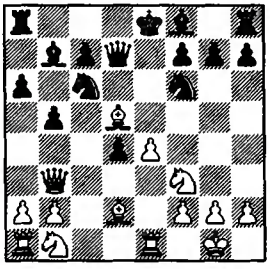
7.♕b3 Safer, but also less promising is 7.e5 ♘e4 8.♖e1 ♘c5 9.♗g5 ♗e7 10.♗e7 ♕e7 11.♘d4 ♘d4 12.♕d4 ♗e6 13.♗f1.

7...♕d7 8.♗d2 a6

Or 8...a5 9.♖e1 a4 10.♕b5 ♘d8 11.e5 ♘g4 12.♘d4 ♘e6 13.♘e6 fe6 14.h3 ♕b5 15.♗b5 c6 16.♗c6 bc6 17.hg4±, Morovic Fernandez – Stevic, Pula 1999.

9.♖e1! b5 10.♗d5 ♘d5

10...♗b7 is bad indeed, but we had to spend a lot of time to refute it:



11.♘g5 ♘d5 (11...♘d8 12.♗b7 ♘b7 13.e5 ♘d5 14.e6→). 12.ed5 ♘e7 13.d6 ♕d6 14.♕f7 ♔d7 15.♘f3!! (All attempts to attack through the e6-square are futile due to the strong defensive resource ♕d5. White should forget about the enemy king and break through the centre.)

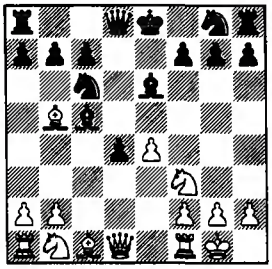
15...♖d8 (or 15...♗d5 16.♕h5 c5 17.b4 g6 18.♕h3 ♘f5 19.bc5 ♕c5 20.♘e5+–) 16.♗g5 ♗d5 17.♕h5 c5 (17...♔c8 18.♘d4±) 18.♘bd2 ♔c8 19.b4 c4 20.♘d4 ♔b8 21.♖ad1 h6 22.♘e4±.

11.ed5 ♘e7 12.♘d4 ♗b7 13.♘c6! ♗c6 14.dc6 ♕c6 15.a4→ Khalifman – C. Bauer, Istanbul 2000. For a pawn, White has a terrible attack.

Let us return to the main line:

A. 7.♗b5
B. 7.♗e6
Or 7.♕b3 ♗c4.

A. 7.♗b5 ♗c5



A1. 8.♘g5
A2. 8.♘bd2
A3. 8.♕c2
A4. 8.b4

A1. 8.♘g5 ♕e7

Another good option is 8...♕d7 (But not 8...♕d6 9.e5! ♕e5 10.♖e1↑or 8...♘f6 9.e5 ♘d5 10.♘e6 fe6 11.♕g4 ♕e7 12.♘d2±) 9.♘e6 ♕e6 10.♗f4 ♗b6∞ Krush – Bergsson, Reykjavik 2004.

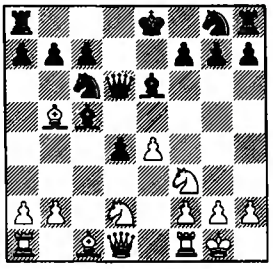
9.♗c6

9.f4 is more consistent, but we doubt that one can win a game by just pushing pawns while his pieces remain on the initial positions.

9...bc6 10.♘e6 ♕e6 11.♘d2 ♖d8 12.♕c2 ♗b6 13.♕d3 ♘f6 14.♘c4 ♘d7 15.b4 c5 16.b5 c6 17.bc6 ♕c6 18.♗g5 f6 19.♗h4 ♗c7 20.f4 0-0 21.♖ac1 ♖de8∓, Vyzmanavin – Rublevsky, Novosibirsk 1995.

A2. 8.♘bd2 ♘ge7!

The game Kasparov – Anand, Linares 1999 introduced a dubious novelty – 8...♕d6?!



9.e5 (or 9.♘c4 ♗c4 10.♗c4 ♘ge7 11.♖e1 f6 12.e5 ♘e5 13.♗f4 0–0–0 14.♘e5 fe5 15.♕g4 ♔b8 16.♗e5 ♕g6 17.♕g6 ♘g6 18.♗g7 ♖he8 19.g3±. The bishop pair secured a slight edge to White in Tunik – Nachev, Saratov 1999) 9...♕d5 10.♘g5! 0–0–0 (10...♖d8 11.♗c4 ♕e5 12.♘e6 fe6 13.♖e1+–) 11.♗c4 ♕d7 12.♘e6 fe6 13.b4! ♘b4 (13...♗b6 14.♕b3 ♕e7! 15.♗e6 ♔b8 16.♘f3 ♕b4 17.♕b4 ♘b4 18.♗g5⩲; 13...♗b4 14.♕b3 ♖e8 15.♖b1→) Kasparov played here 14.♕b3 and had the edge, but 14.♗a3!?, suggested by L. Ljubojevic, is even better, e.g. 14...a5 (14...♘d3 15.♕b3) 15.♘e4 ♗b6 16.♕b3 ♖e8 (16...♘d5 17.♘d6 ♔b8 18.♗d5 ed5 19.♗c5 cd6 20.e6 ♕e6 21.♕b6) 17.♗b4 ab4 18.a3!→.

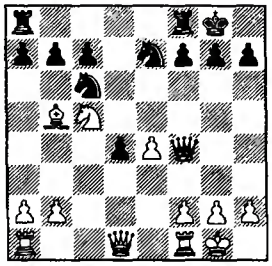
9.♘g5

9.♘b3 ♗b6 10.♘bd4 ♗d7 11.♘c6 ♗c6 12.♕b3 0–0 is not impressive either, 13.♗g5 ♗b5 14.♕b5 ♕e8=, Sargissian – Kaidanov, Moscow 2005.

9...♕d7 10.♘e6 ♕e6 11.♘b3 ♕d6

Defending the d4-pawn.

12.♗f4 ♕f4 13.♘c5 0-0



White has some temporary initiative while Black can boast with an extra (central!) pawn and no weaknesses. Our opinion is that Black can be confident about future, provided he neutralises White's threats in the next few moves.

14.♖c1

Alternatively, 14.g3 ♕h6 15.♖c1 ♖fd8 16.♘b7 ♖db8 17.♕a4 ♘e5 18.♖c7 ♘f3 (18...♘7g6?±, Dreev – Svidler RUS-ch 1997) 19.♔g2 ♘h4! 20.♔h1 (20.gh4 ♕f4! 21.♖fc1 ♖b7) 20...♘f3, draw.

14...a6

Black opts for a central strategy. He could also set up a repelling operation, starting with:

14...♖fb8 15.g3 ♕h6 16.f4 a6 17.♗d3 a5 18.♕a4 (White is struggling after 18.a3 b6 19.♘a6 ♖b7! 20.♕e2 ♖d8∓.) 18...♘b4 19.♗c4 b5! (19...c6 20.♕b3 ♕h5 21.a3±) 20.♗b5 ♘a2 21.♖c4 c6 22.♕a2 cb5 23.♖d4 ♕b6∓, Browne – Kaidanov, Denver 1998.

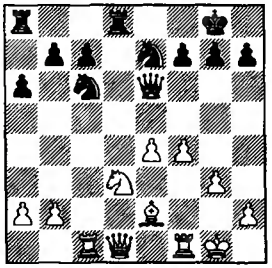
15.g3

It is not easy to give White a sensible advice. 15.♗a4 also does not promise full compensation in view of 15...b6 16.♘d3 (16.♘a6 ♖a6 17.♗c6 ♘c6 18.♖c6 ♕e4 19.♖c7 ♖a2 20.♕b3 ♕e6 21.♕e6 fe6∓) 16...♕e4 17.♖e1 ♕d5 18.♗c6 ♘c6 19.♕c2 ♕f5 20.♖ed1 ♘e5 21.♘e5 ♕e5 22.♕c7 ♕b5!∓.

15...♕h6 16.♗e2

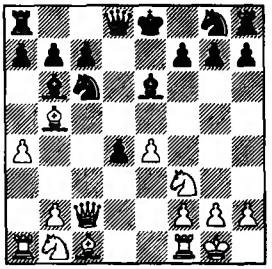
Sakalauskas suggests 16.♗c6 ♘c6 17.f4 b6 18.♘d3 ♖fe8 19.e5, but 19...♘e7∓ seems convincing.

16..♖fd8 17.f4 d3! 18.♘d3 ♕e6∓



The queen is coming back into play with a double attack on e4 and a2. In addition White is discoordinated.

A3. 8.♕c2 ♗b6 9.a4



We have never understood why everybody inserts this move, thus weakening the b4-square. Anyway, this variation is quite rare, so we'll not discuss it in detail.

9...a5 10.♗c6 bc6 11.♕c6 ♗d7

12.♕c2 (Perhaps White would have been better off with 12.♕c4 ♗e6 13.♕c6 draw!?) **12...♘e7 13.♘a3** (**13.♘e5** 0–0 14.♘d2 ♗e6 15.♘dc4 ♘g6 16.♘b6 cb6 17.♘g6 hg6∓, Sorin – Sorokin, Salta 1995) **13...0-0 14.♘c4 ♘c6** (**14...c5 15 ♗f4⩱**)

The game is level. Van Wely – Anand, Amber-blind Monte Carlo 1997 saw further:

15.♖d1 ♘b4 16.♕b3 c5 17.♗d2 ♗c7 18.♗b4 ♖b8! 19.♕c2 ♖b4 20.♘ce5 ♗d6 21.♘d7 ♕d7 22.b3 ♕e6 23.♘d2 ♖fb8↑.

A4. 8.b4 ♗b6 9 a4

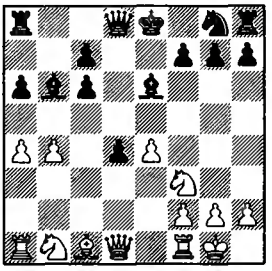
The current status of this line is rather unclear. Aronian tried to rehabilitate it in the Candidates matches and had an advantage deep in the endgame. Twenty days later Onischuk repeated the same variation versus Nisipeanu, improved on White's play, and was better on move 20. Then Topalov and Ponomariov used it in very important games and in both cases it was White who made novelties. Despite the two victories, I remain with the impression that White got nothing of the opening.

Apparently there is some venom in White's idea, but we'll need more games to get some answers.

Black has also tried 9.♗b2 ♕d6!? (Black does not risk anything with 9...♘ge7 10.♗d4 0–0 11.♗c5 ♗c5 12.bc5 a6 13.♗c6 ♘c6 14.♘c3 ♕e7= Beliavsky – Sherbakov, Niksic 1996 or 14...♗c4 15.♖e1 ♕e7=, Kanep – A. Mihalcisin, Calvia 2004.) 10.a4 ♘ge7 11.a5 ♕b4 12.♕e2 d3 13.♗d3 ♗d4 (but not 13...♘d4? 14.♗d4 ♗d4 15.♖a4!±) 14.♘d4 ♘d4 15.♗d4 ♕d4 16.♘a3 0–0. The position is unclear but at least Black is a pawn up.

9...a6 10 ♗xc6+ bxc6

The first critical moment.



Should White play a5 or not? This move has obvious drawbacks: it opens the b-file and Black could attack the b4-pawn from b8, as we'll see from my analysis. I've also found a variation, where Black uses the b5-square for his light-squared bishop. On the other hand, Black could play ...a5 himself, thus getting rid of the problem a6-pawn.

11 a5

Let us examine two newer games:

Topalov – Nisipeanu, Vitoria Gasteiz 11.11.2007:

11.♗b2 ♘f6 12.a5 ♗a7 13.♘bd2 0–0 14.♕c2

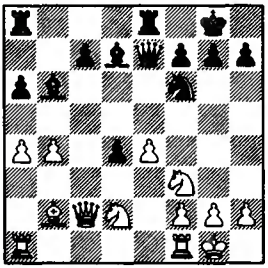
Here Nisipeanu miscalculated something and played 14...♘g4?, obviously intending to answer 15.h3 with 15...♘e3, but when Topalov did followed with 15.h3, he probably saw that 15...♘e3 16.fe3 de3 17.♘b3 e2 18.♖f2 ♗b3 19.♕b3 ♖e8 20.♕c3± was in White's favour and reconsidered his plans. After 15...♘f6 he lost tempi and became slightly worse: 16.♘e5

♗d7 17.♖fe1 ♕e7 18.♘df3 c5 19.bc5 ♕c5 20.♕d2±. Instead of his blunder, Black had the interesting sacrifice:

14...d3!? 15.♕c6 ♗d7 16.♕c3 ♗b5 with active pieces.

The next attempt was Ponomariov – Sasikiran, World Cup Khanty-Mansiysk RUS (4.1), 03.12.2007:

11.♘bd2 ♘f6 12.♕c2 0–0 13.♕c6 ♖e8 14.♗b2 ♗d7 (14...a5) 15.♕c2 ♕e7

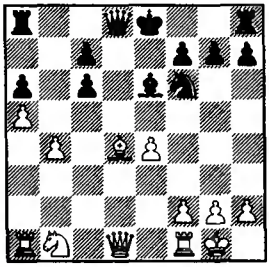


With this double hit on e4 and b4 Black equalises:

16.♘d4 ♕b4 17.♗c3 ♕c5 (17...♕d6 18.♘c4 ♕c5 19.♘b6 cb6 20.f3 b5=) 18.a5 ♗a7 19.♖ac1. Here 19...♘e4 20.♘e4 ♕d5∓ would have been slightly better for Black.

It remains to answer why White did not follow the previous games in that line, which had developed favourably for him.

11...♗a7 12 ♗b2 ♘f6 13 ♘xd4 ♗xd4 14 ♗xd4



A crucial moment. Both recent games went on with:

14...♘xe4

I do not know what is wrong with 14...♖b8!?, attacking the b4-pawn. Here are some variations:

15 e5 ♘d5 16 ♗c5 ♘xb4 17 ♕a4 ♘d3 18 ♗a7 ♖b5 19 ♘c3 0–0! 20 ♘xb5 cxb5↑;

15 ♕d2 ♘xe4 16 ♕b2 ♕e7 17 ♕c2 ♖xb4 18 ♕xe4 ♕d7 19 ♖d1 0–0 20 ♘c3 ♖d8 21 ♕e2 ♖xd4 22 ♖xd4 ♕xd4 23 ♖d1 ♕f6 24 ♖xd8+ ♕xd8 25 ♕xa6 h6 26 ♕f1 ♕d4 27 ♕a1 ♗c4∓;

15 ♖a3 ♖xb4 16 ♖d3 ♗c4 17 ♖d2 ♕e7 18 ♗c5 ♕xc5 19 ♖d8+ ♔e7 20 ♖xh8 ♗xf1 21 ♕d8+ ♔e6 22 ♕c8+ ♘d7 23 ♕d8 ♘f6=.

15 ♖e1

This should be an improvement on 15 ♗xg7, which had aslo turned well for White after 15...♖g8 16 ♗e5 ♗h3 17 ♗g3 ♘xg3 18 hxg3 ♕xd1 19 ♖xd1 ♗e6 20 ♘c3 ♖g4 21 ♖ab1 ♖b8 22 f4± in Aronian-Shirov, WCh Candidates Finals Elista 08.06.2007.

15...♘f6∞

Suggested by Golubev in Chess Today. In Onischuk-Nisipeanu, Foros, 29.06.2007 was 15...♕d5?! 16 ♕d3 c5 17 ♖xe4 cxd4 18 ♘c3 ♕b3?! 19 ♖xd4 0–0 20 ♕d2±.

Whatch out for new ideas in that line! If so many super GMs liked White's position, they should certainly have some trumps up their sleeves.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♘c6 6.0–0 ♗e6)

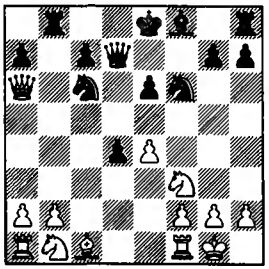
B. 7.♗e6 fe6 8.♕b3

8.♘g5?! ♕d7 9.♕h5 g6 10.♕h3 0–0–0∓, Herndl – Ibragimov, Vienna 1996.

8...♕d7

8...♕c8 cannot be refuted directly, but is too passive and has no adherents.

9.♕b7 ♖b8 10.♕a6 ♘f6



11.♘bd2

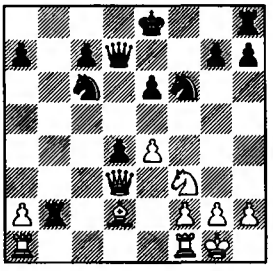
As we'll see below, White misses one tempo to achieve his dream set-up (♕d3, ♘c4, a3, h3), while restricting at the same time Black's activity. In the diagram position nearly everybody plays 11.♘bd2, but the immediate 11.♕d3 is also possible. It seems that Black should answer with 11...♗d6, so that move order allows to shun the variation 11...♗b4.

11...♗d6

11...♗b4 has been less popular lately due to 12.♕d3.

Instead, 12.♘c4 0–0 13.a3 ♗c5 14.b4 fails to 14...♘e4!! 15.♖e1 ♕d5 16.♖e4 ♕e4 17.♘cd2 ♕d5 18.bc5 e5 (18...♕c5!?) 19.♕d3 e4! (opening files for the rooks) 20.♕e4 ♕c5 21.h4 ♖fe8 22.♕d3 ♕c3 23.♕c4 ♔h8 24.♕a2 d3∓ Szymanski – Barglowski, Bydgoszcz 2001. 14.♖e1 is not much better due to 14...d3 (14...♖b3 15.e5 ♘d5 16.♘cd2 ♖bb8 17.♕c4±) 15.b4 ♗b6 16.♗e3 ♗e3! 17.♖e3 ♘g4 18.♖ee1 ♖f3 (also interesting is 18...♘d4 19.♘d4 ♕d4 20.♕e6 ♔h8 21.♕g4 ♕c4∞) 19.gf3 ♘ge5 20.♘e5 ♘e5 21.♖e3 ♖f8↑. All these niceties are however irrelevant as the pawn sac linked with 12.♕d3 is a sterner test.

12...♗d2 13.♗d2 ♖b2



14.♖ac1!?

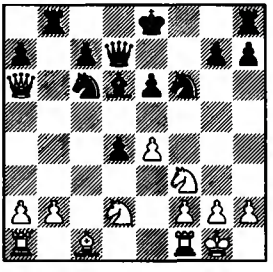
14.♗c1 ♖b6 15.♗a3 ♘b4 16.♕c4 also gives White the initiative.

14...0–0

Or 14...♕d6 15.♕c4 ♘e5 16.♘e5 ♕e5 17.♕a4! with initiative, as in Z. Peng – Jackova, Germany 2001.

15.♖c5 ♘g4 16.h3, A. Bykhovsky – R. Lev Herzliya 1998.

White maintains the initiative, Obviously Black's task in this line is not simple.

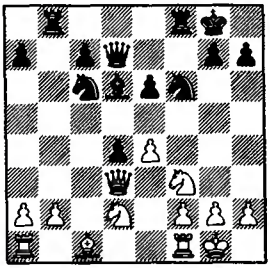


B1 12.♕d3
B2 12.b3!?
B3 12.a3

B1. 12.♕d3

This variation has drifted away from fashion, but still it is very solid, and gives White a slight edge, as we'll see in line B1c.

12...0-0



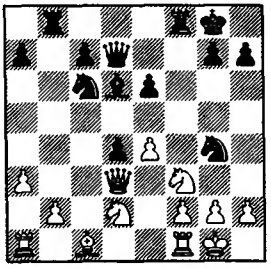
B1a. 13.a3; B1b. 13.♘c4; B1c. 13.h3

B1a. 13.a3

White should not allow Black's knight to reach e5.

13...♘g4!

13...a5 could be met by 14.h3! – see B2c. 14.b3?! is less convincing due to 14...♘g4! 15.h3 ♘ge5 16.♘e5 ♘e5! (16...♗e5 17.♘c4 ♗f4 18.♗f4 ♖f4 19.♖ac1 e5 20.♘e3!±) 17.♕d4 ♘d3 18.e5 ♘e5 19.♗b2 ♖b5!∓.



14.h3

After 14.b3 the pawn is vulnerable in some variations – 14...♘ce5 15.♘e5 ♘e5! 16.♕d4 ♘g4 17.e5 ♘e5 18.♗b2 ♖b5! Now White would like very much to play 19.♘e4, but it fails to 19...♖b3, while 19.♘c4 leads to the game Galliamova – Rublevsky, St. Petersburg 1998 which went on 19...♖d5 20.♕e4 (20.♕h4 ♘d3 21.♗c3 ♖f4 22.♕h3 ♗c5∓; 20.♕c3 ♘d3 21.♘d6 cd6∓) 20...♘d3∓.

14...♘ge5 15.♘e5 ♘e5 16.♕d4 ♕b5

Or 16....♘g4⩱ Bacrot – Waitzkin, Bermuda 1999.

17.♕c3

17.b4 ♘c6 18.♕c4 ♕e5 19.g3 ♕a1 20.♕c6 ♕d4 21.♔g2 ♕f6∞ ½–½ P. Nikolic – Anand, Monte Carlo 1999.

17...♕e2 18.♕e3 ♕e3 19.fe3 ♘d3 20.♖f8 ♔f8 21.♘c4 ♗e7 22.b4 c5 23.♗d2=, Gormally – I. Krush, London 1999.

B1b. 13.♘c4

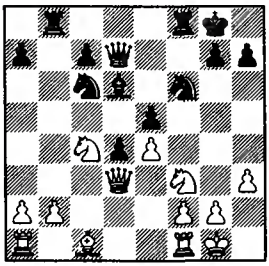
An attempt to take control of the sensitive point e5. Black saves the day with a tactical device.

13...♘g4 14.h3 ♖f3 15.♕f3 ♘h2 16.♕d3

Similar is 16.♕e2 ♘f1 17.♕f1 ♖f8 18.♗d2 ♗g3 19.♗e1 ♘e5 20.♘e5 ♗e5 21.♕c4=.

16...♘f1 17.♔f1 ♘b4 18.♕b3 ♘c6 19.♕a4 ♖b4 20.♕c2 ♘e5 21.♘e5 ♗e5 22.♕d3 c5 23.b3 c4 24.bc4 ♕c6=, Topalov – Anand, Monte Carlo 1997.

B1c. 13.h3 e5 (13...♘b4? 14.♕c4) 14.♘c4



Unfortunately, White has no time for 14.a3 in view of 14...♘e7 15.♘c4 ♘g6 16.b4 ♘h5↑ and Black succeeds in bringing the second knight towards the enemy king.

14...♘b4!

White took measures against ♘f6-g4, but left uncovered his left wing. Black must grasp the moment until the enemy has not covered yet the sensitive squares around the blockading queen.

14...♔h8 goes halfway to White's plans:

15.♗d2 ♕e6

15...♘h5 intends to double the rooks on the f-file and sacrifice on f3. Perhaps best is to anticipate that idea with 16.♖fc1, when 16...♘f4 (or 16...♕e6 17.♘d6 ♕d6 18.♕c4±) 17.♗f4 ♖f4 18.a3 ♖bf8 19.♘d6 cd6 20.♕b5 ♘b8 21.♕d7 ♘d7 22.♖c6 is grim for Black. Note that 16.♖ac1 is also possible, as 16...♘f4 17.♗f4 ♖f4 18.a3 ♖bf8 19.♘d6 cd6 20.♕b5 ♖f3 21.♕c6 ♖3f7 (21...♕c6 22.♖c6 ♖b3 23.♖d6 ♖b2 24.f4) 22.♕d7 ♖d7 23.f4 ♔g8 24.fe5 de5 25.♖c5± is in White's favour.

16.♖ac1!±

16.a3 ♘d7 17.b4 gives Black time for redeploying: 17...♗e7 and now 18.♖fc1 could be met by 18...a5 19.♘a5 ♘a5 20.ba5 c5∓, whereas 18.♖fb1 allows 18...♖f3 19.gf3 ♕h3 20.♖b3∞ or 18...♘d8∞)

16...♗b4 (16...♘e7 17.♘g5 ♕d7 18.f4±) 17.a3 ♗d2 18.♘cd2 ♘h5 (18...♖b2?! was bad for Black following 19.♕c4! ♘d8 20.♕c7 ♘f7 21.♕a7 h6 22.♖c7±, Notkin – Makarov, Maikop 1998) 19.♕c4! Black has serious structural problems and he can compensate for them only with active play against the enemy king. Without queens he is often worse even with an extra pawn. For example:

19...♖f6 20.♕e6 ♖e6 21.♖c5± ♖b2 22.♖fc1 ♖b6 23.♘c4 ♘f4 24.♘b6 ♘e2 25.♔f1 ♘c1 26.♘d5 ♘b3 27.♖b5 ♘ba5 28.♘c7 ♖e7 29.♘a6±.

15.♕b3 ♘bd5!

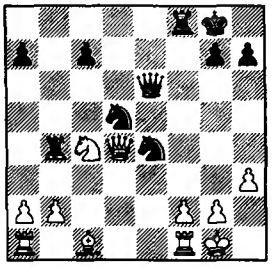
Again 15...♔h8 is too slow:

16.a3 ♕e6 17.♘g5 ♕g8 18.♗d2 ♘a6 19.♕c2 h6 (or 19...♘c5 20.♗b4 ♘e6 21.♘f3!±) 20.♘f3 ♕e6 21.♘h4± ♖fd8.

In the previous edition we considered only 21...♘d7 22.b4 c5 23.f4→. The text is suggested by Rizzitano, "with roughly level chances", but White is obviously better strategically:

22.b4 d3 (Or 22...c5 23.b5! ♖b5 24.f4→) 23.♕d3 ♗b4 24.♕c2 ♗d2 25.♘d2 Not only Black's pawns are split, but also his knight on a6 is out of play, e.g. 25...♔h7 26.♖fd1 ♖b6 27.♖ac1 ♖bd6 28.♘hf3±.

16.♕d1 ♘e4 17.♘fe5 ♗e5 18.♘e5 ♕e6 19.♕d4 ♖b4 20.♘c4



A critical position which arises nearly by force after 14.♘c4. In practice Black has lost both games:

20...♘b6 21.b3 ♘c4 22.♖e1! ♖e8 23.bc4±, C. Hansen – Schandorff, Aarhus 1999;

20...♘g3 21.fg3 ♖f1 22.♔f1 ♖c4 23.♕d3 c5 24.♗d2 ♖d4 25.♕e2± Cmilyte – Korbut, Chisinau 2005.

However he has a third possibility which saves the day:

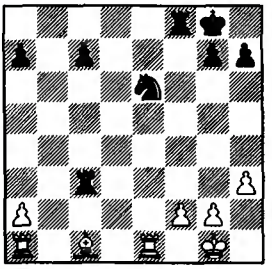
20...♘dc3! 21.bc3 ♖c4 22.♕e3

22.♕a7 leads to a perpetual after ♘f2 23.♗g5 ♘h3 24.gh3 ♖g4=.

22...♖c3 23.♕e2!

Again the only way to escape the perpetual after 23.♕a7 ♖h3!! 24.gh3 ♕h3 25.♗f4 ♕g4 26.♗g3 ♘g3 27.fg3 ♕g3 28.♔h1=.

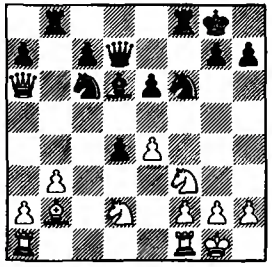
23...♘c5 24.♕e6 ♘e6 25.♖e1



How would you evaluate this ending?

I (S.S.) would propose 25...♔f7 26.♖e3! ♖c6 27.♖a3 a6 28.♗e3±. I think that most humans would conclude that White's chances are preferable. He has a bishop vs knight in an open position, and his pawns are less vulnerable. However, the engines see only a tiny edge here so we should wait for tournament games.

B2. 12.b3!? 0-0 13.♗b2



White completes development, planning to organise an attack on the c-file. The bishop on b2 plays a restricting role by presurising the centre. If Black pushes e5, he'll plug up his d6-bishop. Still, that option bolsters the centre and should be tested as Black has not find so far a clear equaliser after 13...♗f4 14.♕d3 ♖bd8 15.♘c4 ♘b4 16.♕d4±, Van Wely – Sasikiran, Moscow 2004.

This idea saw further development in the first game of the Candidates match Aronian – Shirov, Elista 06.06.2007:

13...♗f4 14.g3

A novelty. Other games have shown that it is useful for White to have this move.

14...♗h6

14...♗d2!? 15.♘d2 e5.

15.♗a3

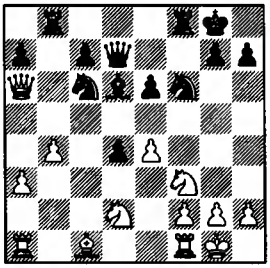
Here, instead of the "normal" 15...♖f7, Shirov suddenly sacrificed the exchange with:

14...♘e4 16.♗f8 ♘d2 17.♘d2 ♗d2 18.♗a3,

but quickly went astray and lost following 18...♕d5 19.♕c4 ♕c4 20.bc4 ♘e5 21.♖ab1± ♖d8 22.c5 ♘c4 23.♗c1 d3 24.♖b7 c6 25.♗d2 ♘d2 26.♖d1 ♘e4 27.f3 ♘c3 28.♖d2 ♘a2 29.♖b3 ♘c1 30.♖b1 ♘e2 31.♔f2 etc. All the commentators suggested as an improvement:

18...♘e5! 19.♕a7 ♕c8 20.♖fc1 ♗c1 21.♖c1 ♕b7 22.♖c7 ♕a7 23.♖a7 d3 24.♔f1 ♖c8= with a drawish endgame. I do not know whether such course of events would satisfy Black players. Anyway, in the third game of the match Aronian deviated first from the dispute in that line, so the issue remains open.

B3. 12.a3 0-0 13.b4



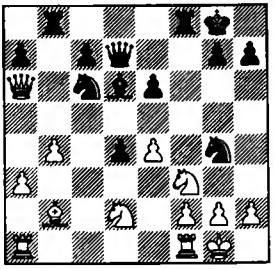
B3a. 13...♘g4; B3b. 13...e5; B3c. 13...♗f4!

This extended fianchetto is White's most aggresive response to Black's risky strategy. The a3-pawn controls possibles jumps of the c6-knight to b4, while the b4-pawn is constantly threatening to move forward. The queen remains active on a6, keeping all options open. Later it could rettreat to a4, or even capture the a7-pawn. The whole black construction suddenly becomes unstable.

On the downside, White leaves the f4-square uncovered, which enables the strong redeployment ♗d6-f4, followed by e6-e5. The advanced b4-pawn from a trump could become a handle for Black's counterplay due to the breakthrough a7-a5.

I (S.S.) think that Black has a pleasant game in line B3c, due to my novelty 14...e5.

B3a. 13...♘g4 14.♗b2



14...♗f4

Alternatives:

14...♘ce5 15.♘e5 ♗e5 16.h3 ♖b6 (16...d3 17.♗e5 ♘e5 18.♕a7±) 17.♕d3 ♗h2 18.♔h1 ♘f2 19.♖f2 ♖f2 20.♔h2 e5 21.♖f1 ♖bf6 22.♖f2 ♖f2 23.♔g1±.

14...♖b6 15.♕a4! and the counterplay with 15...a5 fails to 16.h3, whereas 15...♕f7 16.♖ac1 ♘e5 17.h3±

is also gloom.

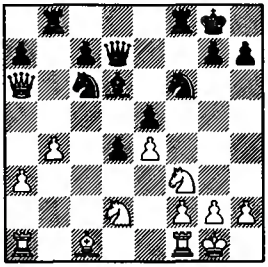
15.♘c4 ♖f6 16.h3 e5 17.b5 ♘e7 18.♕a7±, Yakovich – Kunin, Dresden, 05.04.2007. White's castling position is very solid and can withstand Black's desperate attack.

B3b. 13...e5

Beliavsky won such a fine positional game against Sermek in Portoroz 2005, that many players and commentators burried this move prematurely. Undoubtedly, it is a little passsive, since it plugs up the d6-bishop, but it cannot be so bad as it ensures a firm grip on the centre.

In this situation Black can look for counterplay with a7-a5 or ♘c6-d8-e6-f4.

14.♘e1



14...♖b6

14...♘d8 15.♘d3 ♘e6 16.♘c4 ♘e4 17.♖e1 ♘c3 18.♘de5 ♗e5 19.♘e5 ♕d5 20.♕c6 leads to a slightly better endgame for White.

15.♕e2

Huzman suggests 15.♕d3 ♕f7 16.♘c4 ♖bb8 17.♗d2±, but Black has a better option: 15...♖fb8, setting the stage for ...a5. White cannot waste time, so he will answer with 16.f4 a5 17.♘c4 ♖b5 18.♘f3, when 18...ab4 19.fe5 ♘e5 20.♘ce5 ♗e5 21.ab4 ♗d6 22.♗g5 ♘g4 23.♗d2 h6= reduces the material.

15...♕e6 16.♘c4 ♖bb8 17.♗d2

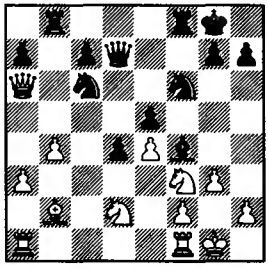
Here Sermek should have taken the chance to organise counterplay in the centre with **17...d3!** 18.♕d3 ♖bd8 19.♘f3 ♗b4 20.♕c2 ♗c5 with complex play. Instead he chose 17...♘d7 18.♖c1 ♘e7, when 19.♘d3± fixed White's clear advantage.

B3c. 13...♗f4!

This thematic move takes the best of the previous two lines. Before pushing e5, Black activates the bishop. His further plans include ♗d2, ♘f6-h5-f4 and a piece attack on the kingside. Critical for its success is to install a knight on f4. The c6-knight also could reach that square via d8-e6. In some variations the rook lift ♖b8-b6-h6 proves effective. At the same time Black is keeping an eye on the other wing, watching for the opportunity to play a5.

14.♗b2 e5!

14...♘g4?! 15.♘c4 transposes to B3a. The text is a novelty. Now, the b2-bishop is neutralised and the main issue becomes the question how dangerous White's pressure down the c-file could be.



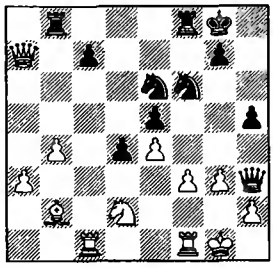
15.g3

The other major alternative is:

15.♖ac1 ♘d8!?

15...♖b6!? meets 16.♕a4!? when critical is 16...♖fb8 (16...♗d2 17.♘d2 ♘h5 18.g3 ♖f6 is inferior due to 19 ♕b3+! ♔h8 20 f4! exf4 21 ♕d5 ♕h3 22 ♖xc6 h6 23 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 24 ♕b3 ♘xg3 25 ♖f3±. Note that instead 19 b5? loses to 19...♘a5!! 20 ♕xa5 ♕h3 21 f4 ♖g6) 17.♖c5 ♕e6 18.♗c1 ♗d2 19.♘d2 d3⇄. The other retreat 16.♕d3 breaks the contact of the queen with the c6-knight and gives Black a terrible attack following 16...♗d2 17.♘d2 ♘h5 18.g3 ♕h3⇄. Black could even trade queens, still retaining his initiative as in the variation: 19.♖c5 ♘b4 (19...♖f6→) 20.ab4 ♖g6 21.♖fc1 ♘f4 22.♕f1 ♖h6 23.♕h3 ♘h3 24.♔h1 ♖f2.

After 15...♘d8 White's play is not clear. On the kingside he will have to withstand the powerful attack of all black pieces: 16 g3 (or 16 ♖c5 ♘e6 17 ♕c4 ♔h8 18 ♘xe5 ♕e8∞; 16 ♕xa7 ♘e6⩱) 16...♗xd2 17 ♘xd2 ♕h3! 18 f3 ♘e6 19 ♕xa7 h5→.



15...♗d2

15...♗h6 is perhaps a bit slow: 16.♖ac1 ♖b6 17.♕d3 ♕h3 18.♖c6 ♖c6 19.♘e5 (19.♘c4 ♘h5 20.♘ce5 ♘f4 21.gf4 ♗f4 22.♖d1 ♖h6 23.♗d4 ♖h5=) 19...♗d2 20.♕d2 ♘g4 21.♘g4 ♕g4 22.♕d4 ♖d6 23.♕c4. This position is probably equal, but still White's play is easier.

16.♘d2 ♘g4!

Freeing the f6-square for the rook.

17.♖ac1 ♖f6 18.♕c4 ♔h8 19.h3 ♘h6 (19...♖h6? 20.hg4 ♕g4 21.♕c6±) **20.♔g2 ♘f7 21.h4 a5!**

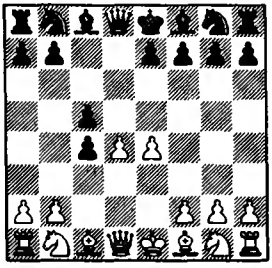
Black consolidated in the centre and now he opens up the queenside.

22.b5 ♘cd8 23.a4 c6⇄.

Conclusion

With this chapter we complete our study of the variation 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 e5. We have focused our attention on the topical 4.♘f3 ed4 5.♗c4 ♘c6 6.0–0 ♗e6 7.♗e6 fe6 8.♕b3 ♕d7 9.♕b7 ♖b8 10.♕a6 ♘f6. White is testing new ideas lately, linked with fianchettoing the dark-squared bishop. 11.♘bd2 remains a good choice, too. White's dream is to cover all approaches to the blockading White queen by h3 and a3 and proceed with ♘c4. As a whole, this line is very sharp and double-edged, but the better pawn structure ensures slightly better prospects to White.

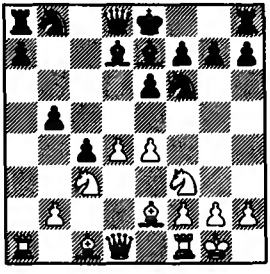
Chapter 5



3...b5?! had been rarely seen until the Deep Fritz-Kramnik match in 2006 which stirred the interest in that line. The game went on with:

4.a4 c6, when the machine transposed into a sideline of the Slav by 5.♘c3 b4 6.♘a2. The alternative 5.b3 is hardly any better, since 5...e5 6.ab5 ♗b4 7.♗d2 ♕d4 8.♗b4 ♕a1 9.♗c4 ♕d4 10.♕c2∞ is risky. Most consistent is:

5.ab5 cb5 6.♘c3 ♗d7 7.♘f3 e6 8.♗e2 ♘f6 9.0–0 ♗e7



White has finished developing and now he breaks through the centre. That ensures him a lasting initiative, because the b8-knight is stuck on its initial position.

10.d5 ed5 11.ed5 ♗c5

Or: 11...♗b4 12.♘d4 ♕b6 13.♗f3 0–0 14.d6 ♘c6 15.♘db5±;

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 3...b5?!; 3...c5?!

(D20)

11...♕b6? 12.♗e3 ♗c5 13.♗c5 ♕c5 14.♕d4±.

12.♗g5 0–0 13.♘e4 ♕e7 14.♘c5 ♕c5 15.♗f6 gf6 16.♘d4 a5 17.♕d2 ♖a6 18.♗f3⩲.

White has good attacking prospects, as well as play in the centre. His game is clearly better.

Now let us go to:

3...c5?!

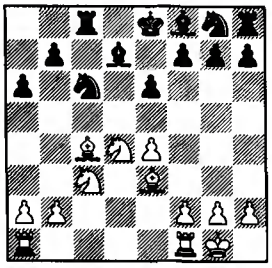
We suspect that this move is dubious. It brought some brilliant victories, but lately it is living through a crisis. Crushial for its future may prove to be line B3.

A. 4.♘f3
B. 4.d5!

A. 4.♘f3

From the times of Rubinstein, who offered a convincing way to equalisation, White has not found new ideas. He resorts to such a harmless set-up explicitly to avoid debates in the complicated lines after 4.d5! Here is one of the model games from the past:

4...cd4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4 ♗d7 7.♗c4 a6 8.♘c3 e6 9.0–0 ♘c6 10.♗e3 ♖c8



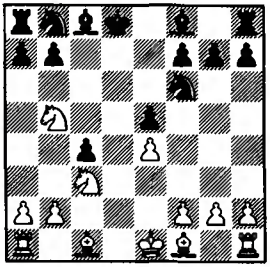
11.♗e2 ♘f6 12.♖ac1 ♗e7 13.♖fd1 ♘d4 14.♗d4 ♗c6 15.f3 0–0 16.♔f2 ♖fd8 17.♗b6 ♖d1 18.♘d1 ♗d7 19.♖c8 ♗c8 20.♘e3 ♘d7 21.♗d4 b5 22.a3 ♔f8 23.♘c2 e5 24.♗a7 ♗c5 25.♗c5 ♘c5 26.b4 ♘a4 27.♔e3 ♗e6 28.♔d2 ♔e7 29.♘e3 ♔d6 30.♗d3 f6 31.♗c2 ½–½, Capablanca – Rubinstein, Bad Kissingen 1928.

And now a modern example:

7.♗c4 ♘c6 8.♗e3 ♖c8 9.♘c6 ♗c6 10.♘d2 a6 11.♖c1 e6 12.f3 ♘f6 13.♘b3 ♗d6 14.♔f2 ♗c7 15.♖c2 0–0 16.♗a6 ♗e4 17.fe4 ♘g4 18.♔f3 ♘e3 19.♖c3 ba6 20.♖hc1 ♘d1 21.♖c7 ♖c7 22.♖c7 ½–½, P. Nikolic – Kotsur, Bled (ol) 2002.

Black could try to complicate things by the tricky move order:

4...♘f6 5.♘c3(5.e5!?)**cd4 6.♕d4 ♕d4 7.♘d4 e5!? 8.♘db5 ♔d8**



At least White has a wide choice and could easier make a wrong step:

9.♗g5?!

9.♗c4 a6 10.♘a3 b5 11.♗d5 ♖a7 12.♘c2 b4 also suits Black, F. Peredy – Z. Nemeth, HUN-ch 1996.

Equal is 9.♗e3 ♗e6 10.♗a7 (10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.♗a7 ♗b4 leads to similar positions) 10...♘bd7 11.♗e3 ♗b4 12.f3 ♖a5 13.0–0–0 ♔e7 14.♗e2 ♖c8= Pein – Zsu. Polgar, New York op 1986.

9...a6 10.♘d5

10.♖d1 ♘bd7 11.♘d5 ab5 12.♘f6 ♗b4 13.♔e2 ♗e7.

10...ab5 11.♘f6 ♗b4! 12.♔e2 ♗e7 13.♖d1 ♗d7

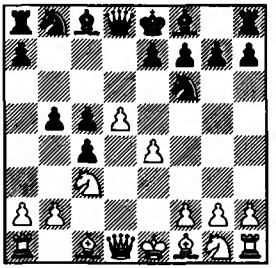
13...♘d7 14.♘d7 ♗d7∓.

14.♘d7 ♘d7 15.g3 ♖a2 16.♗h3 ♖b2 17.♔f1 ♗g5 18.♖d7 ♔e8 19.♔g2 ♖d2 20.♖b7 c3 21.♖b5 ♗e3∓, Van Wely – Zsu. Polgar, Amsterdam 1990.

B. 4.d5! ♘f6

4...e6 is also frequently seen. It is the subject of Chapter 6.

5.♘c3 b5

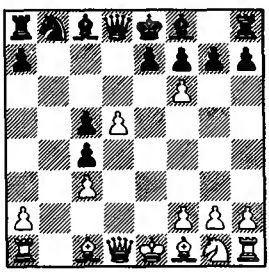


This looks too good to be true. And it is not, indeed. Here is a little background on the theme.

In the old books the diagram po-

sition is evaluated as better to White. The model game was Rashkovsky – Grigorian, URS-ch 1973 which followed with:

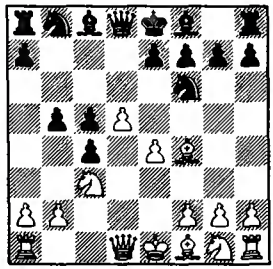
6.e5 b4 7.ef6 bc3 8.bc3 ♘d7 9.♕a4 ef6 10.♗f4 ♕b6 11.♗c4 with a "±" mark. (Actually the game has not proven any advantage – 11...♗d6 12.♘e2 ♗f4 13.♘f4 ♕d6 14.0–0 0–0 15.♗d3 ♘b6 16.♕e4 f5 17.♕f3 c4 18.♗c2 g6 19.♖fd1 ♗b7 20.♕g3 ♖fd8 21.♗f5 ♘d5 22.♘d5 ♗d5 23.♕d6 ♖d6 24.♗c2, ½–½.). The logical conclusion was that Black should anticipate White's manoeuvre by playing 8...♕a5 himself. The game Renet – Semkov, Vrnjacka Banja 1987, saw **8...♕a5** 9.♗d2 ♘d7 10.♗c4 ♘b6 11.♗e2 ef6 12.c4 ♕a4 13.♕b3 ♗d6 14.♘f3 0–0 15.0–0 ♗f5, when White was fine, but he committed a couple of mistakes and lost. The game was published in the Informator and provoked a burst of interest towards this line. It is really very tempting to start fighting for the initiative on move five! Even **8...♕a5** proved to be superfluous, as we can see from the game Ilincic – Hillarp Persson, Batumi 1999:



8...♘d7 9.♕a4 ef6 10.♗f4 ♕b6 11.♗c4 ♗d6 12.♘e2 ♗f4 13.♘f4 ♕d6 14.0–0 0–0 15.♗d3 g6 (a novelty) 16.♖ad1 ♘b6 17.♕e4 ♗f5 18.♕f3 ♗d3 19.♖d3 ♖fe8∓.

Meanwhile White has invented:

6.♗f4!



Now the b5-pawn could be defended by:

B1. 6...a6
B2. 6...♗a6
B3. 6...♕a5!

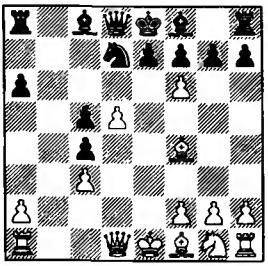
If White completes development, his centre is likely to prevail. Critical for the whole variation in our opinion is 6...♕a5, but the current status of this line favours White.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 c5?! 4.d5! ♘f6 5.♘c3 b5 6.♗f4)

B1. 6...a6 7.e5 b4 8.ef6 bc3 9.bc3

Also interesting is 9.♗c4!? cb2 (9...♕a5! 10.b3 c2 11.♕d2 ♕d2 12.♔d2±) 10.♖b1 ♕b6 11.♘f3 ♕b4 12.♘d2 ♗f5 13.0–0! ♗b1 14.♕g4! ♘d7 (14...♗f5 15.♕f5 ♕b7 16.fe7 ♗e7 17.d6 ♗f6 18.♗d5±)15.fg7 ♗g7 16.♕g7 ♖f8 17.♖b1±, Haba – Putzbach, Hamburg 2003.

9...♘d7



10.♕a4!?

Although White is practically a tempo ahead, compared to the lines with 6.e5 b4, the best set-up for him is not so obvious. Look what happened to Beliavsky in his game against Ehlvest, Belfort 1988: 10.♘f3 ♘b6 11.♗c4 gf6 12.♕b3 ♖g8 13.0–0 ♖g4 14.d6 e6 15.g3 ♘c4 16.♕c4 ♗b7 17.h3 ♖f4⩲ and the bishop pair is very dangerous.

10...ef6 11.♗c4 ♕b6 12.♘f3

White has to be constantly on guard: 12.♘e2 ♗d6 13.♕c6 ♗f4 14.♕a8 0–0 15.♕c6 ♗d2! 16.♔f1 ♕b2∞

12...♗d6 13.♗d3 0-0 14.0-0 ♕c7 15.♗d6 ♕d6±.

B2. 6...♗a6 7.♘f3!

The other options are far from clear. We'll mention 7.e5 b4 8.ef6 bc3 9.bc3 gf6, and now:

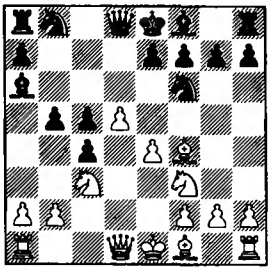
a) 10.♖b1 ♕a5!?

Ponomariov has introduced 10...♗g7 11.♕g4 ♕d5!! 12.♗e2 ♕e4 13.♖b8 ♖b8 14.♗b8 ♕b1 15.♗d1 0–0 16.♗c7 ♖c8 17.♕f4 ♕b7 18.♗a5 ♕b5 19.♗c7 ♕b2 20.♘e2 e5 21.♗e5 fe5 22.♕g4 ♖f8 23.0–0 f5–+, Khalifman – Ponomariov, Neum 2000. Not an improvement was 11.g3 0–0 12.♘e2 ♘d7 13.♕a4 ♘e5 14.♗e5 ♕d5 15.♖g1 fe5 16.♕a6 ♖fd8 17.f3 e4 18.♕b7 Hertneck – Levin, Altenkirchen 2001, 18...♕b7! 19.♖b7 ef3∓.

11.♖b8 ♖b8 12.♗b8 ♕c3 13.♕d2 ♕d2 (13...♕a1=) 14.♔d2 c3 15.♔e1 ♗f1 16.♔f1 ♗h6 17.♘e2 c2 18.♗a7 ♔d7 19.♗c5, Kopylov – Rausis, 2001, 19...♖c8! 20.♗a3 c1♕ 21.♗c1 ♗c1 22.g3=.

b) More promising is 10.g3! ♕a5 (10...♗b7 11.♗c4! e6 12.♖b1! ♗d5 13.♗d5 ed5 14.♗b8 ♖b8 15.♕a4+–) 11.♗g2! ♘d7 (11...♕c3 12.♗d2 ♕b2 13.♘e2 ♘d7 14.♖b1±), Ilincic – A. Horvath, Budapest 2001, when 12.♖c1! ♗b7 13.♘f3 ♘b6 14.♘h4 ♖d8 15.♗c7 ♖d7 16.d6!⩲ gives White an excellent compensation for the pawns. (analysis of Ilincic)

After 7.♘f3 White is ready to push 8.e5, but what about Black?



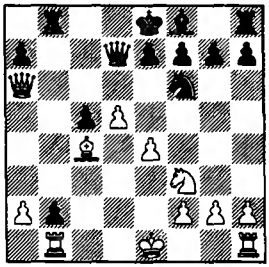
7...b4

Hopeless is 7...e6 12.de6 ♕d1 13.♖d1 fe6 14.♘g5±.

8.♗b8 bc3 9.♕a4 ♕d7 10.♕a6 cb2 11.♖b1 ♖b8 12.♗c4!

After 12.♘e5 ♕c7! 13.♕a4 ♘d7 14.♘c4 g6 15.♕c6 ♔d8 16.♕c7 ♔c7 17.♖b2 ♖b2 18.♘b2 ♗g7 19.♘d1 ♖b8∓

White was struggling to survive in Ivanisevic – Chatalbashev, Antalya 2002.



12...♖b6

What else? 12...♕b7 13.♕a4 ♘d7 14.0–0 offers White a crushing attack, e.g. 14...♕b4 15.♕c6! ♔d8 (15...♕c4 16.♖b2!+–; 15...♕b6 16.♖fd1 e5 17.♖d2±) 16.♗a6! (Completing the immobilisation of the enemy. Premature would be 16.e5? ♕c4 17.e6 ♕b5 18.♖fd1 g6∞) 16...h5 (or 16...c4 17.♖fd1 c3 18.♖d3±) 17.e5 ♕b6 18.e6 ♕c6 19.dc6+–.

13.♕a3 ♘e4

13...♕b7 14.0–0± is not helpful either.

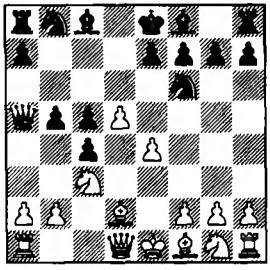
14.♖b2 ♕b7

14...♘d6 fails to 15.♖b6 ab6 16.♘e5 ♕b7 17.♗b5! ♘b5 18.♕a4 ♕d5 19.♕b5 ♔d8 20.0–0 ♕e5 21.♕b6 ♔c8 22.♖d1±.

15.♖b6 ♕b6 16.0-0 f6 17.♕a4 ♔d8 18.d6 e5 19.♗e6 ♕b7 20.♕a5 1-0 P. Nielsen – Karjakin, Hastings 2002.

B3. 6...♕a5! 7.♗d2

A milestone in this variation is the game Gelfand – Anand, Linares 1993: 7.e5 ♘e4 8.♘ge2 ♘a6 9.f3 ♘b4! 10.fe4 ♘d3 11.♔d2 g6!! After 12.b3? ♗g7 Black won a brilliant game. Recent attempts for improvement were not successful too – 12.♔e3 ♗g7 13.g3 g5 14.♗g5 ♗e5↑ Shishkin – Tishin, Simferopol 2003.



7...b4

7...♕d8, hoping for 8.♗f4, fails to 8.♘b5! ♘e4 9.♕a4 ♗d7 10.♗a5 ♗b5 11.♕b5 ♕d7 12.♗c4±.

Alternatively:

7...♘bd7 is a better try, but 8.♘f3 looks in White's favour: 8...b4 9.e5 ♘g4 10.e6↑ or 8...♘g4 9.h3 ♘ge5 10.♘e5 ♘e5 11.♗f4 ♘g6 12.♗e3 ♗b7 (12...e6 13.a4 b4 14.de6 fe6 15.♘b5 ♕b6 16.e5 ♗b7 17.♗c4 ♗g2 18.♖g1 ♖d8 19.♕g4 ♗d5 20.0–0–0±) 13.♗c5 e5 14.♗f8 ♔f8 15.♕d2±.

7...e5 8.de6 fe6 9.e5 ♘fd7 10.♕g4±.

8.e5 bc3

In Van Wely – Azmaiparashvili, Istanbul 2000 was 8...♘g4? 9.e6! ♘f6 10.♗c4! fe6 (Or 10...bc3 11.♗c3 ♕b6 12.♕a4 ♘bd7 13.♘f3±; 10...♗a6 11.♗a6 ♘a6 12.ef7 ♔f7 13.♘ce2 ♘d5 14.♘f3⩲ leads to a ruined kingside) 11.de6! ♗b7 12.♘d5! ♘c6 13.♗b4!+–.

9.♗c3 ♕a6

Similar ideas apply to 9...♕c7 10.ef6 ef6 11.♗c4 ♕d6 (11...♗d6

12.♕e2!? faces Black with the unhappy choice between 12...♔d8 or 12...♔f8 13.♕h5± and inferior ending after 12...♕e7 13.♕e7±). 12.♘e2 ♗e7 13.0–0 0–0 14.♘g3+– ♕f4 15.d6! ♕c4 16.de7 ♖e8 17.♕f3 ♕a6 18.♘h5! 1–0 Sherbakov – Shaginjan, St. Petersburg 1999.

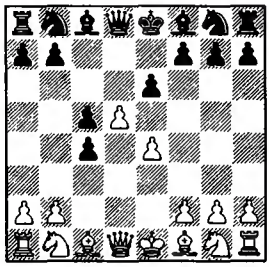
10.ef6 ef6 11.b3 ♗e7 12.♗c4 ♕d6 13.♘e2 0-0 14.0-0 f5 15.♕d3

Shirov created a masterpiece against Kramnik in Linares 1993 after 15.♖e1 ♘d7 16.♘g3 g6 17.♖e7!? ♕e7, but calm analysis showed that Black had sufficient defence.

15...g6 16.♗d2 ♗f6 17.♗f4 ♗e5 18.♗e5 ♕e5 19.♘c3 ♖d8 20.♖fe1 ♕f6 21.♕e3 ♘d7 22.♘a4 ♗b7 23.♕e7 ♖ac8, Lempert – Bukhman, St. Petersburg, 1993. **24.♗b5!+–** (instead of 24.♖ad1±) would have decided the game faster.

Conclusion

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 c5?! enjoyed a 10-years period of glory, but nowadays Black is struggling. 4.♘f3?! is totally harmless, but 4.d5! ♘f6 5.♘c3 b5 6.♗f4! gives White hopes to punish the provocative play of Black. Practice after 6...♕a5 7.♗d2! or 6...♗a6 7.♘f3! has been sad for the second player. 6...a6 7.e5 b4 8.ef6 bc3 9.bc3 ♘d7 10.♕a4± is playable, but who would willingly go for such a position?!



(D20)

5.♘c3 ed5

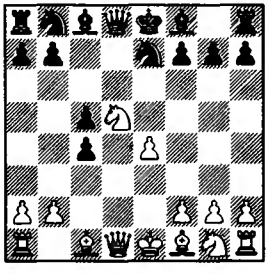
In this variation Black is a bit cramped anyway, but there is no reason to offer White additional possibilities. 5...♘f6 allows 6.♘f3 ed5 7.e5! which is another cause of concern for Black – see Chapter 23 line A, or 6.♗c4! ed5 7.♘d5 ♘d5 8.♗d5, transposing to the main line.

6.♘d5

We do not see any reason to play 6.ed5, e.g. 6...♗d6 7.♗c4 a6 8.a4 ♘f6 9.♕e2 ♕e7 10.♕e7 ♔e7 11.♘ge2 ♖e8 12.♗g5 h6 13.♗h4 ♘bd7 14.0–0=, Volkov – Maljutin, Samara 2000.

6...♘e7

White should meet 6...♘f6 with 7.♗c4 ♗e7!? 8.♘e2 0–0 9.♗f4! ♘c6 10.♘c7 ♖b8 11.♕d8 ♖d8 12.♘d5 ♖a8 13.0–0–0±. Of course, Black can return to the main line by taking on d5.



7.♗c4

It is not surprising that 7.♗g5 h6 8.♗f6 ♘d7 is seldom seen. 9.♗c4 (9.♕a4 is innocuous, e.g. 9...b5 10.♕b5 ♖b8 11.♕a4 ♗b7 12.♗c4 ♗d5 13.♗e7 ♗e7 14.♗d5=) 9...gf6 10.♘f6 ♘f6 11.♗f7 ♔f7 12.♕d8 leads to a position where White has a queen and pawn(s) for 3 minor pieces and Black's king has no shelter. If you ask the chip to evaluate the situation, it will insist on White's edge. Organic players, however, prefer a clear space advantage to the irrational complications after 12...♘c6 13.♕c7 ♗e7 14.♘e2 ♘e4 15.♖d1 ♖g8 16.0–0.

7...♘d5 8.♗d5 ♗e7

Here, White has the pleasant choice between:

A. 9.♘e2

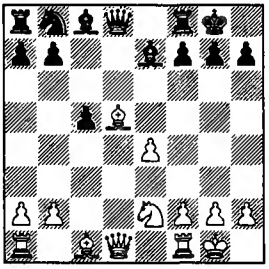
B. 9.♘f3

In both cases his dominance in the centre makes his play much easier. 9.♕h5 0-0 10.♘f3 ♘d7∞ is not impressive.

A. 9.♘e2!? 0–0 10.0–0

Basically Black has 2 plans. The one is to chase the d5-bishop with his knight by means of ♘a6-♘c7 or

♘d7-♘f6. The other one consists in developing the knight to c6, heading for d4. The neutralisation of the ♗d5 is left to the light-squared bishop (by ♗e6), accepting a weak pawn on e6. Here are some examples:



10...♘d7 11.♘c3± ♘b6 12.♗f4 ♗f6 (12...♗g5 13.♗d6 ♗e7 14.e5!±) 13.e5!? ♗e7 (13...♘d5 14.♘d5 ♗g5 (14...♗e7 15.e6!±) 15.♗g5 ♕g5 16.f4!±) 14.♗e4! ♕d1 15.♖fd1±, Khalifman –Vulfson, St Petersburg 1995, notes by Khalifman.

10...♕b6 11.♗e3± (11.♘f4 ♘c6 12.♗c4 ♕d8 13.♘d5 ♗d6 14.f4 ♖e8 15.♕d3 ♗e6 16.♗e3 a6 17.a4 ♘b4□ 18.♘b4 ♗c4 19.♕c4 cb4± Sakaev – Vaulin, Moscow 1998) 11...♘c6 12.♕d2 ♗e6 13.♘f4 ♘e5 14.b4 ♕b4 15.♕b4 cb4 16.♘e6 fe6 17.♗e6 ♔h8 18.f4± Granda Zuniga – Gendler, Erevan 1996.

10...♘a6 11.♗f4 ♘c7 12.♘c3 ♘d5 13.♘d5 ♗d6 14.e5 ♗b8

14...♗c7 loses the exchange after 15.e6 ♗f4 16.e7 ♗h2 17.♔h1 ♕d6 18.ef8♕ ♔f8 19.♕h5 ♗e6 20.♖ad1 ♗e5 21.♘c3 ♗d4 22.♘b5 ♕e5 23.♕h7 ♖d8 24.♘d4 cd4 25.♖fe1±, Pelletier – Krizsany, Bad Woerishofen, 2001.

15.♕b3 ♗e6 16.♖ad1 b6 17.♗g3!

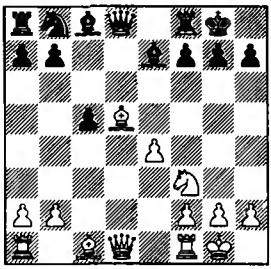
17.♕f3 ♗d5 18.♖d5 ♕e8 19.♖fd1 f6 20.♕b3 ♕e6=.

17...♗c7 18.f4 ♗d5 19.♖d5 ♕e7 20.f5 ♖ad8 21.♖fd1 ♖d5 22.♖d5 ♖d8 23.♕d3 ♖d5 24.♕d5 h6 25.♗f4±.

Black is paralysed and can only wait, while White's king is coming to the centre. We have been following the game A. Greenfeld – Gyimesi, Tel Aviv 2001. We chose it as a model because White's plan is universal in this pawn structure and also because as Black was the prominent adept of this variation Zoltan Gyimesi, who certainly knows what should be avoided.

(3.e4 c5?! 4.d5 e6 5.♘c3 ed5 6.♘d5 ♘e7 7.♗c4 ♘d5 8.♗d5 ♗e7)

B. 9.♘f3 0–0 10.0–0



B1. 10...♘d7
B2. 10...♕b6
B3. 10...♘a6

B1. 10...♘d7 11.♕e2 ♘b6 12.♗b3

White should preserve the light-squared bishop for a while. Otherwise Black has more chances for successful defence: 11.♗e3 ♘f6 12.♕d2 ♘d5 13.ed5 ♗d6 14.♖fe1

♕c7 15.h3 ♗f5 16.♖ac1 ♖ac8 17.b4 b6 18.bc5 bc5 19.♖c4 ♖fe8 20.♖ec1 ♕e7 21.♕c3 ♗e4 22.♘g5 ♗f5 23.♘f3 ♗e4 24.♗c5 ♗f3 25.♗d6 ♖c4 26.♕c4 ♕g5 27.♗g3 ♗d5 28.♕c5 ½–½ Manor – Lev, Bern 1990.

12...♗g4 13.♗e3

13.♗f4!? ♗f6 (13...♖c8 14.h3±) 14.♖ad1 ♗d4 15.h3 ♗f3 16.♕f3± is good too.

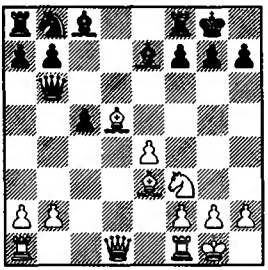
13...♖c8 14.♖ac1 ♕e8 15.♖fd1 ♕c6 16.h3 ♗h5 17.♗d5!

Black's bishop has lost control of the central square and White is going to capitalise on that. The retreat 17.♗c2 led to equality: 17...♕e6 18.b3 ♗g6 19.♘d2 f5!=, Ehlvest – Spangenberg, Villa Martelli 1997.

17...♘d5 18.♖d5 ♗f3 19.♕f3 ♕e6 20.♖cd1 b6 21.♗f4 ♖fd8 22.b3±.

Perhaps Black could hold this position but who would like to be in his shoes?!

B2. 10...♕b6 11.♗e3



11...♘c6

11...♗e6 is more consistent, but it encounters 12.b4!±♗d5 (2...♖d8?! 13.♗c5 or 13.bc5!?±) 13.bc5 (a pleasant alternative is 13.♕d5 ♕b4 14.♖ab1 ♕a4 15.♖b7 ♘c6 16.♘e5 ♘e5 17.♖e7±) 13...♕c7 14.ed5 ♗c5 15.♖c1 ♘a6 16.d6 ♕b6 17.♖c5 ♘c5 18.♕d5 ♖ac8 19.d7 ♖c6 20.♘e5 1–0 Heinig – Berndt, 1992.

11...♘a6!? is not easy to refute: 12.♘e5 ♘c7 (12...♕b2?? 13.♗f7 ♖f7 14.♕d5+–) 13.♗b3 ♕b4! 14.♕c2 ♗e6 15.♘c4!? ♕b5 (15...♗c4 16.♗c4 b5 17.♗e2 ♘e6 18.a3 ♘d4 19.♗d4 ♕d4 20.♗b5 ♖ab8 21.a4±) 16.f4 ♕c6, when Milov's suggestion 17.♘e5± ensures a slight edge.

12.♖c1.

Known games are quite worthless for a meaningful answer to the simple question "how to play with White after 12...♗e6, 12...♘b4 or even 12...♗g4". Let's see the list of options:

B2a. 12...♗e6; B2b. 12...♘b4; B2c. 12...♕b2; B2d. 12...♗g4;

B2a. 12...♗e6 13.a3!?

The thematic 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♕c2 ♘b4 15.♕b3 ♖ad8 16.♘g5 ♗g5 17.♗c5 ♕a6 18.♗b4 ♗c1 19.♗f8 ♗b2 20.♗e7 ♖d7 21.♕b2 ♖e7 22.♖d1 ♖f7 23.h3 ♕a4 24.♖d8 ♖f8 25.♖d4 ♕c6 26.e5± leads to an ending where White still keeps a slight initiative.

13...a5

Taking measures against the threat b4, since 13...♖fd8 is outright bad: 14.b4 ♕a6 15.bc5 ♕a3 16.♖a1 ♕c3 17.♕b1±.

14.♗e6 fe6 15.♕c2

The interpolation of 13.a3 a5 made this attack possible.

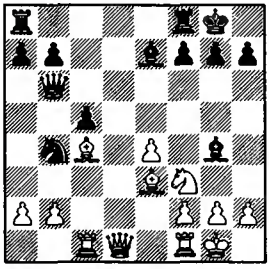
15...♖ac8 16.♗c5 ♗c5 17.♕c5±.

B2b. 12...♘b4 13.♗c4!

13.♕a4 allows 13... ♖d8!=.

13...♗g4

Black is struggling after 13...♗e6 14.♕b3! (14.♗e6 ♕e6 15.♗c5 ♘a2 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♖c4 is not convincing) 14...♗c4 15.♕c4 ♖fd8 16.♗c5 ♗c5 17.♕c5 ♕c5 18.♖c5 ♘a2 19.♖c7 ♖ab8 20.♘g5 ♖dc8 21.♖d7±. Despite mass elimination, a rook on the seventh rank is a major plus.



14.h3 ♖ad8 15.♕e2 ♗e6 16.♗e6 fe6 17.♖cd1 ♘a2 18.♘e5 ♖d1

White has more than sufficient compensation for the pawn because Black's pieces are unco-ordinated: 18...♕c7 19.f4±; 18...♗d6 19.♗g5! ♗e5 20.♗d8 ♖d8 21.♖d8 ♕d8 22.♕c4± with a double attack.

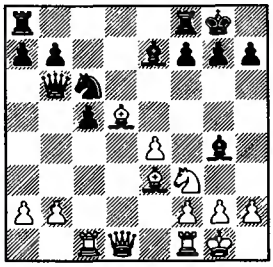
19.♖d1 ♖d8 20.♖d8 ♕d8 21.♕c4 ♕d6 22.♘d3±;

B2c. 12...♕b2 13.♗c5 ♗c5 14.♖c5 ♕b6

14...♗g4 15.♕c1±.

15.♕c2 ♗d7 16.♖b1 ♕c7 17.♘e5 ♖ac8 18.♕b2 Sorin – Cifuentes Parada, Capablanca mem. 1995. The pin will cost Black sooner or later a pawn, e.g. **18...♕d6** 19.♘d7 ♕d7 20.♖bc1 ♖c7 21.e5 ♖cc8 22.f4 ♘e7 23.♕b7 ♖c5 24.♖c5!±.

B2d. 12...♗g4



13.h3

13.♗c6 guarantees a stable advantage after 13...♗f3 (13...♕c6 14.♘e5 ♗d1 15.♘c6 bc6 16.♖fd1±; 13...bc6 14.♕c2 ♗f3 15.gf3±) 14.♕d7! ♗e2 (14...♕c6 15.♕c6 bc6 16.gf3±; 14...bc6 15.gf3±) 15.♖fe1 ♗a6 16.♕e7 ♕c6 17.♗c5±, Sorin – D. Lima, Matanzas 1995.

13...♗e6

13...♗f3 accepts a slightly worse position since Black gets a worse version of line B2a, for White has an extra flight-square on h2.

14.♗e6

14.a3!? is also good: 14...♖ad8 15.b4 ♕a6 16.bc5 ♕a3 17.♖a1 ♕c3 18.♕b1±.

14...fe6 15.♕c2 ♕a6?!

Better was 15...♘b4!? 16.♕b3 ♖ad8 17.♘g5 ♗g5 18.♗c5 ♕a6 19.♗f8 ♘d3 20.♖c4 ♔f8 21.♖d1 ♘f4 22.♖d8 ♗d8 23.♖c8±.

16.♗c5 ♗c5 17.♕c5 ♕a2 18.♕b5 a6 19.♕b7 ♘a5 20.♕c7 ♖f7 21.♕e5 ♘b7 22.♘g5 ♖e7 23.♖c7 ♖c7 24.♕c7 ♕b2 25.e5 ♕b3 26.♕f7 ♔h8 27.♘e6 ♖g8 28.♘d8 1–0 Ibragimov – Estrada Nieto, Ubeda 1997.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 c5?! 4.d5 e6

5.♘c3 ed5 6.♘d5 ♘e7 7.♗c4 ♘d5 8.♗d5 ♗e7 9.♘f3 0–0 10.0–0)

B3. 10...♘a6 11.♗b3!?

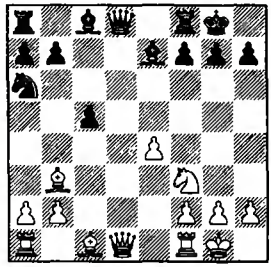
White has many other possibilities. Which one to choose is probably a matter of taste, for instance:

11.♗e3 ♘c7 12.♗b3 ♗e6 13.♗e6 ♘e6 14.♕a4 ♕e8 15.♕c4 b5 16.♕c2 a6 17.♖ad1 ♖d8 18.♖d5 ♕c6 19.♖fd1 ♕c7 20.a4± Peters – Nemeth, Budapest, 1991.

11.♕e2 ♕b6 (11...♘c7 12.♗f4 ♘d5 13.ed5 ♗d6±) 12.♘e5 ♘c7 13.♗f4 ♕f6 14.♗g3 ♘d5 15.ed5 ♗d6 16.♖fe1 ♗f5 17.♕b5! b6 18.♖e3 a6 19.♕e2 ♖ae8 20.♖e1 b5 21.♘c6± Vyzmanavin – Ibragimov, St. Petersburg 1993.

11.♗f4 ♘c7 12.♗c7 (12.♖e1 ♘d5 13.ed5 ♗d6 14.♗d6 ♕d6 15.♘e5 b6= Milov – Afek, Tel Aviv 1993; 12.♗c4 ♗e6 13.♗e2 ♘e8 14.♕c2 h6∞). 12...♕c7 13.h3 ♕b6 14.♕c2 ♗e6 15.♖ad1 ♖ad8 16.b3 ♗d5 17.ed5 ♗f6 Romanishin – Gyimesi, Balatonbereny 1995. In view of the space advantage, White's play is easier, but nevertheless the position should be evaluated as equal.

With 11.♗b3 White demonstrated his intention to swap queens. The only way to avoid it is 11...♕b6, but then the placement of Black's knight on the edge of the board allows 12.♘e5 ♗e6 13.♘d7 ♗d7 14.♕d7 ♗f6 15.♕f5 g6 16.♕f3 ♗g7 17.♖d1 ♖ad8 18.♗g5±. So Black is proceeding with the knight's walk:



11...♘c7 12.♕d8 ♖d8

12...♗d8 (Gyimesi) is no improvement due to 13.♗e3 b6 14.♖ad1 ♗f6 (14...♗b7 15.♘e5 ♗e4 16.♖d7 ♗g6 17.♘g6 hg6 18.♖fd1 ♘e6 19.♗d5±) 15.e5 ♗e7 16.♗g5!?±.

13.♗f4 ♘e6 14.♗g3! ♗f6!?

14...♗d7 15.♗d5 ♗c6 16.♖ad1 ♗f6 17.♗c6 bc6 18.♗e5 ♗e5 19.♘e5 ♘d4 20.f3 ♖ab8 21.b3±.

14...♘d4 15.♘d4 ♖d4 16.♗d5.

15.♘e5! ♔f8

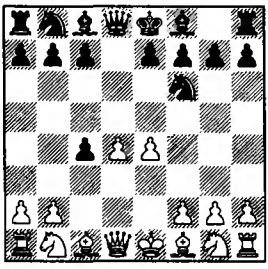
15...♖d2!? 16.♖ab1!? ♗e5 17.♗e5 ♘d4 18.♗d5±.

16.f4!±

Suddenly White reminds that even without queens, his attack on the enemy king could be very dangerous. In Atalik – Gyimesi, Vrnjacka Banja 1998 Black failed to resolve the problems. (Notes by Atalik).

Conclusion

The variation 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 c5?! 4.d5 e6 is often underestimated by White players and in tournaments they are not very convincing. Of course White gets an initial advantage with his bishop proudly nailed on d5, but without a precise and well thought-over plan for deployment, his initiative is bound to disappear. A natural and promising development for White is seen in A. 9.♘e2!? when further ♘c3 and ♗f4 provide a lasting space advantage.



3...♘f6 is nearly as popular as 3...e5 and certainly more promising if you want to impose sharp play without going for broke.

This variation has one major drawback. Black concedes a significant space advantage to the enemy. The strong centre of White allows him to escape with less casualties after some mistake. Black risks more. If you are confident in your home preparation and like double-edged positions, this variation would be a good choice.

4.e5

If White is afraid of deep waters and tries to simplify play, he risks to become even worse after 4.♘c3 e5 5.♘f3 ed4 6.♕d4 ♗d6!? or 5.d5 b5!?

4...♘d5 5.♗c4

A. 5...♘c6
B. 5...♘b6

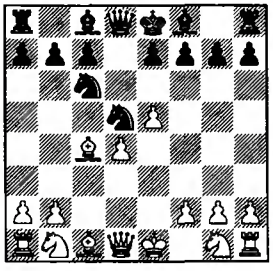
An interesting (albeit dubious) attempt to transpose to the Classical variation (3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3) is 5...e6 6.♘f3 a6 7.0–0 (7.a4) b5 8.♗d3 ♗b7 9.♘c3 (9.♗g5!?) c5 10.♘e4 cd4 11.♗g5 ♕b6∞.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘f6

(D20)

A. 5...♘c6

A tricky move, which aims to avoid dangerous lines after 5...♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6 7.♗e3!? – see Chapter 8. Our opinion is that the cure is worse than the disease. White obtains additional possibilities to fight for the initiative.



6.♘c3

6.♘e2!? might be objectively White's best option. Then 6...♗f5 7.a3 could save a tempo since the bishop would retreat directly to a2. So Black usually transposes to the 5...♘b6-line with 6...♘b6. More enterprising is **6.♗e3!?**, invitating Black to switch to the main path after 6...♘b6 7.♗d3. However, Black can afford to be obstinate – 6...♗f5! when 7.♘c3 e6 8.♗d5 ed5 is hardly a refutation of Black's set-up.

6...♘b6

6..♗e6 7.♗b5 ♘c3 8.bc3 ♕d5 is dubious due to 9.♗e2.

7.♗b5

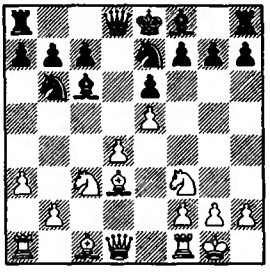
In a blitz game Dreev imperturbably played 7.♗d3?!! and Nikolic thought it wiser to refrain from snatching the d4-pawn! Who knows what could have happened?!

7...♗d7 8.♘f3 e6

8...a6 9.♗d3 ♗g4 10.♗e4 e6 11.0–0 ♗e7 12.♗e3 ♗h5 (12...0–0 13.♕b1!?) 13.d5 ♘e5 14.de6 ♕d1 15.♖fd1 ♘f3 16.gf3 fe6 17.♗b7 ♖b8 18.♗c6 ♔f7 19.b3±, Glek – Kozlov, Frunze 1988.

9.0–0

We all know from the textbooks that tempi should be cherished in the opening, but too often we do not adhere to the rules, mislead by some superfinesse, which seems of primary importance. In a number of games White played the "crafty" 9.a3 only to steer the black knight to a better path: 9...♘e7! 10.♗d3 ♗c6 11.0–0



11...♘f5!?

Black is willing to take risks. Quiter is 11...♘g6 (the untimely 11...♕d7 allowed White to seize the initiative with 12.♘e4 ♘g6 13.h4 0–0–0 14.g3 ♕d5 15.h5 f5 16.ef6± Topalov – Sadler Monte Carlo 1998 blind) 12.♗e3 and now 12...♕d7 intending ♖d8, ♗e7 looks playable for Black.

12.♗f5!? ef5 13.e6 fe6 14.♖e1

Or 14.♘e5 g6 15.♘c6 bc6 16.♖e1 ♔f7 17.♗f4 ♗d6 18.♕f3 ♗f4 19.♕f4 ♕d6=.

14...♗e7 15.♘e5 0–0 16.♘c6 bc6 17.♖e6 ♗d6 18.♕f3 ♕d7 19.♖e1 ♖ae8= Dreev – Fominyh, RUS-Team Smolensk 2000.

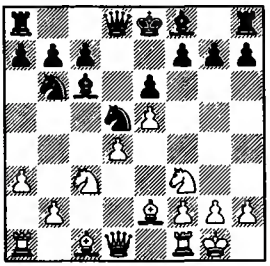
9...♘b4

9...♘e7 is an interesting and nearly unexplored line. At first sight White could seize the opportunity to retreat the bishop to a more active position by 10.♗d3, but then 10...♗c6 would leave open the option of ...♘f5. The attempt to start an attack then with 11.♘g5?! would run into 11...h6 12.♕h5 g6 13.♘ge4 f5 14.♘f6 ♔f7∞, while 11.♖e1 is not too appealing. 10.♗e2 will hardly transpose to the main line as Black's knight might land on f5. Perhaps White should try to provoke some weakness on the queenside by 10.a4!? a5 and now 11.♘e4, (or 11.♕b3 ♗b5 12.ab5 ♘ed5 13.♘e4) when 11...♗b5 12.ab5 ♘f5 13.♗d2 underlines the vulnerability of the a5-pawn.

10.♗e2

After 10...♗e7 White can complete the redeployment of his forces: 11.a3 ♘4d5 12.♘e4 ♗c6 13.♕c2 h6 14.♗d3 a6 15.♘c5 ♗c5 16.dc5 ♘d7 17.♖e1 ♘e7 18.♗e4 0–0 19.♗d2 ♗d5 20.♖ad1↑ Gavrikov – Brunner, Biel 1995.

10...♗c6 11.a3 ♘4d5



12.♕c2!

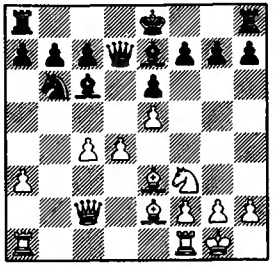
The road junction in White's set-up is the e4-square. Once the knight gets there, it can be directed either towards Black's castling position, or to the sensitive point c5. Unfortunately, immediate **12.♘e4** meets 12...♘f4! (exploiting the fact that the knight is unprotected) 13.♗f4 ♗e4 14.♘g5 ♗g6 (preventing 15.♗h5!) 15.♗f3 ♖b8 (15...♘d5 16.♗d2 ♗e7 17.♘e4 0–0 18.♕b3 ♖b8 19.♖ac1±/=) 16.♕c1 c6!?=. White still possesses more space, but the trade of knights balanced the otherwise overloaded Black's construction and levelled the chances. Similar ideas pursues **12.♗d3** ♕d7! 13.♘e4. After 13...♗b5 14.♖e1 ♗d3 15.♕d3 a6 White practically lost a tempo in futile manoeuvring with his light-squared bishop only to swap it eventually. 16.♗d2 ♕b5 17.♕c2 ♕c4 18.♖ac1 ♕c2 ½–½ Khalifman – Sadler, BL 1998.

Direct assault by 12.♗d3 ♕d7 **13.♘g5** h6 14.♕h5 g6 does not earn White the edge after 15.♗g6 (15.♕h3!? 0–0–0 16.♘ge4∞) 15...hg5 16.♕h8 fg6 17.♗g5 ♕f7 18.♘e4 ♔d7 19.♕h4 ♖e8 20.f3 ♔c8 21.♖ae1 ♔b8 22.g4 ♗g7 23.♕g3 ♖f8 24.♖f2 ♘c8 25.h4 ♘ce7 26.♗d2 ♗d7 27.♘g5 ♕e8=, Volkov – Fominyh RUS-ch 2000.

12...♘c3

Giving White a dynamic pawn structure in the centre. Black should have maintained the tension with 12...♕d7 13.♘e4 ♗b5 although White's space advantage cannot be completely neutralised by only one perfect piece as the d5-knight. 14.♘c5 ♕c6 (14...♗c5 15.dc5 ♗e2 16.♕e2 ♘c8 17.♗d2±) 15.b4 ♗e2 16.♕e2 a6 17.♗d2±.

13.bc3 ♗e7 14.♗e3 ♕d7 15.c4±

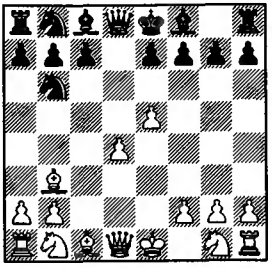


White will soon stage up the break d4-d5, as in Sakaev – A. Mikhalchishin JUG-chT Budva, 2002.

(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4)

B. 5...♘b6 6.♗b3

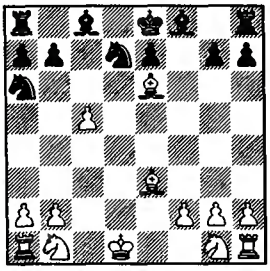
6.♗d3 is the subject of Chapter 8.



6...♘c6

6...♗f5 is not of independent significance. Play soon transposes to the main lines, except the case when Black develops his knight to a6, which is hardly a good place. The only possible reason for this move order could be to avoid analytical dispute in the line 6...♘c6 7.♘f3 ♗g4 8.♗f7 which is not without venom – see B1.

The game Karpov – Short, Candidates sf1 Linares (5), 1992 produced a remarkably early novelty – **6...c5!?** The ex-champion chose the natural 7.dc5 ♕d1 8.♔d1 ♘6d7 9.e6 fe6 10.♗e6 ♘a6 11.c6 bc6 12.♗e3 ♘c7! and the bishop pair is really powerful. Although all the commentators pointed out 11.♗e3 as an improvement, no one was able to present a convincing evidence for White being better.

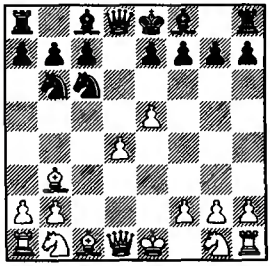


This position looks pretty drawish to us. The game M. Zeuner – A. Breier, Germany, 1995 is the only example. It went on 11...♘ac5 12.♗c4 ♘e5 13.♗b5 ♗d7 14.♗d7 ♘cd7 15.♘c3 ♘g4 16.♘f3 ♘e3 17.fe3 g6 18.♘d5 0–0–0 19.♔e2 ♘f6 20.♖ac1 ♔b8 21.♘f4 ♗h6 22.h3=. Although the play of both sides could be improved, we suspect that White should look for new ideas earlier, perhaps on the eighth move. Rybka likes 8.♗d1 ♘6d7 9.♘c3, but it is not tested at all.

At first, the game Notkin – Suetin, USSR 1994 seemed to offer a promising direction: **7.d5!?** c4 8.♗a4 ♗d7 9.♗c2 e6 10.d6 ♗c6 11.♘f3 ♘8d7 12.♘bd2 g6, when 13.♗e4± would have been slightly better.

Then I found the correspondence game Kartik – Rukshad, WCCF E-mail 2001, which improved with 9...g6 10.♘c3 ♗g7 11.♗f4 0–0 12.♘f3 ♗g4 13.h3 ♗f3 14.♕f3 ♘8d7∞.

One reason or another, Black has been avoiding this variation lately.



Main options are:
B1. 7.♘f3
B2. 7.♗e3
B3. 7.♘e2

Aside from 7.♘f3, which stands up as an independent variation, but is rarely seen, the other two moves commonly lead to the same positions. In line B2 I'll examine only some specific for 7.♗e3 variations, connected with the pawn sac on e6.

(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗b3 ♘c6)

B1. 7.♘f3 ♗g4

Black has no way back. If he wanted to avoid the complications following ♗g4, he should have played 6...♗f5. Now it is already late for this move. You may read in some sources that 7...♗f5? deserved attention, although the following game had said it all: **7...♗f5?** 8.d5! ♘a5 (8...♗b1 9.♖b1 ♘a5 10.♗a4 c6 11.b4! ♘ac4 12.dc6 ♕d1 13.♗d1 bc6 14.e6 f6 15.a4 ♘d5 16.♗e2±) 9.♘c3 ♘b3 10.♕b3 ♗d3 11.e6! f6 12.♗e3 ♗c4 13.♕b4 a5 (13...♗d5 14.0–0–0 c6 15.♘d5 ♘d5 16.♕b7 ♕c8 17.♕c8 ♖c8 18.♗a7±) 14.♕c5 ♕d6 15.♕d6 ed6 16.♗b6 cb6 17.b3 ♗a6 18.♘a4±, Kouatly – Semkov, Burgas 1985. Post-mortem analysis only confirmed the final diagnosis.

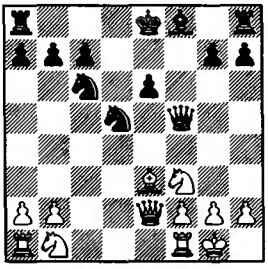
8.♗f7

If you opt for the "spectacular" 8.♘g5 ♗d1 9.♗f7, draw, you'll hardly get the brilliance prize.

8...♔f7 9.♘g5 ♔e8 10.♕g4 ♕d4 11.♕e2 ♕e5 12.♗e3 ♘d5

Black should keep the knights, since they cement his centre – 12...♘d4? 13.♗d4 ♕g5 14.0–0 ♖d8 15.♗b6! ab6 16.♘c3±.

13.♘f3 ♕f5 14.0-0 e6



This variation reached its peak of popularity in the late 80-s and has gradually disappeared from tournaments. Probably the last Mohican is Chris Ward, but he also seems discouraged. White's position is very appealing at the surface, but when things come to "move by move" routine, eventually it all ends in a draw ending. There is no forced sequence and it is quite possible that White could come up with some very tricky move order which would allow him to retain the initiative. We'll confine to some examples.

15.♘c3

Similar ideas pursues 15.♗d2!? ♗d6 16.♖e1 ♖f8 (We can imagine how much Black wanted to castle!) 17.♘c3!? ♘c3 18.♗c3 ♖f7

Or 18...♔f7 19.♘g5 ♔g8 20.♘e6 ♖ae8 (20...♖f7 21.♕c4 ♕f2 22.♔h1 ♕f5 23.♘g7↑) 21.♕c4 ♘e5 22.♖e5 ♗e5 23.♘f8 ♔f8 24.♕c5 ♔g8 25.g3±.

19.b4↑ – Chris Ward. White certainly should not lose this position while Black still has some way to go before claiming the same.

15...♖d8 16.♖fe1

Black's king felt quite comfortably in the middle after 16.♘b5 ♗d6 17.♖ae1 ♘e3 18.fe3 ♖f8=, Moskalenko – Borges Mateos, Belgorod 1990.

16...♗e7 17.♗d2 ♘c3 18.♗c3

There is no venom in 18.bc3 ♖d6 19.♖ab1 b6 20.♖b5 ♕d3 21.♕d3 ♖d3 22.♖e6 ♔d7 23.♖e3 ♖e3 24.♗e3 ♗f6 25.c4 ♘a5 26.♘d2=, Seirawan – Speelman, Saint John 1988/Candidates.

18...♔f7 19.♕c4 ♗f6 20.♖e3 ♖he8!

It is never late to reserve a place in the books: 20...♗c3 21.♘g5!! ♔g6 22.♕c3+–, Alburt – Gulko, Somerset, 1986

21.♖ae1 ♕d5=.

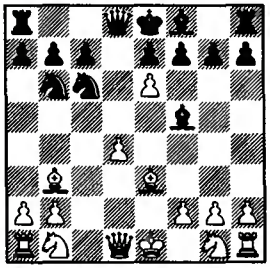
(3. e4 ♘f6 4. e5 ♘d5 5. ♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗b3 ♘c6)

B2. 7.♗e3

Karpov often uses this particular moveorder. The obvious reason is to prevent Black from developing his bishop to g4, which is possible to 7.♘e2. I cannot think of some serious drawback of 7.♗e3 compared to 7.♘e2

7...♗f5 8.e6

8.♘e2 e6 9.♘bc3 ♗e7 or 9...♕d7 transposes to line B3.

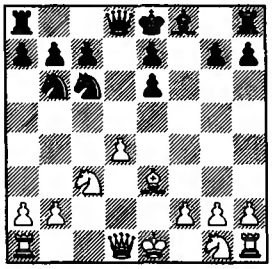


Every 5-10 years appears a candidate to test this pawn sacrifice. It requires the knight to be developed to f3, so 7.♗e3 is an indispensable lead-in. The same idea is possible in other move sequences, often leading to transpositions, e.g. 6...♗f5 7.e6 with unclear evaluation and contradictory results.

8...♗e6

8...fe6 9.♘f3 ♕d7 10.♘c3 h6 11.♖c1→ turned well for White in Mamedyarov – Mannion, Plovdiv 2003: 11...0–0–0 12.♘b5 a6? 13.♖c6+–.

9.♗e6 fe6 10.♘c3



10...g6!

Or 10...♕d7 11.♘f3 0–0–0 12.0–0 h6 13.b4 ♘d5 14.♘e4⩱ Bronstein – Lukin, Yaroslav, 1982.

11.♘f3 ♗g7 12.0-0 ♕d7 13.♕b3 0-0-0

In the game Radjabov – Shirov, rap. Tallinn 2004 Black chose to castle kingside, but White maintained the initiative after 13...♘a5 14.♕c2 ♘ac4 15.♘e4 0–0 16.♘c5 ♕d5 17.b3 ♘d6, when instead of 8.♕e2 ♖f5 19.♖ad1 ♖af8 20.♖fe1 ♖f3! 21.gf3 ♘f5⩱ he could have opened the play by 18.♘g5!? e5 19.de5↑.

14.♘g5 ♖de8 15.a4 ♘d5 16.♖fd1 ♔b8 17.♘ce4 ♘a5 18.♕d3⩱ Karsa – Schrancz, Hungary 1985.

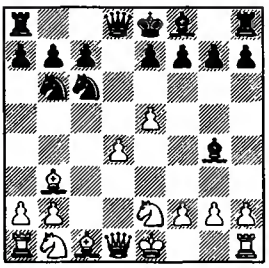
(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗b3 ♘c6)

B3. 7.♘e2 ♗f5

An interesting alternative is:

7...♗g4!?

If it proves reliable, White should probably reconsider his move order in favour of 7.♗e3.



The fine point of Black's manoeuvre is to deprive the opponent's e3-bishop of pawn support after 8.f3 ♗f5. That changes significantly White's plans. He is unable to keep the bishop on e3 when a knight lands on d5. So White should be ready either to destroy any Black's knight that passes through d5, or completely renounce the fight for this square, occupying c5 instead. Practice has shown that if Black follows common developing plans, White enjoys a space advantage, e.g. 9.♘bc3 e6 10.0–0 ♕d7 11.♗e3 ♘b4 12.♘e4 ♘4d5 13.♗f2 ♗e7 14.♖c1 0–0 15.♘c5 ♕c8 16.♕d2, Kisseleva – Semenova, Kishinev 1995. Or 9.♘bc3 e6 10.0–0 ♕d7 11.♗e3 0–0–0 12.♖c1 ♔b8 13.♘a4 ♘b4 14.♘ec3 ♘6d5 15.♘d5 ♘d5 16.♗d5 ♕d5 17.♘c3 ♕a5 18.♕e2, Epishin – Jonkman, Bratto 2004.

The game Stefanova – Harikrishna, Catalan Bay 2004 however presented a new idea which seems vital although Black eventually lost. 8.f3 ♗f5 9.♘bc3 e6 10.0–0 ♘a5!? Black trades light-squared bishops, imposes a blockade on d5 and castles short. 11.♗c2 ♗c2 12.♕c2 ♘c6!? 13.♗e3 ♘b4 14.♕b3 ♗e7 15.a3 ♘4d5 16.♗f2 Everything went smoothly, but here, instead of castling, Black released the blockade and got punished: 16...♘c3 (16...0-0) 17.♘c3 0–0 18.d5!↑

Perhaps White should refrain from 8.f3 in favour of:

8.♘bc3!?

This keeps White's options open. Later he'll decide whether to play f3 or not.

8...e6 9.0–0 ♕d7

The attempt to impose full control over d5 by 9...♘b4 encounters 10.h3 ♗h5 11.f4 ♗g6 (or 11...♗e2 12.♕e2 ♕d4 13.♗e3 ♕d3 14.♕f2 ♘6d5 15.♘d5 ♘d5 16.♗d5 ♕d5 17.♖ac1±) 12.d5! ♕d7 13.de6 ♗c5 14.♔h2 fe6 15.♕d7 ♔d7 16.♖d1 ♘4d5 17.♗d5 ♘d5 18.b4 ♗b4 19.♘d5 ed5 20.♖d5 ♔c6 21.♖d1 ♗c5 22.♗b2 ♖ad8 23.♗d4↑, Adianto – Barua, Dubai 1992.

10.h3

White still could return to 10.♗e3!? followed by 11.f3.

10...♗e2?!

10...♗f5 is better, but that needs testing.

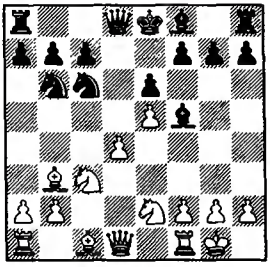
11.♘e2 ♗e7 12.♗e3 ♘b4 13.♘g3! 0–0–0 (At least avoiding the attack after 13...0–0 14.♕g4→) 14.♕e2 ♘4d5 15.♘e4 ♔b8 16.♖ad1 h5 17.a3 with White's initiative in Topalov – Ponomariov FIDE-Wch k.o. Las Vegas, 1999.

Now back to the main line:

8.♘bc3 e6

Most players prefer to put in 9.a3 at this moment, but it is by no means obligatory.

9.0-0



B3a. 9...♗e7; B3b. 9...♕d7

Black has two major plans here. He can castle short or long. The latter has been more popular lately, because it gives considerable chances for counterplay in the centre with ...f6, or a kingside attack with ...h5-h4. It is respectively more risky as White could prove to be faster in getting to the enemy king. This line is considered in B3b.

Short castling is a solid option, which has not been refuted at all. It is difficult even to recommend a clear plan for White. Still, it practically deprives Black of any counterplay, and gives the first player a free hand on both flanks. This option is examined in B3a.

For his part, White has little possibilities for deviations, usually linked with delaying a3. The only reason to avoid that useful prophylactic move is to choose plans with ♗c2. In that case White might not need a3 at all. However, if Black follows up with 9...♗e7 and 10...♕d7, (or in reversed order) White has nothing better than a3. Let us see what could happen should Black attempt to use the b4-square in the diagram position:

9...♘b4?!

9...♗b4 has not caught up. The game Golod – Markowski, Izmir 2004 continued with 10.♗e3 0–0 11.♖c1 ♘a5 12.♗c2 ♗c3 13.♘c3 ♗c2 14.♕c2 ♘c6 15.♖fd1 ♘b4 16.♕b3 a5 17.d5 ♘6d5 18.a3 ♘c6 19.♘d5 ed5 20.♕b7±.

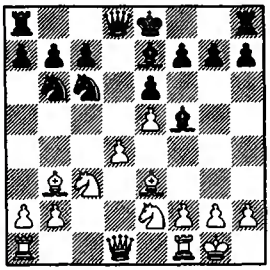
10.♘g3 ♗g6

The central pawn is poisoned: 10...♗d3 11.♖e1 ♕d4 12.♕f3 ♗a6 (12...c6 13.♗e3 ♕d7 14.♗b6 ab6 15.♖ad1+–) 13.♗e3 ♕h4 14.♘f5!! ef5 15.♕f5 ♗c4 16.♗g5 ♕h5 17.♗c4 ♘c4 18.♘b5+–.

Now White accomplishes his main objective in the chosen set-up – to smash the enemy bastions using as a ram the f-pawn:

11.f4 ♕d7 12.f5 ef5 13.e6! fe6 14.♗e6±.

B3a. 9...♗e7 10.♗e3



White might want to play a3 now, or a few moves earlier. It should bring about positions which we examine in the main lines B3b and B3a, the alternatives to 11.♘g3.

10...0–0

10...♘b4 is already a sensible

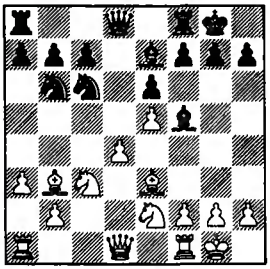
alternative. White is only slightly better after 11.♘g3 (11.♘f4 should be answered with 11...c6! as 11...♕d7? 12.g4 ♗g6 13.h4 ♗h4 suddenly loses a piece to 14.g5±) 11...♗d3 12.♖e1 ♗g6 13.f4 ♘6d5 14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♕f3 c6 [15...♘e3 16.♕e3 0–0 17.d5±] 16.f5 ef5 17.♘f5 ♗f5 18.♕f5 ♕d7 19.♕e4 0–0 20.♖f1±.

10...♕d7!? is a tricky waiting move. White has nothing better than 11.a3 when Black decides where to castle. Note that instead of 11.a3, 11.♘g3 ♗g6 12.f4 is dubious due to 12...0–0–0! 13.d5 ed5 14.♗b6 ab6 15.f5 ♘e5 16.♘d5 ♗c5 17.♔h1 c6 18.♘c3 ♕e7! 19.♕e2 ♖d3 20.♘ce4 ♖e3∓.

11.♘g3

White enters a forced sequence of moves. The other plan is to attack on the queenside, utilising the c5-square as an outpost. Here are some examples:

11.a3

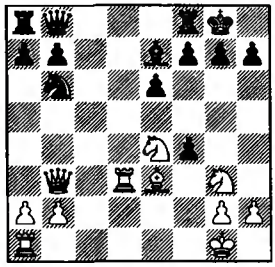


11...♘a5 12.♗c2 ♗c2 13.♕c2 ♘ac4 14.♗f4!? (14.♖ad1 ♘e3 15.fe3 c6 16.♖f3 ♘d5 17.♘e4 ♗g5 18.♕d3 ♕e7 19.♘f4 ♗f4 20.ef4± Karpov – Short, Linares (m/9)/1992) 14...♘d5 (14...c5 15.dc5 ♗c5 16.♘e4 ♗e7 17.♖fd1±) 15.♘d5 ♕d5 (15...ed5 16.a4 a5 17.b3 ♘b6 18.♗g3 f6 19.e6↑) 16.♖ac1 b5 17.♖fd1 ♕d7 18.♖d3 ♖fc8 19.♘c3 ♘b6 20.♗d2±, Nikolic – Van Wely, Groningen, 1993;

11...♕d7 12.♘g3 ♗g6 13.♕g4! ♖fd8 (13...♔h8 14.♗a2 ♖fd8 15.♖fd1 ♗f8 16.♖ac1 ♘e7 17.♗g5 h6 18.♗h4 c6 19.♘ce4± Mamedyarov – Drozdovskij, Peniscola 2002) 14.♖ad1 ♘a5 15.♗a2 ♘ac4 16.♕e2 ♘e3 17.fe3 ♘d5 (17...c6!) 18.♘d5 ed5 19.e4!± Golod – Reyes San Salvador 2002.

In this type of positions, White usually obtains a small, but lasting edge if he swaps the light-squared bishops. (This is true also if Black castles long.)

11...♗g6 12.f4 ♘a5 13.d5 ♘b3 14.♕b3! ♗d3 15.d6 cd6 16.♖fd1 de5 17.♘ce4 ef4 18.♖d3 ♕b8



19.♗b6 fg3?

Black should have destroyed the enemy bishop by **19...ab6**. Even then, most players, I suppose, would prefer to be on the side with the extra piece: 20.♘f1 (20.♘e2!? ♕e5 21.♘2c3 f5 22.♘d2) 20...♕e5 21.♖d7 ♗c5 (21...♖fe8 22.♘c3 ♖ad8 23.♖b7 ♗c5 24.♔h1 ♕d4 25.♘e2±) 22.♘c5 ♕c5 23.♔h1±.

20.♗e3 gh2 21.♔h1 b6 22.♖d7 ♕e5 23.♘d2 ♗c5 24.♗c5 ♕c5 25.♕d3± Sergienko – Kharlov, Po-

dolsk 1992.

All this looks quite convincing, but there is a bell ringing – two years later the "victim" Kharlov entered on full throttle the same tunnel and White deviated first, crashing immediately! 19.♗d4? fg3 20.♖g3 g6 21.♕e3 ♖d8 22.♖f1 ♖d4 23.♕d4 ♕d8 24.♕e5 ♘d5 25.♖gf3 ♕b6 26.♔h1 ♖f8 27.b3 f6 28.♕b2 f5∓, Sherbakov – Kharlov, Leeuwarden 1994. Moreover, another five years later at the supplementary exam, Sherbakov against Kharlov ran away from the dispute much earlier with the same (bad) result. So, forewarned is forearmed! White still has 12.a3 instead of 12.f4 as an emergency exit.

B3b. 9...♕d7 10.♗e3 0–0–0

10...♗e7 11.a3 is discussed in B3a;

10...♖d8 prepares short castling. 11.♘g3 ♗g6 (11...♘d4 12.♗d4 ♕d4 13.♕f3→) 12.h4 ♘d4! 13.♗d4 ♕d4 14.♕f3 ♕h4 15.♕b7 ♗c5 16.♕c6 ♘d7 17.♖ad1 ♗b6!=, Shirov – Anand, Dortmund 1992. The problem is that White could switch to a more sound strategy, reinforcing the critical d4-pawn, while still keeping open the options for pawn advances on the kingside. Black's counterplay (if any!) is not obvious at all. 11.a3! ♗e7 12.♕c1 0–0 13.♖d1 ♔h8 14.♘g3 ♗g6 15.f4 ♗h4 16.d5 ed5 17.♗b6 cb6 18.♗d5 ♗g3 19.hg3±, A. Goldin – Zilberman, Tel Aviv rapid, 1996.

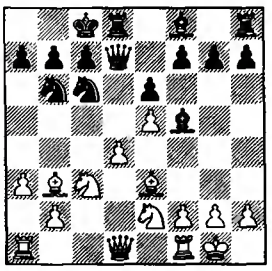
White could also prepare to thrust the b-pawn by 11.♗a2. It brings White excellent pactical results, but offers Black some counterplay, connected with f6 or a5 breaks.

After the long castling White chooses between two different strategical approaches:

B3b1. 11.a3, followed by ♕c1, ♖d1, ♗a2, b4 whereas Black rasps at the centre by f6.

B3b2. 11.♗c2, intending to minimise Black's counterplay.

B3b1. 11.a3



Both sides castled on different wings which supposes pawn attacks against the enemy's king.

White's intention is more or less clear – to open files and diagonals on the queenside. This could be accomplished by freeing lanes to the a and b-pawns with ♗a2 or ♗c2!?, followed by b4-b5, a4-a5. White could push on occasion d5, elliminating the centre in his favour. The latter is especially dangerous if Black becomes too absorbed in his own attacking plans.

Black's task is more complicated. He can hardly hope for success without destroying the enemy's wedge on e5. The only way to rasp at it is f7-f6. Practice has not determined yet which is the best sequence for Black to stage this break-through. It

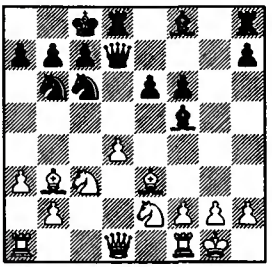
could be done immediately (11...f6), or after some developing move like 11...♗e7 or 11...♔b8. The most ambitious attempt is first to provoke a weakening of White's castling position with 11...h5, planning 12...h4.

Let's examine them:

a) 11...f6

This move leaves White no choice. He is forced to give up his forpost. The downside of the move is that Black is underdeveloped and the opponent is able to convert that into a slightly better ending. Karpov entered it against Onischuk to sign a draw only a few moves later:

12.ef6 gf6



13.♘g3

White would like to preserve tension, for example by 13.♖c1, but 13...♘a5! 14.♗a2 ♗d6 proved double-edged after 15.♘g3 ♗g3 16.hg3 ♘ac4 17.g4 ♗g6∞, Lugovoi – Anisimov, St. Petersburg 2002.

13...♘d4

Perhaps Black should test thoroughly 13...♗g6!? The arising positions after 14.♖e1!? h5 15.♘ge4 ♗e7 16.♕f3∞ or 14.♘ge4 ♗e4 (14...♕e7 15.♖e1∞) 14.♘e4 f5∞ are unexplored.

14.♗d4 ♕d4 15.♕d4 ♖d4 16.♘f5 ef5 17.♘b5 ♖d8 18.♘a7 ♔b8 19.♘b5 c6 20.♘c3 ♗c5

20...♖d2 21.♖ab1 ♗c5 encounters 22.♗e6 and White wins a pawn due to the fork threat on e4. Although Black pieces seem active, they cannot find a target – 22...♖hd8 23.♗f5 ♗d4 24.♗h7 ♘c4 25.♖bc1 ♘b2 26.♘b1 ♖e2 27.g4±.

21.♖fd1!

This improves on Onischuk – Karpov, rapid, Kansas 2003 where White put the other rook on d1 and shortly after that a draw was signed.

21...♗d4

21...♖he8 22.♔f1 ♔c7 23.♘e2± shows White's plan.

22.♔f1! f4 23.♖d3±.

Thanks to the king's manoeuvre to f1 the rook obtains new mobility along the third rank. In Ilincic – Reutsky, Budapest 2004 Black failed to defend adequately and lost.

b) 11...♗e7

White has to decide how to face f7-f6. A model game is Van Wely – Sadler, Tilburg 1998 wich went on with:

12.♕c1

The other moves are not fashionable:

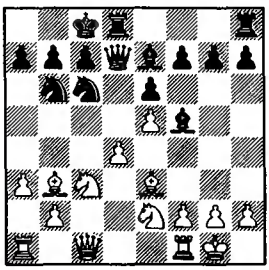
12.♘a4 ♔b8 13.♖c1 (13.♘b6 cb6) 13...f6 14.ef6 ♗f6 15.♘c5 ♕d6 16.♗f4 e5= Pogorelov – Magem Badals, Dos Hermanas 2000;

12.♖c1 ♘a5 (12...f6 13.ef6 gf6 14.♘a4 ♘d5) 13.♗a2 ♘ac4 14.♘g3 ♗g6 15.♕e2 ♘e3 16.fe3 ♔b8=, Sulypa – Maksimenko, Lvov 2000.

12.♗a2 f6 13.f4 h6! (Preparing

to activate the bishop). 14.♕e1 (Or 14.b4 fe5 15.fe5 ♗g5 16.♗f2 h5 17.b5 ♘e7∞) 14...fe5 15.fe5 ♗g5 16.♗f2 h5= 17.♔h1 (17.b4 ♔b8 18.♗b3 h4 19.h3 ♕e8 20.♖d1 ♕g6=, Agrest – Kharlov, Pinsk 1993) 17...♕e7 18.♗g1 h4 19.h3 ♖hf8 20.b4 ♕e8! 21.♗b3 ♕g6∓ Tunik – Kharlov, Elista 1994.

Perhaps the ideas behind 12.♕c1 are best displayed in the game Karpov – Shirov, rapid Bastia, which continued:



12...f6 13.ef6 ♗f6 14.♖d1 ♘e7 15.♘g3 ♘bd5 16.♘ce4 b6 17.♕c4 ♔b8 18.♖ac1±.

Usually Balck prefers:

12...♔b8 13.♖d1 f6

To 13...♘a5 Huzman suggests 14.♗a2 ♘ac4 15.d5!? His analysis follows: 15...♘e3 (15...ed5 16.♘d5 ♘e5 17.♗f4 ♗f6 18.♘f6 ♕d1 19.♕d1 ♖d1 20.♖d1 gf6 21.♗e5 fe5 22.♗f7±) 16.♕e3 ed5 17.♘d5 ♗c2 18.♖d4↑. We suppose that the final position may prove equal, but no one has tested it so far.

14.ef6 gf6 15.♘g3 ♗g6

This position has the reputation of unclear, with active play for Black on the g-file. Van Wely – Sadler, Tilburg 1998 saw furhter 16.♘ge4 ♘a5 17.♗a2 ♘ac4 18.♘c5 ♕c6 19.b4∞.

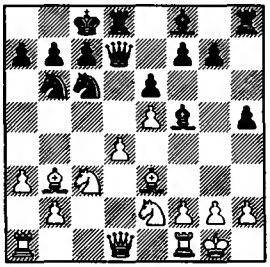
In Agdestein – Gronn, Molde 2004 White attempted to improve by 16.d5!? Critical is 16...♘d5 17.♘d5 ed5 18.♗d5 ♘e5 19.♕c3 ♘d3∞ 20.♗a2 (20.♗c4 ♕c6) 20...♕b5 21.♖d2 ♕e5∞.

Instead, Black chose 16...♘a5?! 17.♗a2 ed5 18.♘d5 ♘d5 19.♖d5 ♕a4 20.♗a7 ♔a7 21.♕e3 ♔b8 22.♕e7 ♖d5 23.♗d5 ♕d4±.

c) 11...♔b8

This prophylactic move does not change the situation. White has all the options from the previous lines open. He could choose 12.♗c2!? or 12.♗a2, intending b4.

d) 11...h5



12.♗c2!?

Black prepares an important attacking role for his light-squared bishop and the idea of exchanging it is logical. Moreover, the g6-square is weakened which could be exploited by White's knight on f4. 12.♕c1 h4 followed by 13...f6 is double-edged.

12...♗c2

Otherwise White will take on f5 and in some variations the e-pawn would be an extra trump. 12...h4 13.h3 f6 14.♗f5 ef5 15.♕c2! (In Be-

liavsky – Sakaev, Vrnjacka Banja 1999 was 15.ef6?! gf6 16.♘f4 ♗d6 17.♕f3 ♗f4∓) 15...fe5 (Or 15...g5 16.ef6 f4 17.d5 fe3 18.dc6 ef2 19.♖f2 ♕c6 20.b4±) 16.de5↑.

13.♕c2 f6 14.b4!?

In Bodicker – Jonkman, Vlissingen 2003 White chose 14.♖fd1 ♘d5 15.♘d5 ed5 when 16.♖ac1± planning b4 would have been in White's favour.

14...h4

14...fe5 15.de5 ♘e5 16.♗b6 ab6 17.♖fd1 ♗d6 18.♘d4→ ♔b8 19.♘cb5+– does not suit Black.

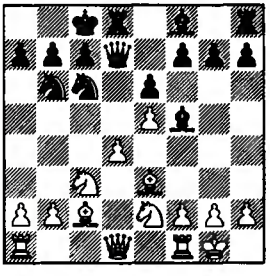
15.h3 ♔b8 (15...♗e7)

White puts then his rook to d1, threatening on occasion d5.

16.♖fd1 ♘d5 17.♘d5 ed5 18.♕c3±

We can conclude that 11.a3 leads to double-edged play with mutual chances. Line b) 11...♗e7 12.♕c1 f6 seems the most reliable choice of Black.

B3b2. 11.♗c2!?



We think that this manoeuvre deserves serious investigation.

At first sight trading light-squared bishops may seem anti-positional. However the benefits are obvious: White frees the lane for the b4-pawn; the queen obtains a more natural place outside the d-file; the most multi-functional Black piece – the f5-bishop, is removed from the board, freeing White's hand for a really quick queenside assault and ensuring the e4-square for a junction point. Of course at some moment White might regret for his bishop, but at least he obtains clear prospects for the next few moves.

11...♗c2

In a similar position Black has also tried:

11...♘b4 12.♗f5 ef5. White is better developed and that allows him in many variations to get a strong initiative, often with the help of the pawn sacrifice d4-d5:

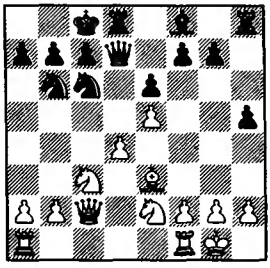
13.♖c1 ♗e7

Black is worse after 13...♔b8 14.♕b3 ♕e6 (or 14...c6 15.d5! ♘4d5 16.♖fd1↑; 14...♘4d5 15.a4↑) 15.d5! ♕e5 16.♗f4 ♕e8 17.d6±; 13...f6 is unprepared in view of 14.♕b3!?

14.a4 ♘c6 15.♕c2 ♔b8 16.a5 ♘a5 17.d5⩲.

As long as White will take on f5 anyway, Black could try to attack immediately the centre by 11...f6. White can follow the same setup as against 11...♘b4: 12.♗f5 ef5 13.♕b3 fe5 14.de5 ♘e5? 15.♗b6±. In the game Szymanski – Makarov, Bydgoszcz 2000 White exchanged first 12.ef6 gf6 13.♗f5 ef5 and only then played 14.♕b3. Although this is less ambitious, he was still better after 14...♘d5 15.♖ad1 ♗b4 16.♘d5 ♕d5 17.♕d5 ♖d5 18.a3±.

12.♕c2 h5



The pawn attack by 12...f5 (since 12...f6 could be met by 13.a3!? fe5 14.de5 ♘e5 15.♗b6→) is not efficient. White embarks on his main plan – rolling queenside pawns, as in Mecking – Disconzi da Silva, Sao Paulo zt Sao Paulo, 1995: 13.a3 ♖g8 14.b4 g5 15.b5 ♘e7, when White's attack is faster, e.g. 16.a4 f4 (or 16...♘bd5 17.a5 ♔b8 18.b6 (18.a6 b6 19.♖fc1) 17.a5 ♘bd5 18.b6 ab6 19.♘d5 ♘d5 20.ab6 ♘b6 21.♗d2→.

13.a3!?

White can hardly allow to make normal developing moves like 13.♖fd1. Korchnoi – Markowski, rap. Warsaw 2002 saw further 13...h4 14.h3 ♘b4 15.♕b3 ♗e7 16.a4 ♘6d5 17.♗d2 ♔b8 18.♘e4, when instead of 18...f5 19.♗b4 Black could have blocked the queenside by 18...♘c6 19.a5 a6∞.

13...f6

This position is considered in B3b1d. White has the initiative.

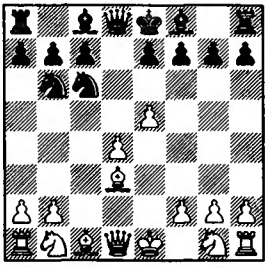
Conclusion

Lately 6.♗b3 has become fashionable again. Most of the games reach line B3b1 where theoretical dispute goes on with varying success.

We think that the plan of B3b2 deserves serious attention. By exchanging the light-squared bishops, White gets more freedom for his queen. White's rooks are also more active which often makes possible the break-trough d4-d5.

Perhaps Black should try to hinder the enemy's plan at an earlier stage by 7...♗g4 in order to provoke 8.f3. Respectively White is able to anticipate that by developing firstly the bishop to e3. The abundance of different move orders requires from both sides a good understanding of the strategic ideas. White's task is somewhat easier as the strong centre enables him to choose a plan according to his style.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6



(D20)

6.♗d3 is as topical as ever, although White has not come up with new ideas recently.

In the diagram position White can defend the pawn by:

A. 7.♘e2
B. 7.♗e3

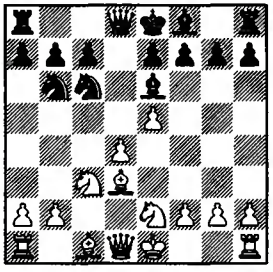
7.♘e2 is the best choice for players with a leaning to positional fight. Unlike 7.♗e3, which assumes long forced sequences, it leads to very complex play of strategical character. In some sources 7.♗e3 is accompanied with an exclamation mark, but we think that it is just a matter of taste.

It seems that most of the chess jet league prefer to adhere to the classical laws, developing knights before bishops!

A. 7.♘e2 ♗g4

Why is Black provoking f3? At first sight it is only in White's favour since in some variations he can stay with his bishop on e4 and its exchange would bring another White pawn to the centre. However Black has a remedy to that – by playing f7-f5 at the appropriate moment he repels it back. On the other hand, after 8.f3 White is deprived of his most natural developing plan that features ♗e3, ♕c2, ♖d1, ♘e4, when an exchange on e3 would reinforce the pawn centre and open the f-line, giving White a free hand on the kingside.

Some players doubt that the insertion of 7...♗g4 8.f3 is in Black's favour and adhere to the immediate 7...♗e6 8.♘bc3.



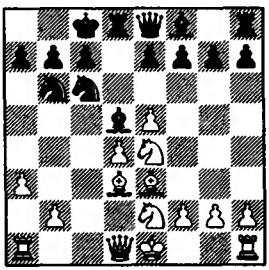
We think that in most sharper lines this version is better for White, because e3 is not weakened.

8...♕d7

Black is undeveloped for 8...♗c4?! 9.♗c4 ♘c4. It could be punished with

10.e6! We borrowed this idea from line A1, but, "technically", it is a novelty. 10...fe6 11.0-0 ♕d7 12.♘f4 0–0–0 13.♕e2 ♘b6 14.♘e6 ♘d4 15.♘d4 ♕d4 16.♖d1⩲.

9.♘e4 (9.♗e4 0–0–0 10.♗e3 ♗f5 11.0–0 ♗e4 12.♘e4 e6 13.a3 ♗e7 14.b4 f5, Van Wely – Rustemov, Moscow 2004 leads to a version of line B3b2 from the previous chapter. The difference is in the placement of White's knight on e4 which gives Black more chances, because f5 would be with a tempo.) 9...♗d5 10.♗e3 (10.0–0 e6 11.a3 ♗e7 12.♕c2 0–0–0 13.♘c5! ♕e8 14.b4± is known to be better for White, but instead of 10...e6 Black can try Anand's plan with long castling.) 0–0–0 11.a3 ♕e8



Kamsky won against Anand in Wijk aan Zee, 2006 after 12.♕c2 f5 13.♘4c3 ♗g2 14.♖g1 ♗f3 15.♗f5, but his position is hardly much better. It would be interesting to try 12.♘f4!? ♗e4 13.♗e4 ♘e5 14.a4 e6 15.0–0 with an obvious compensation, for example: 15...♘ec4 16.♕b3 ♘e3 17.fe3 a5 18.♖ac1 ♗b4 (18...♔b8 19.♖c7±) 19.♘d3 ♘d5 20.♗d5 ed5 21.♘b4 ab4 22.♖f3±.

7....♘b4 is seldom seen. White's play is clear and easy: 8.♗e4 f5 9.exf6 exf6 10.0–0 f5 11.♗f3 ♗d6 (11...♗e7 12.♘bc3 0–0 13.♖e1±) 12.♘bc3 0–0 13.a3 ♘c6 14.♘b5 ♘e7 15.♕b3+ ♔h8 16.♘xd6± Bareev – Kharlov, Kazan 2005

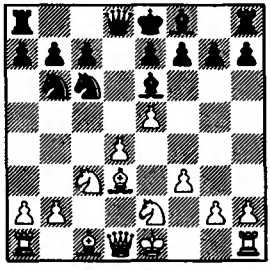
8.f3

As we saw in the previous chapter with the bishop staying on b3, this move is not obligatory. However latest games indicate that Black has found a good counter-action to 8.♗e3: 8...♕d7! 9.♘bc3 0–0–0! 10.♗e4 f5 11.♗c2∞ Dreev – Yakovich, Samara 1998. In Volkov – A. David, Istanbul 2003 Black chose 10...♗f5?! instead of f5. According to our observation, such an exchange is rather in White's favour. The game went on with 11.0–0 ♗e4 12.♘e4 e6 13.a3 ♗e7 14.♕c2 f5 15.ef6 gf6 16.b4 ♖hg8 17.b5 ♘a5 18.a4 f5, when 19.♘4g3 (instead of 19.♘c5) 19...♘bc4 20.♗f4 ♗d6 21.♖ac1 would have given White better co-ordinated pieces.

8...♗e6

Black is solid, but passive after 8...♗h5 9.♘bc3 e6 10.♗e4 ♗g6 11.0-0 ♕d7 12.♗e3±, Sakaev – Rabiega, Germany 2003.

9.♘bc3



The main line branches here to:
A1. 9...♗c4
A2. 9...♗d5
A3. 9...♕d7

(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6 7.♘e2 ♗g4 8.f3 ♗e6 9.♘bc3)

A1. 9...♗c4

This is the most testing and risky response. There are many games where Black proudly puts his bishop on d5 only to discover a few moves later that he had 3 pieces competing for one square, d5. So he does play ♗c4, thus losing a tempo. Of course, as it often happens, there is a downside too, namely a possible pawn sac on e6.

10.♗c4

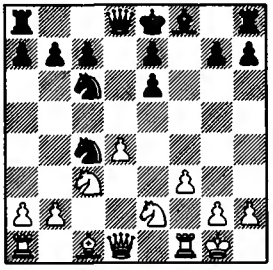
10.♗e4 looks like a loss of tempo after 10...♕d7, intending a long castle and f7-f5.

10...♘c4 11.e6!?

If Black completes development, he will have a cramped, but very solid position. Practice has shown that 11.0–0 e6 12.a3 ♕d7 or 11.♕b3 ♘b6 12.♗e3 e6 13.0–0 ♕d7 do not promise White a tangible advantage.

11...fe6 12.0-0!

An excellent idea! White plays a real gambit, nevertheless keeping the options for a better ending open. The immediate 12.♕b3 is not so good, because the d4-pawn is hanging. After 12...♘b6 13.♕e6 is a strike at the air in view of 13...♕d7! (13...♘d4?! 14.♕e4 ♘e2 15.♔e2 c6 16.♖d1⩲, Volkov – Kharlov, Ekaterinburg 1999) 14.♕d7 ♔d7 15.0–0 ½–½, Khalifman – Magem Badals, Liepaja rap. 2001. Otherwise White should place the bishop to e3 – 13.♗e3∞ Khalifman – Karjakin, Moscow 2004, instead of activating it through f4 (see the next paragraph).



12...g6

Undoubtedly, critical is 12...♕d7 13.♕b3 ♘b6 (13...♘d6 14.♗f4) 14.♖d1 (threatening d5!) 14...0-0-0 15.♗f4!? ♘d5 (15...g6 16.♘b5±) 16.♗e5! Black's bishop is clogged, so White has nice compensation for the pawn. Now, 16...♘e3 would fail to 17.♘e4 ♘d1 18.♘c5 ♘a5 19.♕b4±, while 16...♘e5 17.de5 g6 18.♘e4 ♗h6 19.f4 b6 20.a4→ is also very appealing.

13.♕b3 ♘b6 14.♕e6 ♕d7 15.♕d7 ♔d7 16.d5 ♘b4 17.♖d1 ♗g7 18.a3 ♘a6 19.♗e3±, Comas Fabrego – Markowski, IECC Istanbul 2003.

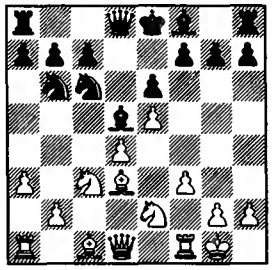
(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6 7.♘e2 ♗g4 8.f3 ♗e6 9.♘bc3)

A2. 9...♗d5 10.0-0

10.♘d5!? ♕d5?! 11.♗e4 ♕d7 12.e6! fe6 13.♗c6 ♕c6 14.♗f4 ♘d5 15.♖c1 ♕b6 16.♗e5 turned very well for White in Bareev – A. Mikhalchishin, Plovdiv 2003. However,

10...♘d5 allows Black to consolidate, and the trade of one minor piece is a good news to him in this cramped position. Still, this line might be White's best chance for an advantage.

10...e6 11.a3



11...♕d7

In Svetushkin – Markowski, Istanbul 2003, Black chose a different set-up, 11...♗e7 12.♕c2 ♗c4 13.♗c4 ♘c4 14.♖d1 ♘b6, but was worse as he would be unable to stop the central break-through d4-d5, for instance, 15.♗e3 0–0 16.♘f4 ♖e8 17.d5±. It is better to keep the e7-square for the knight.

12.♕c2 ♗c4 13.♗c4 ♘c4 14.♖d1 ♘b6 15.♗e3 ♘e7! 16.♘f4 c6

One move later Aseev and Makarov, Krasnodar 2002, signed a draw. Although White still seems better, the concrete play is not in his favour: 17.♕b3 0–0–0! (17...♘bd5 18.♘cd5 ♘d5 19.♘d5 ed5 20.♗g5±) 18.d5 ♘ed5 19.♘cd5 cd5 20.♗b6 ab6 21.♕b6 ♔b8 22.♘d3 ♖c8∞.

(3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6 7.♘e2 ♗g4 8.f3 ♗e6 9.♘bc3)

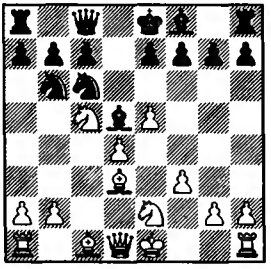
A3. 9...♕d7 10.♘e4

There is no other defence against 10...0–0–0, followed by ♘e5.

10...♗d5 11.♘c5

In most games this knight returns to e4 very soon, so 11.0–0 e6 12.♗g5! is worth consideration: 12...♘b4 13.♗b1 ♗c4 14.♖e1 ♘c6 15.♘4c3 ♗e7 16.♗e7 ♘e7 17.♗e4 0–0–0?! 18.a4 f5 19.a5! ♘bd5 20.♗d3 ♗d3 21.♕d3±, Shabalov – Drasko, Pula 1989.

11...♕c8



White would like to stay with his knight on c5 and take with the d4-pawn in case Black exchanged it. The big problem is that it would cost him the g2-pawn:

12.a3 e6 13.♕c2 ♗c5 14.dc5 ♘d7 15.f4 ♗g2 16.♖g1 ♗f3 17.♖g7 ♕d8! 18.♗e3 ♕h4 19.♖g3 0–0–0↑, Dreev – Salov, President's Cup 1998.

Apparently, White cannot afford to be overambitious, and should take on c5 with a piece. So:

12.♗e3 e6 13.♖c1 ♘b4. Alas, in this line White has to part with his bishop since the a2-pawn is hanging: 14.a3 ♘d3 15.♕d3 ♘d7 (15...♗c6 16.0–0 a6∞, Comas Fabrego – De la Villa Garcia, Pamplona 1995) 16.♘e4 ♕d8 17.0–0 ♗e7 18.f4 ♘b6 19.♘2g3=, Meulders – Van der Sterren, Lyon zt 1990.

12.♘f4 e6 13.♗e3 ♘b4 14.♗b5 c6

15.♗e2 ♗c4=, Gelfand – Ivanchuk, Odessa 04.07.2007.

Finally we reach the conclusion that White has to try:

12.a3 e6 13.♕c2 ♗c5 14.♕c5 ♕d7 15.0-0

Or 15.♗e3 ♕e7 16.♕c2 ♕h4 17.♗f2 ½–½, Tyomkin – Shipov, Montreal 2005.

15...a6

A model game for this variation is Bukic – T. Petrosian, Banjaluka 1979: 15...♕e7 16.♕c2 ♕d7 17.♗d2 ♘e7 18.♖ac1 ♗c6 19.♗e3 ♘bd5 20.♗f2 ♗b5 21.♘g3 ♗d3 22.♕d3 0–0= where White apparently was at a loss what to play.

16.♕c3 0-0

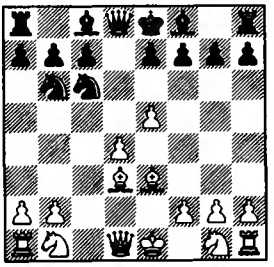
More chances to White leaves **16...f5** 17.ef6 gf6 18.♗f4 0–0 (18..♖g8∞!) 19.b4 ♘a4 20.♕d2 ♔h8 21.b5 ab5 22.♗b5 ♖g8 23.♗g3 ♕g7 24.♘f4±, Gulko – Chandler, OHRA 1987, but **16...♘e7** 17.b3 ♗c6 18.a4 f5 19.ef6 gf6 20.♗a3 0–0–0 21.♗c5 ♘ed5 22.♕d2 ♕g7 23.♖ae1 ♘d7 24.♗a3 ♖hg8⇄ deserves attention, Vyzmanavin – Meister, Cheliabinsk 1990.

17.♗e3 ♘e7 18.♕c2 h6 19.♘g3 ♗c6 20.♖fd1 ♘bd5 21.♗f2 ♘f4 22.♗e4 ♘ed5=, Vyzmanavin – Yakovich, Cheliabinsk 1990.

In this line (9...♕d7) Black holds his position quite easily. It is White's turn to produce new ideas.

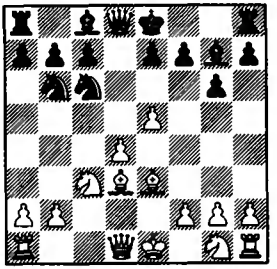
(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗d3 ♘c6)

B. 7.♗e3



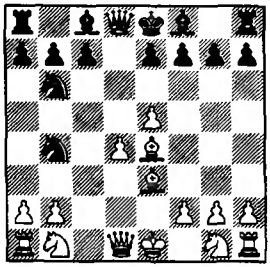
B1. 7...♘b4
B2. 7...♗e6

7...g6 looks like a provocation. White should better refrain from attacks that feature h2-h4. Instead he can focus on the d5-square: 8.♘c3 ♗g7. Black can carry on his policy of luring the opponent into tactical complications by 8...♘b4 9.♗e4 ♗f5!? 10.♗f5 gf5 and again the strict positional treatment 11.♘h3 (11.e6 fe6 12.a3 ♘4d5 13.♕h5 ♔d7 14.♘f3 ♗g7⇄) 11...e6 12.♖c1 ♗e7 13.♘f4± is the most effective.



9.♘ge2 0–0 10.♗e4 ♘b4 11.♕b3 a5 12.♘f4!± e6 13.a3 ♘4d5 (13...♘c6 14.♖d1±) 14.♘fd5 ed5 15.♗d5 a4 16.♕a2 ♖a5 17.♗c4 ♘c4 18.♕c4 b6 (18...♗e6 19.♕b4 c5 20.dc5 ♗e5 21.♖d1±) 19.0–0–0± Timman – Kortschnoj, EU-chT, Pula 1997.

B1. 7...♘b4 8.♗e4

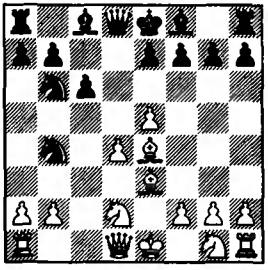


8...f5

This idea of Yuri Markov, a master from Novosibirsk, was introduced back in 1985, but only recently became the most popular weapon against White's set-up. Although Black's longing to eliminate the e5-pawn is understandable, this move is not very flexible. It closes White's doubts how best to unfold his army, providing him with clear objectives – the open e-file, together with an outpost on e5.

The older 8...c6 faces White with a difficult choice – how to arrange his pieces, and more importantly, where to find targets.

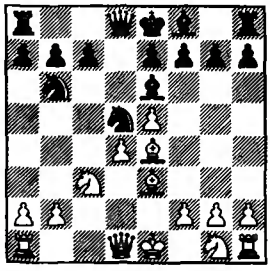
An example of creative thinking is 9.♘d2!?



White admits that he is not able to compete for the d5-square and directs the knight straight to c5. That could be the best approach in the current situation. Apparently the expert for Black Sadler reached the same conclusion since as White he met 9...♗e6 with 10.♘gf3 (White cannot afford to lose a tempo by 10.a3 ♘4d5 11.♘gf3 ♕d7 12.♘b3 ♘e3 13.fe3 ♗b3 14.♕b3 e6=, Dydysko – Zhuravliov, St. Peterburg 1992. It is important to preserve the dark-squared bishop. Without it White's prospects for a kingside attack are problematic.) 10...♕d7 (10...♘4d5 11.♘g5) 11.♘b3 ♗b3 12.♕b3 e6 13.0–0 ♗e7 14.♖fd1 ♘4d5 15.♗d2 a5 16.a3 h6 17.♖ac1 ♔f8 18.h4±, Sadler – Shaw, Isle of Man, 1994.

8...c6 is frequently answered with 9.♘c3. Black completes his entrenchment around the d5-square, keeping f7-f5 in reserve – 9...♗e6 10.♘ge2 ♘4d5 11.0–0 ♕d7 (11...♗g4 12.♕b3 ♗e2 13.♘e2 e6 14.a4 a5 15.♗d5 ed5 16.f4 ♗b4 17.f5↑ A. Greenfeld – A. Bykhovsky, Tel Aviv 1999) 12.♘g3 f5! 13.ef6 ef6 14.♖e1 0–0–0=, Beliavsky – Yakovich, Sochi 1986.

Sometimes Black employs the sneaky move order 7...♗e6 8.♘c3 (8.♘f3!) ♘b4! 9.♗e4 ♘4d5

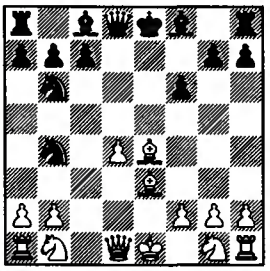


If White had developed the king's

knight, he would have had 10.♘g5, seizing the initiative. In the diagram position the ambitious continuation would be 10.♕f3 c6 11.♘h3 f6 12.♘f4 ♘f4 13.♕f4 g6 14.h4!, but the exchange of one pair of knights provides Black with vital operational space and he is able to complete his development undisturbed: 14...f5 15.♗c2 ♖g8 (15...♘d5!? 16.♘d5 ♕d5 17.0–0 ♗g7=) 16.♕f3 ♕d7 17.0–0–0 0–0–0=, Boensch – Varga, Baden 1999.

The game Shaked – Ibragimov, Berlin 1997, saw 10.♘ge2 when Black should have played 10...♕d7, followed by c6 and g6. Instead, he opened play by 10...f5?! 11.ef6 ef6 12.♘f4 ♘f4 13.♗f4 ♗d6 14.♗d6 ♕d6 15.♗b7 ♖d8 16.♕h5 ♗f7 17.♕b5 ♘d7 18.♕e2± and lost a pawn.

9.ef6 ef6



10.♘c3

10.a3 is a very sharp continuation. By all evidence it cannot qualify for the main weapon against Black's set-up, but it requires concrete knowledge:

10...f5

In a blitz game Shirov tried successfully against Karpov (Prague 2002) 10...♘4d5 11.♕h5 (11.♘c3 f5=) 11...g6 12.♗g6 hg6 13.♕h8 ♕e7 14.♘e2 ♗f5 15.♘bc3 0–0–0 16.0–0 (An inaccuracy. White had to exchange a pair of knights on d5 – 16.♘d5 ♘d5 17.♕h4!? ♘e3 18.fe3 ♕e3 19.♕g3 ♕e4 20.♖c1 ♗d6 21.♕f3±) 16...♘e3 17.fe3 ♕e3 18.♔h1 ♗a3∞. Shirov's idea is worth testing, but Black has found safer ways.

11.ab4 fe4!

A number of games proved that White's initiative after 11...♗xb4?! 12.♘c3 fe4 13.♕h5 ♔f8 14.♘ge2→ is very dangerous.

12.♘c3

Or 12.♕h5 g6 13.♕e5 ♔f7 14.♘c3 ♗b4 and Black has the edge.

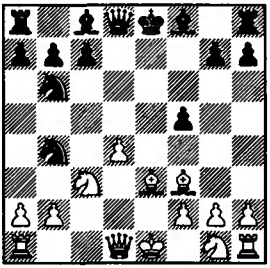
12...♗e6! 13.♘h3 ♗d6 14.♘g5 ♗c4

Black prevented White from castling and got a nice compensation in Miton – Sadvakasov, Continental Open 2000.

10...f5

Here White chooses between: B1a. 11.♗f3 and B1b. 11.♗b1!?

B1a. 11.♗f3



In this line White hopes to exchange two minor pieces on d5 and his dark-squared bishop through f4 or g5 in order to occupy e5.

11...♘4d5

Black can bolster the centre first by 11...c6 12.♘h3 ♘6d5 (or 12...♗e6 13.0–0 ♗d6 14.♖e1 0–0 15.♘g5 ♗c4 16.b3 ♗f7 17.♘f7 ♖f7 18.a3 ♘4d5 19.♘d5 ♘d5 20.♗d5 cd5 21.♕f3 ♕h4 22.g3 ♕e4∓, Zaja – Ganguly, Istanbul 2000) 13.0–0 (the tactical encounter 13.♗g5 ♗e7 14.♕e2 0–0 15.♘d5 ♗g5 favours Black – 16.♘c7 ♕c7 17.♘g5 ♕d8 18.♕c4 ♘d5 19.♗d5 cd5 20.♕c1 ♖e8∓) 13...♗e7 14.a3!? (14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♕b3 ♘e3 16.fe3 ♕b6=, Rausis – Volzhin, Dhaka 2001) ♘c3 15.bc3 ♘d5 16.♗d2 0–0 17.♘f4 ♘f4=.

12.♗d2

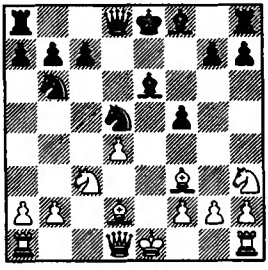
This bishop is important – 12.♘h3 ♗e7 13.♘f4 ♘e3 14.fe3 0–0 15.0–0 ♗d6=.

12...♗e6

The game Hellborg – Vernersson, 2002 went on 12...♗e7 13.♘ge2 ♗e6 14.♘f4 ♘f4 15.♗f4 c6 16.0–0 0–0 17.♖e1 ♗f7 18.♕c2 ♕d7 19.♖ad1 ♖ad8 20.♗e5 ♖fe8 21.a3 ♗f8 22.♗e2 ♗e6 23.♗d3 ♕f7 24.♕e2 ♗b3∓.

13.♘h3

This is supposed to improve on 13.♘ge2 ♕d7 14.0–0 0–0–0 15.♖e1 ♖g8! 16.♗g5 ♖e8 17.♘f4 ♘f4 18.♗f4 g5 19.♗e5 ♗g7 20.♖c1?! ♗e5∓ (C. Hansen) Karpov – Short, Linares 1992.



13...♗e7

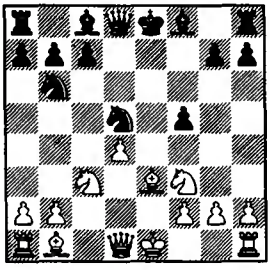
In an earlier game Shirov had chosen 13...♕d7 14.0–0 0–0–0 15.♖e1 ♘c3! 16.bc3 ♗a3! 17.♘f4 ♗c4 18.♕c2 ♖he8 19.♘d3 ♕a4!=, paralysing the queenside, Dreev – Shirov, Moscow 2002. Still, the long castling looks risky as White could have started an offensive with 15.a4!? Against Karpov Shirov fixed up his plan:

14.0-0 0-0 15.♖e1 ♗f7 16.♘d5 (16.♘f4 ♘f4 17.♗f4 c6=) **16...♘d5 17.♕c2** (17.♕b3!? ♗f6! 18.♕b7 ♕d6! 19.♕b3 ♖ab8 20.♕d3 ♖b2=) **17...♕d7 18.♘g5 ♗f6⇄ 19.♘f7 ♖f7 20.♕b3 c6=** Karpov – Shirov, Corus Wijk aan Zee 2003.

B1b. 11.♗b1!? ♘4d5

Perhaps the most precise move order is 11...♗d6!? White has nothing better than 12.♘f3 ♗e6 13.0–0 (13.♘g5?! ♕d7 14.♕f3 0–0! 15.a3 ♘4d5∞) 13...♕d7 and Black went round most opening reefs, reaching a comfortable position – 14.a3 ♘4d5 15.♘g5 ♘c3 16.bc3 ♗d5 17.♗d3 0–0 18.♖e1=, Pelletier – Sorokin, Elista 1998.

12.♘f3



There is one delicate question

which Black has to answer: should he take on e3. Right now, it is not advisable, since the loss of so many tempi with the knight would make White's lead in development overwhelming. 12...♘e3?! 13.fe3 ♗d6 14.0–0 0–0 15.♕b3 ♔h8 16.e4 fe4 17.♘e4→ Salov.

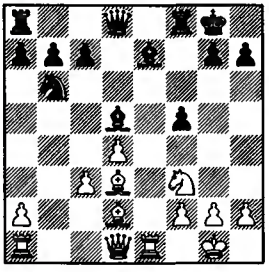
Another important topic is where to place the dark-squared bishop.

12...♗d6

Or 12...♗e7 13.0–0 0–0 14.♖e1 ♔h8 15.♗d2 ♗f6 16.a3± Palac – Raetsky, Geneve 2007.

13.♗g5 ♕d7

A sad necessity which could have been avoided, had Black played ...♗e6 in time (see the note to the move 11). Of course, also possible is 13...♗e7, but there must be something wrong with a variation where you play ♗d6 only to step back on the next move. The same does not apply to White, since he is striving to clear the e-file for the rook – 14.♗d2 0–0 15.0–0 ♘c3 16.bc3 ♗e6 17.♖e1 ♗d5 18.♗d3 (18.♘e5 c5⇄).

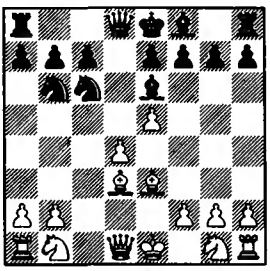


Black is far from equality with this hole on e5 and c3-c4 coming soon. 18...c5 stumbles against White's central domination: 19.♕e2 ♗d6 20.c4! ♗f3 21.♕f3 ♕h4 (21...cd4 22.a4!±) 22.h3! ♕d4 23.♖ad1 ♘c4 (23...♖ae8 24.♖e8 ♖e8 25.♗e3 ♕e5 26.g3 ♕f6 27.a4!↑) 24.♗c4 ♕c4 25.♗g5±. Black cannot find a place for his bishop.

The above variations shed some light on the reason behind the positional concession 18...♘c4 which happened in the game Shirov – Ponomariov, Linares 2002: 19.♗c4! ♗c4 20.♘e5 ♗f7 (20...♗d5 21.c4 ♗e4 22.♗c3±) 21.♘f7 ♖f7 22.♕b3±.

14.0–0! (but not 14.♕e2? ♕e6= Timman – Salov, Sanghi Nagar 1994) **14...0–0 15.♖e1 ♖e8 16.a4±** leaves open the question how Black can coordinate his pieces.

B2. 7...♗e6



This leads to patterns similar to line A. Black exchanges his light-squared bishop through c4 and gets a solid, albeit somewhat passive position.

8.♘c3

I can see strong arguments in favour of 8.♘f3!? In that case the modern plan with 8...♗c4 is probably dubious due to 9.♗c4 ♘c4 10.e6!? fe6 11.0–0 g6 12.♕b3 ♘6a5 (12...♘e3 13.fe3 ♕d7 14.♘g5 ♗h6 15.♘e6 ♘a5

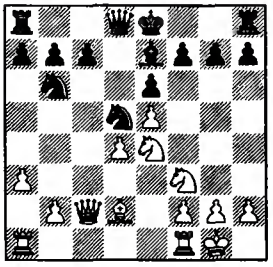
16.♘g7 ♔d8 17.♕c3↑) 13.♕c3 ♕d5 14.b4 ♘c6 15.b5↑. In all cases White has good compensation.

Alternatively, 8...♗d5 9.♘c3 e6 10.0–0 is slightly better for White, who has developed harmoniously his pieces. Perhaps Black's best answer is 8...♕d7 9.♘c3 ♘b4 with rich play, for example:

10.♗b5 c6 11.♗e2 ♗f5 12.0–0 e6 13.♘h4 ♗e7 14.♘f5 ef5=, Karpov – Nikolic, Amber-blind Monte Carlo, 1999;

10.♗e4 ♗c4 11.b3 ♗a6 12.d5 e6 13.de6 ♕e6 14.a3 ♘c6∞.

8...♗c4 9.♗c4 ♘c4 10.♕b3 ♘6a5 11.♕c2 e6 12.♘f3 ♘c6 13.a3 ♘b6 14.0-0 ♘e7 15.♘e4 ♘ed5 16.♗d2 ♗e7∞



This position arose in Sargissian – Granda Zuniga, Zafra 23.03.2007. We commonly accept that White is slightly better, because his strong centre allows him to display activity on both flanks. On the other hand, Black has no weaknesses and his pieces are well placed. If he plays accurately, he should be able to parry White's attempts for making progress.

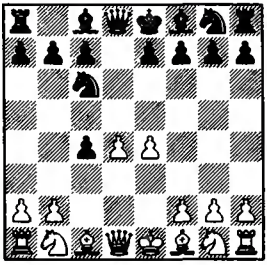
Conclusion

I cannot say that 6.♗d3 is better than the other retreat of the bishop, but it is undoubtedly more complex.

After 7.♘e2 critical appears to be 7...♗g4 8.f3 ♗e6 9.♘c3 ♕d7 with a solid position.

From strategic point of view, the line 7.♗e3 is less risky since in most games both kings castle on the same wing. It is up to you to decide is it a plus or a minus! Statistical data show that White achieves 58% in the main line B1b. 11.♗b1!? which is a good indicator that his game is slightly preferable.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘c6



(D20)

This variation has been for a long time in the back yard of the e4-system. At first sight it is against the principles of chess, if anyone knows them at all ... We suspect that its reputation is going to change. In all main branches Black players are generating a lot of new ideas, while White is still preferring to follow in the footsteps of few chess giants. Nowadays White is struggling in some variations that only a decade ago were labelled "White is better". The most attractive feature is that the arising positions are very complex, offering a chance for the better player (or better prepared!) to impose his will. If we take into account that the 3...c5 system is currently in crisis and 3...e5 is in stagnation, even more evident becomes the fact that 3...♘c6 is bursting with new interesting ideas, mostly for Black.

A. 4.♗e3?!

B. 4. d5;

4.♘f3 is seen in Chapter 10.

4.♗e3?! ♘f6

4...e5 leaves too many options to White. That seems a good reason to claim it premature. We'll note here only the wild game Shirov – Murshed, Brno 1991 which went on 5.d5 ♘ce7 6.♗c4 ♘g6 7.♗b5!?

Perhaps more precise is 7.♕b3!? intending to meet 7...♘f6 by 8.d6, although the game Garcia–Mamedova, Moscow 1994 has not impressed us: 9...♗d6 10.♗f7 ♔f8 11.♘f3 ♕e7 12.♗c4 h6 13.a4 ♘f4 14.0–0 g5 15.♘e1 ♔g7 16.♘c2 ♗d7 17.♗d2 ♕e8 18.♘e3 ♕h5∞.

7...♗d7 8.♕b3 ♘f6 9.♗d7 ♘d7 10.♕b7 ♖b8 11.♕c6 ♘h4! 12.♔f1□ ♗c5! (12...♖b2 13.g3 ♘g6 14.♘d2!±) 13.♗c5□ ♕g5 14.♘d2□ ♕d2! 15.♗a3 ♕d3 16.♘e2 ♘g2!? 17.♕c3! ♕c3 18.♘c3 ♘f4 19.♖g1 g6 20.♘e2! ♔d8 (20...♘d3? 21.♖g3 ♘b2 22.♖c1 ♔d8 23.♖gc3+–) 21.♖c1 ♘f6?! (⌓21...♘d3 22.♖c2 f5! 23.ef5 gf5±) 22.♘f4 ef4 23.d6!±.

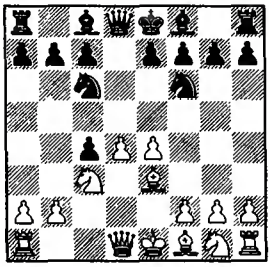
Now White defends e4 by:

A1. 5.♘c3

A2. 5.f3

There is also a third (seldom seen), possibility – 5.e5, to which we recommend 5...♗g4!? 6.f3 (6.♘f3 ♘d5 is a good version of the 3...♘f6 system.) 6...♘d5 7.♗f2 ♗e6 8.♘c3 f6!? 9.♘e4 fe5 10.♘c5 ♕d6∓.

A1. 5.♘c3



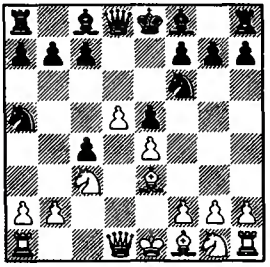
5...e5

5...♘g4?! (planning 6...e5), could be met by 6.e5, swinging the scales in White's favour since the arising pawn structure does not promise Black any counterplay. White has only to transfer his knight to f4 via e2, taking the centre under full control. Probably 6.♗c4 is also good.

6.d5

6.♘f3 is good only in case of 6...♗g4?! 7.d5 ♘e7∞ (7...♘b8?!) or 6...♘g4?! 7.d5 ♘e3 8.fe3 ♘b4 9.♗c4 ♗d6 10.a3 ♘a6∞. Black's knight is miserable on the rim, but White's pieces do not seem very productive either. However the continuation 6...ed4! 7.♘d4 ♘e5 gives Black the initiative.

6...♘a5



Our opinion is that Black should avoid the set-up, arising after 6...♘e7 7.♗c4 a6, especially when White did not put yet his knight on f3. This sort of positions is difficult to evaluate and tournament experience does not help much – see A2.

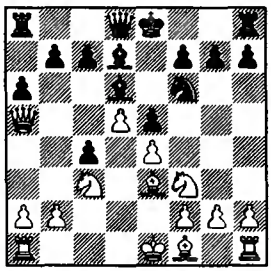
7.♘f3

7.♕a4 c6 is roughly equal: 8.dc6 (8.b4? cb3 9.ab3 b5!) ♘c6 9.♗c4 ♗b4 10.♘f3 0-0 11.0-0 ♗c3 12.bc3 ♘e4 13.♗f7=, Vyzmanavin – Sadler, Paris rap. 1994.

Black can also experiment with 7...♗d7?! 8.♕a5 a6 9.d6! White risks to get crushed after 9.♘a4 ♘e4! 10.♗c4 b6∓ or 9.b4 b6 10.♕a3 a5 11.♕c1 ab4 12.♘d1 b5↑.

9...♗d6 10.♘d5 ♘e4 11.0-0-0! (11.♗c4 b6 12.♘b6 cb6 13.♕d5 ♗b4 14.♔f1 ♘d6 15.♕e5 ♔f8! 16.♗d3 ♕e7=) 11...b5 12.♘e2±.

7...♗d6 8.♕a4 ♗d7!! (Sadler's patent) **9.♕a5 a6**



We vote for the brilliancy prize! After the "quite" pawn move White has a whole lot of possibilities, but none of them is appealing:

10.♘a4 ♕e7! 11.a3 ♘e4 (11...0-0 12.♘d2±) 12.♗c4 b5=. (Haba)

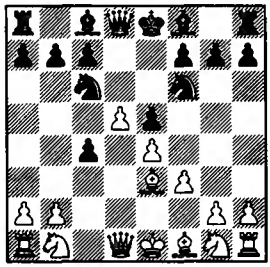
10.b4 b6 11.♕a3 a5 12.♕c1 ab4 13.♘d1 (13.♘e2 b5!⩱) 13...b5 14.♗g5 h6 15.♗f6 ♕f6⩲ Sturua – Kharlov,

Batumi 2002.

10.♘e2 ♘e4 11.0–0–0 c3 12.b4 b6 13.♕a3 a5 14.♕b3 ab4 15.♘g3 ♖a3 16.♕a3 ba3 17.♘e4 0–0 18.♘c3 f5 19.♗c4∓, Shabalov – Miton, Bermuda 2003.

10.♗c4 b6 11.♕a6 ♖a6 12.♗a6 0–0 13.0–0 ♘g4 14.♗d2 f5 15.ef5 ♗f5 16.h3 ♘f6 17.♖fe1 ♕e8∞, Karpov – Lautier, rapid Monte Carlo 1996.

A2. 5.f3 e5 6.d5



Black can relentingly switch to a slightly better for White structure by A2a. 6...♘e7, or stake on enterprising play by sacrificing "only" a pawn – A2b. 6...♘d4!? There is a third possibility which apparently has only one drawback – it leads to a quite dumb ending – A2c. 6...♘b4. Finally, the brave – A2d. 6...♘a5!?, which deserves attention.

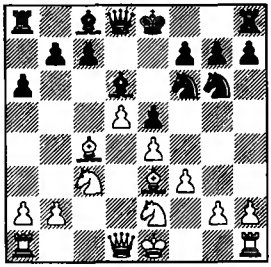
A2a. 6...♘e7

As long as this continuation seems irrelevant for the opening theory of our days, we'll cite a few games with different plans for White – with a long and a short castle.

7.♘c3

7.♗c4 is inaccurate in view of 7...c6 8.dc6 ♕d1 9.♔d1 ♘c6 10.♘c3 ♗e6 ♗e7!=/∓.

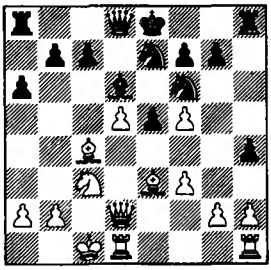
7...♘g6 8.♗c4 a6 9.♘ge2 ♗d6



10.0–0 b5 11.♗d3 ♗d7 12.a4 b4 13.♘b1 c6 14.dc6 ♗c6 15.♘d2 ♕e7 16.♖c1 ♗d7=, Kalesis – P. Nikolic, Biel 1993;

10.♕d2 0–0 11.♘g3 (Perhaps White should have got in 11.h4!?) **11...♘f4**

Black also can use the rook's pawn: **11...h5** 12.0–0–0 h4 13.♘f5 ♗f5 14.ef5 ♘e7∞



15.g4 hg3 16.hg3 ♖h1 17.♖h1 ♘f5 18.♗g5 ♕d7 19.♗f1 ♘d4 20.♖h8 ♗f8 21.♗h3 ♕d6 22.f4 ♘d5 23.fe5 ♕e5 24.♗f4 ♘f4 25.gf4 ♕d6= Beliavsky – Lautier, Linares 1994.

12.0–0 ♘e8 13.♘ce2 ♕g5 14.♘f4 ef4 15.♗d4 ♘f6 16.♖fe1 ♖e8 17.♘h1 ♘d7 18.♘f2 ♘e5 19.♗e2 ♗d7 20.♔h1

♕h4 21.♗f1 g5 22.♖ac1 g4→ Baquero – Ibragimov, Philadelphia 1992.

These examples show that White cannot rely on his pawn centre too much, since his pieces cannot find active places. Of course, if Black stays passive, slowly White will get some play along the c-file, but in general, Black has good prospects.

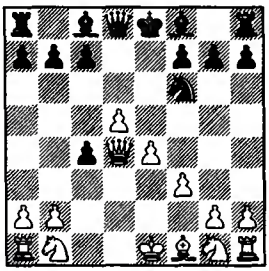
A2b. 6...♘d4!?

Chess commentators like sacrifices, especially when others are on the receiving end! Although practical results suggest that Black is walking a tight rope and must be very precise, we'll join the common opinion that the pawn is a Greek gift indeed!

7.♗d4

Such a knight cannot be tolerated: 7.♗c4?! ♗c5 8.♗f2 c6 9.dc6?! (9.♘c3 cd5 10.ed5 0–0∓) 9...♕b6! 10.cb7 ♗b7 11.♘d2 0–0∓, Yermolinsky – D. Gurevich, Seattle 2000.

7...ed4 8. ♕d4



8...c6

According to Psakhis, 8...♗b4?! 9.♘c3 0–0 10.0–0–0 ♗c3 11.♕c3 b5 fails to solve Black's problems – 12.♘e2 (12.g4!? c6 13.d6) 12...c6 13.dc6 (13.d6 ♕b6 14.♘f4 b4 15.♕d4 c3 16.bc3 bc3 17.♕c3 ♖b8⇄) 13...♕b6 14.♘d4 ♗e6 15.♘e6 fe6 16.♖d6! ♖fd8 (Or a)16...♖ad8 17.♖e6 ♔f7 ♖d4 18.c7 ♕c5 19.♖c6 ♕c6 20.♕d4 ♕c7 21.♗e2±; b)16...♖ac8 Ftacnik 17.♖e6 ♖c6 18.♖c6 ♕c6 19.♗e2±) 17.♖e6 b4 18.♗c4!+–.

9.♘c3

In Timoshchenko – Balashov, Sverdlovsk 1987, was 9.♗c4 cd5 10.ed5 (or 10.♗b5 ♗d7 11.♗d7 ♕d7 12.e5 ♕e6 13.♘c3 ♖c8 14.♕a7 ♕e5 15.♘ge2 ♗c5 16.♕a4 ♔f8∓, Ilincic – Koons, Budapest 15.05.2007) 10...♗d6 11.♗b5 (11.♘c3 0–0 12.♘ge2 ♕c7 13.0–0–0 ♗d7 14.♔b1 ♖fc8 15.♘b5 ♗b5 16.♗b5 a6 17.♖c1 ♗c5 18.d6 ♕d6=, Vareille – Sulava, Cannes 1989) ♗d7 12.♗d7 ♘d7 13.♘e2 0–0 14.♘bc3 ♗c5 15.♕d3 when 15...♖e8!∓ would have given Black the upper hand. (Balashov)

9...cd5

It is already late for 9...♗b4 in view of 10.♕e5 ♕e7 11.♕e7 ♔e7 12.dc6 bc6 13.♗c4 ♘d7 14.0–0–0 ♘e5 15.♗e2 g5 16.h4!±, Karpov – J. Piket, Groningen 1995.

10.0–0–0

10.e5 ♘d7 11.♘d5 (11.♕d5 ♕c7) 11...♗c5 12.♕c4 0–0⩱.

10...♗b4 11.♗c4

11.e5 is dubious again – 11...♗c3 12.♕c3 ♘d7 13.♖d5 0–0 14.♗c4 ♕e7⩱.

11...♗c3 12.bc3

Black gets an obvious compensation after 12.♕c3 0–0 13.ed5 ♗f5→, but White could choose 13.♔b1, intending to evacuate the king before taking the pawn. However Black is not obliged to make presents any

more: 13...♗e6!? 14.ed5 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ♗d5 16.♘e2 ♖c8 17.♕d4 ♕c7∓.

12...0–0 13.ed5 (13.♗d5!?) **13...b5 14.♗b3 a5!** (14...♕d6 15.♕b4=) **15.♘e2 ♕d6 16.♘g3 a4 17.♗c2 ♕a3 18.♔b1 ♖d8,** Beliavsky – Ehlvest, Moscow 1988. Black could have fixed his edge with **18...♘d5!** 19.♕d5 ♗e6 20.♗h7 ♔h7 21.♕d2 ♖fb8 22.♕b2 b4→.

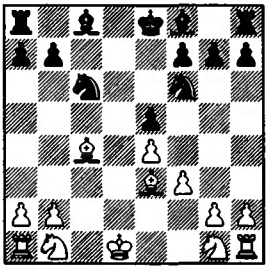
A2c. 6...♘b4 7.♗c4

7.♘c3 ♘d3 8.♗d3 cd3 9.♖c1 a6 10.♕d3 ♗d6 11.♘ge2 0–0 12.g4 ♗d7 13.♘g3 c6 14.g5 ♘e8 15.♘f5 ♗f5 16.ef5 ♗b4 17.♕e4 ♗c3 18.♖c3 ♘d6∓, Laasanen – Kivimaki, Heart of Finland op 1997.

7...c6 8.dc6

8.♘c3 fails to 8...♘fd5! 9.♘d5 ♘d5 10.♗d5 cd5 11.♕d5 ♕d5 12.ed5 ♗b4 13.♔f2 b6 14.♘e2 ♗b7 15.a3 ♗d6 16.♘c3 ♖d8∓, Sorvari – Kivimaki, Jyvaskyla 1996.

8...♕d1 9.♔d1 ♘c6



10.♘e2 (10.♘c3 ♗e7)

10...♗e7 11.♘bc3 0–0 12.♔c2

Hardly good is Huzman's recommendation 12.a3 in view of 12...♘a5 13.♗a2 ♗e6 14.♗e6 fe6 15.♔c2 ♘c4↑.

12...♘a5! 13.♗d5 (13.♘d5 ♘c4 14.♘e7 ♔h8 15.♗g5 ♗e6 16.♖ad1 h6! 17.♗c1 ♖fe8 18.♘d5 ♗d5 19.ed5 ♖ad8∓). Now the symmetrical pawn structure determines an equal ending.

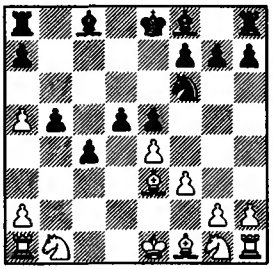
13...♘d5 14.♘d5 ♗d6 In Polovodin – Najer, St Petersburg 1999 White "found" a way to ruine his position by 15.♖hd1 ♗e6 16.♘ec3? (16.♖ac1!=) 16...♖fc8 17.♖d3 ♘c4 18.♗f2 b5∓. Instead **15.♖ac1!** ♘c4 16.♗f2 ♗e6 17.♖hd1= would have reduced the suspense.

A2d. 6...♘a5

If Black is afraid to shed a pawn, he'd be even more reluctant to part with a piece. Nevertheless we like to sacrifice pieces at someone else's expense and we'll recommend this one for free.

7.♕a4 c6 8.b4 b5! Two games have seen 8...cb3?! 9.ab3 b5 10.♕a5 ♕a5 11.♖a5 ♗b4 12.♗d2 ♗a5 13.♗a5 cd5 14.♘c3 de4, but 15.♗b5 ♗d7 16.♗c4± clearly shows who is on top.

9.♕a5 ♕a5 10.ba5 cd5



11.♘c3

11.ed5 ♘d5 12.♗d2 ♘b4 13.♘a3 a6 14.♖b1 ♘d5 15.♘c2 ♗f5∓.

11...♗b4 12.♗d2 d4 13.♘b5 c3 14.♗g5 0–0∞.

B. 4. d5

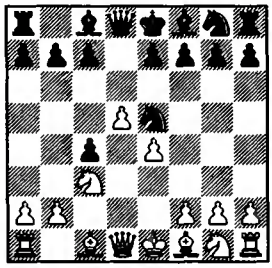
This move is better than its reputation. At least White reaches a very complicated position where most variations are still with "unclear" status.

4...♘e5

B1. 5.♗f4

B2. 5.♕d4!?.

The other popular move 5.♘c3 is "too" flexible.



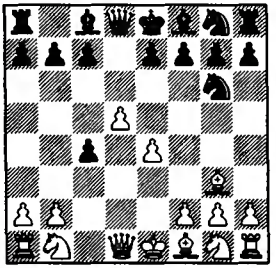
The idea is to get a better version of B1 or B2, for instance after 5...♘f6, when both 6.♗f4 and 6.♕d4 lead to known positions with Black's knight already committed to f6. (Let's note that 5...♘f6 6.♕d4 ♘g6 7.♕c4 e5 cannot be punished by 8.de6 ♗e6 9.♕b5 ♗d7 10.♕b7 ♗c5 with a full compensation for the pawn). The relatively bad news is that Black has his trump too – the possibility of switching to:

5...e6 6.♘f3 (6.♗f4 ♗d6; 6.f4 ♘d3) ♘f3 7.♕f3 ed5 8.ed5 ♘f6 9.♗c4 ♗e7 10.0–0 0–0 11.♖e1 ♗g4 12.♕g3 ♗d6 Wagner – Levin, Neubrandenburg 1998 with good chances to level the play some day.

B1. 5.♗f4 ♘g6

B1a. 6.♗g3; B1b. 6.♗e3!?

B1a. 6.♗g3



6...h5!?

The other continuations also promise Black good play:

6...e5 7.♗c4 ♗d6 8.♘c3 ♘f6 9.♗b5 (OK, it is wiser to refrain from this check, but anyway White seems without a plan) 9...♔f8 10.♘f3 a6 11.♗e2 ♘h5 12.♘d2 ♘hf4∓, Kumaran – Murshed, London 1990.

6...♘f6 7.♘c3 e6 8.♗c4 ed5 9.ed5 ♗d6 (9...a6!?) 10.♗b5 ♔f8 11.♘f3 a6 12.♗e2 h5∞.

7.♘f3

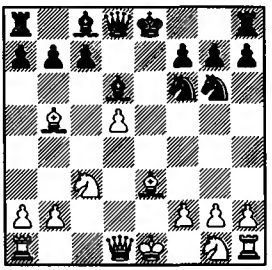
Harmless is 7.h3 h4 8.♗h2 e6 9.♘c3 ♘f6 10.♗c4 ed5 11.ed5 ♗d6 12.♕e2 ♔f8 13.♘f3 ♗h2 14.♘h2 ♕d6 15.0–0 ♗d7 16.♕d2 ♘f4 17.♘f3 ♖h5=, Gauglitz – Tomaszewski, Halle 1987.

7...h4 8.♗e5 e6 9.♗c4 ♘e5 10.♘e5 ♗d6 11.♕a4 ♔f8 12.f4 ♕f6 13.♘c3 ♗e5 14.fe5 ♕e5 15.0–0–0 ♘f6 16.de6 ♗e6 17.♕b4 c5 18.♕b3∞, Albert – Speelman, London 1986.

B1b. 6.♗e3!? ♘f6 7.♘c3 e6

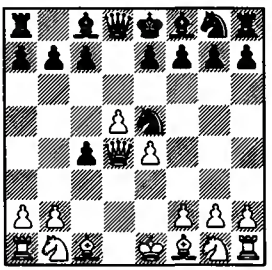
In the current situation with White's bishop staying perfectly on e3 and the knight not pinned to f3, 7...e5 is not good, since 8.♗c4 ♘g4 fails to 9.♗b5 c6 10.dc6 ♕d1 11.♖d1 b6 12.c7 1–0 Karpov – Baud, Bastia 1998.

8.♗c4 ed5 9.ed5 ♗d6 10.♗b5



This position has been reached in Vakhidov – Graf, Tashkent 1992 when Black suddenly gambled with 10...c6 11.dc6 0–0 12.♘f3 ♘g4 13.0–0 ♕c7 14.♘d5 ♗h2 15.♔h1. White is on top – 15...♕d6 16.♖c1!±. Instead **10...♘d7** or **10...♗d7** would have been correct.

B2. 5.♕d4



B2a. 5...♘d3?!; B2b. 5...♘g6.

B2a. 5...♘d3?! 6.♗d3 cd3 7.♘c3 c6

White was threatening ♘b5, e.g. 7...e6 8.♗f4 ♘f6 9.♘b5.

8.♗f4

If White is planning to castle long, this move should be made before ♘f3, as we'll see in a moment. Besides, 8.♘f3 ♘f6 9.0–0 is also good – 9...cd5 10.ed5 e6 11.♖e1 ♗e7 12.♗f4 ♕b6 (12...ed5? 13.♘b5) 13.♕d3 0–0 14.d6 ♖d8 15.♖ad1±, Baburin – Ibragimov, Gorky, 1989.

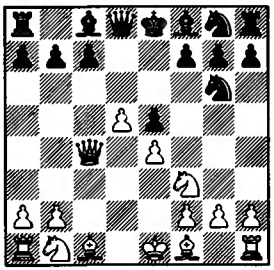
8...♘f6 9.0–0–0 g6

Now White should be careful to guard his dark-squared bishop by:

10.♖d3!? ♗g7 11.♗e5 0–0 12.♘f3± Instead in Volkov – Ibragimov, Moscow 1995 followed 10.♘f3 ♗g7 11.♖d3 ♘h5 12.♗e5 f6 13.♗g3 when 13...♘g3!? 14.hg3 ♕c7∞ (Chekhov) would have destroyed the dangerous bishop.

B2b. 5...♘g6 6.♘f3 e5 7.♕c4

7.♘e5 loses a pieces after ♗b4 8.♗d2 c5.



This position needs further investigation. Usually on c4 is the bishop. This circumstance can prove in White's favour – the light-squared bishop can find a good stand on

g2 or even on h3 after a previous h4-h5, g3. If Black fails to obtain counterplay by b5, c6, he risks to be smothered. Due to insufficient practice, both sides are still groping for the best move order.

7...♘f6

It seems that 7...♗d6 is not so indispensable and should be delayed for a while in favour of preparing c6 as fast as possible. Here are some other examples:

7...a6 8.g3 ♗d6 9.♗g2 ♘f6 (9...♘8e7 10.0–0 c6 11.dc6 ♗e6 12.♕e2 ♘c6 13.♖d1 ♕c7 14.♗e3 ♖d8 15.♘c3 f6 16.♘d5 ♕f7, Sorokin – Maljutin, Wisla 1992 when 17.b4! ♗d5 18.ed5 ♘b4 19.♗b6 ♖b8 20.♘d2± would have imposed White's superiority) 10.0–0 0–0 11.♖d1 ♗d7 12.♗e3 ♕e7 13.h3 h6 14.♕d3 c5 15.a4 b5 16.b3 ♖fc8 17.♘c3 ♕e8 18.ab5 ab5 19.♗f1 ♖ab8 20.♖a6 c4 21.bc4 bc4 22.♕c2 ♗b4 23.♘d2± Sorokin – Scarella, San Martin 1993.

8.h4!?

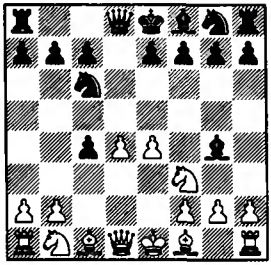
A model for Black could be the game Sherbakov – Komarov, Niksic 1996 where 8.g3 was met by 8...♗d7 9.♘c3 a6 10.a3 b5 11.♕e2 c5 12.dc6, ½–½.

8...♗d7 9.♘c3 a6 10.a4 h6 11.♕b3

Probably White was planning something of the sort of 11.g3 ♘f6 12.h5 ♘e7 13.♗h3 ♗h3 14.♖h3 ♕d7 15.♖h4 c6 16.dc6 ♘c6 17.♗e3, but wanted first to find a less vulnerable place for the queen. Black accepts the challenge.

11...♘f6 12.♕b7 0–0 13.a5 ♕e7 14.♕b3 c6 15.h5 ♖fb8 16.♕c2 ♘f8 17.♗c4 cd5 18.♗d5 ♘d5 19.♘d5 ♕d8 20.♗d2 ♗g4 21.♗c3 ♗f3 22.gf3 ♘e6 23.♖d1 ♘d4 24.♕d3 ♗c7 25.b4± and White enforced his will, Volkov – Volzhin, Dubai 2002.

Chapter 10

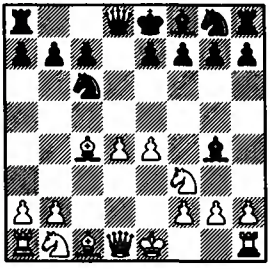


In this chapter we deal with the most testing system against 3...♘c6. Indeed, 4.d5 ♘e5 5.♗f4 ♘g6 6.♗e3 (see B3) offers White a better pawn centre without any weaknesses. However Black has some counterplay linked with the break-trough c7-c6 at an oportune moment, or a kingside pawn storm.

The other major lines 5.♗c4 or 5.♗e3, aimed at maintaining a perfect pawn centre for a long time, are not too efficient. White gets doubled pawns on f3 and f2 and his bishop pair is unable to operate in full power.

A. 5.♗c4
B. 5.d5
5.♗e3 transposes to A2a.

A. 5.♗c4



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘c6 4.♘f3 ♗g4

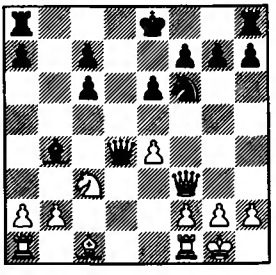
(D20)

Our main line branches here to:
A1. 5...♗f3?!
A2. 5...e6!

A1. 5...♗f3?! 6.♕f3 e6 7.♗b5!

White resorts more frequently to 7.d5 ♘e5 8.♗b5 c6 9.♕c3 cb5! (9...♕b6? 10.♕e5 ♕b5 11.♘c3 ♕a5 12.♗f4 cd5 13.ed5 ♘f6 14.0–0±, Sargissian – Kupreichik, Istanbul 2003) 10.♕e5, but the ending after 10...♕f6 11.♕c7 ♕e7 12.♕e7 ♗e7 13.♘c3 a6 14.de6 fe6=, Peng – Lin Ta, Beijing 1993 is very comfortable for Black.

7...♗b4 8.♘c3 ♕d4 9.♗c6 bc6 10.0-0 ♘f6, J. Christiansen – L. Hansen, Aalborg 1994.



Now **11.♖e1!?**↑ retains some initiative to White, perhaps just enough for a sufficient compensation for the

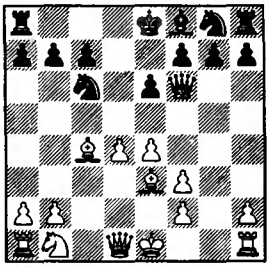
pawn. Let's note that 11.♗e3 is met by 11...♕e5!=, intending ♕h5.

A2. 5...e6!

A2a. 6.♗e3?!; A2b. 6.d5; A2c. 6.♗b5!?

A2a.6.♗e3?! ♗f3 7.gf3 ♕f6!

White has a lot of options here, but he is struggling in all of them.



8.e5

Strategically, this is a very risky move, but after all, you cannot have a strong pawn centre and two bishops for nothing!

Alternatively:

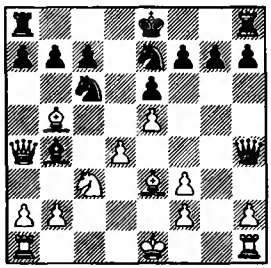
8.♘c3 0–0–0 is clearly in Black's favour: 9.d5 ♗b4 10.♕b3 ed5 11.♗d5 ♕f3 12.♖g1 ♘ge7 13.♖d1 ♗c3 14.♕c3 ♘d5 15.ed5 ♖d5∓, Dudas – Z. Lehmann, Budapest 1997.

8.♗b5 ♗b4 9.♘c3 ♘ge7 10.f4 (10.a3?! is "a clumsy move, as Black will dispose of an extra piece to hit on d4 with ...♗b6" – Lautier. 10...♗a5 11.f4 0–0–0 12.e5 ♕h4 13.♕a4 a6! 14.♗c6 ♘c6 15.0–0–0 ♗c3 16.bc3 g5!∓) 10...0–0–0 11.♕a4 ♘d4 12.0–0–0 ♗c3 13.♕a7 ♘ec6 14.♗c6 ♘c6 15.♕a8 ♘b8 16.bc3 ♕c3 17.♔b1 ♕b4 (17...b6∓) 18.♔a1 ½–½ Lorscheid – Hegeler, Krumbach 1991.

8...♕h4 9.♗b5

White would be very happy to save a tempo with 9.♘c3. Then the inertial 9...♗b4 10.♕a4 ♘ge7 11.0–0–0± is bad, but 9...0–0–0! 10.♕a4 ♖d4! 11.♗d4 ♕d4 12.♖d1 ♕e5∓ is rather convincing.

9...♗b4 10.♘c3 ♘ge7 11.♕a4



11...0–0–0!∓

As strange as it may seem, in all three known games Black players castled under an obvious attack: 11...0–0? 12.0–0–0 ♗c3 (12...a6 13.♗c6 ♘c6 14.♘e4 ♕h5 15.♖hg1→) 13.bc3 ♘d5 14.♕c2. We believe that White has a dangerous initiative here. This is for the record only since after the long castling Black's king is perfectly safe while the d4-pawn is over-attacked.

12.0–0–0 a6 13.♗d3

Or 13.♗c4 ♗c3 14.bc3 ♘d5 15.♗a6 ♘b8.

13...♗c3 (13...♘d4 14.♘e4↑)

14.bc3 ♘d5!∓

White has saved the pawn, but his position is gloom, for 15.♗a6 fails to 15...♘b8∓.

A2b. 6.d5 ed5 7.♗d5 ♕f6! 8.♕b3

The alternatives are inferior:

8.♘c3 ♗b4 9.h3 ♗f3 10.♕f3 ♘d4 11.♕d3 c6 12.0–0 ♖d8 13.e5 ♕e5 14.♗f7 ♔f7 15.♕c4 ♕e6 16.♕b4 ♘c2 17.♕f4 ♘f6 18.♖b1=/∓;

8.♕a4 ♗f3 9.♗c6 bc6 10.gf3 ♗c5 11.f4 (or 11.♘c3 ♘e7 12.f4 0–0 13.♕c4 ♗b6 14.♗d2 ♖ad8 15.0–0–0 ♗f2 16.♘e2 ♖d2 17.♖d2 ♗e3 18.♕d3 ♗d2 19.♕d2 ♘g6 20.♖d1∓, Ward – Baburin, Isle of Man 1997) 11...♘e7 12.♕a5 ♗b6 13.♕e5 ♕h4 14.♖f1 f5 15.♗d2 fe4 16.♘c3 e3 17.♗e3 0–0–0∓, K. Arkell – Rowson, London, 2001.

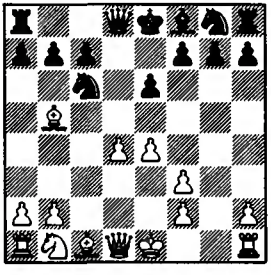
8...♗b4 9.♗d2 ♗f3 10.♕f3 ♘d4 11.♕d3 ♗d2 12.♘d2=.

A2c. 6.♗b5!?

In practice Black has not been convincing in coping with this move. I think that he should double the enemy pawns:

6...♗f3 7.gf3

Or 7.♗c6 bc6 8.gf3 ♗b4 9.♘c3 ♘e7=.

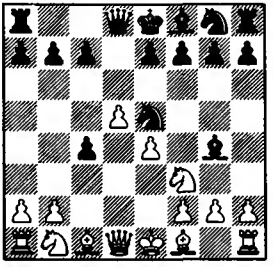


7...♘ge7!?

This is a novelty. I'm not too happy with Black's play in the game Onischuk – Miton, Montreal 2006 which went 7...♗b4 8.♘c3 ♘ge7 9.a3 ♗c3 10.bc3 a6 11.♗d3 e5 12.d5 ♘a5 13.f4 ef4 14.♗f4 0–0, when 15.0–0± would have been pleasant for White with his bishop pair in a rather dynamic position. My suggestion needs testing as 8.♗g5 (8.♗e3 a6) 8...f6 (8...♕d6 9.♘c3 0–0–0 10.♗c6 ♕c6∞) 9.♗e3 a6 10.♗e2 ♕d6∞ leads to a complex, strategically unbalanced game.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘c6 4.♘f3 ♗g4)

B. 5.d5 ♘e5



Major options are:

B1. 6.♕d4?

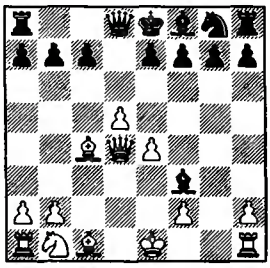
B2. 6.♘bd2

B3. 6.♗f4

6.♘c3 ♘f6 7.♗f4 ♘g6 transposes to B3. That might be a problem if Black wanted to develop the knight to e7. He could try to deviate with Morozevich's suggestion 7...♗f3 8.gf3 ♕d6, but I like White's game after 9.♗g3.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘c6 4.♘f3 ♗g4 5.d5 ♘e5)

B1. 6.♕d4? ♘f3 7.gf3 ♗f3 8.♗c4



This tricky line is incorrect, but Black should know its refutation or he might easily get lost in the maze of sharp variations.

B1a. 8...c6; B1b. 8...f5?! B1c. 8...a6; B1d. 8...♕d6; B1e. 8...e6 B1f. 8...e5!

B1a. 8...c6 9.♖g1 ♘f6 10.♘c3 e6 11.♗g5!

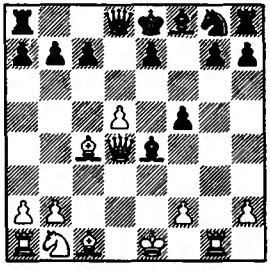
11.♖g3 is worse due to 11...ed5! 12.♘d5 ♘d5! (12...cd5?! 13.♗b5 ♘d7 14.♕d5 ♗d6 15.♖f3 0–0∞ Tauber – Fochtler, 1994) 13.♖f3 ♘f6.

11...♗e7 12.♗f6 ♗f6 13.e5±.

B1b. 8...f5?!

A very interesting suggestion of Ch. Ward, but it is not enough to solve all the problems.

9.♖g1 ♗e4



Without pretending to know the truth in the last instance, we have a hunch that Black will suffer in this situation. White has too many attacking possibilities. Following the first rule of analysis, we'll show that White has at least a draw:

10.♘c3 e5!

An excellent resource! The "natural" 10...♘f6 sumits Black to a total attack. Here is an example – 11.♘e4 fe4 12.♗g5 ♕d6 13.0–0–0 g6 14.f3!? ef3 (14...♕b6 15.♕c3→ ♗g7 16.fe4 0–0–0 17.♔b1!) 15.♖ge1 0–0–0 16.♕a7 ♘d7 17.♖e3 ♗g7 18.♕a8 ♘b8 19.♗f1±.

11.♕e5

As long as 11.♕e3 ♘f6 12.f3 f4 13.♕e2 ♗g6 14.♕e5 ♕e7 or 11.♕d1 (intending f3) 11...♕d6! misses the mark, White has to exchange the queens.

11...♕e7 12.♗f4 0-0-0 13.♘e4 fe4 14.d6! ♕e5 (14...cd6? 15.♕a5!) **15.♗e5 cd6 16.♗e6 ♔b8 17.♗g7 ♗g7 18.♖g7 ♘f6 19.♖c1 ♖he8!**

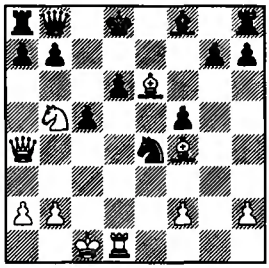
Otherwise Black can only lose: 19...♘h5 20.♖f7 ♖df8 21.♖cc7 or 19...♘e8 20.♖e7 d5 21.♖c5 d4 22.♗d5 ♘d6 23.♗e4±.

20.♖cc7 ♖e6 21.♖b7 ♔a8 22.♖a7 ♔b8=. White has no time to launch the a, b pawns, therefore it is a draw by perpetual check.

Once the draw ensured, you can spend as many days as you like to analyse **10.♗f4!?**

The idea is to prevent the discoordinating e7-e5. Pawns do not count! Black still has **10...c5**, but it is not so nasty as e5: **11.♕d1!?** ♕a5 12.♗d2 ♕c7 13.♕a4 ♔d8 14.♘c3

♘f6 15.0–0–0 ♗f3 16.♘b5 ♗d1 17.♖d1 ♕b8 18.d6 ed6 19.♗f4 ♘e4 20.♗e6+–.

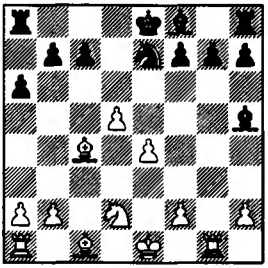


A funny position, isn't it! Though a bit co-operative, this line displays the potential power of White's pieces. As a reserve, White can choose also **11.♕e3!?** ♗d5 12.♗d5 ♕d5 13.♘c3 ♕d4 14.♕f3 ♘f6 15.♖d1 ♕b4 16.♗e5, when the hunting season on black king is open.

B1c. 8...a6

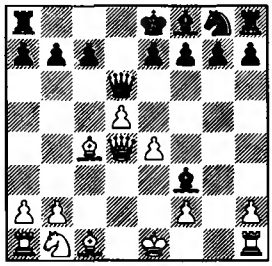
This is not very ambitious, but undoubtedly it is a decent option.

9.♖g1 e5 10.♕e5 ♕e7 11.♕e7 ♘e7 12.♘d2 ♗h5



13.b3∞.

B1d. 8...♕d6



After this move White must be very ingenious in order to get compensation. Now the obvious 9.e5 fails to 9...♕d7! 10.♖g1 e6 11.♘c3 ♘e7∓.

9.♗b5 ♔d8

9...c6 is also unclear after 10.♘d2!! ♗h1? (perhaps Black should take on b5) 11.dc6 ♔d8 12.cb7 ♖b8 13.♕a7 ♕c7 14.♘c4! (White has a perpetual 14.♕d4=, but his attack is worth more than a rook!) 14...♖b7 15.♕d4 ♔c8 16.♗a6 e5 17.♗b7 ♔b7 18.♕d5 ♔c8 19.♗g5+–.

10.♖g1∞

The only sure thing about this position is that noting is clear!

If you ask Fritz, "he" will tell you that White should seriously consider resigning, because of the line

10.♖g1 c5 11.♕e3 ♕h2 12.♖g3 ♗g2.

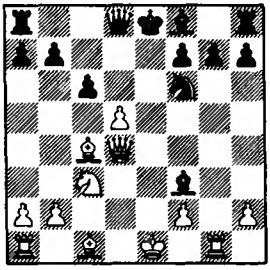
However White has such an overwhelming space advantage, that we cannot imagine that Black can finish development without considerable casualties. For instance:

13.♗f1! ♗f1 14.♔f1 ♘f6 15.e5 ♘d7∞ (15...♘d5 16.♕f3 e6 17.♘c3→) **16.e6 ♘f6 17.♘c3→.**

B1e. 8...e6

I encountered this move in several blitz games. It poses some problems to White, but apparently it does not give full equality.

9.♖g1 ed5 10.ed5 ♘f6 11.♘c3 c6



12.♔f1! ♘d5

Or 12...♗d5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♗d2→ ♕f6 15.♖e1+– ♔d7 16.♕g4 ♔c7 17.♗d5 cd5.

13.♗g5 f6 14.♖e1! ♗e7

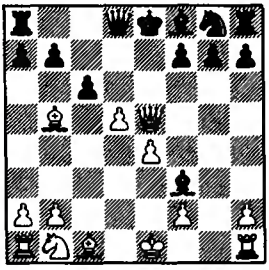
14...♔f7 loses to 15.♕e3.

15.♘d5 ♗d5 16.♗d5 ♕d5

16...cd5 17.♗f6± gf6 18.♕f6+–.

17.♕d5 cd5 18.♗f6 gf6 19.♖g7 ♔d7 20.♖ee7±.

B1f. 8...e5! 9.♗b5 (9.♕c3 ♕f6∓) **9...c6 10.♕e5**



10...♗e7!

10...♘e7? fails to 11.♘d2!! ♕b8 12.dc6±, Oltean – Meszaros, Eger 1990.

10...♕e7? is also bad: 11.dc6 ♕e5 12.cb7 ♕b5 13.ba♕ ♔d7 14.♕a7 ♔e6 15.♘c3 ♗b4 16.♕e3 ♗c3 (16...♗h1? 17.♗d2≅). 17.bc3 ♗h1 18.♗a3 with full compensation for the piece.

11.♖g1 cb5 12.♘d2 f6 13.♕f5 ♗e4 14.♘e4 g6∓.

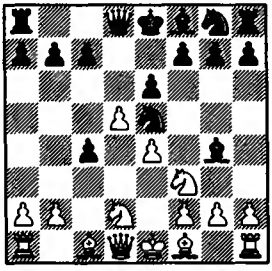
B2. 6.♘bd2

This line could be used only as a surprise.

6...e6!

White's sixth move counts on a tempting pawn sacrifice after 6...♘f6 7.♘c4 ♘c4 8.♗c4. Indeed 8...♘e4?! 9.h3! ♗f3 10.♕f3 ♘d6 11.♗b3 g6 12.♕c3 f6 13.0–0 offered White enterprising play in the simultane game Kasparov – Louro, Lisbon, 1999. Better is 8...e5! 9.de6 ♕d1 10.♔d1 fe6 11.h3 ♗f3 12.gf3± and the bishop pair favours White, Volkov – Quinn, 2000.

6...♕d6 7.♘c4 ♘c4 8.♕a4± is also good for White.

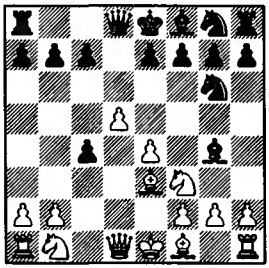


7.♕a4 ♕d7 8.♕d7 ♘d7 9.de6 ♗e6 10.♘d4 ♘e5 11.♘e6 fe6= 12.♘c4 (Or 12.♗c4 ♗b4 13.♗e6 ♘d3 14.♔f1 ♖d8 15.♘b3 ♘c5 16.♘c5 ♖d1 17.♔e2 ♖h1 18.♗d7 ♔f7=, Sherba-

kov – Karpatchev, Novgorod 1999) 12...♗b4 13.♗d2 ♗d2 14.♔d2 ♖d8 15.♔e3 ♘g4 16.♔e2 ♖d4 17.♘d2 ♖d2=, Krasenkow – Kharlov, ECC 2003 Rethymnon, Crete 2003.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e4 ♘c6 4.♘f3 ♗g4 5.d5 ♘e5)

B3. 6.♗f4 ♘g6 7.♗e3



7.♗g3 is well met by 7...e5 and sooner or later White will have to transfer the bishop to the other diagonal. Another drawback is that White is deprived of any plan with h4, g3.

Now Black has to decide:

1. To insert or not 7...♘f6 8.♘c3 before moving the e-pawn:

2. How far to advance the e-pawn.

There is another key point to discuss – should Black lose a tempo to prevent a check from b5, which is linked with the first question.

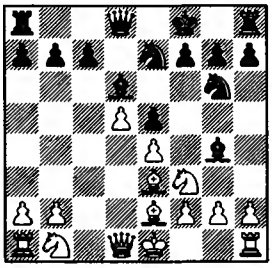
7...♘f6

Recently the most prominent adept of the 3...♘c6 line, Baburin, chose a very rare plan with development of the knight to e7. In all his games he aims to nail the g6-knight on f4 at the first opportunity, so apparently he reached to the conclusion that the other knight should also prepare to strengthen the central dark squares from g6. Another possibility of Black is to thrust ...f7-f5. So he plays:

7...e5 8.♗c4 ♗d6 9.♗b5 ♔f8

9...♗d7 is positionally dubious. Many games have confirmed that Whites has a small, but lasting advantage if he succeeds in trading the light-squared bishops.

10.♗e2 ♘8e7



Now, critical for Baburin's idea is 11.♘fd2! ♗d7 12.0-0. Instead White played the common move:

11.♘c3 ♘f4

Black has lost the right to castle, but impeded his opponent's plans.

12.♗f4 ♗f3! 13.♗g5

I have also analysed 13.♗f3 ef4 14.♕b3. I believe that Black can sacrifice the b7-pawn with 14...♘g6 15.♕b7 (After 15.0–0–0 ♘e5 16.♘e2 Black chooses between 16...a5 17.♕b7 g6 18.h4 h5 19.♘d4 ♔g7 20.♕b3 a4 21.♕c3 ♕f6⩱ or 16...g6 17.♘f4 ♕f6 18.♘d3 ♔g7 19.♔b1 a5⩱) 15...♘e5 16.♕a6 g6 17.h4 h5 18.0–0–0 ♔g7 19.♘e2 ♕f6. In all cases Black has counterplay due to the weak dark squares.

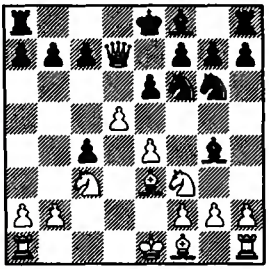
13...♗g2 14.♖g1 ♗h3 15.♗h5 ♗d7∞ Rombaldoni – Baburin, Arvier 19.06.2007.

In Smyslov – Semkov, Roma 1990, the ex-chapmion refrained without any hesitation from checking from b5 in favour of 9.h3 ♗d7 10.h4!? and was better after 10...h6 11.h5 ♘f8 12.♘h4 ♘e7 13.g4. Later games in similar positions have shown that Black should stop further advance of the h-pawn with 10...h5.

Finally, no one has tried 7...e5 8.♗c4 a6 9.♗e2 ♗d6 10.♘fd2 ♗d7 11.0-0 ♘8e7. This set-up is suitable for pawn breaks such as ...c6 or ...f5, but the knight is more passive on e7 than to f6, for it does not hit e4.

8.♘c3 e5

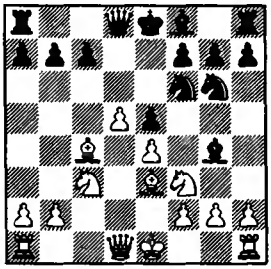
Black used to try quite successfully 8...e6 9.♕a4 ♕d7 10.♕d7, but the intervention of two ex-champions showed that the ending is difficult to Black.



10...♘d7 11.♗c4 ed5 12.♘d5 ♗d6 13.♘d4 c6 14.♘c3 ♘de5 15.♗f1 ♗d7 16.h3 f6 17.0–0–0 ♗c5 18.f4 ♘f7 19.g3 h5 20.♘a4 ♗d6 21.f5 ♘ge5 22.♘e6±, Smyslov – Fontaine, Cannes, 1996.

10...♔d7 11.♘g5! ed5 12.♘f7 ♖g8 13.f3 ♗e6 14.♘g5 c6 15.0–0–0 h6 16.♘e6 ♔e6 17.♗d4 ♗d6 18.♗f6 gf6 19.ed5 cd5 20.♖d5 ♘e5 21.g3 ♗b4 22.♖d4± Karpov – Lautier, Amberblind, Monte Carlo 1997.

9.♗c4



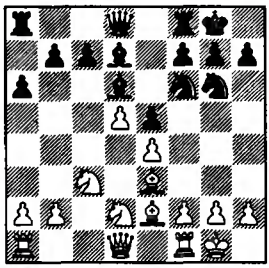
9...a6

I admit that 9...♗d6 10.♗b5 ♔f8 (trading the light-squared bishops deprives Black of any counterplay) looks quite unnatural. In Hauchard – Baburin, Andorra 1998 Black organised some counterplay after 11.♗e2 ♘f4!? 12.♗f4 ♗f3 13.♗f3 ef4 14.♕b3 g6 15.♕b7 ♔g7 16.0–0 h5 17.♘b5 ♖b8 18.♕a6 ♘g4, but his construction is too one-sided and risky.

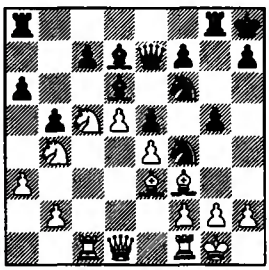
10.♗e2

10.h3 unpins the knight, but probably White would feel safer without weaknesses on the kingside: 10...♗d7 11.0–0 11...♗d6 12.♘d2 0–0 13.♖e1 ♘e8 14.♗f1 ♗e7 15.♘c4 ♘d6 16.♘d6 ♗d6 17.♖c1 ♕h4 18.g3 ♕e7 19.♗g2 h6 20.♘b1 f5 21.ef5 ♗f5 22.♘d2 ♕d7 23.♕h5 ♘e7 24.♘e4 ♗g6 25.♕g4 ♗f5 26.♕h5 ♗g6 ½–½ Razuvaev – Ibragimov, Dortmund 1992.

10...♗d6 11.0-0 0-0 12.♘d2 ♗d7



Perhaps this is the most critical position of the 3...♘c6 line. Its current theoretical status is in White's favour on the ground of the game Karpov – Milov, Biel 1997. It went 13.♖c1?! (13.a3!) ♕e7 14.a3 b5 15.♘b3 ♘f4 16.♗f3 ♔h8? (16...a5!∞) 17.♘a2 g5 18.♘c5 ♖g8 19.♘b4±



Black should avoid such positions. His kingside attack is not too efficient, while the enemy knights will snatch some material on the opposite flank or in the centre.

19...♖g6 20.♕c2 g4 21.♗e2 ♖ag8 22.♖fd1 ♘6h5 23.g3 ♗c8 24.♘c6 ♕g5 25.♗f1 ♖h6 26.♕c3 ♘f6 27.♘d3 ♕h5 28.h4 gh3 29.♘de5+–.

Let me formulate now some conclusions about this line, drawn from the analysis of all the games in my database.

1. I have not seen a single game where Black triumphed with a kingside attack, no matter what he tried.

2. Black had a good game only when he achieved the c6-break at the right moment, or when he cut off White's knights from the fifth rank, thus getting a free hand on the kingside.

3. If White reaches the c5-square with a knight, he gets a clear edge.

Therefore, I will not discuss whether Black should attack with the h or g-pawn, and how he should set up his knights on the kingside. To me that is irrelevant for the evaluation of the position. It is more important to see could Black defend his queenside from the invasion of White's knights.

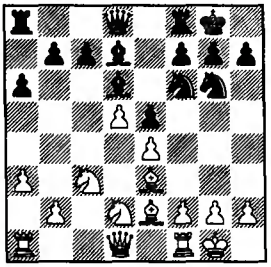
13.a3! (anticipating b5-b4).

The move order is very important. The alternatives are:

13.♘c4 ♗b4. Here a3 would have been welcomed! Attacking the e4-pawn Black wins the tempo, needed for undermining White's centre. 14.♕c2 b5 15.♘d2 c6 16.dc6 ♗c6 17.♖fd1 ♕e7 18.a3 ♗d6 19.♘b3 ♖ac8 20.f3 ♘f4 21.♗f1 ♖fd8=, Beliavsky – Kharlov, Istanbul 2003.

13.♖c1 allowed Black to expand on the queenside in A. Kuzmin – Baburin, Andorra 1998: 13...b5 14.a3 c5 (or 14...♕e7 15.♘b3 ♘f4 16.♗f3 a5!∞) 15.dc6 ♗c6 16.♘a4 ♖c8 17.♘c5 ♘f4, A. Kuzmin – Baburin,

Andorra 1998 when 17...♗c5! 18.♗c5 ♖e8= would have given Black a comfortable equality.



13...b5

This is the most popular answer, but probably it is not best! Perhaps 13...♕e7!? is more precise. Then 14.♖c1 b5 is satisfactory for Black, as we'll see later, so White should go for 14.♘c4 ♗c5 15.♗c5! (15.♗g5 ♕d8 16.♖c1 ♗d4 was roughly equal in Yakovich – Kharlov, Kazan 1997) 15...♕c5 16.♖c1. He has a slight edge here, but Black's position is quite solid.

14.♘b3!

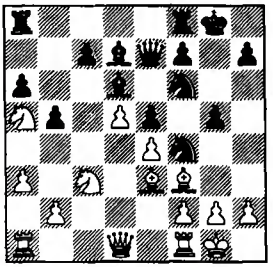
14.♖c1 ♕e7 transposes to the game Karpov – Milov. White chose 15.♘b3 ♘f4 16.♗f3, when instead of 16...♔h8? 17.♘a2±, Black had 16...a5! The point is that 17.♘a2 would be met by 17...b4! with counterplay.

White could try to manoeuvre the other knight to c6: 15.♘a2, but then 15...a5 is also good, as well as 15...♘f4 16.♗f3 (or 16.♘b4 ♘e2 17.♕e2 ♘g4 18.♘c6 ♕h4 19.♘f3 ♕h5 20.h3 ♘e3 21.♕e3 f5∞) 16...a5.

14...♕e7 15.♘a5

White's knight managed to sneak into Black's camp. However on a5 it is not as efficient as it would have been from c5. That gives Black chances to maintain some balance.

15...♘f4 16.♗f3 g5



Here, 17.♘c6 is premature, due to 17...♗c6 18.dc6 ♗c5.

Let's try 17.g3. Then: 17...♔h8! 18.gf4 gf4→ 19.♗d2 ♖g8 20.♔h1 ♘g4 21.♗g4 ♗g4 22.f3 ♗h3 23.♖f2 ♗c5 24.♖e2 ♕g5–+. Clearly, c5 is a critical square, so 17.b4!? looks consistent. Probably Black should then try a pawn storm with 17...h5 with sharp play (still I prefer White). Here are two variations:

18.g3?! (the engines like this move very much!) 18...♔h8 19.gf4 gf4 20.♗d2 ♘g4 21.♗g4 hg4 with nice compensation, e.g. 22.♔h1 ♕h4 23.♖g1 ♖g8 24.♖g2 ♖g7 25.♕g1 ♖h7 26.♘b7 ♔g7 27.♘d6 cd6 28.f3 g3 29.♗e1 ♗h3→;

18.♕d2 ♔g7 19.♘b7 ♖h8 20.♘c5 g4 21.♗e2 h4 22.♘d7 ♕d7 23.g3 ♘e2 24.♕e2 ♖h5 25.♕d3 ♖ah8 26.♖a2 ♗e7 27.♖d2 ♘e8∞.

Finally, 17.♖c1 transposes to the game Lugovoi – Kharlov, Rethymnon 2003. Let's follow it:

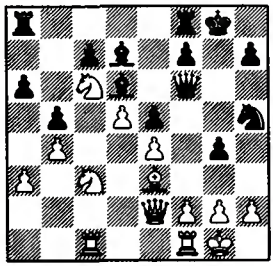
17.♖c1 g4 18.♗e2 ♘e2

Computers suggest 18...b4 19.ab4 ♗b4 20.♘b3 (20.♖a1 ♗c3 21.bc3 ♘e4 22.♗f4 ef4 23.♗g4 ♘c3 24.♕f3

♗g4=) 20...♖fb8 21.♘d2 a5 22.g3 ♘h3 23.♔g2 h5, but Black's king is rather weak.

19.♕e2 ♘h5 20.♘c6 ♕f6 21.b4

(see the diagram)



Both sides realised their plans. I think that Black would have had sufficient counterplay with 21...♕g6 22.♕d2 (22.g3 f5) 22...f5⇄, instead of the passive 21...♖fe8.

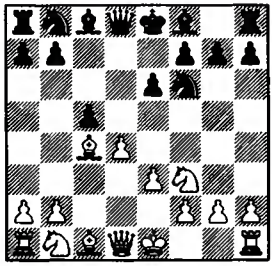
Conclusion

3...♘c6 is probably the most interesting response to 3.e4 nowadays, with a surprisingly small percentage of draws. In many lines Black gets surprisingly rich play against the enemy pawn centre. White should be very careful to avoid numerous traps. For instance, 4.♗e3 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.d5 ♘a5! is linked with a promising piece sacrifice, and 5.f3 e5 6.d5 ♘d4! offers a pawn. In both cases Black has good compensation as seen in Chapter 9.

4.♘f3 ♗g4 5.d5 ♘e5 is the "academic" line. Then 6.♗f4 ♘g6 7.♗e3 ♘f6 8.♘c3 e5 leads to a well known pawn structure where White's better centre should offer him some advantage. At highest level Black's kingside attack most often fails against precise defence. However Black could choose a more complex strategy than just throwing everything against the enemy king. He should look for a chance to undermine the centre with...c6, or at least deprive White's knights of c5 and c4-squares. Then he would get time for expanding on the kingside. A good resource in such cases is opening the f-file with ...f5.

Part 2

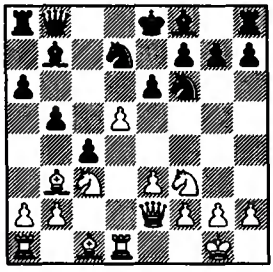
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5



In this part we examine the most popular system against the QGA. No matter how fashionable 3.e4 or some other variation may be, the calm natural development 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 occurs in good two thirds of all the games that feature the QGA. It is widely known as the Classical System.

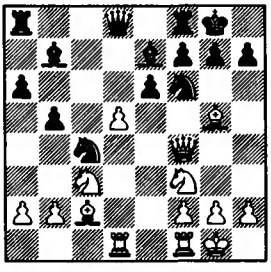
For a non-professional player it has one very attractive feature – one can play it without too much digging in the books. Opening catastrophes are very rare as White's play follows fundamental strategic rules – quick development, fight for the centre, no weaknesses, good piece co-ordination. This approach is like an insurance policy against opening surprises. At the same time the Classical system offers a wide range of plans to suit any taste. Nowadays 6.0–0 a6 7.♗b3 is probably the sharpest and most testing variation, but 7.dc5 which leads to a calm symmetrical ending, has its venom too. In short, you can pick a suitable line, invest some time to study it, and you'll have a reliable weapon against the QGA for years.

The first thing White should learn is that the old "main" lines that could be found in some dusty books, are insufficient for even the smallest advantage and have practically become obsolete. After 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗b3 ♗b7 9.a4 b4 or 9...♘bd7 Black equalises, while 9.♖d1 ♘bd7 10.♘c3 ♕b8! 11.d5 c4 is even risky for White.

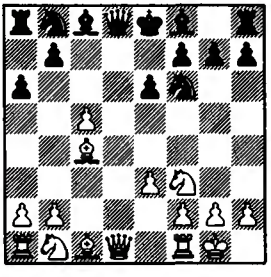


The decline of these variations shifted the focus of investigations to other options on the seventh move. Apart from 7.a4, which is analysed in Chapter 18, White players have also adopted the moves 7.♗d3 and 7.♗b3. Both are aimed at hindering the normal development of Black with b5, which would be countered

by 8.a4. Modern practice has shown that even then Black gets fair counterchances. Do not forget however, that this is the fast theoretical lane where things change quickly. Every strong tournament produces important novelties. We devote three chapters to 7.♗b3 because of its importance for the theory. Another thing to know before going to these chapters is that White accepts to play with an isolated queens pawn and often sacrifices it on d5 for a kingside attack.



The antipode is the exchange system 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.dc5.



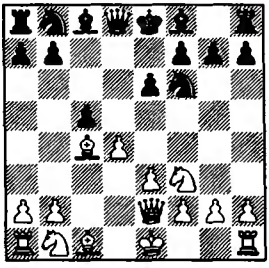
Symmetry and simplification could be very deceiving. Black usually has to work hard for many moves before becoming able to breath freely. More than once Black seemingly resolved the problems of development, significantly reduced the material, only to discover that his situation is aggravating with every move. Some very strong players admit that Black's position is solid, but quite annoying to defend. If you play the QGA for Black, do not underestimate this system! Do your homework and learn well some clear-cut defensive plan. Of course, this system will never be the most dangerous plan against the QGA, but it is the safest for sure.

More ambitious plan is the Furman variation – 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2, intending to meet 6...a6 with 7.dc5. Black is not able to prevent the opponent from pushing e3-e4, so he must quickly look for counterplay on the queenside by b7-b5. White obtains some temporary initiative.

7.a4 is a universal plan which is possible against nearly every move order or trick of Black. However there is a deficit of new ideas in that variation and usually White does not achieve anything substantial.

Chapter 11

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2



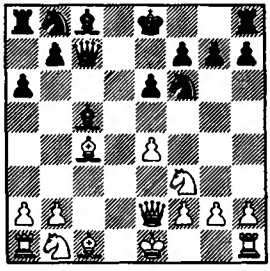
(D26)

This variation has been introduced by the prominent Soviet player and coach Semen Furman. For many years it had the role of a side lane in the QGA. Probably it was due to the symmetrical type of the arising positions, that was quite mistakenly assumed as a herald of draw. Funny enough, the Furman variation has always been earning White better results than its reputation. If you check the statistics in a huge database, you'll be surprised to see that White scores about 64% after 6.♕e2, while the most common 6.0–0 hits "only" 57%. We believe that such result is not by chance and Black must be very well prepared to avoid falling into a cramped position without any counterplay, right from the opening. As in most symmetrical structures, the extra tempo offers White an initial pressure, which could be neutralized only with very accurate play. Latest researches found new resources for White in some lines which have been assessed as harmless. This limits Black's choice at some key points to a narrow path into the jungle of variations.

Most of the lines in the Furman variation are not forced, (at least for White!) and it is difficult to distribute the ample practical material into distinct main branches. However several key positions should be kept in mind:

Key Position 1

6...a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.e4 ♕c7



One of the main positional threats of White in the Furman variation is to nail a pawn on e5, gaining space in the centre. Respectively, Black tries to hinder that, and his last move is aimed exactly against e4-e5. The latest games prove that:

1. Black is unable to prevent the White pawn from reaching e5.

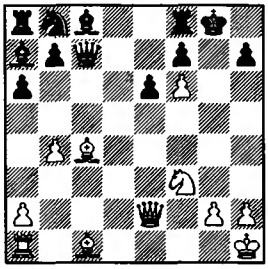
2. Black cannot win the over-

extended e5-pawn without considerable concessions.

9.e5! (nonetheless!) **9...♘g4 10.0-0 ♘f2 11.♘c3!?**

Ivan Sokolov's patent.

The game Lputian – Dlugy, New York 1998 produced a sensation with the novelty 11.b4!? ♘h3 12.♔h1 ♘f2 13.♖f2 ♗f2 14.♘bd2 ♗a7 15.♘e4 0-0 16.♘f6! gf6 17.ef6



17...♘d7? 18.♕d2!+–. The enormous analysis, published by Stohl, effectively confused everybody and annihilated all the itching to retest this idea. In short, it appears that Black could have survived with 17...♖d8! 18.♗g5 b5 19.♗b3 ♘c6, when 20.♕e4 ♘d4 21.♗h6 ♘f5 22.♕g4= leads to perpetual, while 20.♖c1!? is still unclear.

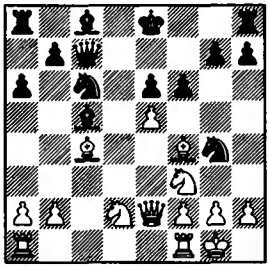
Even more unclear is the situation after 11...♗a7!? (instead of 11...♘h3). White can venture into 12.♘bd2 (12.♗e3 ♗e3 13.♕e3 b5 14.♗e2 ♘g4 15.♕e4 ♕a7 16.♔h1 f5∓) 12...♘g4 13.♔h1 ♘e3 14.♗b2 ♘f1 15.♖f1 to be followed by ♘e4. How strong is White's attack could be decided after a practical test.

After 11.♘c3 the play could go on **11...♘e4** (11...b5 12.♗b3 ♘e4 13.♔h1 ♘c3 14.bc3 h6 15.♘d4 ♕e7 16.♕g4↑ I. Sokolov – K. Georgiev, Tilburg 1994) **12.♔h1 ♘c3 13.bc3 ♘d7!** (13...♗e7 14.♘g5 ♗g5 15.♗g5 ♘c6 16.♕h5 h6 17.♖ad1 ♖f8 18.♗h4 ♗d7 19.♖d6 ♘e5 20.♕e5 ♕c4 21.♖fd1 ♕h4 22.♖d7 ♖c8 23.♖b7 1–0, I. Sokolov – Brenninkmeijer, NLD-ch 1995). We think that the initiative of White is beyond doubt and it could be developed by 14.♕e4!? (Stohl suggests 14.♘g5 ♕e5 15.♕h5 g6 16.♕f3 ♕g7 17.♘f7 0–0 18.♘h6=) 14...♖a7 15.♕g4→.

Key Position 2

OK, the white pawn can reach e5, but how safe it will be there?

6...a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.e4 ♕c7 9.0–0 ♘c6 10.e5 ♘g4 11.♗f4 f6 12.♘bd2



Black eventually wins the cramping pawn, but the price is too high – he will be deprived of any counterplay. White should only be careful to move the queen away from e2 before playing ♘d2-f3. Otherwise Black will trade the knights through d4, equalizing.

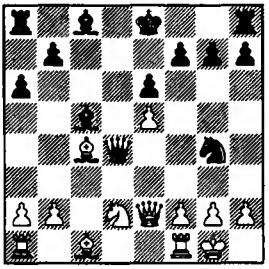
12...♘ge5 (Delaying the capture is to no avail, 12...0–0 13.♖ac1 ♗a7 14.♗g3! f5 15.♗f4! ♗d7 16.h3 ♘h6

17.♗e3!±, Semkov – Sapi, Forli 1988) **13.♘e5 fe5 14.♗g3** 0–0 **15.♖ac1 ♕e7** (or 15...♗e7 16.♘f3 ♗f6 17.♖fd1 ♔h8 18.♗d3 ♕f7 19.h4 ♗d7 20.♘g5 ♗g5 21.hg5 ♖ad8 22.♖c4±, Moskalenko – Dao Thien Hai, Budapest 1994) **16.♕e4↑** ♗d4 17.b3 ♗d7 18.♘f3 ♕f6 19.♗d3 g6 20.h4 ♕g7 21.♖fe1 ♖f5 22.♕e2 ♖h5 23.♗e4± ♖e8 24.b4 ♕e7 25.b5 ab5 26.♕b5 ♕b4 27.♕d3 ♖a8 28.♖b1 ♕c3 29.♖b7 ♕d3 30.♗d3 ♗c8 31.♖c7 ♘b4 32.♗e4 ♘d5 33.♗d5 1–0, Kempinski – Meins, Groningen 1998.

Key Position 3

The other way to win the e5-pawn also puts Black to the wall:

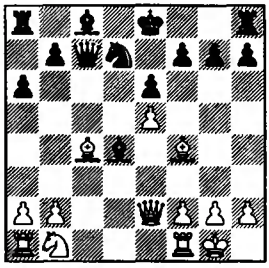
6...a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.0–0 **♘c6 9.e4 ♘g4 10.e5 ♘d4 11.♘d4 ♕d4 12.♘d2!**



12...♘e5 (12...b5 13.♗d3 ♘e5 14.♘b3±) **13.♘b3 ♕c4 14.♕e5 ♗f8 15.♗e3** (15.♖d1, intending to prevent ♕d5, is over-ambitious – 15...f6 16.♕g3 e5 17.f4 ♕e2 18.♗e3 ♕g4 19.♕e1 ♗e7 20.fe5 0–0 21.ef6 ♖f6 22.♗c5 ♗c5 23.♘c5 ♗f5=, Stojanovic – Ibragimov, Ubeda 1997) **15...♕d5** (15...f6 16.♕h5 g6 17.♕f3 ♗e7 18.♖ac1 ♕d5 19.♕d5 ed5 20.♖fe1± Lerner – Sorokin, Moscow 1992) **16.♕g3 ♗d6!? 17.f4! ♕e4 18.♖ad1 ♗e7 19.f5! ef5 20.♖fe1!±** ♕g4 21.♕c7 ♗e6 22.♖d4 ♕g6 23.♕b7 ♖c8 24.♗f4 intending 25.♗d6+–, Gelfand – Salov, Madrid 1996.

Key Position 4

6... a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.0–0 **♘c6 9.e4 ♕c7 10.e5 ♘d7 11.♗f4 ♘d4 12.♘d4 ♗d4**

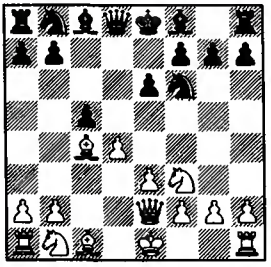


13.♖d1! (after 13.♖c1 ♕b8! White will have to play 14.♖e1) **13...♗b2** 14.♕b2 ♕c4 15.♖d4 ♕b5 16.♕d2 0–0 17.♘a3 ♕c5 18.♘c4 (Black is in a kind of zugzwang) 18...f6 19.♖c1 ♕e7 20.ef6 ♕f6 21.♗g5 ♕g6 22.♖d7 ♗d7 23.♘e5±, Wolff – Rachels, USA 1992.

These examples show that the main defence of Black from some ten years ago has suffered severe blows and must be reconsidered. Nowadays Black players steer their investigations in another direction, successfully meeting 8.e4 by b5.

Adequately armed with the knowledge of our key positions, we can proceed now to the move-by-

move presentation.



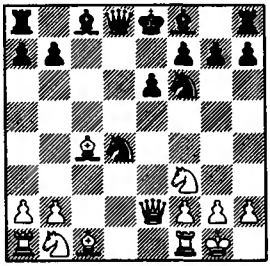
6...a6

6...♘c6 is not entirely in the spirit of the QGA. White can simply castle and wait to see what will be coming next: 7.0–0. Then 7...cd4 will lead to the Steinitz system, and **7...a6** will offer White a very pleasant choice between the common 8.♖d1 and 8.a3. The latter is designed against a possible waiting game of Black, when he plays b7-b5, ♗b7, ♗e7, refraining from creating an isolator on d4. In such case White will exchange on c5 and, depending on the situation, will push b4 or e4. A separate branch could be **8.a3** cd4 9.♖d1 b5 10.♗a2 **d3** 11.♖d3 ♕c7 12.e4! ♘g4 13.h3 ♘ge5 14.♘e5 ♕e5 15.♗e3! ♗b7 (15...♕e4 16.♘c3 ♕g6 17.♘d5 ed5 18.♗d5±) 16.♘c3 ♗c5 17.♖ad1 0–0, Kramnik – Topalov, FIDE-Wch k.o. g/25+10 Las Vegas 1999, when instead of 18.f4 even stronger was 18.♖d7!?±.

6...cd4 7.ed4 ♘c6 could be used to test White's nerves. What shall he do now? He can choose the ugly move 8.♗e3. Then he will have to play an IQP position with an early commitment of the bishop to e3. It is certainly not the ideal disposition for it. Black has a wide choice – an early ♘d5 or ♕a5 to vacate the d8-square for the rook. The most popular is 8...♗e7 9.0–0 0–0 10.♘c3 ♘a5 11.♗d3 b6 12.♖ad1 ♗b7 13.♘e5 We are inclined to assess this position as equal and probably the best way to prove that is 13...♘d5! The normal 13...♖c8 met a bold reaction in Agrest – Magem Badals, Metz 1999: 14.f4!? ♘d5 15.f5 ♘e3 16.♕e3 ♗g5 17.♕f2 ♗h4 18.♕f4 ♕g5 19.♘e4 ♕f4 20.♖f4±.

Whoever wants to play the Furman variation should be prepared to sac the central pawn:

8.0–0! ♘d4?



The game Mchedlishvili – A. Mikhalchishin, Turkiye, 2006 has practically killed this move! The alternative 8...♗e7 is however passive: 9.♖d1 0–0 10.a3! when neither 10...a6 11.♘c3 b5 12.d5! ed5 13.♘d5 ♗d7 14.♗a2 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ♕c7 16.♕e4 ♖ae8 17.♗f4 ♕c8 18.♖ac1 ♗d6 19.♗d6 ♖e4 20.♗e4+–, P. Nielsen – Sadvakasov, Bled 2002., nor 10...♘d5 11.♘c3 ♖e8 12.♕e4! ♘f6 13.♕c2 ♘d5 14.♗a2 ♗f6 15.♘e4± would offer Black an easy life. More details on this variation could be found in another CHESS STARS publication

– "Opening for White according to Kramnik" by Khalifman, vol.4, pp. 117-118.

9.♘d4 ♕d4 10.♖d1!

It is important to repel the queen to the queenside.

After 10.♘c3 ♗d7 11.♖d1 the queen can go to g4!

11.♘c3!

Or 11.♗b5 ♗d7 12.♗d7 ♘d7 13.♘c3 ♘f6 14.♗e3 ♕a5=.

11...♗d7

Alternatively: 11...♗e7 12.♗e3 ♕a5 13.♗b5 ♗d7 14.♗d7 ♘d7 15.♕f3⩲; 11...a6 12.♗e3 ♕a5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♖d5 ♕c7 15.♖c1±.

12.♗g5 a6

12...♗e7? loses to 13.♖d7 ♔d7 14.♗b5 ♔c7 15.♘a4. Mchedlishvili suggests in Informator 96 12...♗c6 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♕e6 with equality, but instead of that sacrifice, White achieves a big advantage with 13.♘b5 ♗e7 14.♗e3 ♕a5 15.a3 ♘d5 16.b4 ♕d8 17.♗d5 ♗d5 18.♗c5±.

13.♗f6 gf6 14.♘d5 ♕d8 15.♖d2!±

White won the game in a crushing style. I suppose that no one will take on d4 again.

7.dc5 ♗c5

The Furman variation branches here into two distinct lines. In the first one, White sets about gaining space in the centre, trying to build a set-up which features a pawn on e5 and a knight on e4 – A. 8.e4. It should be noted right away that as most ideal things in life, this one is also unlikely to be achieved against best defence. That is why B. 8.0–0 is seen more often. It is more flexible and allows White to keep the e4-plan for the most appropriate moment, holding in reserve an entirely different approach – a3, b4, playing for quick development.

A. 8.e4 b5!

The latest development of this variation proved that Black's attempts to impede the advance e4-e5 are futile:

8...♕c7?! 9.e5! ♘g4

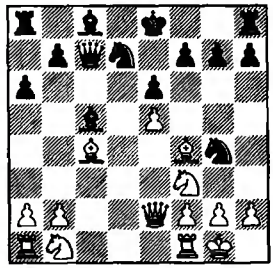
9...♘d7 10.0–0 ♘c6 11.♗f4 ♘d4 12.♘d4 ♗d4 13.♖d1!± leads to Key Position 4.

10.0-0 ♘d7

10...♘f2 brings us to Key Position 1, (see the beginning of the chapter) when 11.♘c3!? ♘e4 12.♔h1 ♘c3 13.bc3 ♘d7! 14.♕e4!? looks very attractive.

10...♘c6 11.♗f4 f6 12.♘bd2± is Key Position 2. Instead of the dubious 11...f6 Black might test 11...b5 12.♗d3 ♗b7, but 13.♘c3!± should be enough to win the opening battle.

11.♗f4



11...b5

You cannot lose tempi in a cramped position and hope to emerge unpunished: 11...♘f8 12.♘bd2 ♘g6

13.♗g3 0–0 14.♖ac1 ♕e7 15.♘e4 ♗a7, Kallai – Hauchard, France, 1996, 16.♘d6±.

12.♗b3 ♗b7 (12...f6? 13.ef6! ♕f4 14.♕e6 ♔d8 15.fg7+–) 13.♘bd2 0–0

In Baburin – Peric, France 1995 was 14.h3?! ♘f6!, returning into the game. As Baburin pointed out,

14.♖ac1 ♕b8 15.♗c2± would have earned White an edge.

Black has also been trying without much success:

8...♘c6, when 9.e5! ♘g4 10.0–0 ♘d4 11.♘d4 ♕d4 12.♘d2± faces us with Key Position 3.

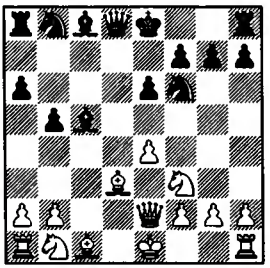
Now White has two retreats of roughly equal worth:

A1. 9.♗d3 and A2. 9.♗b3.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.e4 b5)

A1. 9.♗d3

This move could be very good, provided White succeeds to play e5. However Black possesses at least two methods of preventing it: to incorporate a pawn or a knight on the way of the white pawn. Here are some examples:



9...♘c6 10.♘bd2 e5 11.a4 (11.0–0 0–0 12.♘b3 ♗b6 13.♗e3 ♗g4 14.♖fd1 ♗e3 15.♕e3 ♕e7 16.♖ac1 ♖ac8=, Najdorf – Rossetto, Mar del Plata1961) **11...ba4 12.♖a4 0-0 13.0-0=**, Komarov – Lazarev, Saint Vincent 2000.

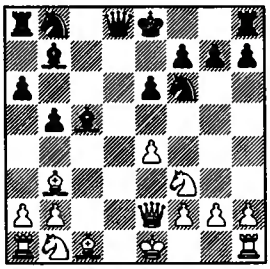
9...♘c6 10.♘bd2 ♘g4 11.0–0 ♘ge5 12.♘e5 ♘e5 13.♗c2 0–0 14.♘b3 ♗b6 15.♖d1 ♕f6 16.♖b1 ♗b7 17.♗e3 ♗e3 18.♕e3 ♖ac8∓, Lputian – A. Horvath, Halkidiki 2002.

9...♘c6 10.♘c3 e5 (the other plan is also good – 10...♘g4 11.0–0 ♘ge5 12.♗c2 ♘f3 13.♕f3 ♘d4↑, Dittmar – Levin, Bad Woerishofen 1996) **11.h3 ♘d4 12.♘d4 ♗d4=**, Tyomkin – Lazarev, Montreal 2000.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.e4 b5)

A2. 9.♗b3 ♗b7!

That is the prime drawback of the early e4 – White has to defend the pawn. Of course, he could also push it forward, but after 10.e5 ♘d5 the white knight is not able to reach the crucial point e4. Passing through c3, it would be exchanged, while ♘bd2 would leave the f4-square unguarded.



A2a. 10.♗c2 ♘c6!

Common sense in chess prompts

Black to fight for the weakened d4-square. The passive 10...♘bd7 11.0–0 ♕b8 12.♘bd2 0–0 13.e5 ♘g4 14.♘e4 ♘ge5 15.♗f4 ♘f3 16.♕f3 ♕a7 17.♕h3 ♗d4 18.♘c5 ♘f6 19.♘d7! gave White an edge in Sadler – Brunner, Bern 1996.

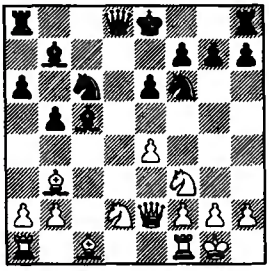
11.♘bd2 (11.0–0 ♘b4; 11.♘c3 b4 12.♘a4 ♘d4!) **11...♕c7 12.0–0 ♖c8!↑**

White is already on the defensive.

13.e5 ♘d4 14.♘d4 ♗d4 15.ef6 ♕c2 16.fg7 ♖g8∓, Wells – Maksimenko, Copenhagen 1996.

A2b. 10.♘bd2 ♘c6 11.0–0

The most flexible option. In Rapoport – Maryasin, Beersheba 1998 was 11.e5?! ♘g4 12.0–0 ♘d4 13.♘d4 ♕d4 14.♘f3 when the most simple decision would have been 14...♕e4!? and Black has excellent game since 15.♕e4 ♗e4 16.♗f4 ♗d3∓ would be a catastrophe.



11...♘d4!

Strangly, this natural move has not occurred in tournaments yet. The other attempts are not entirely convincing because of some tactical nuances that provide White with the initiative.

For example 11...e5 is met by 12.a4! ♕b6 13.ab5 ab5 14.♖a8 ♗a8 15.♗d5 0–0 16.♗c6 ♗c6 17.♘e5±, Buckley – Duncan, Hampstead 1998.

11...♘d7 12.♗c2 e5 13.a4 b4 14.♘b3 ♗a7 15.♗g5 ♕c7 16.♖fc1!? 0–0 17.♗d3↑ ♕d6 18.♗c4 ♘d4 19.♘fd4 ed4 20.♘a5!±, Kempinski – Kharlov, Saint Vincent 2000 also proved in White's favour, but in this game 12...♕c7! 13.♘b3 ♗b6 14.♗e3 0–0 15.♖ac1 ♖ac8 would have brought Black very close to equality.

12.♘d4 ♕d4 13.♗c2 ♕e5 14.a4 0–0=.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5)

B. 8.0–0

Main options are:
B1. 8...♘c6 and B2. 8...b5

B1. 8...♘c6

This move order appears to be optimal for Black. The key moment is that Black cannot successfully exploit the advance 9.e4 (intending e5) and should rather look for counterplay connected with harassing the ♗c4 by 9...b5. If White then settled for 10.♗d3, Black is best off after 10...e5 when ♗d3 is not a gem in White's set-up. Accordingly, if White refrains from pushing the e-pawn, Black could also avoid creating a crucial in some cases weakness on c5 – he could play b7-b6 or direct the bishop to d7-e8.

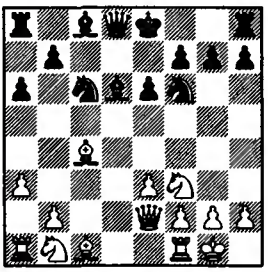
B1a. 9.a3 ♗d6

Black could preserve symmetry,

but that would mean struggling for the draw: 9...b5 10.♗d3 ♗b7 11.b4 ♗e7.

Special attention deserves 11...♗d6 12.♗b2 0–0 13.♘bd2 ♕e7 14.♖ac1!? ♖fc8, when 15.♗f6! gf6 (15...♕f6 16.♘e4 ♕e7 17.♘d6 ♕d6 18.♘g5 h6 19.♘e4 ♕e7 20.♘c5↑) 16.♘e4 ♘d8 17.♘d4↑ ensured White some initiative in Khalifman – Kharlov, Novosibirsk, 1995. The possibility of the hit 15.♗f6! could explain why Kasparov preferred to retreat the bishop to e7 while evacuating the queen to b6.

12.♗b2 0–0 13.♘bd2 ♕b6, Kramnik – Kasparov, 5' Moscow 1998. Here, 14.♘b3?! a5= allowed Black to annihilate the queenside pawns, achieving full equality. A sterner test would have been 14.♖ac1, having in mind the manoeuvre ♘f3-g5-e4, or even e4, should Black weaken his castle by h7-h6. At the same time, the already familiar method 14...a5 is bad in the concrete situation, e.g. 15.ba5 ♖a5 16.♖c3 ♖fa8 17.♖b3±.



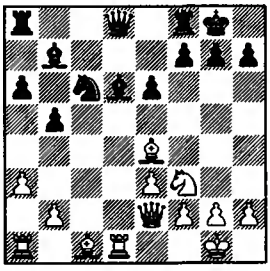
10.♘bd2 0–0

We already know that Black cannot completely level the chances by swapping a couple of minor pieces. He loses tempi in the process, which may eventually tell: 10...♕c7 11.b4 ♘e5 12.♗b2 0–0 13.♗e5 ♗e5 14.♖ac1 ♕b8 15.♘e5 ♕e5 16.♘f3 ♕b8 17.e4 e5 18.♕b2 b5 19.♗b3 ♗b7 20.♘e5 ♗e4 21.♖c5±, Maksimenko – Kharlov, Niksic 1996.

11.♗d3

Or 11.b4 b5 12.♗a2 a5 13.ba5♗a6= Ionov – Vorobiov, Sochi 2007.

11...b5 12.♘e4 ♘e4 13.♗e4 ♗b7 14.♖d1



14...f5!?

A thematical strike, which usually allows Black to obtain fair counterplay, though not without risk.

15.♗b1 ♕c7 16.a4 ba4 17.♖a4 ♘b4 18.e4 a5 19.h3∞.

We have been following the game Topalov – Lautier, Amsterdam 1996. Instead of 19...♗c5, **19...♗a6 20.♕e1 ♗c4=** would have led to double-edged play.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.0–0 ♘c6)

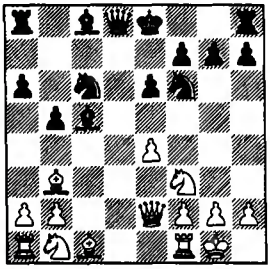
B1b. 9.e4 b5!

It is better not to hinder e4-e5: 9...♘g4?! 10.e5! ♘d4 11.♘d4 ♕d4 12.♘bd2↑ – see Key Position 3 in the beginning of the chapter. Or

9...♕c7?! 10.e5! ♘g4 (10...♘d7 11.♗f4 ♘d4 – see Key Position 4) 11.♗f4 f6 12.♘bd2↑ – see Key Position 2.

10.♗b3

Or 10.♗d3 e5=, Kortschnoj – Karpov, Zuerich, 2006.



10...♘d4!?

10...e5 is too straightforward, though White players have not been too successful against it: 11.♗e3 ♕b6 (11...♗e3 leads to similar positions) 12.♘c3 ♗e3 13.fe3 ♗e6! 14.♗e6 fe6 and 15.♖ad1 (15.♘g5 ♘d8□=) 15...0–0 16.♖d6?! ♕c7 17.♖e6 does not work in view of 17...♕d7 18.♘g5 h6 19.♖d1 ♕c8 20.♘d5 ♘d5 21.ed5 ♘d8∓. We believe that White retains some pressure after 12.♗c5! ♕c5 13.♘bd2 0–0 14.♖ac1 ♕d6 15.♕e3 ♘d4 16.♘d4 ed4 17.♕g5 ♖e8 18.♖fe1±.

10...♗b7 is not concrete and after 11.♘c3! Black again will have to resort to 11...♘d4! (11...b4 12.♖d1 ♕c7 13.e5±) 12.♘d4 ♗d4 13.e5 ♘d5 (13...♗c3 14.bc3 ♘e4 15.♕g4±) 14.♘d5 ♗d5 15.♖d1 ♗b3 16.ab3 ♕b6 17.b4 0–0 18.♗g5 f6 19.ef6 ♗f6 20.♗e3 ♕c6=.

11.♘d4 ♕d4 12.♗e3!

12.♘c3 is well met by 12...♕e5 13.♗e3 ♗e3 14.♕e3 ♘g4=.

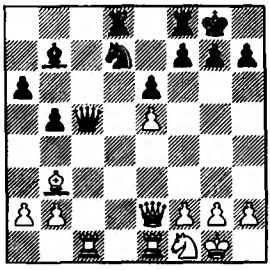
12...♕e5!

The latest word in this line. There is no reason to give White the initiative by 12...♕e4 13.♘d2 ♕f5 14.g4↑.

13.♗c5 ♕c5 14.♘d2

14.♘c3 is innocuous: 14...♗b7 15.♖ac1 (15.♖ad1! b4 16.♘a4 ♕b5 17.♕e3 0–0 18.♘c5 ♖fd8=) 15...♖c8 16.♕d2 ♕b4 17.♖fd1 0–0 18.f3 ♖c7=, Radjabov – G. Kasparov, Linares 2003.

14...♗b7 15.e5 ♘d7 16.♖fe1 ♖d8 17.♘f1 0–0 18.♖ac1



This position has been reached in Vera – Lesiege, Montreal 2003, which went on 18...♕b6? 19.♖c3 ♖c8 20.♖g3 ♖c5 21.♕d2 ♕c6 22.♕h6 g6 23.f4 ♘b6 24.h4 ♖c1 25.f5 ♖c8 26.♖c1 ♕c1 27.fg6 hg6 28.♖g6 1–0.

Keeping the queen in the centre **18...♕d4 19.♖c3 ♘b6=** would have secured Black from any dangers.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.0–0)

B2. 8...b5 9.♗d3 ♘c6

9...♘bd7 leads to a passive set-up with a certain edge for White. He has a free hand for a4 and e4, combining play on both flanks – 10.e4! (It is good to provoke first e6-e5 and only then to get in a4. The immedi-

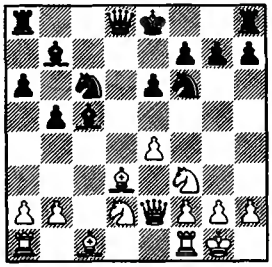
ate 10.a4 could be met by 10...ba4 11.♘c3 a3! and Black should gradually level the game) 10...♗b7 11.♘bd2 (To 11.a4 we have the same prescription – 11...ba4, followed by a3) 11...e5 (It is about time to defend against 12.e4 and 13.♘e4) 12.a4! ba4 (Black is obviously behind in development and with the weakness created on e5 with his last move, opening up the queenside is not in his wish list. However 12...b4 is just dull – 13.♘c4 ♕c7 14.♗g5 0–0 15.♘fd2 h6 16.♗h4 ♖fe8 17.♖ac1 ♗c6 18.b3 ♘h7 19.♘e3±, Landgren – Hjelm, Sweden 2002.) 13.♘c4 0–0 14.♖a4 ♗c6 15.♖a1 ♕e7 16.♗d2±.

We examine further:
B2a. 10.♘bd2; B2b. 10.♖fd1.
Or 10.♘c3 ♗b7 11.♘e4 ♗e7=.

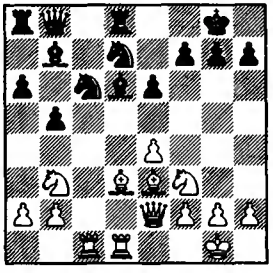
B2a. 10.♘bd2 0–0

The main drawback of 10...♗b7 is that the bishop leaves the important diagonal c8-h3, facilitating 11.e4! We already had the occasion to note that 11.a4 is usually good only after the insertion of e4 e5. White needs it in order to create two targets. In the other cases this typical break is sooner helping Black to unwind – 11...ba4 12.♘e4 ♘e4 13.♗e4 ♕e7 14.♖a4 0–0! (Unnecessarily timid is 14...♘b4 15.♗b7 ♕b7 16.♗d2 ♘d5 17.b4 ♗e7 18.b5 ♘c7 19.ba6 ♖a6 20.♖c4 ♖a8 21.♖fc1 ♘a6 22.h3 ½–½ Schlosser – Tkachiev, Besancon 2003.) 15.♕c4 f5! 16.♗b1 ♖ac8↑.

This position is still far from equal. Black will have to endure a lasting pressure in view of the weakness on c5 and the lack of safe place for the b7-bishop.



The game Wojtkiewicz – Yakovich, Yerevan 1996 went on 11...♘d7 12.♘b3 ♗d6 13.♖d1 ♕b8 14.♗e3 0–0 15.♖ac1 ♖d8!? [The unloading operation 15...♘ce5 16.♘e5 ♘e5 17.♗c5 ♖d8 18.♗d6 ♖d6 did not solve the structural problem of Black – what to do with the light-squared bishop. Ruban – Ehlvest, Novosibirsk 1993 saw further 19.♕e3± (19.♘c5!? might have been even better) 19...♘c4 20.♗c4 ♖d1 21.♖d1 bc4 22.♘c5 ♗c6 23.♕d4± when the c4-pawn looks doomed].



16.♗b1 ♘de5 17.♘e5 ♘e5 18.♗b6 ♖c8 19.♖c8 ♗c8 20.♗d4±.

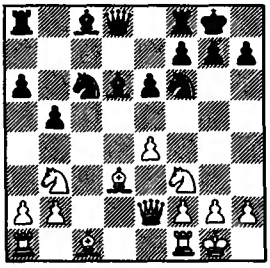
11.♘b3

The outwardly dubious move 10...0–0 conceals an interesting pawn sacrifice: 11.♘e4?! ♗e7 12.♘f6

♗f6 13.♕c2. Never underestimate the enemy! As much as it may look like a blunder, in fact Black gets certain compensation, which makes the conversion of the extra pawn improbable. 13...♘b4 14.♗h7 ♔h8 15.♕c5! ♔h7 16.♕b4 ♗b7 17.♕g4! (with other moves White could easily get worse) 17...♕d3! (The whole idea of the sacrifice is that White cannot develop his c1-bishop. In I. Sokolov – A. Miles, Hastings 1999 occurred 17...♖c8 18.e4±) 18.♖e1 ♕f5!∞ (Huzman).

11.e4 is well met by 11...e5! and the black bishop is happy to find a good place on g4 or e6.

11.♘b3 ♗d6 12.e4

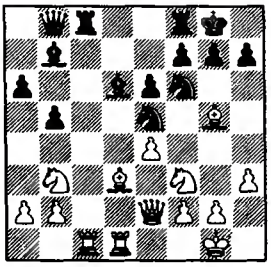


12...♕c7

It is probably better to obey the rule and avoid playing twice with an already developed piece. Nevertheless 12...♘g4 turned out very comfortably for Black after 13.♗g5 f6 14.♗h4 ♘ce5 15.♘e5 ♘e5 16.♖fd1 ♕e7 17.♗g3 ♖d8 18.♘d4 ♗b7 19.♗c2 ♘c4 20.♗b3 ½–½ Shipov – Karjakin, Moscow 2002.

13.h3 ♗b7 14.♗g5 ♖ac8! 15.♖ac1 ♕b8 16.♖fd1 ♘e5

Huzman suggests here 16...♘d7!? 17.♗b1 ♘ce5=.

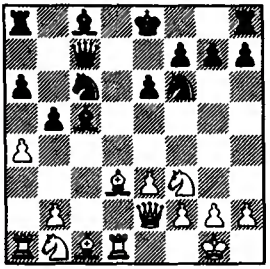


17.♘e5 ♗e5 18.♘c5 h6 19.♗e3 ♖fd8 20.b4 ♘d7 21.♘b7 ♕b7 22.♖c8 ♖c8 23.a4 ♖b8 24.ab5 ab5 25.♖c1 ♗d6=, Ivanchuk – Anand, Prague 2002.

B2b. 10.♖fd1 ♕c7

Rublevsky has chosen 10...♕b6 against Anand, who replied rather unambitiously 11.♘bd2. What has he planned to the obvious 11.a4!? Perhaps Black would have sacrificed a pawn, but that still needs testing.

11.a4



White could further maintain the symmetry by **11.a3** ♗b7 12.b4 ♗d6 13.♗b2 ♘e5 14.♘e5 ♗e5 15.♗e5 ♕e5 16.♘d2 0–0. Black drew the two important games that have reached this position, but the assessment is not clear yet:

17.♘b3 ♗d5 18.♘c5 a5 19.f4 ♕c7 20.♗b5 ab4 21.ab4 ♖a1 22.♖a1 ♖b8±, Malaniuk – Vladimirov, 1987.

17.e4 ♖fd8 18.♘b3 h5 19.f3 h4 20.♖ac1 ♖ac8 21.♘c5 ♗a8 22.♕f2± , Graf – Lekic, Korinthos 1999.

11...ba4

In this sort of positions 11...b4 is usually worse than 11...ba4, but in the current situation it may be even better – 12.♘bd2 0–0 13.♘b3 ♗d6 14.e4 ♗b7 15.♗g5 ♘g4 16.h3 ♘e5 17.♘e5±. Our opinion is that Black can hold this position.

12.♖a4!

Creating direct threats. Less convincing is 12.♘c3 ♗b7 13.♘a4 ♗d6 14.♗d2 0–0 15.♖dc1 ♖fd8 16.♖c2 ♕b8 17.♘b6 ♖a7 18.♘c4 ♘b4 19.♗b4 ♗b4∓, Lesiege – Tkachiev, New Delhi/Teheran 2000.

12...♘b4 13.♗b5 ♗d7

13...♘d7 led Black very quickly to a pawnless ending: 14.♗d2 ♖b8 15.♗b4 ♖b5 16.♕c2 ♘b6? (16...♕b7 17.♗c3↑ – Huzman) 17.♖a5 ♗d6 18.♕c7 ♗c7 19.♖b5 ab5 20.♘c3 ♗d7 21.♘d4 ♗e5 22.♘db5±, Krasenkow – Shirov, Wijk aan Zee 2003.

14.♗d7 ♘d7 15.♗d2 a5

In this situation White in Botvinnik – Flohr, Leningrad 1933 played the normal, but not best 16.♖c1 and 16...♕b7 led to a quick draw. The future world champion could have retained pressure by:

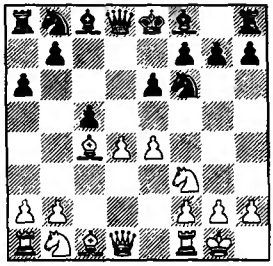
16.♘a3 0–0 17.♘c4 ♖fd8 18.♖da1±.

Conclusion

The Furman variation has been rejuvenated in the last years. It has been proved that Black cannot organize a successful blockade on the e5-square against the main positional threat of White – to gain space by an early advance e3-e4-e5. However, Black maintains the balance by harassing the light-squared bishop of the enemy and occupying the weakened d4-square in White's camp: 6.♕e2 a6 7.dc5 ♗c5 8.0–0 ♘c6 9.e4 b5!, see B1b. Gradually gaining in popularity is the plan where White first develops his knight to d2 resorting only later to e4, often followed by a4. In this case the direction of the main strike is Black's queenside.

Chapter 12

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.e4



(D26)

One of the numerous patents of Efim Geller. White adopts the most straightforward approach, but in our opinion 7.e4 is either a bit premature or on the contrary – 4 moves late!

Black's options are:

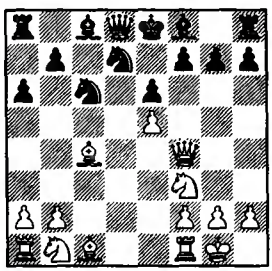
A. 7...cd4

B. 7...♘e4

C. 7...b5

In the first case Black must be ready to defend a dangerous position, hoping to convert an extra pawn. In the second, a drawish ending is on the doorstep. 7...b5 (C) is much more interesting. It provides an ample choice of hazy double-edged positions.

A. 7...cd4 8.e5 ♘fd7 9.♕d4 ♘c6 10.♕f4



The last move is in effect a pawn sacrifice, but the more restrained 10.♕e4 ♘c5 11.♕e2 b5 12.♖d1 ♕c7 seems harmless.

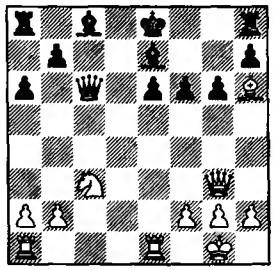
10...♕c7 11.♖e1 ♘de5 12.♘e5 ♘e5 13.♕e5 ♕c4 14.♘c3

14.♘a3 fails to 14...♕g4 15.h3 ♕g6 16.♘c4 ♗d7 17.♗f4 ♗c6 18.♗g3 ♕f6∓.

14...f6 15.♕h5 g6 16.♕f3 ♗e7

16...♗g7 17.♘d5 0–0 18.♘b6 ♕b4 19.♗e3 ♖b8 20.♖ac1⩲, Morovic Fernandez – W. Arencibia, Havana 1998.

17.♗h6 ♕c6! 18.♕g3



18...♔f7

Huzman suggests 18...e5?!, considering only 19.f4?! ef4 20.♕f4 ♔f7∓. We are far from pretending

to know the final diagnosis, but it seems that White has a strong initiative after 19.♘e4! ♗f5 20.♖ac1 ♕b6 (probably 20...♕e6 is wiser, but then 21.f4! hits the mark – 21...♗e4 22.♖e4 ♕b6 23.♔h1↑) 21.♘f6!! ♗f6 22.♖e5 ♗e6 23.♕f4! ♔e7 24.♖c7 ♕c7 25.♖e6 ♔e6 26.♕c7 ♖hd8 27.♕b6 ♖d6 28.♕b3 ♖d5 29.g4!±. Black's king will hardly find peace in this lifetime.

19.♖ac1 (19.♖ad1!?) **19...♖d8 20.♕h4 e5 21.♗e3 h5 22.♘e4 ♕e6 23.f4!↑ ♕g4**

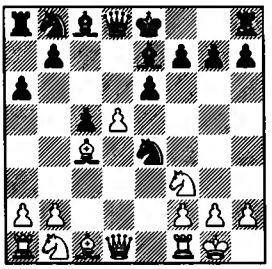
It is very unpleasant to defend such position. 23...♖d5 could be met by 24.♘c3♖d8 25.fe5→.

24.♕f2! ♗e6 25.h3 ♕f5 26.♘g3 ♕d3 27.fe5±, Hebden – Baburin, Port Erin 1999.

B. 7...♘e4 8.d5

8.♕e2 nearly disappeared from tournaments in view of 8...♘f6 9.d5 ♘d5 10.♖d1 ♕e7! e.g. 11.♗g5 f6 12.♗h4 ♘c6 13.a4 ♘b6 14.♗b3 c4∓ 15.♗c2 ♗d7 16.♘c3 0–0–0 17.a5♘d5 18.♗e4 ♘c3 19.bc3 ♕c5∞, Saucey – Karpatchev, Montpellier 2003.

8...♗e7



8...b5 only creates weaknesses. Probably White should play similarly to the other lines, opting for a better ending, e.g. 9.de6 fe6 10.♕d8 ♔d8 11.♗d3 ♘f6 12.♘g5±.

8...♘f6 9.de6 ♗e6 10.♗e6 ♕d1 11.♗f7 ♔f7 12.♖d1 ♘c6 13.♘c3 is slightly better for White.

9.♖e1

This move is more popular lately, but objectively 9.de6 is better. At least White has some initiative in an equal endgame after 9...♗e6 10.♕d8 ♗d8! (10...♔d8 11.♗e6 fe6 12.♖e1 ♘d6 13.♘c3 ♘c6 14.♘a4 ♘f5, Aleksandrov – Waitzkin, New York 1998, 15.♘g5!±) 11.♗e6 fe6 12.♖e1 ♘f6 13.♖e6 ♗e7 14.♘c3 ♘c6 15.♗f4 0–0 16.♖ae1 ♖fe8= Aleksandrov – Sadler, Koge 1997.

9...b5

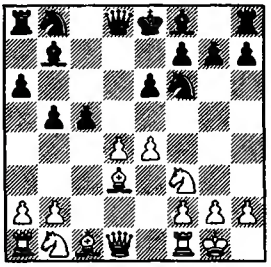
9...ed5 10.♕d5 ♕d5 is roughly equal. 10...♘d6 allows White to keep the initiative after 11.♗d3 0–0 12.♗f4 ♘c6!? – suggested by Kramnik as an improvement on 12...♘f5? 12.♘c3±, Gelfand – Lautier, Belgrade 1997. Not better is 12...♗e6 13.♕h5 g6 14.♕h6→), 13.♖e7 ♕e7 14.♗d6 ♖d8 15.♕c6 ♖d6 16.♕c5 ♕d8 17.♘e1 (17.♗f1 ♖d1→) 17...♖d3 18.♘d3 ♕d3 19.♘c3 ♗e6 20.♖d1 ♕c4 21.♕b6 ♕c8±. **11.♗d5 ♘f6 12.♘c3 ♘c6 13.♗g5** Black should not be worse in this ending. He could stay passively by **13...♗d7** or undertake a further simplification with 13...♗e6 14.♗e6 fe6 15.♖e6 ♔f7 16.♖ae1 ♖he8 17.h3 h6 18.♗f4 ♗f8 19.♖e8 ♖e8 20.♖e8 ½–½, Shulman – Sherbakov, St. Petersburg 1998.

The game Kononenko – A. Maric, Budva 2003 showed another good path for Black – 9...♘d6 10.♗b3 c4 11.♗c2 0–0.

10.♖e4 bc4 11.♘c3 ♗b7∞, Shulman – Kaidanov, San Diego 2004

C. 7...b5 8.♗d3 ♗b7

9...cd4 is risky (there was a transposition which accounts for the different numbering) 10.a4 ba4 11.e5 ♘d5 12.♕a4 ♗d7 13.♕d4 ♘c6 (after 13...♕c7!? White, if in the appropriate frame of mind, could throw into the fire two bits in exchange for a terrible initiative – 14.♘c3 ♘c3 15.bc3 ♘e5 16.♘e5 ♕e5 17.♗f4 ♕c3 18.♕g3→) 14.♕g4 ♘cb4 15.♗e2 g6 16.♘c3 ♘c3 17.bc3 ♘d5 18.♗d2 a5 19.♘g5 ♗e7 20.c4±, Antic – Zontakh, Jahorina 2000.



Our main line branches here to:
C1. 9.e5
C2. 9.♗g5
C3. 10.♖e1

The game I. Sokolov – Kraut, Germany, 1998 saw 9.dc5, but after 9...♗e4 10.♗e4 ♕d1 11.♖d1 ♘e4 12.b4 ♘c6 White was probably wondering what exactly had been his idea.

(3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.e4 b5 8.♗d3 ♗b7)

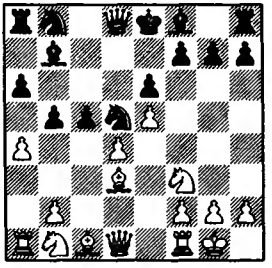
C1. 9.e5 ♘d5

For some reason **9...♘fd7** is rarely seen, although tournament experience favours it. Here is an example: 10.♘g5 (or 10.a4 ba4 11.♘c3 cd4 12.♘e4 ♘c6 13.♗f4 ♘b4↑) 10...♗e7 11.♕h5 g6 12.♕h6 ♘e5 (12...♗f8!? 13.♕h3 cd4 14.♗f4 ♗g7∞) 13.de5 ♕d3 14.♕g7 ♖f8 15.♘h7 ♘d7 16.♘d2 ♕e2 17.a4 b4 18.♘f8 ♗f8 19.♕h8 ♘e5↑ 20.f3 0–0–0 21.♘e4 ♗e4 22.fe4 ♕e4 23.♕f6 ♗d6 24.♗g5 ♖d7 25.♖ad1 ♘d3 26.♕h8 ♔b7∓, Lautier – W. Arencibia, Salamanca 1998 when suddenly a draw was agreed.

10.a4

10.♘bd2 is well met by 10...cd4 11.a4 ♘b4 12.♘e4 ♕d5∓, B. Maksimovic – Semkov, Heraklio 1993.

10.♗g5 ♕b6 11.dc5 ♗c5 12.♘bd2 is hardly a fun for White (In an earlier game of Baburin occurred 12.♘c3 h6 13.♗h4 when Black could have overtaken the initiative by 13...♘c3! 14.bc3 0–0 15.a4 ♘d7 16.♕e2 ba4 17.♖a4 ♕b3 18.♖g4 ♕c3∓) 12...h6 13.♗h4 ♘d7 14.♘e4 0–0 15.a3 ♗e7 16.♗g3 ♘c5 17.♘c5 ♗c5 18.♕e2 ♖fd8 19.♘d2 ♘e7 20.♘e4 ♘f5 21.♘c5 ♘g3 22.hg3 ♕c5↑, J. Nilssen – Baburin, Torshavn 2000.



10...c4

This move may look antipositional, but having seen all the evidence, we decided that it was a good choice after all.

The alternative 10...ba4 (10...b4 transposes to other schemes where White has a certain edge, while 10...♕b6 11.ab5 ab5 12.♖a8 ♗a8 13.dc5 ♗c5 14.♘a3± is unattractive too) could be put to test by 11.dc5! ♗c5 (11...♘b4 12.♕a4 ♘8c6 13.♗e4 ♗c5 14.♗d2 ♕b6 15.♗b4 ♗b4 16.♘d4 ♖c8 17.♘c6 ♗c6 18.♗c6 ♖c6 19.♖c1+– Eriksson – Hartman, Stockholm 1998) 12.♕a4 ♘d7 13.♕g4↑, Bratchenko – Kiselev, St. Petersburg 2002. The swift manoeuvre of White's queen spells problems for Black.

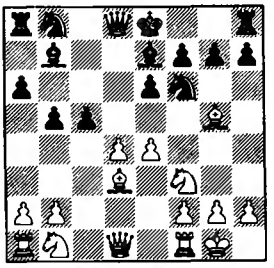
11.♗e2

Probably 11.♗e4 is better, but still hardly enough for an edge, since the e4-square is assigned to a knight.

11...♘d7 12.b3 ♖c8 13.ab5 ab5 14.bc4 bc4 15.♘a3 ♘7b6 16.♗g5 ♕d7 17.♕c1 h6 18.♗h4 ♗b4∓, Astolfi – Villeneuve, Cannes 1989.

C2. 9.♗g5 ♗e7!

9...h6?! 10.♗f6 ♕f6 11.a4 b4 (11...cd4 12.ab5 a5 13.b6 ♗c5 14.♕a4 ♔e7 15.♘bd2 ♘d7 16.♘b3 e5 17.♘a5↑ Rustemov – Dolgov, Moscow 1997) 12.♘bd2 cd4 13.e5 ♕d8 14.♖c1 ♗e7 15.♗b1 ♘d7 16.♖e1 0–0 17.♘b3 ♘b6 18.a5 ♘d5 19.♖c4 ♕d7 20.h4 ♖ac8 21.♕d3 g6 22.♖d4 h5 23.♘fd2 ♖fd8 24.♘e4 ♕a4 25.♕g3↑, Aleksandrov – Novgorodskij, Kstovo 1998. Or 9...cd4 10.a4, with similar to the main line positions.



10.♗f6

The hit on e4 limits White's choice:

10.a4 c4 11.♗f6 ♗f6 12.♗c2 0–0∓, Akesson – Svensson, Gothenburg 1998;

10.dc5 ♗e4 11.♗f6 ♕d3= ½–½, Shulman – Vaulin, Minsk 1997;

10.♖e1 ♘bd7 11.a4 ba4=, Sashikiran – Sorokin, Sanghi, Commonwealth-ch 2000.

10.e5 ♘fd7! 11.♗e7 ♕e7 12.♘bd2 cd4∞.

10...♗f6 11.e5 ♗e7 12.dc5

Or 13.ab5?! 0–0 14.♘bd2 ab5 15.♖a8 ♗a8∓, Kozul – Stevic, Nova Gorica 2007.

12...♘d7! 13.b4 ♗f3 14.♕f3 ♘e5 15.♕e4 ♘d3!

It is already clear that Black is near to the equality, but he still needs another couple of accurate moves. 15...♗f6 is less convincing in view of 16.♘c3 ♘d3 17.♖ad1 0–0 18.♖d3 ♕c7 19.♖fd1 ♖ad8 20.♘e2!±, when the powerful protected pawn on c5 could be a mighty trump in future.

16.♖d1 ♕d5

Black possesses a drastic, but effective way to draw the game at once – 16...♘b4!? 17.♖d8 ♖d8 18.♘c3 ♗c5 19.♖b1 ♘d5 20.♖d1 0–0 21.♘d5 ed5

22.♖d5 ♖d5 23.♕d5 ♖e8=.

17.♕d5 ed5 18.♖d3 ♗f6 19.♘c3 0-0-0 20.a4 ba4 21.♖a4 ♖he8 22.♔f1 ♗c3 23.♖c3 ♔b7 24.♖a5 ½–½, Shulman – Rublevsky, Ohrid 2001.

C3. 9.♖e1 cd4

Black could treat this type of positions with 9...♗e7, preferring to restrict a possible play of the enemy in the centre. It is a matter of taste. White could go on 10.♗g5 (10.a4 is best met with 10...ba4) 10...h6 11.♗f6 ♗f6 12.e5 ♗e7 13.dc5 ♗c5 14.♘c3 0–0, Hebden – Krush, Hastings 2002. White should play accurately to maintain balance.

10.a4 ba4

10...b4 is passive. The game Hebden – Sadler, Torquay 1998 did not help much to clarify the evaluation of this move. After 11.e5 ♘fd7 White had to choose 12.♗g5 ♗e7 13.♗e7 to avoid the threat 12...♘c5. Without the bishop White has only minimal chances for a kingside attack, but the weakness of the dark squares could ensure him good play in the centre and on the queenside – 13...♕e7 14.♘bd2 ♘c6 15.♖c1 0–0 16.♘db3.

The game Shipov – Slipak, blitz 2003 showed an interesting move order which allowed White to keep the dark-squared bishop:

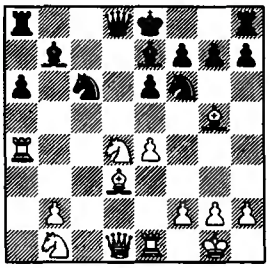
11.♘bd2!? ♘c6 12.e5 ♘d7 13.♘b3 ♗e7 14.♕e2 0–0 15.♕e4 g6 16.♕g4 h5 17.♕g3 ♔g7 18.a5 h4 19.♕g4 ♖h8 20.♗f4±.

11.♗g5

Or 11.♖a4 ♘fd7 12.♘d4 ♗e7 13.♗c2 ♘c6 14.♘c6 ♗c6 15.♖d4 ♗c5=, L. Portisch – Petrosian, Stockholm izt. 1962. Watching the manoeuvres of the white rook along the 4th rank, it is becoming clear that White's strategy is quite wrong.

11.e5 ♘fd7 12.♖a4 ♘c6 13.♗e4 ♕b6 14.♘bd2 ♘c5 is unclear.

11...♗e7 12.♖a4 ♘c6 13.♘d4



13...♘e5! 14.♗f1 h6! 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.♕b3 ♖b8 17.♕a3 Hebden – Tkachiev, Hastings 1998.

Black can repeat moves by 17...♗e7 18.♕g3 ♗f6 19.♕a3.

Conclusion:

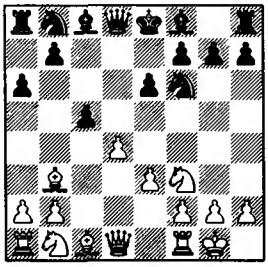
The 7.e4 variation is now out of fashion. Its main drawback is that instead of ensuring attacking possibilities (even at the cost of a pawn), it could lead by force to an ending with strong drawish tendencies (as in line B).

After 7...b5 8.♗d3 ♗b7 9.e5 the move 9...♘fd7!? is nearly unexplored and needs testing (C1). The latest outcry of fashion 9.♖e1 is not really dangerous. Black can experiment with 9...♗e7 (C3), whereas White is apparently short of new ideas.

Chapter 13

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 7...b6; 7...♘bd7

(D27)



7.♗b3 is currently the big hit of White against the QGA. Black has suffered several heavy losses in the main lines after having faced a number of novelties. However, towards January 2008, when I am writing this page, Black has successfully patched the biggest holes in his defence. Of course there are enough sidelines which also deserve attention.

The retreat of White's bishop anticipates b5, intending to counter it by 8.a4. This approach outlines two main themes for discussion:

1. Is 7...b5 really so bad;

2. In which favour is the position with an isolated pawn after 7...cd4 8.ed4. In this scheme Black often tries to put off the opponent by delaying the exchange on d4. Play could transpose then to fashionable lately symmetrical structures after d4xc5 at some moment.

We'll start with the rare continuations:

A. 7...b6

B. 7...♘bd7?!

The other main options of Black 7...♘c6 and 7...b5 are subject of the next chapters.

A. 7...b6

By his last move White prepared to meet 7...b5 with 8.a4. So Black decides to proceed with a similar plan without granting the opponent a lever on the queenside. In fact, the "little" difference of one square renders many typical ideas from the 7...b5-line inapplicable. White's knight has a direct access to d5 and e4 via c3. The b3-bishop is supported by the a2-pawn which gives White a free hand on the kingside.

8.e4!

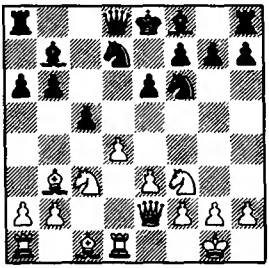
White can do better than calmly developing with:

8.♘c3 ♗b7 9.♕e2

The game Wang Yue – Xu Jun, Qingdao 2002 presents an instructive example how easily Black can get into difficulties after 9.dc5 ♕d1 10.♗d1! ♗c5 11.♘a4 ♘bd7 12.♘c5 ♘c5 13.♘e5 0–0 14.f3 a5 15.e4 ♗a6 16.♖f2 ♖fd8 17.♗e3 ♖ac8 18.♗e2 ♗e2 19.♖e2 ♘fd7 20.♘d7 ♘d7 21.♖d1 ♔f8 22.♖ed2±. Lately in similar positions

Black prefers to take immediately on c5, not being afraid of losing the right to castle.

9...♘bd7 10.♖d1



10...♗d6!?

Black can also defend with 10...♕b8 11.d5 ♘d5 12.♘d5 ♗d5 13.♗d5 ed5 14.♖d5 ♗e7 15.e4 ♕c8, Epishin – Godena, Bratto 1999, but the initiative of White is quite perceptible after 16.♗g5 ♗g5 17.♖ad1! The same intermezzo is the hidden trump of White in the case of 15...♕b7 16.♗g5 ♗g5 17.♖ad1 ♘f6 18.♖e5±, Tkachiev – G. Flear, France 1996.

11.d5 ed5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♗d5 14.♖d5 ♘f6 15.♖d1 ♕e7 16.e4 0–0 17.e5 ♖fe8, Kruck – Meschke, Wuerttenberg 2001. Instead of losing a pawn with 18.♕c4?, White has 18.♗f4, although after 18...♗c7 Black should gradually level the game.

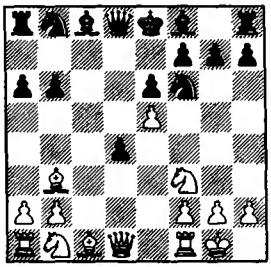
11.dc5 ♗c5 12.♗d2 b5 13.♖ac1 0–0 14.♗e1 ♕b8=, Summerscale – Sadler Nottingham 1996.

8...cd4

For the record only, 8...♘e4 9.d5 ♗b7 10.de6 is obviously better for White.

No one has tested 8...♗b7!? 9.e5 ♘d5. It deserves a try.

9.e5



9...♘fd7

9...♘e4 seems bad due to 10.♘d4 ♗b7 11.♗c2! ♗c5 12.♗e3 ♕d5 13.f3 ♘g5 14.♘c3 ♕e5 15.♖e1 ♘c6 16.f4 ♕e3 17.♖e3 ♘d4 18.♔f2 ♖d8 19.b4+–.

9...♘d5 is met by 10.♕d4! (In Farago – Putzbach, Hamburg 2002 White wanted to punish the enemy outright by 10.♗g5 ♗e7 11.♗d5 ♕d5 12.♗e7 ♔e7 13.♕d2 ♖d8 14.♕g5, but 14...♔f8 15.♖d1 ♘c6 16.♘c3 ♕d7= must have dampened his enthusiasm.) 10...♗b7 11.♗g5±.

10.♕d4 ♗b7

Or 10...♘c6 11.♕g4 ♗b7 12.♗f4 ♘c5 13.♖d1 ♕c7 14.♘bd2 ♘b3 15.ab3 0–0–0 16.♘e4 ♖d1 17.♖d1 h5 18.♕g3± Djukanovic – Peric, YUG 1996.

11.♕f4

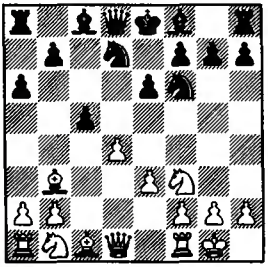
This position arose in Shipov – Miles, Hastings 1998, when instead of 11...♘c5? 12.♘c3! ♘b3 13.ab3± Black could have played:

11...♘c6.

However White's slight edge is beyond any doubt. After, for instance, 12.♘c3, he has more space and active pieces.

B. 7...♘bd7?!

Just like White, Black is trying to present the best order of moves. The idea of this manoeuvre is similar to 7...b6. Black is planning ...b6 (or ...b5) and ...♗b7, but he firstly develops a piece. The game Dautov – Mista, EICC Warsaw 2005 looks like the refutation of the text-move and probably we'll not hear about this line anymore.



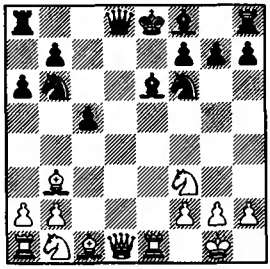
8.e4!

8.♕e2 is too timid. Besides 8...b5 9.e4 (9.a4 ♗b7=, see Chapter 20) 9...♗b7 10.d5 c4 11.♗c2 ♕c7!=, Black also has 8...♕c7!? We have no suggestion to White at this stage. He should either play 9.♘c3 or 9.♖d1, transposing to not very ambitious systems, or follow Ehlvest – Rantanen, Kuopio 1992 where every move of Black has numerous tempting alternatives, but the only certain thing is that nothing is clear: 9.e4 cd4 10.e5 d3 11.♕e1 ♘g4 12.♗f4 g5 13.♘g5 ♘ge5 14.♘d2 ♗e7 15.♕e3 ♕c5 16.♕g3 ♘g6 17.♗e3 ♕f5 18.♘c4 h6 (18...♖g8 19.♘d6 ♗d6 20.♕d6 ♘h4∞ 21.♕d4 ♖g5 22.♕h4 ♖g4 23.♕h3) 19.♘f3 e5 20.♖fe1 ♔f8 21.♗d2 ♘f4 22.♘ce5 ♘e5 23.♘e5 ♘e2 24.♖e2 de2 25.♘f7 1–0. As risky as looks White's play, it is not easy to refute it.

8.e4! ♘e4 9.♕e2!

9.♖e1 ♘ef6! had been topical for a while.

10.d5 ♘b6 11.de6 ♗e6



12.♗e6

More popular, but hardly better, is 12.♕d8 ♖d8 (12...♔d8?! 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♖e6 ♘bd5 15.♘c3 ♔d7 16.♘d5! ♘d5 17.♖e5 ♔c6 18.♖g5!?±, Tregubov – Godena, Saint Vincent 2000) 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♘g5 e5! 15.♖e5 ♗e7 16.♘c3 ♖d7=, Tregubov – Rausis, Belfort 2004.

12...♕d1 13.♗f7 ♔f7 14.♖d1 ♘bd5 15.♘c3

Or 15.♘e5 ♔e6 16.♖e1 ♖g8∞.

15...♘c3!

15...♖d8?! turned in White's favour after 16.♘e5 ♔g8 17.♗g5±, Sherbakov – Nadyrhanov, Krasnodar 1997. The text looks dubious, but concrete analysis does not show a way for White to exploit his initiative. Black's king is shaky indeed, but it is in the centre. That could be a weighty factor with the reduced numbers of pieces.

16.bc3 ♗e7 (planning b7-b5=).

17.♘e5 ♔e6 18.♖e1 ♖he8∞.

Black's king is amazingly light-heeled. In case of 19.♗a3 it goes

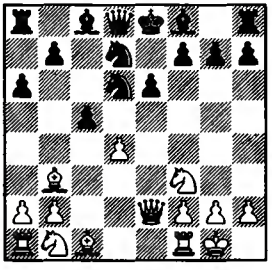
queenside – 19...♔d6 20.♘f7 (20.f4 ♔c7) 20...♔c6 and after 19.♗b2 ♘d7 20.♘c6 ♔f7 it feels well on the kingside.

9...♘d6

The alternatives are hardly any better:

9...c4 10.♗c4 ♘d6 11.♗b3 ♗e7 12.♘c3 0–0 13.♗f4±;

9...♘df6 10.♗c2 ♕d5 11.♕e2 ♘d6 12.♘c3 ♕c6 13.♗f4 cd4 14.♘d4 ♕c5 15.♖ad1 ♗d7 16.♗b3 ♕h5 17.♘f3 ♘f5 18.♖d7 ♘d7 19.♗e6+–, Romanishin – Baburin, Linares 1996.



10.d5 e5 11.♘e5 ♗e7

11...♕e7 is relatively better, but White still has a clear edge following 12.f4 f6 13.♕h5 ♔d8 14.♘d7 ♗d7 15.♘c3 ♔c7 16.f5.

12.♘d7!

This exchange disco-ordinates Black's pieces

12...♕d7

After 12...♗d7 13.♖e1 Black is unable to castle. By capturing with the queen he solves the castling problem (13.♖e1 0-0!), but the decisive blow comes from the other flank.

13.♘c3 b5

13...0–0 14.♘a4 ♕c7 loses a pawn due to 15.♘c5 ♘b5 16.♘e4 ♘d4 17.♕e3 ♘b3 18.♕b3.

13...b6 14.♗g5± is similar to the main line.

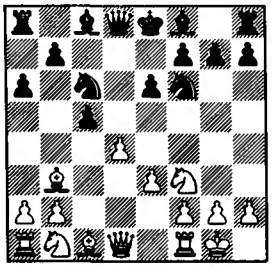
14.♗g5 f6 15.♗f4 0-0 16.♖e1±

White went on to win in Dautov – Mista, EICC Warsaw 2005.

Conclusion:

The rare lines 7...b6 7...♘bd7?! look dubious nowadays. They are passive and give White time to expand in the centre by 8.e4! In that case the bishop on b3 proves extremely powerful. It supports the break-trough in the centre d5 and in some lines it could be sacrificed on e6. As a whole, White obtains a strong initiative.

Chapter 14



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 ♘c6

(D27)

In this chapter we examine positions with an isolated pawn on d4. That is a logical plan for Black, and probably the most complex. White links his hopes with a kingside attack or the central break d4-d5. Often both ideas work well together.

Black should decide when to define the pawn structure in the centre by taking on d4. White's first task is to choose the best setting of his major pieces.

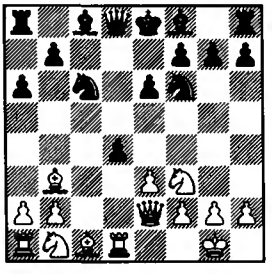
A. 8.♕e2

B. 8.♘c3

A. 8.♕e2 cd4

The waiting strategy 8...♕c7 9.♘c3 ♗d6 or 9...♗e7 is discussed in line B.

9.♖d1



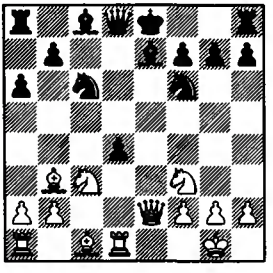
A1. 9...♗e7

A2. 9...d3!?

The game Mohota – Teske, Barbera del Valles 09.07.2007 saw 9...♗d7 10.ed4 ♗e7 11.♘c3 0–0, when 12.♘e5± would have led to a typical IQP position.

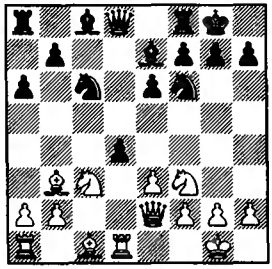
A1. 9...♗e7 10.♘c3!

An important fine point in White's plan. Immediate 10.♘d4 ♘d4 11.ed4 allows Black to blockade d5 by 11...♗d7! 12.♘c3 ♗c6 13.♗g5 0–0 14.♗f6 ♗f6 15.d5 ed5 ½–½, A. Bykhovsky – Zifroni, Herzliya 2000. We know that there is no free lunch, so 10.♘c3! also has its downside. In our case it is the possibility of 10.♘c3! e5!? 11.ed4 ed4.



However, White found a way to fight for the opening advantage with 12.♗e3! (12.♘d4=) 12...♗g4 13.♗a4 0–0 14.♗c6 bc6 15.♗d4± in Harikrishna – Sorokin, Hyderabad 2000. For instance, 15...♘d5 could be met by 16.h3 ♗e6 17.♘e4.

10...0-0!



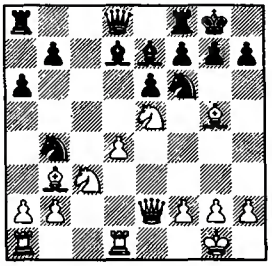
A1a. 11.ed4; A1b. 11.♘d4!

A1a. 11.ed4 ♘b4

The once popular 11...♘a5!? 12.♗c2 b5 had disappeared from tournaments for a while, mostly in view of 13.♘e4 ♗b7 14.♘c5 ♗d5 15.♘e5, but in Acs – Korchnoi, Hungary 2004 Black found a way to consolidate his position with 16...♖c8!, when 17.♘a6 ♕d6! regains the pawn with good play, e.g. 18.♘c6 ♗c6 19.♘c5 ♕d5 20.f4 ♗c5 21.♗f6 gf6 22.dc5 ♕c5 23.♔h1 ♔h8=.

Tomashevsky – Hossain, World Cup Khanty-Mansiysk 27.11.2007 saw 13.♗g5 ♗b7 14.♗f6 ♗f6 15.♗e4 ♗e4 16.♘e4 ♗e7 17.♘e5 ♕d5 18.♘c3 ♕d6 19.♖d3=, when 19...b4 20.♘e4 ♕d5 intending ...f6 would have been roughly equal.

12.♘e5 ♗d7 13.♗g5



13...♗c6

The "too subtle" 13...♗e8 faces Black with problems after 14.♕f3! ♗c6 15.♕h3 ♗d5 16.♘d5 ♘fd5 17.♗e7 ♕e7 18.a3 ♘f4 19.♕f3 ♘bd5 20.g3 ♘h3 21.♔g2 f6 22.♘d3, Rogozenko – Marjanovic, Bucharest 1999, when 22.♘g6 hg6 23.♗d5 ed5 24.♕d5 ♔h7 25.♔h3 ♖fd8 26.♕f3± would have snatched a pawn.

14.a3

Too untargeted is 14.♖ac1 ♗d5 15.♘d5 ♘bd5 16.♕f3 ♖c8 17.♖c8 ♕c8 18.♖c1 ♕d8 19.g3 ♕d6=, Akopian – Huebner, Dortmund 2000.

14...♘bd5 15.♘c6 bc6 16.♖ac1 ♕b6 17.♗c4 h6 18.♘a4 ♕a5 19.♗f6 ♘f6=, Petran – Gyimesi, Budapest 1993. Although White possesses the initiative thanks to his space advantage, Black's position is firm and sound.

A1b. 11.♘d4! ♕c7

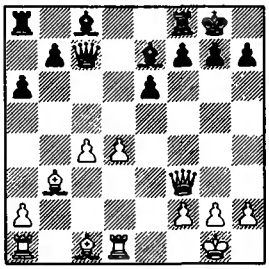
After the game Kasparov – Spangenberg, Buenos Aires 1997 11...♘d4 12.ed4 ♘d5 is in deep crisis:

13.♕f3

A good alternative is 13.♕e4!? ♘c3 14.bc3 ♗f6 15.♗f4 ♖a7 16.♗b8 ♖a8 17.♗e5 ♗e5 18.de5 ♕c7 19.♖d3

♖d8 20.♖h3 h6 21.♖f3 ♔f8 22.♖e1, Epishin – Lammens, Vlissingen 2000.

13...♘c3 14.bc3 ♕c7 15.c4



Black is in trouble not only because he is lagging behind in development, but also because his king could become an easy target. 15...♗d6? 16.c5 ♗e7 17.♗f4 ♕d7 18.♖ac1 ♕c6 19.d5 ed5 20.♗d5 ♕g6 21.h3 ♖a7 22.♕e3 ♗f6 23.c6 bc6 24.♗e4 ♗f5 25.♗f5 ♕f5 26.g4 1–0.

In the diagram position Black has also tried without success other moves, for instance: 15...a5 16.♗f4 (16.c5!? e5 17.♕g3 ♗f5 18.♗h6 ♗g6 19.♗e3±) 16...♗d6 17.♗d6 ♕d6 18.c5 ♕a6 19.♗c2! ♗d7 20.♗d3!±.

12.♘c6 ♕c6 13.e4 b5

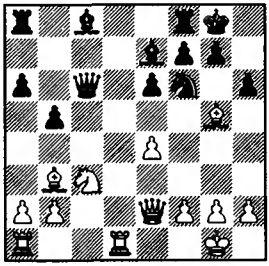
The main item on Black's agenda is to deploy the light-squared bishop, while fending White's knight off the sore point d6. Moves like 13...♖d8 fall out of this scheme: 14.♗g5 h6 15.♗h4 ♕e8 16.e5 ♖d1 17.♖d1 ♘d7 18.♗e7 ♕e7 19.♗c2 ♘f8 20.♘e4 ♗d7 21.♘d6 ♗c6 22.♗e4±, Ruck – Eliet, Charleville 2000.

14.♗g5 h6

14...b4? runs into 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.♘d5 ed5 17.♗d5.

More consistent is 14...♗b7 15.♖ac1 ♕e8. If White thinks that the rook endgame with an extra pawn, which occurred in Khenkin – Volzhin, Stockholm 2002, is not convertible – 16.a4 b4 17.e5 ♘d7 18.♘e4 ♗e4 19.♗e7 ♕e7 20.♕e4 ♘c5 21.♕b4 ♖ab8 22.♕c5 ♕c5 23.♖c5 ♖b3 24.♖d2 g5!±, he can try 16.e5!? ♘d7 17.♘e4! The e5-pawn is tactically defended due to 17...♘e5 18.♖c7!, while 17...♗e4 18.♗e7 ♕e7 19.♕e4 ♘c5 20.♕b4± presents a case when White is better off with equal number of pawns (compared to the line 16.a4 b4).

14...h6 is aimed at preventing similar tricks. (plus ensuring a luft, of course)



15.♗h4

White has more space, so there is no reason to exchange pieces, although 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.e5! ♗g5 17.♗c2 ♗b7 18.♗e4 ♕c7 19.♗b7 ♕b7 20.♘e4± is in his favour.

15...♗b7 16.♖ac1 ♕e8 17.♗g3

The pawn sacrifice 17.e5 ♘d7 18.♗e7 19.♘e4?! from the game Kramnik – Ivanchuk, Moscow 2002 is not entirely correct – 19...♘e5 20.♘d6 ♘g6.

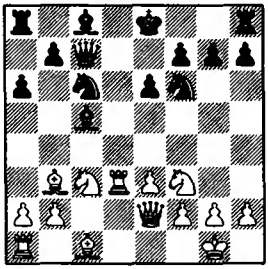
17....♘d7 18.a3 ♖c8 19.♗a2 ♖c6 20.♗f4 ♕c8 21.e5 ♖d8 22.♕g4±, Ruck – Acs, Budapest 2004.

A2. 9...d3!?

This is not very ambitious indeed, but in practice Black gradually equalises with accurate play.

10.♖d3 ♕c7 11.♘c3 ♗c5

11...♗d6 12.e4 leaves the initiative to White. Playable is 11...♗e7 12.e4 ♘d7, when direct attempts to refute Black's set-up are likely to fail, e.g. 13.♘d5?! ed5 14.ed5 ♘c5! 15.d6 ♕d8 16.♘g5 ♘d3 17.♘f7 ♕d7∓. White can rely on some edge due to his space advantage. He should preserve from exchange his light-squared bishop by 13.♖d1! 0–0 14.♗e3 ♘c5 (In Efimov – Bacrot Nice 1994 was 14...b5 15.♖ac1 ♗b7 16.♘d5±) 15.♗c2 b6 16.♖ac1 ♗b7 17.a3 ♗f6 18.b4! ♗c3 19.bc5 bc5 20.♗c5 ♖fd8, Cvitan – Magem Badals, Pula 1997, when 21.♗d3! ♗f6 22.♕e3± would have given White a bind, according to Huzman.



12.h3

12.a3 is not impressive due to 12...0-0 13.♗d2 b5 14.♖c1 ♕b6= Piket – Lautier, Euwe Memorial 1995.

We would like to put some order in the comments of **12.e4 ♘g4** 13.♘d1. We do agree that Black has the initiative, but only after some common developing move like 13...♗d7! 14.h3 h5↑. On the contrary, Lautier's suggestion 13...♘d4(?) is outright bad in view of 14.♖d4 ♗d4 15.h3 h5 16.e5! That has been correctly noticed by Ward, but his argument was not best – 16...♗a7 (relatively better is 16...♗c5) 17.hg4 hg4 18.♘d2(?). In all cases, 18.♘g5!± closes the discussion.

The game V. Salov – Waitzkin, New York 1996 saw a clumsy attempt for improvement – 12.♘a4 ♗a7 13.♗d2 0–0 14.♖c1 e5 15.e4, when 15...♗g4! 16.h3 ♗h5 17.♗e3 ♗e3 18.♕e3= would have equalised.

12...0-0 13.e4 ♘d7 14.♗e3 ♘ce5

White's pressure along the d-file is a weighty argument in his favour in case of 14...b6 15.♖ad1 ♗e3 16.♕e3 ♘c5 17.♖d6 ♗b7 18.♘a4±, Lukacs – Grund, Budapest 1999.

15.♘e5 ♘e5 16.♖dd1!

The only chance to maintain some pressure. 16.♗c5 ♕c5 17.♖d2 b5 18.♖ad1 ♗b7 was equal in Antunes – Van Wely, Linares 1995.

16...♗d7 17.♖ac1 ♗e3 18.♕e3 ♗c6

18...♖ad8 was not really an improvement: 19.♘b5 ♕b8 20.♘d6 ♗a4 21.♕c5 ♗b3 22.ab3 ♘c6 23.e5 ♖d7 24.f4 ♖fd8 25.♔h2 ♘e7 26.♖d4±, Eljanov – Charbonneau, Montreal 2006.

19.♘d5 ed5 20.ed5 ♖fe8 21.♕f4!

By pinning the e5-knight White keeps a small edge. 21.dc6 ♘c6= Erdos – Stevic, Bizovac 2005.

21...♖ad8 22.dc6 ♖d1 23.♖d1 ♕c6±.

Black should be able to hold this position.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 ♘c6)

B. 8.♘c3

B1. 8...♕c7
B2. 8...♗e7
B3. 8...cd4
B4. 8...b5!?

White develops his knight, waiting to see the opponent's set-up. In this branch his queen goes to the kingside via the dark squares – usually d2-f4. Lately White has been obtaining some bind, and he often succeeded in placing the blow d4-d5 with a devastating effect. We think that Black should pay serious attention to the move 8...b5, followed by a quick queenside development while keeping White's dark-squared bishop restricted.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 ♘c6 8.♘c3)

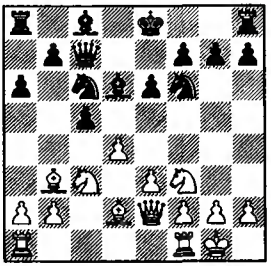
B1. 8...♕c7 9.♕e2 ♗d6

9...b5 10.♖d1 ♗b7 11.d5! ed5 leads to a well known position where White can choose between the double-edged 12.e4 d4 13.♘d5 ♕d8 (13...♘d5!? 14.ed5 ♘e7 15.a4 0-0-0∞) 14.a4↑ or the classical example Euwe – Kramer, New York 1948: 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♗e7 14.b3 0–0 (14...♗f6? 15.♗b2 ♗b2 16.♕b2 0–0 17.♖ac1±) 15.♗b2 ♖fd8 16.e4 ♘b4 17.♗b7 ♕b7 18.♗c3 ♘c6 19.♖d5±.

Another option is 9...♗e7 which often interweaves with our main line 9...♗d6. White has some initiative after 10.dc5!? ♗c5 11.h3 (Or 11.♗d2 0–0 12.♖ac1 ♗a7 13.h3 ♖d8 14.♖fd1 ♗d7 15.e4 ♗e8 16.e5 ♘d7 17.♗g5 ♖dc8 18.♗f4±. Dautov – Arbakov, Bad Woerishofen 1998. The ♘e4 is eyeing the d6-square, comments of Dautov) 11...0–0 12.♖d1 ♘e5 (12...b5 13.e4 ♘h5 14.♗e3 ♘f4 15.♕d2 ♗e3 16.♕e3 ♗b7 17.♖ac1±) 13.e4 ♘g6 14.♗e3±, Topalov – Nikolic, Monte Carlo 1999.

10.♗d2

Probably 10.dc5 is more promising – see the note about 9...♗e7.



10...0-0 11.♖ac1 b6

It is a little early for **11...cd4** 12.ed4 ♗f4 13.♖fd1 ♗d7 14.♘e4 and Black's bishop is clumsy on d7 – 14...♘d5 15.♘c5 ♗d2 16.♕d2 ♖ad8 17.♗d5 ed5 18.♘e5 ♗e8 19.♕c3 ♘e5 20.de5 ♗b5 21.♕d4 ♕e7 22.a4 ♗e2 23.♖e1 ♗c4 24.a5±, A. Petrosian – Gulko Tashkent 1984, but perhaps **11...♖d8** is playable, e.g. 12.h3 (12.dc5!?) 12...cd4 13.ed4 ♗f4 14.♗e3 ♗d7 15.d5 ed5 16.♘d5 ♘d5 17.♗d5 ♗e3 18.fe3 ♗e8 19.e4 ♕e7 20.♕c4 ♖ac8, D. Gurevich – Raetsky, Bern 1995, 20...♘b4=.

12.dc5 ♗c5 13.♘a4 ♗e7 14.e4 ♗b7 15.e5 ♘d7 16.♗f4 b5 17.♘c3 ♘c5

Black must prevent White's knight from invading d6 – 17...♖ac8 18.♘e4 ♕b8 19.♘d6 ♗d6 20.ed6±.

18.♗c2 ♘b4 19.♗b1‡ ♖ad8? 20.♘e4 ♗e4 21.♕e4+–, Gustafsson – Janz, Fuerth 1999.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 ♘c6 8.♘c3)

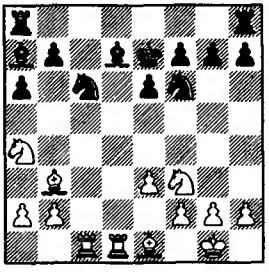
B2. 8...♗e7 9.dc5

Some 10 years ago commentators used to accompany such moves with a disdainful note in the sense "Black trades queens with a dead draw". Nowadays things do not appear that simple. Still, we think that 9.♕e2 is richer on ideas – see line A.

9...♕d1

The only drawback of 9...♗c5 is not that Black will lose the right of castle after 10.♕d8=, but the possibility of White to play 10.♕e2.

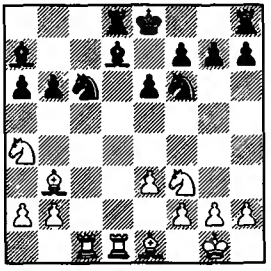
10.♖d1 ♗c5 11.♗d2 ♗d7 12.♖ac1 ♗a7 13.♗e1 ♔e7 14.♘a4



14...♖hb8!?

It is worth mentioning the famous game Karpov – Gulko 1996 which illustrates the tactical potential of White's pieces: 14...b6 15.♖d7! ♔d7 16.♘b6 ♗b6 17.♗a4 ♔c8 18.♘e5 ♔b8 19.♘c6 ♔b7 20.♘e5 ♖ac8 21.♗c6 ♔a7 22.♘f7± and White went on to win.

Another variation on this theme is seen in Epishin – Korchnoi, Willingen 1999: 13.♗e1 ♖d8 14.♘a4 b6



15.♖d7!! ♔d7 16.♘b6 ♔c7, when 17.♘e5 ♔b6 18.♖c6 ♔b7 19.♖c4 ♖c8 20.♘f7 ♖c4 21.♗c4± would have guaranteed White's edge.

Several games of A. Gershon proved that Black's troubles are not easy to solve by just trading some pieces:

14...♘e4 15.♘d2 ♘d2 16.♖d2 ♖hc8 17.♖dd1! ♗e8 (17...♘e5 18.♗b4 ♔e8 19.♗d6±) 18.♘c5 ♖ab8 (18...♘a5!? 19.♗b4 ♘b3 20.♘b7 ♔f6 21.♗c3! ♔g6 22.ab3±) 19.♘e4 ♖d8 20.♖d8 ♖d8 21.♘c5 ♗c5 (21...♖b8 22.♗d1!±) 22.♖c5 f6 23.♖c1! e5 24.♗d1 ♗f7. Here 25.a3!±, to be followed by b4, a4, would have rendered Black quite helpless.

14...♖hd8 15.♘c5 ♗c5 16.♖c5 ♗e8 17.♖dc1! ♘e4 18.♖5c4 ♘d6 19.♖4c2 f6 20.♘d4! ♘d4 21.ed4 ♘b5 22.♗a5 ♖d7 23.d5! ed5 24.♗b4 ♔d8 25.♗c5 ♗f7 26.♖e1 ♘c7 27.♗b6+–, Iljushin – Hunt, Patras 1999.

14...♖hc8 This is a better version of the previous game: 15.♘c5 ♗c5 16.♖c5 ♘e4 17.♖c4 ♘d6 18.♖c2 ♗e8 19.♗c3 a5 20.♖e2 f6 21.♘d4! ♘d8=, Gershon – Jonkman, Tel Aviv 2000.

The last example seems to show the right direction for investigations. We see that Black's main concern is the b7-pawn. He often has to part with his bishop conceding a small, but lasting edge to White. The idea of protecting the poor pawn with the rook is thus very logical. After consolidating his forces Black adopts the tactics of repelling or exchanging all active enemy pieces. It is true that he has not any sensible plan of his own, but neither White does!

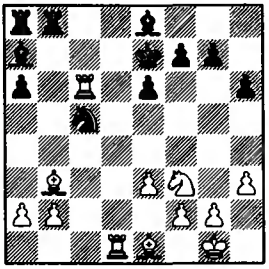
15.♘c5 ♗e8 16.h3 h6 17.♖c2

Black is ready to repel White's pride ♘c5 by 17...♘d7!. The manoeuvre 17.♘d3 ♖c8 18.♘fe5 ♔f8 19.♗c3 does not earn White dividends.

17...♘d7! 18.♘a6

18.♘d7 ♗d7 19.♗c3 f6 20.♘d4 ♖d8 is close to equal.

18...ba6 19.♖c6 ♘c5



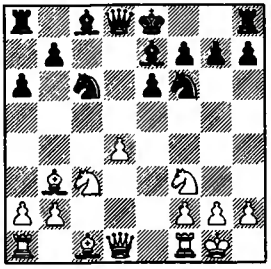
Lautier suggests here 20.♖c7! ♔f8 21.♖d6 ♘b3 22.ab3 ♗b6 23.♖c2 ♗d8 24.♖d3±, but we think that the doubled extra pawn of White causes Black only a mild discomfort.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 ♘c6 8.♘c3)

B3. 8...cd4 9.ed4

Or 9.♘d4 ♗d7!=.

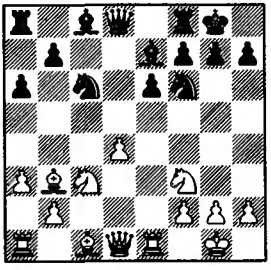
9...♗e7



B3a. 10.a3; B3b. 10.♗g5; B3c. 10.♖e1

Black is struggling in this line lately. That is mostly due to the fact that the opponent is able to get quickly at his king following the scheme 10.♗g5, ♕d2-f4-h4 and somewhere in this sequence the break d4-d5 could prove very efficient! Perhaps Black is better off delaying the exchange on d4, as shown in line B4.

B3a. 10.a3 0–0 11.♖e1

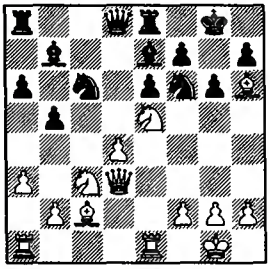


11...♘a5

The downside of 11...b5 is that Black has not even the slightest chance to win the ending, arising after 12.d5 ♘d5 13.♘d5 ed5 14.♗d5 ♗b7 15.♗f4. In fact, White's initiative is quite ephemeral and with a couple of accurate moves Black should steer the game to a draw, e.g. 15...♖c8 16.♖c1 ♗f6 17.b4 ♗a8 18.h3 ♘d4 19.♗a8 ♖a8 20.♗c7 ♘f3 21.♕f3 ♕d4= 22.♖ed1 ♕b2 23.♕d3 ♕a2 24.♖d2 ♕e6 25.♖e2 ♕c8 26.♖ec2 ♖e8 27.♗f4 ♕b7 28.♖c6 ♖e1 29.♔h2 ♖c1 30.♖c1 ♖c8 31.♕f3 ♕d7 32.♖d1 ♕c6 33.♖c1 ♕d7 34.♖d1 ½-½, Harikrishna – Ganguly, Torquay 2002.

12.♗c2 b5 13.d5

White would certainly be happier to play for checkmate with 13.♕d3 ♗b7 14.♗g5 g6 15.♗h6 ♖e8 16.♘e5, but his attacking pieces would easily be repelled after 16...♘c6:



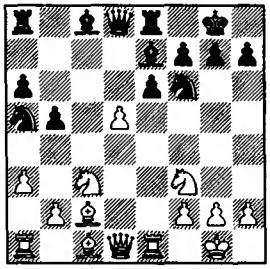
17.♕g3 (Indirectly protecting the d4-pawn, e.g. 17...♘d4? 18.♗g6!+–. The seemingly attractive 17.♕h3?! could turn the tables after 17...♘d4! 18.♖ad1 ♘c2 and Black's pieces control the centre. Even the chip "thinks" that Black is OK despite "his" affection to queens)

17...♘h5 18.♕f3 ♘e5 19.♕b7 ♕d4 20.♖ad1 ♕c5 21.♗e3 ♕c4 22.♗d4 ♘g4 23.♕f3 e5 24.♘d5 ♕c2 25.♘e7 ♔g7 26.♕g4 ed4 27.♕d4 ♘f6 28.♘d5 ½–½, Zugic – Lazarev, North Bay 1999.

Finally, another example of how easily White could turn even worse with an isolator on d4 – 15.♘e5 ♖c8 16.♖ad1 ♘c4 17.♘c4 bc4 18.♕h3 ♘d5 19.♗h6 ♖e8 20.♘e4 ♕b6∓, I. Sokolov – C. Hansen, Malmoe 1998.

13...♖e8

Capturing on d5 is not healthy in the current situation. After 13...♘d5 14.♘d5 ed5 15.♕d3 g6 16.♗h6 ♖e8 17.♕c3 f6 18.♘d4 or 18.♘h4 White's pressure is tangible. 13...ed5 is even worse – 14.♗g5 ♗e6 (14...♗b7 15.♕d3 g6 16.♕d4↑) 15.♘d4 ♕d7 16.f4 g6 17.f5 gf5, Se. Ivanov – Vorobiov, Petersburg 2003 when 18.♕f3!↑ would have left Black struggling.



14.♕d3

14.♘e5?! fails to 14...ed5! 15.b4 ♗d6!∓, while 14.♗g5 ♘d5 usually transposes to the main line.

14...g6 15.♗g5

White created the threat of 16.d6, thus forcing the enemy to define the situation in the centre.

15...♘d5 16.♘d5 ed5 17.♖e7 ♖e7 18.♕c3 ♖aa7!?

More ambitious than 18...♘b7 19.♕d4! (19.♘d4 ♖c7!) 19...♕e8 20.♗e7 ♕e7 21.♕d5±/=.

19.♕f6

White had a rich choice of unpleasant continuations: 19.♗h6 f6∓; 19.a4 ba4 20.♖a4 ♘c4∓; 19.♗e7 ♖e7 20.♘d4 ♕c7∓; 19.♘d4 ♕c7 20.♗e7 ♕c3 21.bc3 ♖e7 22.a4 ba4 23.♗a4 ♘c4∓.

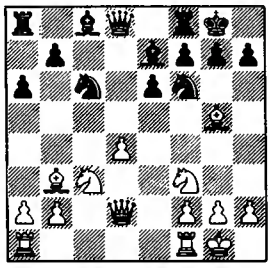
19...♕f8 20.♗d2! ♖e6 21.♕h4 ♘c6! 22.♘g5 ♕g7 23.♘e6 ♗e6

We suppose that a good defender would prefer to be on Black's side in this position. The b2-pawn is hanging and 24.♗c3?! ran into 24...d4 25.♗d2 d3! 26.♗c3 dc2!! 27.♗g7 ♖d7 28.♖f1□ ♖d1 29.♗h6 ♗c4–+ in Rahman – Volzhin, Dhaka 2001.

B3b. 10.♗g5 0–0 11.♕d2

11.♖e1 is less concrete. Black feels comfortable either with 11...b5 12.d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ed5 14.♕d5 ♕d5 15.♘d5 ♗g5 16.♘g5 ♗b7 17.♘e4 ♘d4 18.♘e7 ♔h8 19.♖ac1 ♗e4 20.♖e4 ♖fd8 ½–½, I. Sokolov – Sadler, Hastings 1998 or 11...♘a5 12.♗c2 b5 13.♕d2 ♗b7 14.♕f4 ♗f3 15.♕f3 ♘c4 16.♘e4 ♘e4 17.♗e7 ♕e7 18.♕e4 g6 19.d5 e5=, Smirnov – Rustemov, Togliatti 2003.

11.♖c1 ♗d7 (It is important to develop the bishop, and d7 is a safer place than b7 as Black avoids weaknesses.) 12.a3 b5 13.d5 led to mass elimination in Bareev – Dreev, Krasnoyarsk, 14.09.2007 after 13...♘d5 14.♘d5 ed5 15.♕d5 ♘a5 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♖c7 ♖ad8=.



11...b5

11...♘d5!? might be the safe way to treat this version of IQP position. Black gets a somewhat passive, but symmetrical position with good prospects to hold it: 12.♘d5 ed5 13.♗e7 ♘e7 14.♖fe1 ♕d6 15.♖ac1 ♗e6 16.♘e5 ♖ac8 17.h3 ♖c1 18.♖c1 ♖c8 19.♖c8 ♗c8 20.♕c3 b6 21.♗c2 f6 22.♘f3 a5 23.a3 ½–½ Moiseenko – Kharlov, Fuegen 2006.

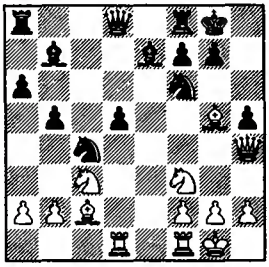
11...♘a5 usually transposes to the main line after 12.♗c2 b5 13.♖ad1. White could try to skip ♖ad1, but our analysis shows that Black is OK after 13.♕f4 g6! (Anticipating White's threats! In Tkachiev – Lesiege, New Delhi/Teheran, 2000 occurred 13...♗b7 14.♖ad1 g6 15.♗h6 ♘h5 16.♕g4 f5 17.♕h3 ♖c8 18.d5!±) 14.♕h4 (14.♖ad1 ♘h5 15.♕g4 ♗g5 16.♘g5 e5 17.♕h4 h6=) 14...♖e8! (Overprotecting in advance the other sensitive point – e7) 15.♘e5 (15.d5 ♘d5 16.♘d5 ed5 17.♖ae1 ♖a7; 15.♘e4 ♘e4 16.♗e4 ♗b7 17.♗e7 ♕e7 18.♘g5) 15...♘h5 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♕e7 ♖e7 18.b4 ♗b7 19.ba5 ♖c8↑Kharlov – Torbin, Togliatti 2003.

11...h6 is against the rule to avoid weaknesses on the flank where the opponent is going to attack. Here is

an example: 12.♗f4 ♖e8 13.♖ad1 ♗f8 14.♘e5 ♘e7 15.♕d3 ♘ed5 16.♘d5 ♘d5 17.♗c2 f5 18.♕g3±, Barsov – Lesiege, Montreal.

12.♖ad1 (12.d5!?±) **12...♘a5** (12...♗b7 13.d5±) **13.♗c2 ♗b7**

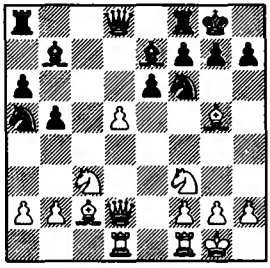
It was tempting to start probing White's weaknesses by 13...♘c4?!, but eventually Black would only lose a tempo after 14.♕f4 ♗b7 (14...♖a7 15.♘e5±, Kramnik – Anand, Leon rapid 2002), 15.d5! ed5 16.♕h4 h5, Degerman – Johansson, Sweden 2002.



With only moves White obtains full compensation for the pawn – 17.b3! (in the game was 17.♖fe1 ♘b2! 18.♘e4 de4↑, not an improvement would have been 17.♘e4 de4↑) 17...♘b6 (17...♘b2 18.♖d2 ♕c8 19.♘e2± – Black's knight went astray; 17...♘d6 18.♘d5 ♘d5 19.♖d5±) 18.♖fe1! (again 18.♘e4 is not the best – 18...♖c8 19.♗b1 de4! 20.♖d8 ♗d8 21.♘d4 ♖c5 22.♘e2 ♖e8 23.♘g3 ♖ee5∞) 18...♖c8 19.♗f6 ♗f6 20.♕h5 g6 21.♗g6 fg6 22.♕g6 ♗g7 23.♘g5 ♖f6 24.♕h7 ♔f8 25.♕h5 ♔g8 26.♖d3! (26.♘ce4 de4 27.♖d8 ♖d8 28.h4↑) 26...♕d7 27.♕h7 ♔f8 28.♖de3 ♖c3 29.♖c3 d4 30.♖g3±. This analysis may not be encompassing, but it is enough to reveal the tactical ideas of both sides.

14.d5

The older move 14.♕f4 is well met by 14...b4!, when the defensive potential of Black should be enough to tame the desperate onslaught 15.d5?! e.g. 15...bc3 16.♕h4 h5 17.de6 ♕c7 18.♗f6 ♗f6 19.♕h5 g6 20.ef7 ♖f7↑, Epishin – Hort, Hoogeveen 2001. Or 15.♘a4 ♗d5 with excellent coordination.



14...ed5!

14...♘d5? loses material to 15.♗e7 ♘e7 16.♗h7! or 15...♕e7 16.♘d5 and 17.♕a5.

Cebalo – Stevic, Zagreb 2004 saw 14...b4? 15.♕d3! g6 16.d6 ♗d6 17.♕d6 ♕d6 18.♖d6 ♘e8 19.♖b6 bc3 20.♗e7±.

15.♕f4

The text aims to shift the queen to h4. 15.♕d3 g6 16.♖fe1 is worse due to 16...b4 17.♘d5 ♘d5 18.♗e7 ♘e7 19.♕d8 ♖fd8 20.♖e7 ♗d5∓ Janssen – J. Ivanov, Amsterdam 2005.

15...♘h5!?

Instead, 15...b4? fails to 16.♕h4 h6 17.♗h6+–, while 15...♘c4?! 16.♕h4↑ would transpose to the game Degerman – Johansson, Swe-

den 2002 (see the analysis to Black's move 13).

15...♖c8?! 16.♕h4 h5 17.♗f6 ♗f6 18.♕h5 g6 leads to a better engame for White: 19.♗g6 fg6 20.♕g6 ♗g7 21.♘g5 ♖f6 22.♕h7 ♔f8 23.♘ce4 ♖h6 24.♕f5 ♔g8 25.♘f7 ♖f6 26.♘f6 ♕f6 27.♕f6 ♗f6 28.♘d6 ♖d8 29.♘b7 ♘b7 30.♖d2±

16.♕h4 ♗g5 17.♕h5 h6=.

B3c. 10.♖e1!?

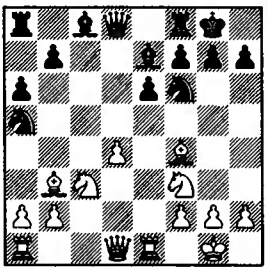
This move had usually led to transpositions to line B3a and B3b, until Topalov linked it with the idea of restricting Black's queenside expansion by a4. He and his second at the WCC match in Elista Cheparinov tried it successfully at highest level, so the onus is on Black.

10...0-0

10...♘a5 11.♗c2 b5 does not work due to 12.d5↑.

11.a4!?

Black has discovered several safe ways against an early break in the centre: 11.♗f4 ♘a5



12.d5 ♘b3 13.♕b3 ed5 (Or 13...♘d5 14.♖ad1 ♘f4 15.♖d8 ♖d8 16.♖d1 ♘d5 17.♘e5 ♗f6 18.♘c4 ♖b8!=, Kramnik – Kasparov, 5', Moscow 2001). 14.♖ad1 ♗e6 15.♕b7 ♗d6 16.♗g5 ♖b8 17.♕a6 ♖b2 18.♗f6 ♕f6 19.♕d6 ♕c3=, X3D FRITZ – Kasparov X3D Match 2003.

White has also tried to delay d4-d5, without much success though, e.g. 12.♗c2 b5 13.d5 ed5 14.♕d3 (14.♗g5 ♘c6 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.♘d5 g6 17.♘f6 ♕f6 18.♗e4 ♗f5 19.♗c6 ♕c6 ½–½ Yevseev – Yakovich, Samara 2000) 14...♘c6 (14...g6 15.♖e7 ♕e7 16.♗g5 ♕d6 17.♕d4 ♘h5 18.♘d5 ♘c6 19.♕d2 f6 20.♗b3 ♔h8 21.♗e3 ♗g4–+, Illescas Cordoba – Anand, Leon m 1997) 15.♗c7 ♕d7 16.♘e5 ♘e5 17.♗e5 g6 18.a4 ♗b7 19.ab5 ab5 20.♕b5 ♕b5=, Kramnik – Anand, Mainz 2001.

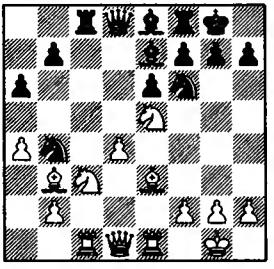
11...♗d7

The later game Cheparinov – Negi, Malmo 2007, was quite bizarre: 11...♕b6 12.♗e3 ♘a5 13.♗c2 ♘c4 14.♗g5 ♘d6 15.♕d3 g6 16.♖ad1 ♘f5 17.♕d2± and White won in style. I cannot understand what went wrong with Negi's home preparation, but his redeployment was really clumsy.

13.♘e5 ♗e8

13...♘b4 would have enabled the rook lift 14.♖e3 ♗c6 15.♖g3. By his last move Kramnik prevents this possibility.

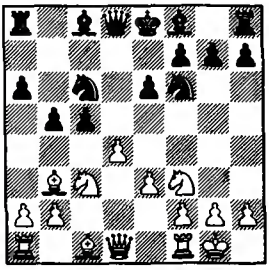
14.♗e3 ♖c8 15.♖c1 ♘b4



16.♕f3 ♗c6 17.♕h3 ♗d5

Black has consolidated, but his position is still a little cramped. However, in the game Topalov – Kramnik, Elista (7), 2006, White failed to crush it.

B4. 8...b5!?



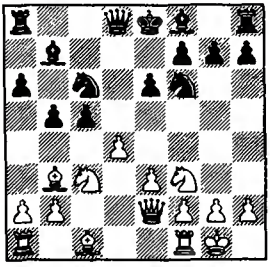
B4a. 9.♕e2; B4b. 9.d5; B4c. 9.dc5

The move 8...b5 is capable of spoiling the fun to the fans of 7.♗b3. Black has waited for 8.♘c3, so he is not afraid of a4 anymore. On the other hand, Black keeps all his options open. For instance, after 9.♕e2 ♗b7 10.♖d1 ♘a5 11.♗c2 cd4 he can transpose to a good version of an IQP position. The difference to line A1a is that instead of the "normal" ♗e7 and 0-0 Black got in ♗b7, thus closing the pass to the neuralgic c5-square via e4. This line is analysed in line B4a.

The most principled response to 8...b5, namely 9.d5, is currently under Black's control.

9.dc5 should not be that dangerous until Black's bishop is still on f8, although Black urgently needs some fixes in his play.

B4a. 9.♕e2 ♗b7



9...♗e7? 10.dc5!± is a sort of the Furman variation with an extra tempo.

10.♖d1

The exchange on c5 requires of Black a couple of only moves: 10.dc5 ♗c5 11.e4!? ♘d4! (11...b4 12.♖d1 ♕c7 13.e5±) 12.♘d4 ♗d4 13.e5 ♘d5 (13...♗c3 14.bc3 ♘e4 15.♕g4±) 14.♘d5 ♗d5 15.♖d1 ♗b3 16.ab3 ♕b6 17.b4 0–0 18.♗g5 f6 19.ef6 ♗f6 20.♗e3 ♕c6=.

10...♘a5 11.♗c2 cd4

Black can persist with the waiting game with 11...♕b6 12.a3 cd4 13.ed4 ♗e7 14.♗g5 ♖d8=, Kharitonov – Vorobiov, Sochi 2007.

12.ed4 ♗e7 13.♗g5

13.♘e4 ♗b7 14.♘c5 ♗d5 15.♘e5 had been assessed in White's favour, but in Acs – Korchnoi, Hungary 2004 Black found a way to consolidate his position with 16...♖c8!, when 17.♘a6 ♕d6! regains the pawn with good play, e.g. 18.♘c6 ♗c6 19.♘c5 ♕d5 20.f4 ♗c5 21.♗f6 gf6 22.dc5 ♕c5 23.♔h1 ♔h8=.

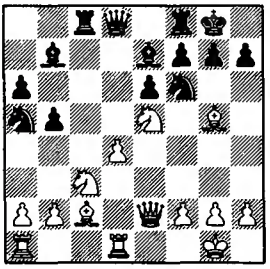
13...0–0 14.♘e5

Another version of the same strategic idea is 14.♖ac1 ♖c8 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.♗e4 ♕c7 17.♗b7 ♘b7 18.♕e3 ♕a5

19.♘e4 ♗e7 20.♕b3 ♖c7 21.d5=, Piket – Ivanchuk, Amber-blind 2000.

Tomashevsky – Hossain, World Cup Khanty-Mansiysk 27.11.2007 saw 14.♗f6 ♗f6 15.♗e4 ♗e4 16.♘e4 ♗e7 17.♘e5 ♕d5 18.♘c3 ♕d6 19.♖d3=, when 19...b4 20.♘e4 ♕d5 intending ...f6, would have been roughly equal.

14...♖c8



Different paths lead to this position. It is crucial for the evaluation of the set-up with ♕e2-♖d1. Black successfully developed his pieces, a d5-break is not imminent in near future and he needs only simple accuracy to extinguish the temporary initiative of White.

15.♗f6

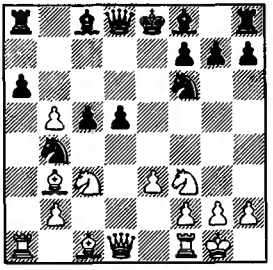
It is tempting to checkmate the enemy, but the "direct approach" is not advisable: 15.♖d3 b4 (or 15...♘c4 16.♖h3 g6 17.♗b3 ♘d5 18.♗e7 ♕e7 19.♘d5 ♗d5 20.♗c4 ♗c4 21.♕e3 f6↑, Potapov – Kashtanov, St. Petersburg 2000) 16.♖g3 g6 17.♗f6 ♗f6 18.♘e4 ♗e4 19.♕e4 ♘c4 20.♗b3=, Gutman – Savon, Alushta 1999.

15...♗f6 16.♗e4 ♕c7!

Last fine point. In C. Horvath – Gyimesi, Hungary, 1998 was 16...♕e7 17.♗b7 ♕b7 18.♘e4 ♗e7 19.♘c5! ♕a7 20.b4 ♘c6 21.♘c6 ♖c6 22.a4±.

17.♗b7 ♘b7 18.♘g4 ♗e7 19.d5 b4 20.♘a4 =, Dizdar – Lazarev, Paris 1996

B4b. 9.d5 ed5 10.a4 ♘b4 11.ab5



11...♗e7

11...♗d6 is also playable – 12.e4 de4 13.♗g5 ef3 14.♖e1, Romanishin – Rublevsky, Ohrid 2001, and now 14...♔f8! would have parried the attack, leaving White with only a small edge (analysis of Romanishin in Chess informant 82).

12.e4 c4 13.e5

Maksimenko – Zontakh, Ukraine (ch) 2002 saw 13.♗c2!? ♘c2 (Zontakh suggests 13...de4! 14.♕d8 ♗d8 15.♗e4 ♘e4 16.♘e4 ♗e7! 17.♘c3 ♗b7=) 14.♕c2 de4 15.♖d1! Here 15...♕b6!? 16.♗e3 ♕b7!= would have been comfortable for Black.

13...♘d7 14.♗c2 ♘c5

14...♘c2!? 15.♕c2 ♘c5 16.♘d4 ♗b7 17.ba6 ♖a6= is safer.

15.♘d4 ♗d7!

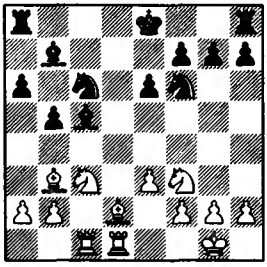
As shaky as Black's position may seem, White has nothing concrete. Without the help of a rook he cannot mate. Less accurate is 15...0–0, which happened in the game Dreev – Markowski, Moscow 2002. White had the strong answer 16.♘d5!±.

16.ba6 (16.♗f5 ♗b5∞) **16...♖a6**

16...0–0 is also playable – 17.a7 (17.♗f5 ♘b3 18.♗d7 ♘a1 19.♗b5 ♘b3 20.♘b3 cb3 21.♕b3∞) 17...♕b6 18.♕f3 ♗e6 19.♗f5 ♖a7 20.♖a7 ♕a7 21.♕g4 ♔h8= 22.♗e6?! fe6 23.♘e6 ♘e6 24.♕e6 ♗c5 25.♘d5 ♘d3↑.

17.♖a6 ♘ca6 18.♗f5 (18.♗b1!? ♘c5) **18...♘c5 19.♕f3 ♘e6 20.♘e6 ♗e6 21.♗e6 fe6 22.♕g4 ♔f7 23.♕h5=.**

B4c. 9.dc5 ♕d1 10.♖d1 ♗c5 11.♗d2 ♗b7 12.♖ac1



This position arose in the game Tregubov – Tkachiev, Corsica 1997. Black decided to treat it "safely":

12...♗e7?! 13.♘e2 0–0 (Perhaps there is no path to full equalisation: 13...♘e4 14.♗e1 ♖c8 15.♘ed4 ♘d4 16.♖c8 ♗c8 17.♘d4±) 14.♘ed4 ♘d4 15.♘d4 ♖fc8 16.♖c8! (Karpov played against Anand, Amber rapid 1997 the strange move 16.f3 and Black went on to draw. It is unbelievable that both Karpov and Anand overlooked ♘e6. More likely they assessed it as harmless, nevertheless we'd bet on White) 16...♖c8 17.♘e6 fe6 18.♗e6 ♔f8 19.♗c8 ♗c8 20.f3±.

We suspect that there will be no excess of candidates to defend Black's side in the above ending, so we propose as improvement:

12...♗d6!?

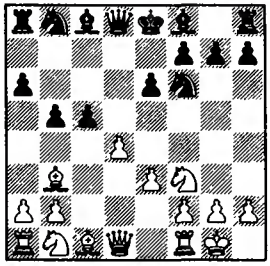
12...♗b6 might be a fair alternative: 13.♗c2 ♘e7 14.♘g5 0–0 15.a4 h6 16.♘ge4 ♘e4 17.♘e4 ♖fd8=, Tregubov – Vorobiov, Krasnoyarsk, 11.09.2007.

The bishop is a bit hanging there, but otherwise it is much better placed than on e7. We did not find anything for White here: 13.♗c2 (13.♘g5 ♘e5) 13...♔e7 14.♘g5 ♖hd8 15.♘ce4 ♘e4 16.♘e4 ♗b4=.

Conclusion

The 7.♗b3 system is currently the weapon of choice of the elite. If Black then tries some tricky move orders with b7-b6 or ♘bd7, White obtains strong initiative by the help of the pawn sacrifice e4. The acid test for the variation is the position with an isolated pawn on d4. As a rule, White has some initiative, but Black could hold the position with precise defence. The hotest new idea has been introduced by Topalov and his second Cheparinov. Before organising a kingside attack, they restrict Black's queenside play by a4. This concept could be anticipated with an early b5, which is the subject of line B4. By this move order Black could even steer the game into independent, non-IQP paths, as shown in line B4a: 7...♘c6 8.♘c3 b5 9.♕e2 ♗b7 10.♖d1 ♘a5 11.♗c2 ♕b6.

Chapter 15



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 b5

(D27)

You should pay an utmost attention to this chapter! We deal here with currently the most topical variation of the QGA.

7...b5 is the most interesting and challenging answer against the 7.♗b3 system. It follows the true spirit of the QGA as Black fights for the initiative by expanding on the queenside. That grants White a lever which he exploits by 8.a4. As a result, he gets in his possesion the important square c4, but is deprived of c3. In the long run, the b4-pawn could prove dangerous and the b3-square weakened, but only if Black survives the opening initiative of White.

Play is extremely sharp and requires some memorisation. I recommend to Black players to focus their attention to line B which is the safer option nowadys.

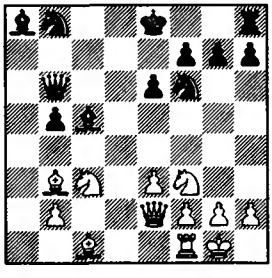
8.a4 b4

Most QGA experts do not consider this move as a big concession. However, sometimes we can see other approaches:

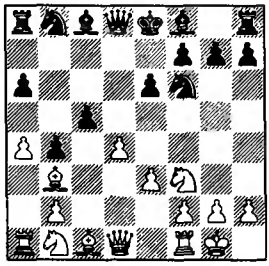
8...ba4 9.♗a4 ♘bd7 10.e4 cd4 11.e5 ♘d5 12.♗c6 ♖b8 13.♗d5 ed5 14.♘d4 ♖b6 15.♘c3±, Rublevsky – Vaulin, Smolensk 1991.

8...c4 9.♗c2 ♗b7 10.ab5 ab5 11.♖a8 ♗a8 12.♕e2 ♘c6 13.b3 cb3 14.♗b3 ♕b6 15.e4 ♘a5 16.♗c2 ♗e7 17.♗g5 h6 18.♗h4±, Dautov – Pelt, Deizisau 2002.

8...♗b7 9.ab5 ab5 10.♖a8 ♗a8 11.♕e2 ♕b6 (11...b4 12.♗a4 ♘bd7 13.♘e5±, Yermolinsky – Quinn, London 1994. Also good is 13.♕b5±) 12.dc5 ♗c5 13.♘c3. White has the initiative. The old encounter Weinstein – L. Kovacs, Leningrad 1960 presents a good example to follow:



13...b4 (look at the dangers for Black after 13...♗c6 14.♘e5 ♘e4 15.♘f7!! ♘c3 16.♕h5±!) 14.♘a4 ♕a5 15.♘c5 ♕c5 16.♗a4 ♘bd7 17.♗d2 0–0 18.♖c1 ♕d6 19.♖c4 ♕a6 20.♗d1±.



In this topical position White has two major plans:

1. White plays on the queenside. His set-up includes a4-a5, ♗a4, ♘bd2-c4, ♘f3-e5, ♕e2, ♖d1. As tempting as it may seem, in practice this plan does not yield significant advantage.

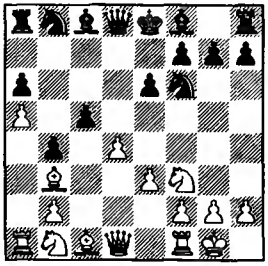
2. White pushes e3-e4-e5 and goes with his queen's knight to c4 or e4, eying the d6-square. This is a dangerous plan which scores well. Black has not really a choice, but to take on d4 and try to organise some counterplay against the e5-pawn or the b3-bishop. The big question is how and when to capture on d4. The fine point is that if Black plays early c5xd4, his b7-bishop remains barred by his own knight on c6. Rublevsky defended this idea in many games, linking it with pressure on e5 while the light-squared bishop remains on c8. His two losses at Karpov Poykovsky tournament 2005 have shaken the confidence in that plan.

Ponomariov and Ivanchuk hold their own by trying to take on d4 by knight. Thus Black achieves two goals: reduces the number of pieces for an easier defence, and opens up the main diagonal to his bishop. White can oppose to that approach a dangerous kingside attack. He provokes g7-g6 to weaken the dark squares, and takes on c5 himself. That way he opens the d-file and distracts one defender from the kingside.

9.e4!?

9.♕e2?! ♗b7 transposes to the Classical system (Chapter 20, line B2). It is considered innocuos.

White's most forward attempt is 9.a5, but this move does not achieve its goals. Black easily completes development:



9...♗e7 (More tangled is 9...♘c6 10.♘bd2!? ♗b7!? 11.♗a4 ♗e7 12.dc5 0–0 13.♘b3 ♕c7= or even 9...♗b7 10.♗a4 ♘bd7 11.e4 ♕c7 12.♗g5 ♘e4 13.♘e5 ♘g5 14.♗d7 ♔e7 15.f4∞, Avrukh – Karjakin, Biel 2003. We have some suspicions that Black should be able to parry the attack, but we'll leave the investigation to the interested parties)

10.♗a4 ♗d7 11.dc5 0–0=, Vl. Georgiev – A. Mikhalchishin 2003.

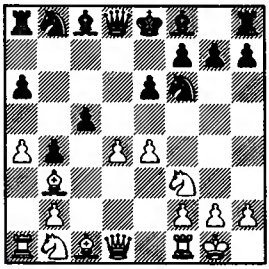
In most games White plays on the ninth move:

9.♘bd2!?

Then 9...♗b7 10.e4 transposes to the main line.

9...cd4 should be met by 10.e4! which is covered in line A. Not so dangerous for Black is 10.♘c4 ♗e7 11.♘d4 ♗b7 12.♘e5 ♗d5=, J. Piket – Tkachiev, Cannes 2000. The pawn structure that arises after 10.ed4 ♗e7 11.a5 0–0 12.♘c4 ♗b7 13.♘fe5 ♘bd7= is too static.

9...♗e7 is also playable. White's best answer is perhaps 10.e4 cd4, transposing to line A. 10.dc5 brings good results, but Black should not complain after 10...0–0! (10...♗c5?! 11.e4 ♗b7 12.♕e2 ♕c7 13.e5 ♘fd7 14.♘c4 ♘b6 15.♘b6 ♕b6 16.a5 ♕c7 17.♗a4 ♗c6 18.♗e3 ♗e3 19.♕e3±, A. Maric – Krivec, Leon 2001.) 11.a5 (11.e4 is a strike at thin air – 11...♘fd7 12.♕e2 ♘c5 13.♗c2 a5↑, Palo – C. Hansen, Aarhus 2003 or 12.e5 ♘c5 13.♗c2 ♗b7∓, Kharlov – Yakovich, Krasnoyarsk 2003) 11...♕c7 and White probably must think about completing development with 12.♗c2, followed by b3 and ♗b2. Black is currently OK here.



Black's major options are:
A. 9...cd4?!
B. 9...♗b7!

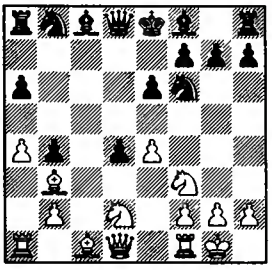
A. 9...cd4

9...♘e4 leads to an inferior ending after 10.d5 ♗e7 11.♖e1 ♘f6 12.de6 ♗e6 13.♕d8 ♗d8 14.♘g5±;

9...♗e7 runs into 10.d5!, when 10...♘e4 leads to the above line.

10.♘bd2

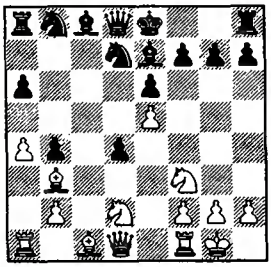
10.e5 ♘e4 11.♘d4 is well met by 11...♘c5! 12.♗c4 ♗b7 13.a5 ♕c7 14.♘d2 ♕e5 15.♘2f3 ♕d6 16.♗d2 ♘e4! 17.♕a4 ♘c6∓.



A1. 10...♗e7
A2. 10...♗b7

10...♘c6 11.e5 ♘d7 12.♘c4 ♗e7 transposes to A1. If Black decides to counter-attack without "wasting time" on development, he could easily become a co-author of a miniature, e.g. 12...♘c5? 13.♗g5 ♗e7 (We'll show some excerpts from our analysis to illustrate the dangers that are awaiting Black after 13...♕c7 – 14.♖c1 ♗b7 15.♖e1 ♘b3 16.♕b3 ♗c5 17.♘cd2 ♗a7 18.♘e4 0–0 19.♘f6 gf6 20.♗f6 ♖fd8 21.♕d3+– or 17...♗e7 18.♘e4 0–0 19.♗f6 gf6 20.ef6 ♗d8 21.♕d3 ♕f4 22.♖c5 ♕h6 23.♖g5 ♔h8 24.♕d2±.) 14.♘d6 ♔f8 15.♗e7 ♔e7 16.♘d4 ♘e5 17.f4 ♕d6 18.fe5 ♕b6 19.a5 ♕b7 20.♖c1 ♘d7 21.♘c6 1-0, Galliamova – Danielian, Istanbul 2000.

A1. 10...♗e7 11.e5 ♘fd7



12.♘c4

White has also good attacking prospects after 12.♘e4 ♘c6 13.♗f4, but this continuation is double-edged in view of the weakness of the e5-pawn. Perhaps Black should castle quickly, because things turned bad for him after 13...♗b7 14.♖e1 (13.♘d6 ♗d6 14.ed6 ♘c5∓) 14...♕a5 15.♘d6 ♗d6 16.ed6 ♕f5 17.♗g3 d3 18.♗c4±, Sasikiran – Tkachiev, Bastia 2003. Thus I recommend 13...0–0 14.♗f4 ♘c6 15.♗c2 ♕a5, as in Inarkiev – Karjakin, Moscow 2004.

12...♘c6 13.♘d4 ♘ce5

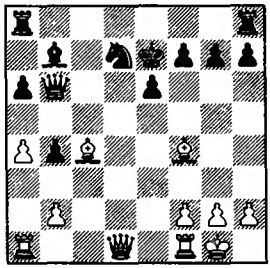
13...♘de5 was tried in Krivoshey – Zambrana, Las Palmas 2005 which went on 14.♘c6 ♘c6 15.♕d8=. Critical though is 15.♗f4⩲, when 15...♕d1 leads to the same ending with an extra tempo for White, whilst 15...0–0 16.♕f3 ♗d7 17.♖ad1 is more than risky.

14.♗f4 ♘c4 15.♘c6!

Previously White had been linking his hopes for advantage with the ending after 15.♗c4 ♘b6 16.♗b3 ♗f6 17.♘c6 ♕d1 18.♖fd1. In Lautier – Rublevsky, Poikovsky 2003 White emerged from the ensuing tactical fight with an extra pawn (though hardly convertible):

18...0–0 19.a5 ♘d5 20.♗d5 ed5 21.♘b4 ♗e6 22.♘d5 ♗b2 23.♖ab1 ♖fd8 24.♘c7 ♖ac8 25.♘a6 ♗f5 26.♗c7 ♗b1 27.♖d8 ♖d8 28.♗d8±. Black could improve earlier with 16...♗b7!? 17.a5 ♘d5∞.

15...♕b6 16.♘e7 ♔e7 17.♗c4 ♗b7



We have reached the most topical position in this line. Latest practice shows that White's initiative is highly unpleasant. The first player is able to create threats on both flanks. Especially vulnerable is the pawn on b4 and the h4-square. The loyal servant of this variation Rublevsky lost two consecutive encounters which is a sure sign that Black's defence is not easy.

Most convincing seems the game Grischuk – Rublevsky, 6th Karpov Poikovsky 2005 which went on:

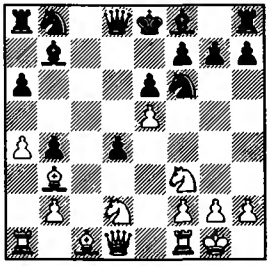
18.♕b3!? ♘c5 19.♕e3 ♕c6 20.f3 ♖hd8 21.♖fc1 ♖ac8 22.♕e1±.

(3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 b5 8.a4 b4 9.e4 cd4 10.♘bd2)

A2. 10...♗b7 11.e5

(see the next diagram)

11...♘d7

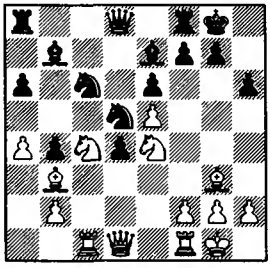


The candidates for trying 11...♘e4 12.♘e4 ♗e4 are scarce. By playing a couple of normal moves, White obtains a clear edge – 13.♘d4 ♗c5 (13...♘c6 14.♘c6 ♗c6 15.♗e3 ♕d1 16.♖fd1 ♖d8 17.♖d8 ♔d8 18.♗c4 ♗b7 19.♖c1±) 14.♗e3 ♗d4 15.♗d4 ♘c6 16.♗c5 ♕d1 17.♖ad1 ♘a5 18.♗a2 b3 19.♗b1 ♗b1 20.♖b1 0–0–0±, Klimov – Vaulin, Ekaterinburg 2002.

The game Kasparov – J. Piket, Tilburg 1997 cast a shade of doubt over:

11...♘d5?! The knight bars the diagonal to the b7-bishop, but more important is that Black is left without any counterplay. 12.♘c4! ♘c6 (12...♗e7 is dubious due to 13.♗g5 0–0 14.♘d6 ♗g5 15.♘b7 ♕e7 16.♗d5 ed5 17.♘d6±.) 13.♗g5 ♕d7 (Black had not much choice: 13...f6? 14.ef6 gf6 15.♖e1 fg5 16.♖e6 ♔d7 17.♖c6 ♗c6 18.♘ce5 ♔c7 19.♘c6 ♔c6 20.♘d4 ♔b6 21.a5+–; 13...♕c7 14.♖c1 ♗c5 15.♘d6 ♗d6 16.♗d5 ♗e5 17.♗c6 ♗c6 18.♖e1 f6 19.♘d4 ♗d4 20.♖e6 ♔d7 21.♕g4 h5 22.♕f5 g6 23.♕h3+–.) 14.♖c1 h6 (14...♗c5 15.♘cd2!? ♗e7 16.♗e7±) 15.♗h4 ♗c5 16.♘fd2! 0–0 17.♘e4 ♗e7 18.♗g3! ♕d8

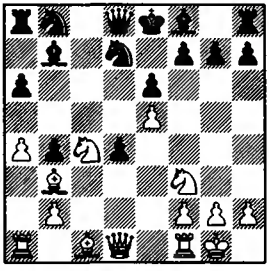
A spectacular position! White has a strong bind in the centre and is able to prepare the final attack at his leisure.



19.♘cd6 ♘a5 20.♗c2 b3 21.♗b1 ♕b6 22.♕d3 g6 23.♘c5 ♗c8 24.h4 ♘c6 25.a5! ♕a5 26.♘f7 ♖f7 27.♕g6 ♔f8 28.♘e6 ♗e6 29.♖c6! ♗d7 30.♕h6 1–0. Kasparov – J. Piket, Tilburg 1997.

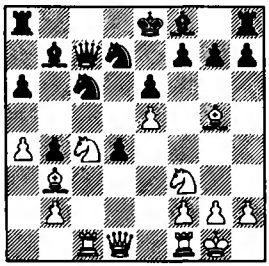
12.♘c4

This variation also does not promise Black much fun, although he is still trying to amend its notorious reputation.



A2a. 12...♘c6
A2b. 12...♗e7;
A2c. 12...♘c5

A2a. 12...♘c6 13.♗g5 ♕c7 14.♖c1



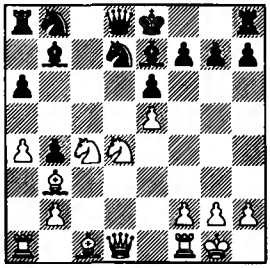
14...♗c5

Black tried to improve later with 14...♘c5 15.♗a2 ♘e4? 16.♗h4 g5, but both 17.♗g5 ♘g5 18.♘g5 0–0–0 Bareev – Timman, Sarajevo 1999 19.♕f3! ♖g8 20.♘d6+– or 17.♗b1 d3 18.♗d3 ♖d8 19.♗g5 ♘g5 20.♘g5 ♘e5 21.♕h5 ♘g6 22.♘e6+–, Tregubov – Brynell, Rowy 1999 ensured White a clear edge. Bareev suggested 15...h6! 16.♗f4 g5 17.♘d6 ♗d6 18.ed6 b6 19.♗g3∞, but we suspect that no one will strive to defend Black's position. White could also produce an improvement, for instance 15.♖e1 with excellent coordination.

15.♘d4 (or 15.♖e1 0–0 16.♕d3 ♖fe8 17.♗f4 ♖ad8 18.♘g5± Xd6, Ulibin – Ghorbani, Tehran 2004) **15...♘de5** (15...0-0 16.♘c6±) **16.♘e5 ♕e5 17.♘f3 ♕d6 18.♕c2 ♗a7 19.♖fd1→**, Topalov – Lautier, Amber-rapid 1997.

A2b. 12...♗e7 13.♘d4!?

13.♕d4 ♘c5 14.♕d8 ♔d8 15.♗c2 seems more natural, but the ending is probably equal. Black's king is dubiously placed, but the superb posts for the bishop on d5 and the knight on c5 amply compensate for that. 15...♘bd7 (15...b3 16.♗d1 ♘bd7 17.♗d2 ♗d5 18.♗e2±) 16.b3 (White is unable to retain his centre after 16.♗e3 ♗d5 17.♘fd2 ♖c8 18.b3 f6 19.f4 due to 19...f5, when 20.h3 ♖g8 21.g4 is met by 21...g6!, threatening with 22...fg4 23.hg4 h5). 16...♗d5 17.♘fd2 f6! 18.ef6 ♗f6=, Kir. Georgiev – Ibragimov, New York 1998.



13...0–0

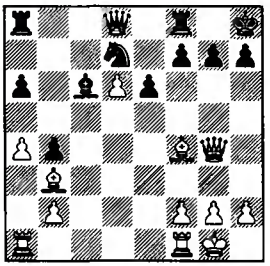
Several games went on 13...♘c5 14.♕g4, only to prove White's clear edge. e.g. 14...g6 15.♗h6± ♘b3 16.♘b3 ♘d7 17.♖ad1 ♖c8 18.♖fe1 ♗c6 19.♘d6 ♗d6 20.ed6+–, Tkachiev – Sadvakasov, Moscow 2002.

14.♕g4 ♔h8 15.♗f4!

White's knights in the centre are hanging and the best policy is to trade them profitably. The game Evseev – Feoktistov, Kalotturneringen 1999 followed 15.♖d1 ♘c6 16.♘c6 ♗c6 17.♗f4 ♗d5 18.♘d2 ♘c5 19.♗c2 ♖e8 20.♕h3 ½–½. Black succeeded in neutralising the attack. After the text White is ready to introduce a knight on d6:

15...♘c6 16.♘c6 ♗c6 17.♘d6 ♗d6 18.ed6±.

Every exchange of minor pieces makes Black's queenside pawns more vulnerable.



Neither 18...♕f6 (18...♘c5 19.♖ac1) 19.♗e3, nor 18...♕a5 19.♖ac1 ♗d5 20.♗d5 ♕d5 21.♖c7 ♖fd8 22.♗g3± could ensure an easy life to Black. Rizzitano advocates for 18...♗d5 19.♗d5 ♘f6, but then 20.♗g5± leads to a clear edge in the endgame.

A2c. 12...♘c5 13.♗g5 ♕c7!

13...f6? 14.ef6 gf6 is refuted by 15.♘d4! h5 16.♘e6 ♕d1 17.♖ad1 fg5 18.♘c5 ♗c5 19.♖fe1 ♔f8 20.♖e5 ♗e7 21.♘d6+–, J. Goormachtigh – Jonkman, Gent 2001.

14.♘d4 ♘b3 15.♕b3

In Tregubov – Sherbakov, Krasnoiarsk 1998 was 15.♘b3 h6 to be followed by an unexpected draw. We can only guess the motives of Black, who is about to win a piece without running immediate risks.

15...♘c6

Despite some temporary discomfort, caused by the hanging state of the ♘c4, the positional pluses of White should eventually prevail after 15...♗d5 16.♖ac1 ♘d7 17.a5 ♖b8 18.♗f4±.

16.♘c6 ♕c6 17.f3 ♗c5 18.♔h1 0–0 19.♖ac1±.

(3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♗b3 b5 8.a4 b4 9.e4)

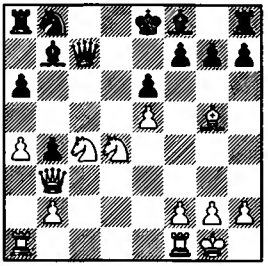
B. 9...♗b7! 10.♘bd2!

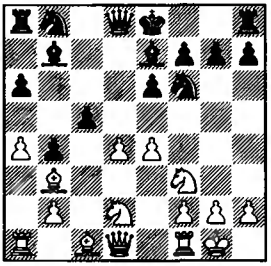
10.e5?! allows 10...♘e4! (10...♘fd7? 11.d5! ♗d5 12.♗d5 ed5 13.♕d5 ♘b6, Hillarp Persson – Yakovich, Koge 1997, 14.♕d8! ♔d8 15.♖d1 ♔e8 16.a5 ♘6d7 17.♘bd2±) 11.♘bd2 ♘d2 12.♗d2 cd4 13.♗g5 ♗e7 14.♗e7 ♕e7 15.♘d4 0–0 16.♕g4 ♘c6 17.♘c6 ½–½, Iljushin – Makarov, Krasnodar 2002.

10...♗e7

The latest trend for Black is to delay taking on d4, giving highest priority to development.

Capturing on e4 is self-destructing: 10...♘e4? 11.♘e4 ♗e4 and White is free to decide in what sequence to play the moves ♗g5, ♖e1 and dc5, regaining the pawn with a clear edge.

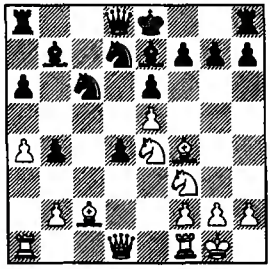




11.e5

It is early for 11.dc5 in view of 11...♘e4! 12.♘e4 ♕d1=.

In Epishin – Karpatchev, Bad Zwesten 2002 White outwitted his opponent by 11.♗c2!? cd4 (11...♘c6 12.dc5) 12.e5 ♘fd7 13.♘e4 ♘c6 14.♗f4

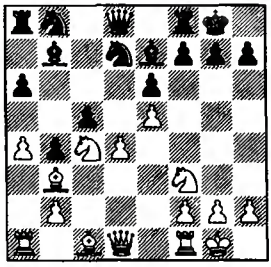


14...h6?! 15.♖e1 ♕a5 16.♘d4 ♘ce5 (or 16...♘d4 17.♕d4 ♕b6 18.♕d1±), when 17.♘f5! ef5 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.♕d6 f6 (19...♕d5 20.♕d5 ♗d5 21.♗e5 ♘e5 22.♖e5 ♗e6 23.♗f5 0–0 24.♗e6 fe6 25.♖e6 ♖ac8±) 20.♗f5 ♕d5 21.♗d7 ♔f7 22.♕d5 ♗d5 23.♗e5 ♖ad8 24.♗g4 fe5 25.♖e5± would have ensured an edge. However in the diagram position 14...0–0!? (or 14...♕a5 15.♖e1 0-0) 15.♕d3 g6∞ would have been more testing to White's idea. Notice that typical sac 15.♘d6 ♗d6 16.♗h7? fails to 16...♔h7 17.♘g5 ♕g5!

11...♘fd7 12.♘c4

This is the best stand for the knight! 12.♖e1 0–0 13.♘e4 leaves the e5-pawn vulnerable – 13...cd4 14.♗c2 ♘c6 15.♕d3 g6 16.♗f4 ♕a5!∓, Vera – Karjakin, Benidorm 2002. In general, Black has good counterplay if he manages to plant his queen on a5.

12...0–0



The most sensitive point in Black's set-up is the d6-square. However, White is unable to permanently install a knight there, due to the weakness of the e5-pawn. Thus more realistic plans are a kingside attack, using a battery along the b1-h7 diagonal, or central play, based on a bishop pair advantage. (after ♘d6)

White has tried many moves here, but currently Black is holding quite well:

B1. 13.♗f4
B2. 13.♘d6
B3. 13.♗c2
B4. 13.♗e3

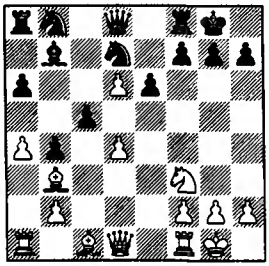
B1. 13.♗f4

It is good to develop pieces, but this move seems inaccurate because the bishop could turn more useful on h6. The game Sundararajan – Wang Hao, Hyderabad 2005 showed a forced way to equality:

13...♘c6 14.♗c2 ♘d4 15.♘d4 cd4 16.♕d4 b3! 17.♗b3 ♘c5 18.♕d8 ♖fd8 19.♗a2 ♖ab8 20.♘d6=

Here simplest would have been 20...♗a8.

B2. 13.♘d6 ♗d6 14.ed6



14...c4!?

I like this move, for it helps Black immediately kill the awkward pawn on d6. Dreev – Ponomariov, Panormo 2001 went on: 14...cd4, when 15.♗g5? walked into 15...♗f3 16.♕f3 ♕g5 17.♕a8 ♘c5 18.♕f3 ♘bd7 19.♖ad1 ♘e5↑. Instead, 15.♘d4 ♘c5 16.♗e3 would have been more testing, but apparently Black is also OK after 16...♘b3 (16...♕d6 17.♘f5 ♕d1 18.♘e7 ♔h8 19.♗d1 ♘bd7 20.♖c1 ♖fe8 21.♖c5± ♘c5 22.♗c5 ♖ad8 23.♗b4 ♖d4 24.♗c5 ♖c4 25.b4 ♖c5 26.bc5 ♖e7 27.♗e2; 16...♖e8 17.♖c1 ♘b3 18.♘b3 ♗d5 19.♘d2 ♘d7 20.♘c4 ♖c8) 17.♘b3 ♗d5 18.♖c1 ♖e8.

Or 14...♕f6?! 15 d5↑

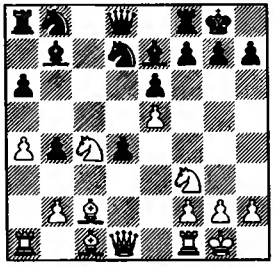
15.♗c4 ♘b6 16.♗d3 ♕d6 17.a5 ♘d5 18.♘e5 ♘c6 19.♖e1

This is a typical IQP position where Black has solved the opening problems. He can play, for instance, 19...♖ac8∞. Instead, the source game Moiseenko – Nisipeanu, ECC Kemer, 08.10.2007 saw 19...♘d4?! 20.♗h7 with initiative.

B3. 13.♗c2 cd4

The game Dreev – Ponomariov, Yerevan 2001, introduced the move 13...♘c6 14.dc5 ♘c5 15.♘d6 b3 16.♗b1 ♕c7∞. Later 14.♘d6!? ♗d6 15.ed6 cd4 16.♘d4 has been proposed. Perhaps 14.♕d3 g6 15.♗h6 ♖e8 16.dc5 ♘c5 17.♕e3! (ECO 4th edition) is a better try. Then 17...♘a5 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.ed6 ♕d6 20.♖ad1 ♕e7 21.♘e5 f5 22.h4 gives White pressure on the dark squares.

In the game Mastrovasilis – Moutousis, Athens 2004 Black tried the thematic pawn sacrifice 13...b3 a bit too early, as after 14.♗b3 cd4 White could have recaptured on d4 by knight.



14.♕d4

Alternatively:

14.♗f4 ♘c6 15.♘d4 ♘d4 16.♕d4 b3 transposes to line B1.

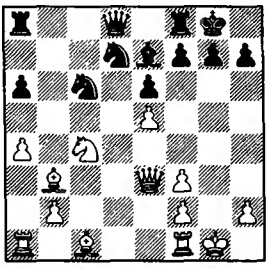
14.♘d4 ♕c7 (Or 14...♗d5 15.♘e3 ♘e5 16.♕h5 g6!? 17.♕e5 ♗d6 18.♘e6 ♗e6 19.♕e4 ♖a7=.) 15.♕d3 g6 16.♗f4 ♘c6 17.♘f3 ♖fd8 was good for Black in Ernst – Krush, Bermuda 2002.

14...b3

14...♗d5 15.♕g4 f5 16.ef6 ♘f6, Gunina – Matveeva, Samara 2005 is unclear after 17.♕h4.

15.♗b3 ♗f3 16.gf3 ♘c6 17.♕e3

Black has sufficient compensation.



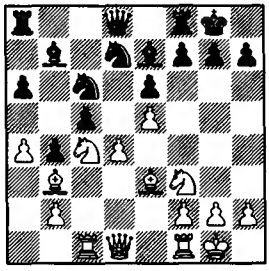
17...♕c7 18.f4 ♘c5 19.♗d1 ♖fd8! 20.♖a3 ♘b4, Riazantsev – Rublevsky, Sochi 2005.

There have been no attempts to improve White's play so far.

B4. 13.♗e3 ♘c6

White has a slight edge following 13...♗d5 14.dc5 (14.♖c1 ♘c6) 14...♘c5 15.♗c5 ♗c5 16.♘d6 ♗f3 17.♕f3 ♘d7 18.♘c4 ♕g5 19.♕e4 ♖ac8 20.♖ad1± due to his spatial advantage.

14.♖c1



14...cd4 15.♘d4 ♘ce5 wins only temporarily a pawn, while offering White the initiative after 16.♘e5 ♘e5 17.f4 ♘g6 18.f5 ef5 19.♘f5↑.

14...♖c8 15.♘d6 ♗d6 16.ed6 ♘a5 17.dc5

White's decision to open up the centre is positionally correct as he has the bishop pair. 17.♗c2 c4 is quite risky for White since it gives the opponent a big advantage on the queenside. Meanwhile he would be unable to convert his initiative into something tangible: 18.♘e5 (or 18.♗d2?! ♖b8! 19.♘e5 ♗d5 20.♕g4 f5 21.♕g3 ♖b7∞) 18...♗d5!? (or 18...♘f6 19.♗f4 ♕b6=) 19.♕g4 f5 20.♕g3 ♘f6 21.♗h6 ♘h5 22.♕g5 ♕d6 23.♕h5 gh6.

17...♗f3 18.gf3 ♘c5 19.♗c2 ♖c6!

There is no reason to shy away from the challenge by 19...♘ab7 20.♕d4±.

20.♗b1

Raetsky and Chetverik suggest 20.♗c5 ♕g5 21.♔h1 ♖c5 22.♕d4, but then 22...g6 23.♕b4 ♖c4∓ would clearly favour Black.

20...g6 21.♗h6 ♖d6 22.♕e1 ♖d5 23.♕b4 ♘c6

Black's pieces are more active.

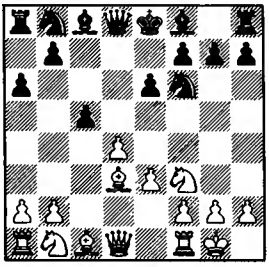
Conclusion:

7...b5 is playable and in good theoretical shape nowadays. However, that is true only for the lines where Black delays capturing on d4. His well tested set-up is to quickly develop the bishops to b7 and e7, retreat with the f6-knight to d7, and castle.

The critical position arises after 7.♗b3 b5 8.a4 b4 9.e4 ♗b7 10.♘bd2 ♗e7 11.e5 ♘fd7 12.♘c4 0–0 (line B) when White has tried 4 moves, but without being able to prove any advantage so far. I would even say that currently he is running short on new ideas. On the contrary, he is quite convincing against an early ...cd4, which opens up the centre to his favour.

Chapter 16

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♗d3



(D27)

This variation looks similar to 7.♗b3, but in fact it is closer to the Furman system. (6.♕e2)

White prepares e3-e4-e5, anticipating b7-b5. At the same time he would not mind to enter an isolated queen's pawn position. Lately the most prominent adherent of the variation is Kramnik, while Karpov feels comfortably on both sides. Although the 7.♗d3-variation is still occurring at top level, its popularity is gradually going downhill after a peak in 1997-1999.

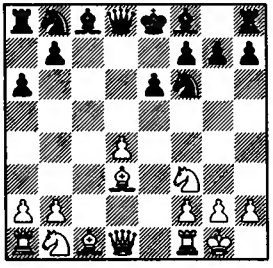
Black's major options are:
A. 7...cd4
B. 7...b6
C. 7...♘bd7!?

Rare alternatives are:

7...b5 8.a4 b4 is cheerless. White has a clear plan – the queen knight heads for c4 via b1-d2, the e3-pawn moves forward to e5 and eventually the f3-knight could find a better place on e4.

7...♘c6 8.♘c3 cd4 transposes to line A3 while 8...♗e7 9.dc5! ♗c5 10.a3 0–0 11.b4 is similar to the Furman variation with White enjoying an extra tempo.

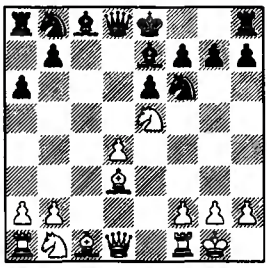
A. 7...cd4 8.ed4



A1. 8...♗e7
A2. 8...♘c6

When playing against an isolated queen pawn, sooner or later Black will have to neutralise threats to h7, usually by g6. Thus 8...g6?! looks very logical. The "only" problem is the unpleasant pin after 9.♘c3 ♗g7 10.♗g5! when 10...h6 11.♗h4 ♘c6 12.♗e4 ♘e7 13.♕a4 ♗d7 14.♕a3± or 10...♘c6 11.♗e4 ♘e7 12.♘e5 0–0 13.♕f3± Barsov – Parmentier, FRA 2002 favour White.

A1. 8...♗e7 9.♘e5!?



Black was intending to fianchetto his bishop to b7 and develop the queen's knight to d7. Then he would reach a nice set-up against the IQP. Karpov has defended successfully such positions:

9.♘c3 b5 10.♖e1 ♗b7 11.♗g5 ♘bd7 12.♘e5 0–0 13.♖e3 ♖e8 14.♖h3 g6=, Bacrot – Karpov, Cap d'Agde 2006.

A sterner test would have been a queenside attack:

9.♘c3 b5 10.a4! b4 11.♘e4 ♗b7 12.♕e2 0–0 13.♖d1 ♘bd7 14.♘ed2 a5 15.♗b5 ♘b6 16.♘b3 ♗d5 17.♘c5 ♘bd7 18.♗e3±, Karpov – Short, Linares 1995, but still Black's position is rather solid.

The text move is an interesting attempt to hinder Black's plan.

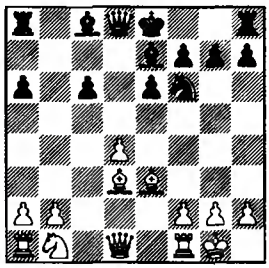
9...♘c6

Black may want to avoid structural deffects by 9...0–0 10.♘c3 ♗d7 (10...b5 11.♕f3±) 11.♗g5 (11.♗e3 ♘c6 12.♖c1 ♖c8 13.a3 ♗d6 14.♘d7 ♕d7 15.♕f3 ♘e7 16.♗g5 ♘ed5=, Kramnik – Karpov, Dortmund, 1999) 11...♘c6. However, that does not help much in view of 12.♕f3! and the d4-pawn is indirectly protected – 12...♘d4? 13.♕h3 h6 14.♗h6! gh6 15.♕h6 ♘f5 16.♗f5 ef5 17.♖fd1±. Barsov – Blees, Hoogeveen 1999went 12...♘b4, when White could have taken the pawn e.g. 13.♕b7 ♖b8 14.♕f3 ♘d3 15.♘d3 ♗b5 16.♘b5 ♖b5 17.♗e3±.

10.♘c6 bc6 11.♗e3

The d4-pawn is hanging, so 11.♘a4 is impossible. This is the fine point of the chosen move order. If Black wants to play ♘c6, he should do it before castling!

It is tempting to fix the c6-pawn without having to expose the bishop on e3 where it will be eventually swapped. However the game Filippov – Volzhin, Elista 1996 showed that such a goal is difficult to achieve – 11.♕c2 ♗b7 12.♖d1 ♕c7 13.♘d2 c5! 14.♘b3 ♕c6 15.f3 cd4 16.♕c6 ♗c6 17.♘d4 ♗b7 18.♗e3 0–0 19.♘b3=.



The theory of this variation is marked by the encounters Gelfand – Anand and Kramnik – Kasparov. White used to place the queen on e2, the knight goes to c5 via e4 or b3, the rooks – to the middle and then the queen had to look for a better place. Black was building his counterplay on the b-file while the a-pawn went as far as possible. All this resulted in more or less balanced positions:

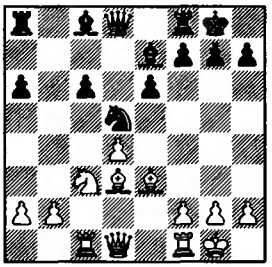
11...0–0 12.♕c2 ♕c7 13.♘d2 h6 (13...g6 14.♖ac1 ♗b7 15.♘e4 ♘d5 16.a3 a5 17.♖fd1 ♖fb8 18.♗c4 ♘e3

19.fe3 ♗a6 20.♗a2 ♖b5 21.♘c3 ♖h5 22.g3 ♖b8 23.♕f2 ♕b7 24.♖d2 c5 25.d5 ♖f5 26.♕g2 ♗g5 27.♖e1 ed5 28.♘d5 ½–½ Gelfand – Huebner, Dortmund 1997)

14.♖ac1 (Or 14.♗e2 ♘d5 15.♖ac1 a5 16.♕c6 ♕c6 17.♖c6 ♘b4=, Gelfand – Anand, Linares 1997.) 14...♗b7 15.♘e4! ♘d5 16.♕e2 ♖fd8 (16...a5!? 17.♖fd1±) 17.♖fd1 a5 18.♘c5 ♘e3 19.fe3 ♗d6±, Gelfand – Anand, Biel 1997.

In Kramnik – Kasparov, m 5' Moscow 2001 Black slightly changed the move order, depriving the opponent of ♕c2:

11...♘d5! 12.♘c3 0-0 13.♖c1

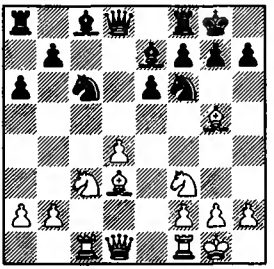


13...♘e3?!

The last move of Black can be explained only as a blitz-blunder. The thematic 13...a5!? 14.♘e4 ♗a6 was about equal in Astrom – Degerman, Borlange 1995. Of course White has 14.♘d5, but after 14...cd5 Black can easily deflect any attempt of White to attack on the kingside, even by f7-f5. At the same time the pawn majority on the queenside is useless with the worthless dark-squared bishop on e3. By all means Black's position in that line, albeit solid, is not very flexible, and in Linares 2003 Kasparov migrated to 7...♘bd7.

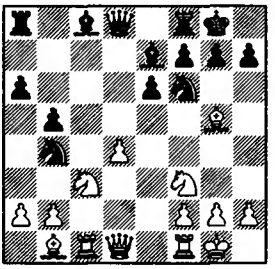
(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♗d3 cd4 8.ed4)

A2. 8...♘c6 9.♘c3 ♗e7 10.♗g5 0-0 11.♖c1



11...♘d5

Karjakin adopted this typical manoeuvre against the isolated queen's pawn (IQP) and feels comfortable in Black's shoes. If one is looking for sharper play, he could choose 11...♘b4 12.♗b1 (12.♗f6 ♗f6 13.♗e4 ♕d6 14.♕b3 ♖d8=, Dreev – Dlugy, Moscow 1989) 12...b5!? (Black's knight should retreat to d5 only after having provoked a3.)



13.a3 ♘bd5 14.♕d3 (14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♗e7 ♕e7 16.♗e4 ♗b7 17.♘e5 ♘f6 18.♗b7 ♕b7 19.♖c5 ♖ac8=) 14...♘c3!?

15.bc3 (Raetsky and Chetverik suggest 15.♖c3 g6 16.♗a2 ♗b7 17.♖fc1 ♗f3 18.♕f3, but Black is not obliged to grab the d4-pawn. Instead 18...♘d5 19.♗e7 ♘e7 20.♕f4 ♘f5= should level the game) 15...g6 16.a4 ♗b7 17.♖fe1 ♖c8 18.ab5 ab5 19.♘e5 ♘d5= Lev – HarZvi, ISR-chT 2002.

11...♗d7!? 12.♖e1 ♖c8 also brings good results: 13.h4 (or 13.a3 ♘d5 14.h4 ♘c3 15.bc3 h6=) 13...♘b4 14.♗b1 ♗c6 15.♘e5 g6 16.♕b3 ♘bd5 17.♘c6, Ivanchuk – Harikrishna, FIDE WCh KO Tripoli 2004. Here 17...♖c6 18.♘d5 ♘d5 19.♖c6 bc6=would have reduced the tension.

Now back to the main line:

12.♘d5

Or 12.h4 (12.♗e3 is unlikely to be dangerous) 12...h6 13.♗e7 ♘ce7 14.♕e1 ♘f6 15.♘e4=, Dreev – Karjakin, Dos Hermanas 2003.

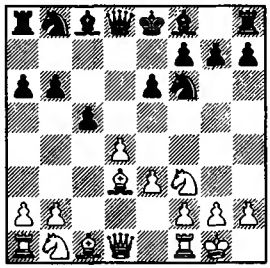
12...♗g5 13.♘g5 ♕g5 14.♘b6 ♖b8 15.♕c2 h6 16.♖fd1 e5 17.♘c8 ♖bc8 18.de5 ♕e5 (or 18...♘e7 19.♕b1 ♕e5=, Moradiabadi – Filippov, Cebu City 22.09.2007) **19.♕c3 ♕c3 20.♖c3=**, Riazantsev – Karjakin, Biel 2003. Black has managed to trade off almost everything and the draw is close.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♗d3)

B. 7...b6

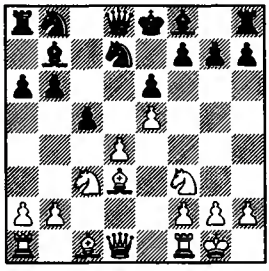
Black meets the pre-emptive measures of the opponent with the same attitude – if 7...b5 fails to a4, then why not 7...b6. Another plus is that the most vulnerable square in Black's camp – c5, in this case is protected. Still White remains with a slight space advantage.

8.dc5



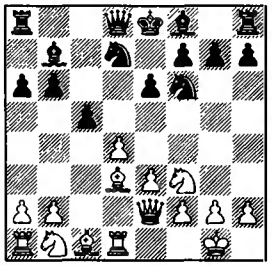
This exchange underlines the main drawback of 7...b6 compared to 7...♘bd7 – Black cannot take with a knight.

In the current pawn structure 8.e4?! is rather dubious – 8...♗b7 9.e5 ♘fd7 10.♘c3!?



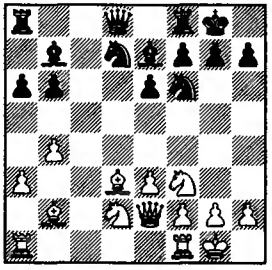
10...cd4! (10...♘c6?! 11.♗g5±; 10...h6? 11.d5! ed5 12.♖e1→) 11.♘e4, Ligterink – Lautier, Breda 1998 and Black could have launched a counter-attack by 11...♘c5 12.♘c5 bc5 13.♘g5 ♗e7 14.♕g4 ♘c6 15.♖e1 ♘b4 16.♗b1∞ h5 17.♕g3 h4 18.♕g4 d3! 19.♖d1 ♕d4 20.♕d4 cd4 21.♗d3 ♘d3 22.♖d3 ♖d8∓.

The typical for QGA setup 8.♕e2 ♗b7 9.♖d1 ♘bd7 is inefficient.



The bishop's retreat to d3 deprived White of his main active resource – the d4-d5 break. The game San Segundo – Sadler, Pula 1997 went on 10.♘bd2 (To 10.♘c3 Black could develop like in the game or even place the queen on c7 and the bishop on d6) 10...♗e7 11.b3 (11.a4?! ♘d5 12.♘c4 ♘b4 13.♗b1 ♖c8 14.b3 ♗e7=, Riazantsev – Rustemov, Krasnoyarsk 2003) 11...0–0 12.♗b2 ♕b8 13.♖ac1 ♖c8 14.♗b1 cd4 15.♖c8 ♕c8 16.♘d4 b5=.

8...♗c5 9.a3 ♗b7 10.♕e2 0–0 11.♘bd2 ♘bd7 12.b4 ♗e7 13.♗b2



White is ready for seizing more space, starting with e3-e4-e5. The set-up of Black's pieces would not allow to stop it by e6-e5 or by planting a minor piece on e5. So it is time to do something on the opposite wing.

13...a5 14.ba5

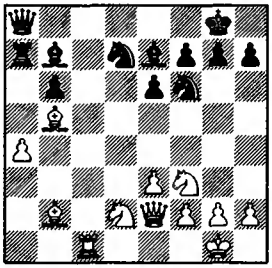
14.b5 also deserves consideration.

14...♖a5 15.♗b5 ♕b8 16.a4 ♖c8

The earlier game Baburin – Godena, La Habana, 1999 reached the same position (but with different number of moves) and proceeded with 17...♖a7!?, which seems a bit more precise. After 18.♘c4 ♖c8 19.♖fd1 ♗a8 (19...♗d5!?) 20.♘fe5 ♘c5 21.f3 ♘a4! Black is OK though he needs some tactical devices to prove it. 22.♖a4 (22.♗a4 b5 23.♗d4 ba4 24.♗a7 ♕a7∞) 22...♖a4 23.♗a4 b5 24.♘d7 ♘d7 25.♖d7 ♖c4 26.♖e7 ♖a4 27.♕d2 and here 27...♗c6! 28.♕c3 ♕f8 29.♖c7 ♖c4 30.♖c8 ♖c3 31.♖f8 ♔f8 32.♗c3∓ was saving the day. Baburin suggests 19.♘fe5!? (instead of 19.♖fd1) as a possible improvement. Perhaps White's play is a bit easier in that case.

Kasparov's move also does not completely equalise.

17.♖fc1! ♖a7 18.♖c8 ♕c8 19.♖c1 ♕a8



20.♘d4

Kasparov suggests here **20.♘c4! ♗d5 21.♘fe5±.**

20.♘d4 ♘c5 21.♘c4 ♘d5=, Kram-

nik – Kasparov, Moscow (m/5) 2001 led to big complications where Black held on successfully.

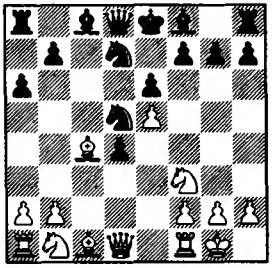
C. 7...♘bd7!? 8.♖e1

8.♕e2 after ♗d3 is inconsistent. Black develops as in the main line with 8...b6.

More enterprising is 8.e4. With his last move Black deprived his knight of its best retreat square and White tries to use it. 8...cd4! 9.e5 ♘d5 10.♗c4.

White players are not too happy with their achievements after 10.♗c4 and are looking for new ways. Tukmakov – Ivanchuk, Odessa, 2006 saw 10.♖e1 ♘c5 11.♗f1 d3 12.♗g5 ♕d7 13.a3 h6 with complex play.

Let's return to 10.♗c4:



10...♘b4

Black takes seriously the positional threat of 11.♗d5. Worse alternatives are 10...♗c5 11.♗d5 (11.♘bd2 ♘e3∞) 11...ed5 12.♘bd2 0–0 13.♘b3 ♗a7 14.♘bd4± or 10...♘c5? 11.♕d4 b5 12.♗g5 ♗e7 13.♗e7 ♕e7 14.♗d5±.

11.a3 ♘c6 12.♖e1 b5 13.♗f1 ♗b7 14.♘bd2, Lautier – C. Hansen, Malmoe, 1998. White's bishop lost so many tempi to arrive finally to its initial square f1, dropping a pawn in the meantime! Black must have some way to punish that, e.g. 14...♕c7!? 15.♕e2 (15.♘b3 ♘de5∓) 15...♖d8∓.

C1. 8...b5?!
C2. 8...♗e7
C3. 8...b6

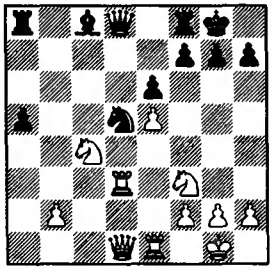
C1. 8...b5?! 9.a4

This line is not too appealing for Black as he gets a cramped position with virtually no chances to win. A typical development of events is:

9...ba4

9...b4 10.♘bd2 cd4 11.ed4 ♗e7 12.♘c4 0–0 13.♗g5± is pleasant for White, whereas 10...♗b7 11.♘c4 ♗e7 12.e4 0–0 13.e5 ♘d5 14.♗c2 ♖c8 15.♕d3 g6 16.♗h6 ♖e8 17.a5 cd4 18.♕d4 b3 19.♗b3 ♘c5 20.♗d1 ♘b4 21.♘d6 ♗f3 22.♕b4± was a disaster in Sasikiran – Markowski, Moscow 2005.

10.e4 (10.♘c3!?) 9...cd4 11.e5 ♘d5 12.♖a4 ♗b4 13.♗d2 ♗d2 14.♘bd2 ♘c5 15.♖d4 ♘d3 16.♖d3 0-0 17.♘c4 a5±



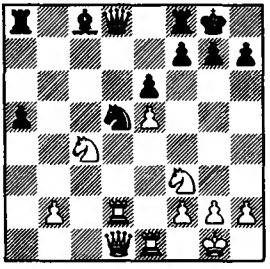
Rublevsky is obstinately defending this position. He even equalised in his latest encounter, but that does not shake my conviction that White's game is to be prefered.

He should place his pieces on the dark squares and wait for a chance to swing the queen to the kingside. At first, Rublevsky's opponents answered with:

18.♖a3, when 18...♗a6 19.♘d6 ♖b8 (19...f6 20.♕d4±) 20.♕d2 ♖b4 21.♘g5 h6?! failed to 22.♘ge4± ♕b6 23.♖g3 ♔h8 24.♘f6!+– Avrukh – Rublevsky, Rethymnon 2003. Avrukh suggests 21...♕b6 22.♕c2 g6 having in mind 23.b3 f6!∞. Instead, a dark-squared strategy should be enough for a long-term pull, for example 23.♘ge4!? ♖b2 24.♕c1 ♕b4 25.♕a1 ♖b8 26.h3 h6 (26...♖b1 27.♖b1 ♕b1 28.♕b1 ♖b1 29.♔h2 ♖b6 30.♖a5±) 27.♖c1±. Then Sasikiran won with 18.♖d4!? ♗a6 19.♘d6 ♖b8 20.♕d2 ♕b6 21.♖g4 ♘e7 22.h4 ♕b2? 23.♕g5 ♘g6 24.h5 h6 25.♕e3! ♖b3 26.♕d2!, Sasikiran – Rublevsky, Khanty Mansyisk 2005, and again Rublevsky came up with an improvement: 22...♘f5!? 23.h5 h6!= M. Gurevich – Rublevsky, Khanty Mansyisk 2005.

These games suggest that perhaps White should anticipate the enemy counterplay against the b2-pawn and try:

18.♖d2!?



White renounces the idea to mate quickly the opponent, but retains a lasting positional edge. Black should probably seek counterplay on the b-file, sacrificing the a-pawn:

18...♖b8

18...♗a6 19 ♘d6 ♕b6 allows 20 ♘g5, whereas 19...♖b8 20 ♘d4 ♕g5 21 ♖e4 ♖b6 22 h4 ♕h6 is simply bad, for example, 23 ♖g4 g6 (23...♖fb8 24 ♘4f5+–) 24 ♘f3 f5 25 ♖a4.

19 ♕a1

Of course, White can also play in the centre, retaining some edge.

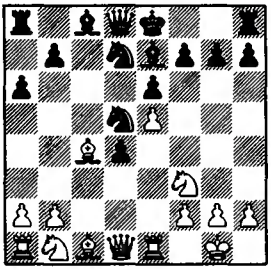
19...♗a6 20 ♘xa5 ♕b6 21 ♘b3 ♗b7 22 ♘bd4 ♖a8 23 ♕d1±.

C2. 8...♗e7

This move loses the battle for the d5-square, but enables quick castling. It is a safe option.

9.e4 cd4 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♗c4!

11.♘d4?! gave Black the initiative following 11...♕c7 12.♕h5 g6 13.♕e2 0–0 14.♗h6 ♖d8 15.♘f3 ♘b4↑ Jovanic – Mikhalchishin, Sarajevo 2006.



The text creates the awkward threat of 12.♗d5. This position defers favourable to White from the one which we discussed after 8.e4 cd4 9.e5 ♘d5 10.♗c4. The insertion of ♖e1 ♗e7 makes the answer 11...♘b4

dubious, for 12.♘d4 ♕c7 walks into 13.♗e6 fe6 14.♘e6 ♕c2 15.♘c3±.

Or 12...0–0 13.♘c3 ♕c7 14.♗f1 ♖d8 (14...♗c5 15.♘b3 ♘e5 16.♘c5 ♕c5 17.♗e3 ♕c7 18.♖c1 ♘bc6 19.♕h5 ♖d8 20.♘a4 ♘d3 21.♗d3 ♖d3 22.♕e2±) 15.a3 ♘c6 16.♘c6 bc6, with a clear edge after 17.♗f4.

11...♘c5! 12.♘d4 0-0

Here White has played:

13.a3 b5 14.♘c6 ♕c7 15.♗d5 ed5 16.♘d4 ♘e6 17.♘c3 ♗b7∞, Gelfand – Salov, Dos Hermanas 1995;

13.b3 ♘b6 14.♗f1 ♕d7 15.♗b2♘d5 16.♘d2 b5 17.♖c1 ♗b7=, Piket – Svidler, Tilburg 1997. Huzman recommends 17.♕g4 ♗b7 18.♘2f3 ♖ac8 19.h4, but then 19...f5 20.ef6 ♘f6 21.♕h3 ♘fe4 22.♖ad1 ♗d5 seizes the centre.

I have analysed another possibility which seems in White's favour at first sight:

13.♗d5 ♕d5 14.♘f5 ♗d8 15.♘d6 ♗d7 16.♕d5 ed5 17.♖d1 ♘e6 18.♗e3 f6!

Now it is becoming clear that the bishop pair provides Black with sufficient counterplay, for instance:

19.♘c3 d4 20.♗d4 ♘d4 21.♖d4 fe5 22.♖d2 ♗c6 23.♘c4 ♗c7=.

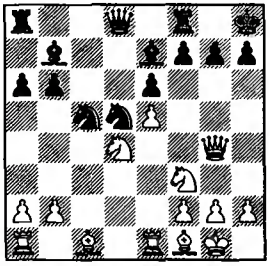
C3. 8...b6

This move order is supposed to be an improved version of line C2. It is enough to say that it was Kasparov's choice against Kramnik in Linares, 2003.

9.e4 cd4 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♘d4

Recently White tried to exploit the absence of the bishop from e7 by 11.♗g5, but it does not seem like an improvement to me:11...♗e7 12.♗e7 ♕e7 13.♘bd2 ♗b7 14.♘d4 0–0 15.♕g4 ♘c5 16.♗f1 ♖fd8 17.a3, Epishin – Krush, Catalan Bay 2007. Black could have taken over the initiative with 17...h5 18.♕g3 ♘c7↑. Instead she prefered 17...b5, and after 18.b4 18...h5 would have been even better than on the previouse move.

11...♘c5 12.♗f1 ♗b7 13.♘d2 ♗e7 14.♕g4 0-0! 15.♘2f3 ♔h8



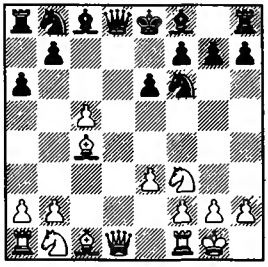
Black is planning to entrench the knight on c5 by a6-a5, securing his king from the most dangerous pieces of the enemy, which are unable to pass through d3 or e4.

The source game Kramnik – Kasparov, Linares 2003 lasted only two more moves – 16.♘g5 h6 17.♘gf3 a5 18.♕h5 ½–½.

Conclusion

The 7.♗d3 system offers Black a fair choice between IQP positions and more complex and risky lines with 7...b6 and 7...♘bd7!?. Especially the latter is in good theoretical shape, but positional players, which like clear plans, might prefer 7...cd4.

Chapter 17



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.dc5

(D29)

In the last years QGA climbed up into the category of the most reliable openings. White players understood that attempts of refuting it are unrealistic. Respectively, more and more frequently they resort to symmetrical systems which ensure lasting initiative with minimal risk. We have already examined the Furman system, where White keeps the queens on, hoping to organise an attack on the kingside. 7.dc5 aims at obtaining a safe position with a slightly better endgame. Although this system should not throw the second player into panic, it nonetheless requires a good understanding of several defensive schemes against the main active plans of the opponent. Many strong players share the opinion that defending Black's position could be a very annoying task, especially after 7...♕d1.

Before passing to practical matters, we would like to formulate some general rules for Black in this type of positions:

1. Exchanges facilitate the defence, but at very different extent. The most dangerous pieces are the rooks. Without them, most endings are drawn. (Conversely, White should not put his rooks on open files if Black can successfully oppose his owns).

2. Second-wanted on the exchange list for Black are the knights, which are extremely powerful on critical squares like c5 or c6. Many games show Black ready to trade any of his bishops for an enemy knight, provided his queenside pawns are not too extended. A bishop pair is not a special achievement of White, if not combined with invasion squares for rooks, or other positional factors.

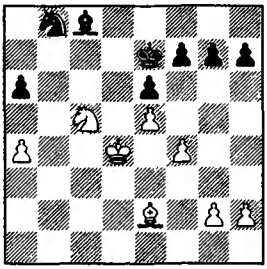
3. Black should not strive for exchanges at all cost. If they lead to a space advantage for the opponent, the queenside pawns could become even weaker.

Have a look at the following instructive game for an illustration:

Baburin – Skripchenko, Bremen 2003

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3 e6 4.♗c4 a6 5.♘f3 c5 6.0–0 ♘f6 7.dc5 ♕d1 8.♖d1 ♗c5 9.♘bd2 b6 10.♗e2 ♗b7 11.♘c4 ♘bd7 12.♘fd2 ♗d5 (12...0-0) 13.♘b3 ♗e7 14.♗d2 0–0 15.♖ac1

♖ac8 (15...♖fc8! 16.f3 e5) 16.f3 b5 17.♘ca5 ♘c5 18.♘d4 ♖fe8 19.b3 ♗f8 20.e4 ♗a8 21.♗e3 ♘b7 22.♘b7 ♗b7 23.a4 ba4 24.ba4 ♗c5 25.♔f2 ♘d7 26.♘b3 ♗e3 27.♔e3 ♖c1 28.♖c1 ♖c8 29.♖c8 ♗c8 30.♔d4 ♔f8 31.♘c5 ♘b8 32.f4 ♔e7 33.e5±



White's king decides the issue.

4. Black's most troublesome piece is his light-squared bishop. If it stays on b7, White plays f3 and e4 with a lasting pull. Black is better off with his bishop on d7 or e6.

5. When Black consolidates, he could think about expanding in the centre with ...g6, preparing e6-e5. This often earns him the initiative.

A. 7...♕d1
B. 7...♗c5!?

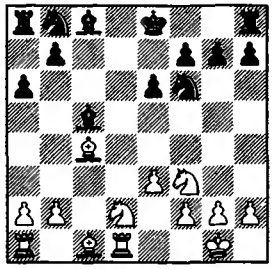
Note that Black cannot avoid the exchange of queens, because 7...♕c7?! 8.b4! is clearly bad for him (8...a5 9.♕a4 ♗d7 10.b5).

In line B Black's king remains in the centre where it is more useful after the swop of queens. The only reason to prefer 7...♕d1 could be to avoid the Furman system, possible after 7...♗c5 8.♕e2. However, in the corresponding Chapter 11, we have shown that anyway Black is unable to escape that system after 6.♕e2, so he should better prepare for it and build his repertoire around 7...♗c5!

A. 7...♕d1 8.♖d1 ♗c5 9.♘bd2

White's plan of fianchettoing the dark-squared bishop is innocuous. Black castles, places the knight on d7 and waits to see where the b1-knight is going to: 9.b3 0–0 10.♗b2 ♘bd7 11.♘c3 (To 11.♘bd2 11...b6 is safe) 11...b5 12.♗e2 ♗b7 13.♖ac1 ♖ac8 14.♔f1 h6 ½–½, Salov – Karpov, Moscow, 1992.

Or 9.a3 ♘bd7 10.b4 ♗e7 11.♗b2 0–0 12.♘d4 ♘b6 13.♗b3 ♗d7 14.♘d2 ♘a4 15.♖ab1 ♘b2 16.♖b2 a5=, Potapov – Kharlov, Ekaterinburg 2002.



9...b6

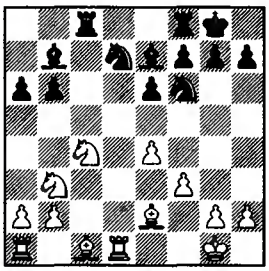
9...0-0 10.♗e2 ♖d8 11.♘e5 ♗e7 is often played and has a solid reputation, but Black is too passive in some variations:

12.♗f3 ♘bd7 13.♘d7 ♘d7 14.♘c4 ♖b8 15.b3 b6 16.♗a3 ♗a3 17.♘a3 ♗b7 18.♗b7 ♖b7 19.♘c4 Pantsulaia – Rublevsky, Warsaw 25.06.2005. Black got into trouble after 19...♔f8? 20.♖d6 and lost, but a few months

later Rublevsky repeated the same variation and his opponent was the first to deviate: 14.♘c4 ♖b8 15.e4 b5 16.♘a5 ♘e5 17.♗e3 ♗d7 18.♗e2 ♗e8=, Kharlov – Rublevsky, Kazan, 08.09.2005. Perhaps Rublevsky's analysis of his game against Pantsulaia had shown that Black would be able to equalise after 19...♖bb8 20.♖d6 b5 21.♘a5 ♘c5 22.♖ad1 ♖d6 23.♖d6 ♖c8.

Still, 9...b6 looks more appealing and natural. After all, Black might not castle at all! Black firstly develops his light-squared bishop. Currently, this is his safest plan. What are White's objectives? If he fianchettoes the dark-squared bishop, Black gets time to connect his rooks and start exchanging pieces. The only accessible weakness is b6, and White should try to attack it quickly. A model game is Malaniuk – Nurkiewicz, Warsaw 2006:

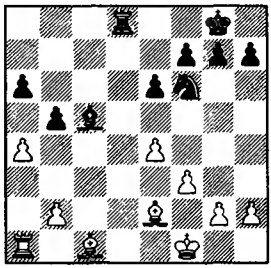
10.♗e2 ♗b7 11.♘b3 ♗e7 12.♘e5 ♘bd7 13.♘c4 0–0 14.f3 ♖ac8 15.e4±



After ♗e3, all White pieces will be targetted on the queenside, whilst the b7-bishop is useless.

Another good example to follow as White is Gyimesi – Stevic, Sibenik 2005:

10.♗e2 ♗b7 11.♘c4 ♘bd7 12.♘d4 0–0 13.♘b3 ♗b4 14.f3 ♖fd8 15.♔f1 ♗d5 16.e4 ♗c4 17.♗c4 b5 18.♗e2 ♘c5 19.♖d8 ♖d8 20.♘c5 ♗c5 21.a4±



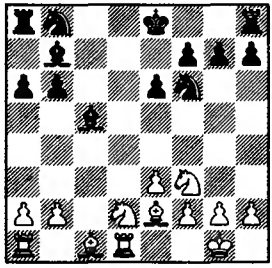
Black got rid of his light-squared bishop, but supplied a lever on the queenside.

To avoid such a scenario, Black should swiftly redeploy his bishop to e6 via d5. That can be achieved with:

10.♗e2

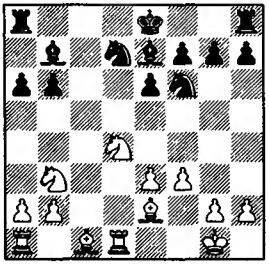
10.a3 ♗b7 11.b4 ♗e7 12.♗b2 0–0 13.♗e2 ♘bd7 14.♘c4 ♗d5 15.♖ac1 a5⇄ was fine for Black in Vl. Georgiev – Jakovenko, Wijk aan Zee 15.01.2007.

10...♗b7



A1. 11.♘b3; A2. 11.♘c4

A1. 11.♘b3 ♗e7 12.♘fd4 ♗b7 13.f3



13...♖c8

Play is not forced and Black can choose between different set-ups. In the game Wojtkiewicz – Lazarev, Geneve 2001, Black showed a very interesting idea: 13...g5!? 14.e4 ♖g8 15.♗e3 g4 16.♔f2 gf3 17.gf3 ♖c8 18.♖ac1 ♖c1 19.♗c1 ♘h5 20.♗e3 ♗h4=.

The famous game Kramnik – Kasparov, WCC London (4), 2000 saw 13...0–0 14.e4 ♖fc8 15.♗e3, when 15...♘c5 16.♘c5 ♗c5 would have been the simplest way to keep the balance. However, the text is more consistent, as Black might need his king's rook on d8, or even on g8.

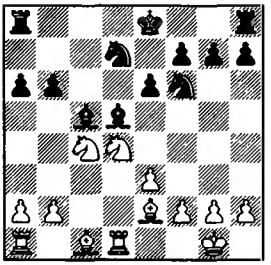
14.e4 g6! 15.♗f1 e5

This thematical thrust effectively levels the chances.

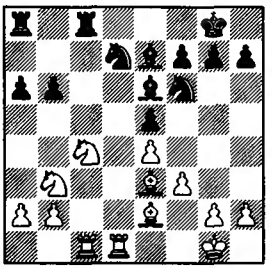
16.♘e2 ♘c5 17.♘c5 ♗c5 18.♔h1 ♔e7 19.♗d2 ♖hd8 20.♗c3 ♘d7= Graf – Rublevsky, Turin ol. 2006.

A2. 11.♘c4 ♘bd7 12.♘d4 (or 12.♘fd2) **♗d5!**

The best move order, shown first in the game Kantsler – Lautier, Ohrid 2001. Black saved a tempo on castling, and now ...e5 cannot be prevented.



13.♘b3 ♗e7 14.♗d2 0-0 15.f3 ♖fc8 16.♖ac1 e5 17.e4 ♗e6 18.♗e3



18...a5!?

The latest development in this line! The guru of the QGA Rublevsky comes once again with a novelty in his favourite opening. 18...♖ab8, played by Lautier, was a bit passive.

19.a4

Or 19.♘b6 ♘b6 20.♗b6 a4 21.♘c5 ♗a2 22.♗b5 a3=.

19...♖c6 20.♘cd2 ♖ac8 21.♖c6 ♖c6 22.♖c1 ♖c1 23.♘c1 ♗c5 24.♔f2 ♗e3 ½-½, Sakaev – Rublevsky, Krasnoyarsk 13.09.2007.

B. 7...♗c5 8.♕d8 ♔d8

White has 3 reasonable plans here:

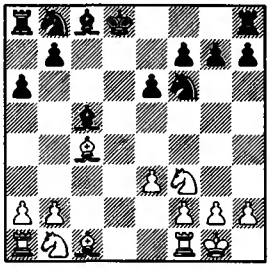
1. An expanded fianchetto with a3,b4. In that case Black adopts the

same strategy, with a fine game:

9.a3 ♔e7 10.b4 ♗d6 11.♗b2 b5 12.♗e2 ♗b7 13.♘bd2 ♘bd7 14.♖ac1 ♖ac8 15.♘b3 e5 16.♘a5 ♗a8 17.♖fd1 h6↑, Maki Uuro – Baburin, Fuegen 2006.

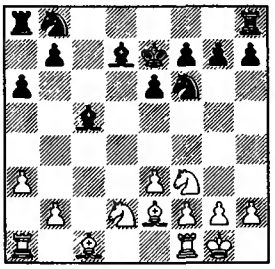
2. A normal fianchetto with b3. It saves a tempo and keeps open the diagonal a3-f8. That could be important if White manages to trade a knight for Black's dark-squared bishop. Black's best set-up is ♘bd7 and b6: 9.b3 ♔e7 10.♗b2 ♘bd7 11.♗e2 b6 12.♘bd2 ♗b7 13.♖fd1 ♖hc8 (or 13...♖hd8 14.♘e1 ♔f8 15.♖ac1 ♖ac8 16.♘d3 ♗e7 17.♘c4 b5 18.♘a5 ♗a8 19.a3=, Karpov – Ponomariov, Benidorm 2002) 14.♘e1 ♔e8 15.♘d3 ♗e7 16.♖ac1 b5 17.♗f3 ♗f3=, Sammalvuo – Yakovich, Gothenburg, 2002.

3. Redeployment of White's knights to c4-d3 or c4-b3, while the c4-bishop heads for f3. This is the most challenging plan and we shall examine it in detail. Currently Black prefers to meet it with ♗d7, ♘c6, leaving the b-pawn on its starting position. That allows him to quickly complete development and level the game.



9.♘e5

Another topical position arises after 9.♘bd2 ♔e7 10.♗e2 ♗d7 11.a3 (11.♘b3 ♗b6)



White intends to meet 11...♘c6 with 12.b4 ♗a7 13.♗b2 or 11...♗b5 with 12.♗b5, so Black anticipates these plans with 11...♗a7!?. Now 12.b4 would allow ♗a4 and 12.♘c4 – ♘c6. Ivanchuk chose 12.b3 ♖d8 13.♗b2 ♗c6 14.♗d4 (14.♖fc1 ♘bd7 15.a4 ♗d5 16.♗c4 ♗f3 17.♘f3 ♗c5 18.♗e2 ♖ac8 19.♘d4 ♗d6=, Piket – Topalov, rapid Monte Carlo 2002) 14...♗d4 15.♘d4 ♗d5=, Ivanchuk – Dominguez, Havana 2007.

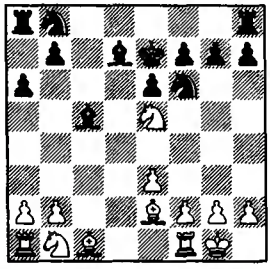
White tried also 10.♗e2. Beside normal developing by ...b6 Black obtains good play by placing the knight on c6 too. Later he can develop the bishop to d7 and even push a6-a5.

9...♔e7 10.♗e2 ♗d7

Recently this idea of Ivanchuk has become Black's main equaliser.

I do not see anything wrong with 10...♘bd7. It is also more complex and better suited for playing for win: 11.♘d3 ♗d6 12.♘d2 ♘c5 13.♘c4 ♘d3 14.♗d3 ♗c5 15.♗e2 ♗d7 Van Wely – Shirov, Wijk aan Zee 2003 or 11.♘c4 ♖d8 12.♘bd2 ♔f8 13.♘b3 ♗e7 14.♖d1 b6 15.♗f3 ♖a7 16.♘d4

♗b7, when 17.♘c6? loses to 17...♗c6 18.♗c6 ♖c8–+.



11.♗f3

11.♘c3 ♖c8 12.♘d7 ♘bd7 13.♗d2 ♗d6 14.♖fc1 ♖c7 15.♘d1 ♖ac8=, Stern – Rustemov, Solingen 2007.

11...♘c6 12.♘c6

Aronian – Karjakin, Warsaw 2005 saw 12.♘d7 ♘d7 13.♗c6 bc6 14.♗d2, when Black's most consistent plan is probably linked with ...a5, for example: 14...♖hb8 15.♗c3 ♗b4 16.♗g7 e5 17.♗h6 ♗c5 18.♘d2 (18.b3? ♖g8 19.e4 ♗d4∓) 18...♖b2=.

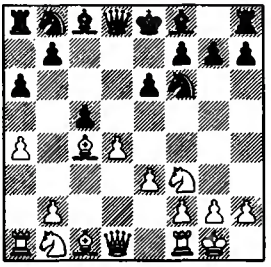
12...♗c6 13.♗c6 bc6 14.♗d2 ♖hb8 15.♖c1 ♗d6 16.♗c3 ♘d5 17.♖c2 ½–½ Kramnik – Kasparov, Linares 2004.

Conclusion

The Exchange variation had a wave of popularity after the London world title match in 2000 where Kramnik chose to slow torture Kasparov in just that line of QGA. Nowadays it is returning its status of a solid, but not too testing system. Black has patched his defence and found precise move orders to follow. Particularly 7...♗c5!? is theoretically rather well for him. Still, positional players with good endgame technique regularly resort to that variation as it offers a safe way to shun off long theory while keeping a modest initiative.

Chapter 18

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.a4

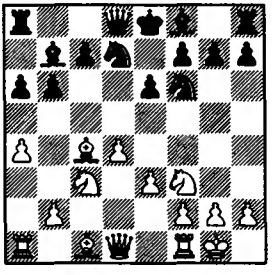


(D27)

This system is the acid test for the QGA. If Black suffers here, the whole opening would be under question because he cannot avoid it.

Polish grandmaster Markowski used to try an innovative set-up, which is mildly speaking "risky". He delayed the move c7-c5, expanding on the queenside first:

5.♗c4 a6 6.0–0 ♘bd7 7.a4!? (7.♖e1 comes into fashion, e.g. 7...b5 8.♗d3 c5 9.a4±) 7...b6?! (7...c5 is more reasonable, but why is the knight on d7?!) 8.♘c3 ♗b7 (8...c5 9.d5 ed5 10.♘d5 ♗b7 11.e4±)



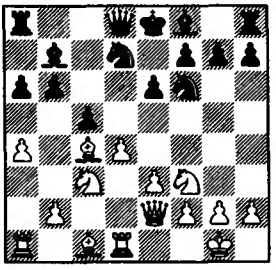
Here, apart from the logical moves 9.♖e1 and 9.♕e2, which prepare e4, White could immediately seize the initiative with 9.e4!?. If Black does not capture the pawn, he is worse, faced with an ideal pawn centre without any counterplay on the flank. 9...♘e4 [9...♗e4 10.♘e4 ♘e4 11.♖e1! (11.♕e2 ♘df6 12.♗a6 ♘d6±) 11...♘df6 12.♕c2 ♘d6 13.♗d5 ♘d5 14.♕c6 ♔e7 15.♕d5 h6 16.♕b3+–] 10.♘e4 ♗e4 11.♘g5 ♗g6 (11...♗d5 12.♗d5 ed5 13.♖e1 ♗e7 14.♕h5 g6 15.♕h6+–) 12.♗e6, when 12...fe6? loses to 13.♘e6 ♕b8 14.♕f3 ♗e7 15.♖e1+–. Thus Black should answer 12...h6 13.♗d7 (13.♗d5 hg5 14.♖e1 ♗e7 15.♗a8 ♕a8 16.♗g5 ♘f6 17.♕e2 ♕d8 18.♕a6∞) 13...♕d7 14.♖e1 ♗e7 15.♘f3 0–0 16.♘e5 ♕d6 17.♗f4 ♕f6 18.♗g3±.

After 7.a4 main options are:

A. 7...cd4

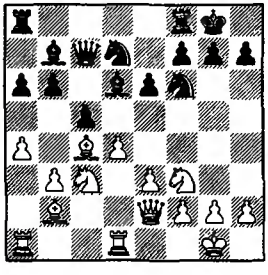
B. 7...♘c6!

Too passive is 7...b6 8.♕e2 ♗b7 9.♖d1 ♘bd7 10.♘c3



10...♕b8

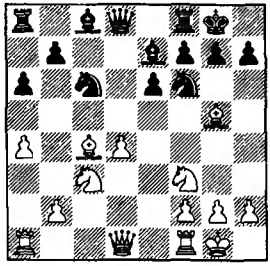
There is a big difference between this position and the Classical variation discussed in Chapter 20. Black's pawn on b6 deprives the d7-knight of its best square and also weakens the a6-pawn. Therefore, Black should look for another defence, but practice shows that he cannot equalise. For instance, 10...♕c7 is met by 11.b3! (the central break is not efficient when the queen is defending the knight on d7– 11.d5 ed5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♗d5 14.♖d5 ♗e7 15.b3 ♕b7 16.♖d3 0–0 17.♗b2 ♖fd8 18.♖ad1 ♘f8 19.♗e5 ♖d3 20.♖d3 b5= 21.h3 ♕e4 22.♕d1 ♖c8 ½–½, Buhmann – Markowski, Erfurt 2003) 11...♗d6 12.♗b2 0–0



13.d5 ed5 14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ♗d5 16.♖d5 ♖fd8, Hora – Vaculik, CZE, 2000, 17.♖ad1±. Black's queenside is paralysed and the pawn on a6 is a target.

11.d5 ed5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♗d5 14.♖d5 ♗e7 15.e4 ♕b7 16.♗g5 ♗g5 17.♘g5 0–0 18.♖ad1 ♘f6 19.♖d6 h6 20.e5 ♖ae8 21.♘f3 ♖e7 22.♕d3 ♘g4 23.♖e1 ♖fe8 24.♖d8 ♕c7 25.♖e8 ♖e8 26.♕f5±, Shchekachev – Wiley, Metz 2003.

A. 7...cd4 8.ed4 ♘c6 9.♘c3 ♗e7 10.♗g5 0–0

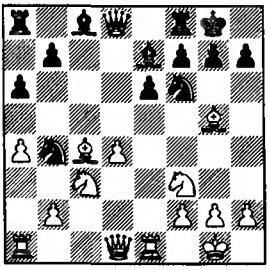


Black determined the pawn structure a bit too early. Thus he hindered the common set-up ♕e2-♖d1, but that is a dubious achievement, since White's queen could be more useful on d2 or b3. Much more important is that White got the option of developing his bishop to g5. As a result, Black is unable to unpin the knight by 10...h6, because after 11.♗f4 0-0 12.♕d2 the threat of sacrifice on h6 is constantly in the air. Another obvious drawback is that the fianchetto is out of question in view of the central break d4-d5!

11.♖e1 ♘b4!?

Frequently seen is 11...♗d7 12.♕e2 ♖e8 (12...♘b4 13.♘e5 ♗e8 14.♖ad1±; 12...♘d5 13.h4!?↑) 13.♖ad1 ♘d5 14.♗d2 ♗f6. In Kramnik – Anand, Mainz 2001 White sacrificed a pawn by 15.♘e4 ♘d4 16.♘d4 ♗d4 17.♗g5 ♕b6 18.a5 ♕a7 19.♘d6 ♖f8, and unexpectedly a draw agreement has been signed. Khalifman assesses this position as slightly better for White. A possible continuation could be 20.♗d5 ed5 21.♗e7 ♗e6 22.♗f8 ♖f8 23.♕f3 ♗b2 24.♖b1 ♗f6 25.♘b7 ♖b8

26.♘d6 ♕c7 27.♕g3 ♖b1 28.♖b1 ♗d4 29.♘e8±. Probably we'll see more of this line since in a later game Anand, this time as White, opted for 12.♕d2 ♖c8 13.♖ad1 ♘b4 14.d5 ed5 15.♗d5 ♗c6 16.♗b3 only to make a draw after 16...♗f3 17.gf3 ♕d2 18.♖d2 ♘c6 ½–½, Anand – Dreev, Hyderabad 2002.



12.♕b3

The only way to exploit the move order, chosen by Black. 12.♘e5 is a natural move, but 12...♗d7! 13.♕b3 ♗c6 14.♖ad1, Schandorff – Danielsen, DEN 1987 14...♘fd5! is holding the position since 15.♗e7 ♕e7 16.♘c6 bc6 17.♗d5 cd5 18.♘d5 ♘d5 19.♕d5 ♕b4= leads to complete equality.

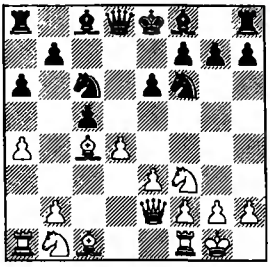
12...♘c6 13.♖ad1 ♘a5 14.♕a2 ♘c4 15.♕c4 h6

The interesting pawn sacrifice 15...b5 16.ab5 ab5 17.♕b5 ♗a6 from the game Markos – Perunovic, Balatonlelle 2001 is not sufficient for full equality after 18.♕e5±.

16.♗f6 ♗f6 17.♘e5 ♗d7 18.♘e4 ♖c8 19.♕b3±, Gligoric – Buljovcic, 1976.

The perfect co-ordination of White's pieces faces Black with certain problems.

B. 7...♘c6! 8.♕e2



Major options here are:
B1. 8...♕c7!?
B2. 8...cd4

In the current situation 8...♗e7 is inaccurate because of 9.dc5! ♗c5 (9...♘e4 10.♘d4 – Bronshtein – 10...♘c5 11.♘c6±) 10.e4! Black is unable to prevent further advance of the pawn since 10...e5? fails to 11.♗f7! The game Botvinnik – Petrosian, World Championship Moscow (8) 1963 went on with 10...♘g4 11.e5! ♘d4 12.♘d4 ♕d4 13.♘a3! ♗a3! 14.♖a3 ♘e5 15.b3!→.

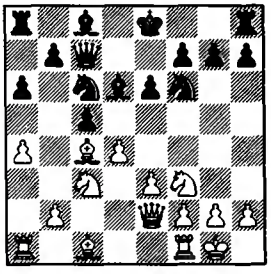
Perhaps 8...cd4, which creates an isolator on d4, is the most testing continuation. However, there are some forced variations that lead more or less directly to a draw. If you want to present your opponent with opportunities to drift, 8...♕c7 should be your weapon of choice. That move gives Black good chances for equalising, avoiding the risk of falling under attack, which is real in line B2.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 a6 6.0–0 ♘f6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2)

B1. 8...♕c7!? 9.♘c3 ♗d6

9...♗e7 is similar, but more passive. It is mainly aimed against 10.dc5, which Black intends to counter with a real pawn sacrifice: 10...0–0!? (We'll see on the next page that 10...♗c5 11.e4 does not pose problems, but it is a matter of taste) Aronian – Morozevich, Moscow 2006 has been the last sifnificant game so far. It went 11.b3 e5 12.h3 (Riazantsev – Rublevsky, Warsaw 2005 had seen 12.♘c3 e4 13.♘d4 ♗g4⩱) 12...e4 13.♘d4 ♘e5 14.b4 b6 15.♘d2 bc5 16.bc5 ♗c5 17.♗a3 ♗a3 18.♖a3 with roughly equal chances.

White can prefer 10.♖d1 when Black's position is very solid. e.g. 10...0-0 11.b3 (11.♗d2 ♖d8, intending ♗d7) 11...♗d7 (11...b6 12.♗b2 ♗b7 is also playable – 13.d5 ed5 14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ♘a5!?∞ Jelen – Mikhalchishin Ptuj, 1993) 12.♗b2 ♖ad8 13.d5 ed5 14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ♗g4. White's pieces are temporarily more active, but it is unclear how to exploit that.



In this line Black refrains from taking on d4. He develops his light-squared bishop to b7 or d7 and brings the rooks in the centre. Meanwhile White is wondering how to activate his c1-bishop. The thematic way is to play e4, but first he should solve the problem of the d4-pawn. 10.dc5 is considered nowadays as innocuous, so d5 seems the main plan. It is more effective when Black's light-squared bishop is already committed to b7. Still Black is able to maintain balance even if he has to lose a tempo on returning the bishop to c8.

Another plan is to finish quickly development, activating the bishop via d2 to c3. In that case White places first a rook to c1 in order to disturb the opponent's queen. In both lines Black holds firm. In distinction to positions with an IQP, he is rarely submitted to kingside attacks.

B1a. 10.♖d1, B1b. 10.♗d2

White has tried without success numerous other moves:

10.d5 ed5 11.♘d5 ♘d5 12.♗d5 0-0=.

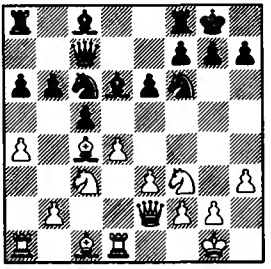
10.h3 0-0 11.dc5 ♗c5 12.e4 ♘d4=.

10.b3 0–0 11.♗b2 b6 12.d5, Leitao – Zambrana, Santiago CHI 2005, when 12...♘a5 13.de6 ♘c4⩱ is promising.

10.dc5 ♗c5 11.e4 ♘g4 12.g3 does not promise White even a temporary initiative. A simple and good response is 12...♘ge5 13.♘e5 ♘e5 14.♗a2 ♕e7! (It is essential to escape the pin 15.♗f4) 15.♗e3 ♗d7= Maninang – Yeo Min Yang,E Bangkok 2004. 12...0–0 13.♗f4 e5 is enough for equality too: 14.♗g5 (14.♘d5 ♕d6 15.♗d2 ♘f6=) 14...h6 15.♘d5 ♕d6 16.♗d2 ♘f6 17.b4 ♘b4!? (17...♘d4 18.♕d3 ♘f3 19.♕f3 ♗d4=)

18.♘b4 ♗b4 19.♗b4 ♕b4 20.♘e5 ♕e7 21.♕b2 ♗e6=.

B1a. 10.♖d1 0–0 11.h3 b6



Now White can proceed with his main idea:

12.d5

Capturing on c5 is ineffective as 12.dc5 bc5 13.e4?! hands the initiative to Black: 13...♘e5 14.b3 ♗b7 15.♗b2 ♘f3 16.♕f3 ♗h2 17.♔h1 ♗e5∓, Capo Vidal, – Matsuura, Cali 2007.

12...ed5 13.♘d5

White can also take with the bishop: 13.♗d5 ♗b7 14.e4 ♖ae8 15.♗e3. (or 15.♗g5 ♘d4 16.♘d4 ♘d5 17.♘d5 ♗d5 18.♘f5 ♖e4 19.♕h5 f6∓, Rakhmanov – Vorobiov,Voronezh 2007) Now 15...♗f4 16.a5 ♗e3 17.ab6 ♕b6 18.♕e3 ♘d4 19.♗b7 ♘c2 20.♖a6 ♕b7 21.♕e2 ♘e4 22.♘e4 ♘b4 is known to be drawish, but Black could continue with a wating game: 15...♕b8 (intending to take on d5) 16.♖ac1 h6, when White is unable to improve his position.

13...♘d5 14.♗d5 ♗b7 15.e4 ♖ae8 16.♗e3 ♗c8!?

This was the pet line of Bulgarian GM Radulov. It used to bring him good results. 16...♗f4 17.♗f4 ♕f4 18.♕d2 is slightly better for White.

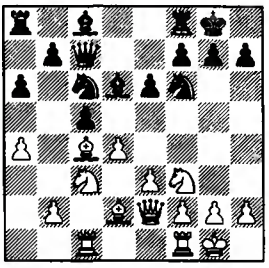
17.♕d2 ♖d8 18.♗g5 ♖d7 19.♕c3 ♘b4 20.♗c4, Malich – Radulov, Skopje 1972 **20...h6=**.

Black's only concern is to prevent e4-e5. For that he can return the knight to c6 with equal play.

B1b. 10.♗d2 0–0 11.♖ac1

We can understand White's longing to X-ray Black's queen on the c-file, but this plan is hardly enough for an advantage. The other plan is linked with the d5-break. 11.d5 right away is totally harmless in view of 11...♘e5 12.♘e5 ♗e5 13.f4 ♗c3 14.♗c3 ed5! 15.♗f6 dc4 16.♗c3 ♗f5 17.♕c4 ½–½ Franco – De La Villa, Mondariz 1995 or 11...ed5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♘e7! 14.♗c4 ♗d7 15.h3 ♗c6 16.♖fd1 ♘g6 Filippov – Ibragimov, Russia Cup 1997.

More sophisticated move order is **11.♖fd1** when the fianchetto idea 11...b6 runs into 12.d5! ed5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♗d5 ♗b7 15.♗c3± ♖ad8 (Simplification does not mean relief for Black, as shown by the game Grabarczyk – Jaracz, Warsaw 1997, 15...♖ae8 16.♕c4 ♘e5 17.♘e5 ♗e5 18.♗b7 ♕b7 19.♖d5± b5 20.ab5 ab5 21.♕c5 ♖c8 22.♕b5 ♕b5 23.♖b5 ♗c3 24.bc3 ♖c3 25.h4!±) 16.♕c4! intending 18.♕g4, Wells – Waitzkin, London 1998. However Black has nothing to fear after **11...♗d7!** (we already know that against d5 Black's bishop is needed on the c8-h3 diagonal.) 12.d5 ed5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♗d5 ♖ae8 15.♗c3 ♗e6 16.♕d3 ♗d5 17.♕d5 ♖e6 18.♖d2=, Crouch – G. Flear, 2000.



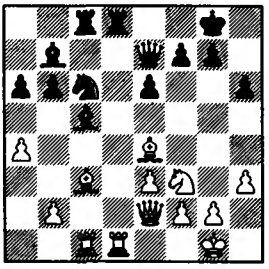
11...b6

11...♗d7!? is a good alternative: 12.h3 h6 13.♖fd1 ♖ad8 14.dc5 ♗c5 15.e4 ♗d6 16.♗a2 ♕b8 17.♗b1 ♘e5 18.♘e5 ♗e5∓, Spielmann – Steingrimsson, Lodi 2006.

12.♗d3 (12.dc5 bc5!=) **12...♗b7 13.♘e4 ♘e4 14.♗e4 ♕e7 15.dc5 ♗c5**

15...bc5 was tried in Collas – Karpatchev, Montpellier 2003 – 16.♗c3 f5 17.♗b1 e5 18.♕c4 ♔h8 19.♕h4, when Black decided to undertake the initiative by 19...♖f6 20.♖fd1 ♘d4? 21.ed4 ♗f3 22.de5 ♖g6 His bluff succeeded after 23.♕e7?? ♖g2∓, but 23.♕f4! ♗d1 24.♖d1+– would have closed the issue. 19...♕e6 is stronger although we prefer White's position.

16.♗c3 ♖ac8 17.♖fd1 ♖fd8 18.h3 h6



This position has been reached in Gelfand – Huzman, Tel Aviv 1999. Khalifman assesses it as slightly better for White. Indeed the bishop on e4 is currently more active than its counterpart on b7, and Black's pawns on the queenside are a bit more vulnerable, but we guess all that is too microscopic. Black needs only a couple of accurate moves to level completely the play.

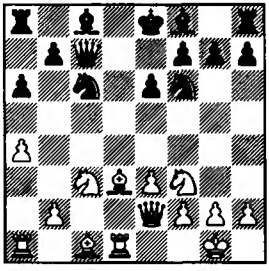
The game Wells – Stevic, Calvia 2004 confirms this evaluation:

18...♘b4 (instead of 18...h6) 19.♖d8 ♖d8 20.♗b7 ♕b7 21.♗b4 ♗b4 22.♕c4 ♗d6 23.♘d4 ♗c5 24.♘b3 ♗f8 25.♘d4 ♗c5 26.♘b3 ♗f8 27.♘d4 ½–½.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 a6 6.0–0 ♘f6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2)

B2. 8...cd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7

Black cannot afford to lose a tempo by 9...d3? 10.♗d3 ♕c7 11.♘c3. The diagram position is difficult for him.



Obviously 11...e5 12.♘g5 (12.♘e4±) 12...♗e7 13.♗c4 ♘d8 14.♗d2± is sad for Black, but the other options could be even worse:

11...♗d7 12.e4! ♘g4 (12...♗d6

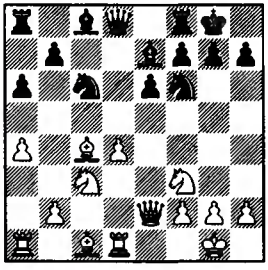
13.♗g5↑) 13.♘d5! ed5 14.ed5 ♘ce5 (perhaps Black should accept the piece sac – he is going to suffer anyway! Vera – Arencibia, Holguin 2002 went on 14...♘e7 15.♗c4 ♕d6 16.♖d4! ♔d8 17.♗f4 ♕b6 18.a5 ♕c5 19.b4 ♕b4 20.♘g5! ♘h6 21.♘e6 fe6 22.de6 ♘hf5 23.♕e5 ♘d6 24.♖d6 ♕c4 25.♖d7 ♔e8 26.♖c1+–) 15.♗f4 f6 16.h3 ♗d6 17.♖ac1 ♕a5 18.hg4± ♗g4 19.♗e5 ♗e5 20.♖c4 ♗f3 21.♕f3 0–0 22.♕h3 g6 23.d6+–.

11...♗c5 12.♗d2!? (12.♘e4 ♗e7±) 12...♘b4 13.♘e4 ♘d3 14.♘f6 gf6 15.♕d3±, Novikov – Skripchenko-Lautier, Cappelle la Grande 1996.

11...♗e7 encounters (together with the calm 12.h3±) typical motives from the Furman variation: 12.e4!? ♘g4 13.h3! h5 14.e5! ♘ge5 15.♗f4 ♗d6 16.♗e5 ♘e5 (16...♗e5 17.♘e5 ♕e5 18.♗e4 0–0 19.♖ac1⩲. Black has yet to discover what to do with his bishop) 17.♗b5!! ♔f8 (17...♘c6 18.♘d5 ♕a5 19.♗c6 bc6 20.♘b6 ♕b6 21.♖d6 0–0 22.♘e5±) 18.♘e5 ♗e5 19.♖ac1±.

10.ed4 0-0 11.♘c3

11.♗g5 ♘d5 12.♗e7 ♘ce7 is equal.



Main branches are:
B2a. 11...♘d5; B2b. 11...♘cb4

White has an obvious plan to attack on the kingside. Main actors in that case are the knights, and White must be sure to keep at least one of them on the board (so playing ♘e5, while Black's knight is still on c6, is a mistake in view of the double swap ♘c6xe5 and ♘d5xc3). The next important resource is a rook, usually transferred via a lift along the third rank. Black must look out for such manoeuvre as it often turns decisive. White would be happy to join his h-pawn to the attack as well. This idea has been fashionable lately.

At the same time White combines his kingside play with a constant observation of the opponent's weaknesses on a6 or c5 and c6.

Black's main task is to activate the light-squared bishop without losing control over the critical d5-square. We prefer the modest ♗d7, because the bishop could go then to the main diagonal avoiding the weakening move b7-b6, but also could give a hand to the king after ♗e8, f6 or f5. The unpleasant in some lines with b7-b6 exchange on d5 is absolutely innocuous here. The other item on Black's agenda is to maintain a knight on b4 with the task of impeding White's bishop from reaching the b1-h7 diagonal. Only make sure to play ♘b4-d5 when White clears the third rank of minor pieces, in order to prevent ♖a1-a3-g3.

B2a. 11...♘d5 12.♗b3

Basically this is a waiting move. White improves the placement of his bishop before committing him-

self with some concrete plan. A similar approach is 12.♗d2 ♘cb4 13.♖ac1. This continuation is gaining popularity in recent years. However, it does not face Black with particular problems. For instance, he can use the same typical plans as 13...b6, or 13...♗d7 14.♘e5 ♖c8 15.b3 ♗e8 16.h3 ♔h8 17.♘d5 ed5 18.♗b4 ♗b4 19.♗d3 f6=, Groszpeter – Ricardi, Novi Sad 1990.

More enterprising is the manoeuvre 12.♗d3. Black gets a good game with the standard plan 14...♘cb4 (with the interpolation of 12.♕e4 ♘f6 13.♕e2 ♘d5 14.♗d3) 15.♗b1 ♗d7 (or 15...b6 16.♕e4 f5) 16.♘e5 ♖c8 17.♘e4 ♘c6 18.♕h5 (18.♘d7 ♕d7 19.♘c5 ♗c5 20.dc5 ♕e7 21.♗e3=) 18...♗e8 19.♕h3 f5!∓ 20.♘c6 ♗c6 21.♘c5 ♗c5 22.dc5 ♘f4–+, Ubilava – Semkov, Elenite, 1986.

Deployment of the bishop to b7 is aslo good: 12...♘cb4 13.♗b1 b6 14.♘e5 ♗b7 15.♖a3 ♖c8 16.♘d5 ♕d5 17.♗h7 (17.♖g3 ♗f6 18.♗g5 ♗g5 19.♖g5 f5= Tregubov – Salakhova, Czestochowa 1992) 17...♔h7 18.♕h5 ♔g8 19.♖g3 ♖c1 20.♖c1 (20.♖g7=) 20...♗f6 21.♘g4 ♕g5∓, J. Piket – Van den Doel, Leeuwarden 2001.

12.♘e5 is positionally dubious since White remains withouit knights for attack: 12...♘e5 13.de5 ♘c3 14.bc3 ♕c7 15.a5 b5! 16.ab6 ♕b6 17.♕g4 ♖d8=, Markus – Arnold, Paks 2001.

Finally, we'll mention 12.♕e4. White's idea is to impede normal development of the enemy by increasing the pressure on d5. Additionally, White's queen is transferred to the right wing. The big question is "is this a better place for the queen at all". In M. Marin – Kharlov, Batumi 2002. White escaped from the nasty black knight, but lost the initiative: 12...♘f6 13.♕e2 ♘d5 14.♕e4 ♘f6 15.♕h4 ♘d5 16.♕g4 ♘f6 17.♕h4 ♘d5 18.♕g4 ♘f6 19.♕g3 ♘h5 20.♕h3 ♘f6 21.♕g3 ♘h5 22.♕h3 ♘f6 23.♗a2 e5 24.♕h4 ♘g4 25.♕g3 ♘d4∓, M. Marin – Kharlov, Batumi 2002.

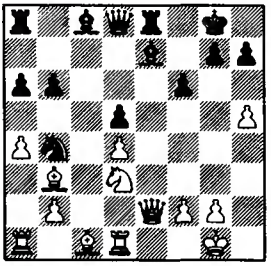
If Black is not content with a repetition of moves, he can try 12...♘cb4 13.♘e5 b6 14.♘c6 ♘c6 15.♘d5 ♖a7 16.♘e7 ♘e7 17.♗g5 ♗b7 18.♕h4 ♖e8 19.♖a3, Kiss – Acs, Budapest 1996, when 19...h6 maintains approximately equal chances.

12...♘cb4

Black reinforces his grip on d5 and keeps White's bishop away from the b1-h7 diagonal. 12...♖e8, although very popular, is somewhat fuzzy. White has the enterprising move 13.h4! As 13...♗h4 14.♘h4 ♘c3 15.bc3 ♕h4 16.♖d3⩱ is dangerous, Black has nothing better than the same old 13...♘cb4 when 14.h5 b6 15.♘d5!? should be met by 15...ed5!

After 15...♘d5 16.♘e5 ♗b7 17.♖d3 f6 White has an edge after 18.♘g4 (18.♘c6 is not clear due to 18...♗c6 19.♕e6 ♔h8 20.♕c6 ♘b4 21.♕f3 ♘d3 22.♕d3 ♗d6 23.♗e3 f5 24.♕f5 ♕h4 25.♕h3 ♕h3 26.gh3 ♖ac8 which is roughly equal, whereas 18...♕d6 19.♘e7 ♖e7 20.♖g3 would favour White) 18...♕d7 19.h6 g6 20.♗d2. Black has no counterplay and his weak e6-pawn needs protection.

16.♘e5 f6 17.♘d3



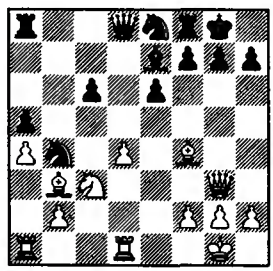
17...♗f5 18.♘b4 ♗b4 19.♗e3 (19.♕f3 ♗e4 20.♕h3 ♖c8=) 19...♕d7 and Black can hope to tune up the co-ordination between his pieces. He can meet 20.h6 with 20...♗e4 21.hg7 ♖e7∞.

Kramnik – Kasparov, London 2000 saw 15.♘e5 ♗b7 16.a5 (16.♘e4 f5 17.♘c3 ♗f6 18.♗d2 ♖c8 19.♖ac1∞ Lautier – Markowski, Ohrid 2001) 16...b5∞. Apparently 12...♖e8 is playable and needs further testing.

13.♘e5 ♗d7 14.♕g4 (14.♘e4 ♖c8; 14.♕f3 ♗c6 15.♕g3 ♔h8 16.♘e4 ♖c8 17.♗d2 ♗e8 18.♗c3 b6 19.♖ac1 f6↑ Werle – Mainka, Remagen 2007) **14...♘f6 15.♕g3 ♗c6**

Black must keep in mind the d5-break, e.g. 15...♔h8?! 16.d5! ed5 17.♘d5 ♘bd5 18.♗d5±.

16.♗h6 ♘e8 17.♘c6 bc6 18.♗f4 a5



How to evaluate this position? We suppose it is a matter of taste. Our opinion is that when Black manages to push his pawn to a5 he can take a relieved breath, since only the c6-pawn remains a target and its weakness is balanced by the vulnerability of the d4 and b2-pawns. It is very important also that White's knight has not an access to a4. The only chance for White remains to organise a kingside attack, but Black has always at his disposal a hedgehog-type set-up (pawns on e6-f6-g6) which should keep his king safe. No one has won this position in tournament although Khalifman prefers White's chances.

19.♗e5 ♕b6 20.♗c4 ♘d5 21.b3 (21.♗d3 g6 22.♖ab1 f6 23.♕g4 ♘g7 24.♗g3 f5 25.♕h3 f4 26.♗h4 ♗h4 27.♕h4 f3∞) **21...♘c3** 22.♕c3 ♘f6 23.♕g3 g6 24.♕h4 ♘d5 25.♕h6 f6 26.♗g3 ♖fe8 27.♕h3 ♗b4 28.♖d3 ♖ad8 29.♖c1, ½–½, Poluljahov – Yakovich, Krasnodar 2002.

B2b. 11...♘cb4 12.♘e5

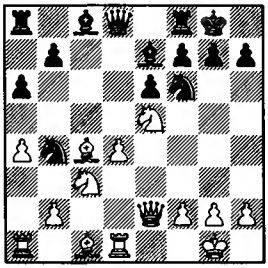
12.♗g5 is not very promising, for 12...♗d7 13.d5 (13.♘e5 transposes to the main line) 13...ed5 14.♘d5 ♘bd5 15.♗d5 ♘d5 16.♖d5 ♗g5 17.♘g5 h6 has proved to be satisfactory for Black.

Black easily drew the four rooks ending after 18.♕d2 hg5 19.♖d7 ♕f6 20.♖b7 ♖ad8 21.♕c3 ♕c3 22.bc3 ♖d2 23.h3 ♖e8 24.♖b6 ♖ee2 25.♖f1 ♖a2 26.♖a6 ♖ec2=, Dorfman – Fontaine, Val d'Isere 2004.

Similar is the situation with

queens: Sundararajan – Aronian, Goa 2002 – 18.♖ad1 ♖e8 19.♕d2 hg5 20.♖d7 ♕f6 21.♖b7 ♖ed8 22.♖d7 ♖d7 23.♕d7 ♕b2 24.h3 ½–½.

If Black wants to avoid mass simplification, he can choose 12...♖e8 13.♘e5 ♘fd5 14.♗e7 ♖e7 15.a5 ♗d7 16.♘d5 ♘d5 17.♖dc1 ♗c6 18.♘c6 bc6=, Milov – Karjakin, Moscow FIDE 2002.



12...♗d7

12...♘fd5 is also playable and brings Black good results.

12...b6 is usually met by 13.♕f3, but Black manages to reject the initial attack. Perhaps White should opt for the pawn raid 13.h4!? intending to push it further.

13.♗g5

Black's last move is based on the tactical blow 13.d5 ♘bd5 14.♘d5 ♘d5 15.♗d5 ed5 16.♖d5 ♗g4!↑ escaping the pin.

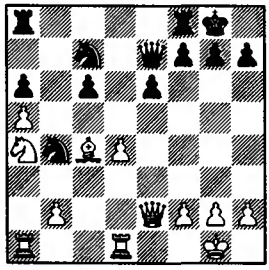
In the game Mikhalevski – Krush, Montreal 2004 White tried the new idea 13.h4!? However, after ♗c6 14.h5 ♖c8 he stopped on the halfway and never pushed h6!? 15.♗b3 (15.h6!?) 15...♘bd5 16.a5 ♘b4 17.♗d2 ♗d5 18.♘d5 ♘fd5 19.♖a4∞ (19.h6).

13...♗c6

The idea of preventing creation of new weaknesses by 13...♖c8 14.♗b3 ♗c6 is logical, but Black must be ready to part with a pawn after 15.♘c6 ♖c6 16.♗f6 ♗f6 17.d5! ed5 18.♘d5 ♘d5 19.♗d5 ♖d6 20.♗b7 a5 21.♗f3±, Smirnov – Anisimov, St. Petersburg 2002. The bishops of opposite colour are a premise for attack against Black's king.

14.♘c6 bc6 15.a5 ♘fd5 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♘a4 ♘c7

Latest practice shows that White's space advantage is deceptive. The excellent outpost on c5 is compensated by counterplay against the d4-pawn.



18.♘c5 ♘b5 19.♕d2 ♘d5 20.g3 ♖fd8 21.♖ac1 ♘dc7 22.♕e3 h6 23.♗f1 ♘d5 24.♕f3 ♖a7 ½–½. Izoria – Ganguly, Nakhchivan 2003.

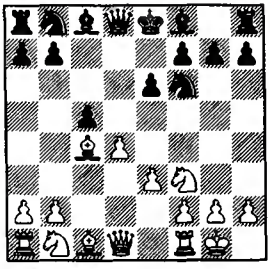
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.a4

Conclusion

The 7.a4-system has proved its vitality over the years. Its fans appreciate highly the fact that it is based on stable positional foundation and the risk to be fatally caught on a home analysis is minimal. The evaluations of the main lines are stable. It is unbelievable that you could lose a game in your favourite variation because your opponent found a killer novelty (which is often the case in many fashionable lines). If you master this system, you'll have a reliable repertoire against the QGA for many years. Of course you'll need more time to perceive the subtleties of the set-up. Playing positions with an isolated queen's pawn demands a higher level of understanding chess, since strategical mistakes are not that obvious for less experienced amateurs, but often have the same final effect as a tactical blunder.

In general, Black copes successfully with the opening problems, especially in line B2a. 11...♘d5 and B1. 8...♕c7. In the first case Black must be ready to defend patiently positions with crippled pawn structure on the queenside – a5-c6 pawns. Such pattern is very static and leaves Black with limited winning chances, while remaining extremely firm. The 8...♕c7-line is more flexible. Black's task there is to neutralise the greater activity of the opponent's pieces, but once that done, there are no side-effects as crippled pawns left.

Chapter 19



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0

(D27-D29)

In this chapter we examine several rare variations which may be not very fashionable, but require at least some minimum of knowledge:

A. 6...♘c6
B. 6...cd4
C. 6...a6 7.♕e2 cd4
D. 6...a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗d3
E. 6...a6 7.a3

A. 6...♘c6 7.♕e2!

White could try to exploit the commitment of Black's knight to c6 by 7.dc5, for instance 7...♗c5 8.♕d8 ♔d8 9.a3 ♗d6 10.♘bd2 ♔e7 11.b3 ♘e5 12.♗e2 ♖d8 13.♖d1 ♘f3 14.♗f3 e5=. The fine point here is that Black had not lost a tempo on a6 and that makes possible the exchange operation through e5.

7.♘c3 cd4 transposes to line B. In the event of 7.a3, Black is much better off fighting against an isolator on d4 with 7...cd4, than struggling in a symmetrical ending after 7.a3 a6?! 8.dc5! Let us see a few examples.

Makarov – Korchnoi, Smolensk 2000: 8...♗c5 9.♕d8 ♔d8 10.b4 ♗d6 11.♗b2 ♔e7 12.♘bd2 ♖d8 13.♖fc1 ♗d7 14.♗e2! b5 15.♘b3 (When you see a knight ready to jump to c5 without facing any hint of counterplay, that is a sure sign that things went wrong for Black.) 15...♖dc8 16.♘c5 ♗e8 (16...♖a7 17.♖c2 ♗e8 18.♖ac1±) 17.♘b7! ♗c7 18.♘d4 ♗b6 19.♘b3 ♖a7 20.♘7c5 g6?! 21.♗f3 ♖cc7 22.♘d3±. If such a war dog as Korchnoi fell into this position, Black's task in this line is not simple.

P. Nielsen – S. Hansen, Aarhus 1999:

8...♕d1 9.♖d1 ♗c5 10.b4 ♗a7 11.♗b2 ♔e7 12.♘bd2 ♗d7 13.♘b3 ♖hc8 14.♗f1 (14.♗d3! is more active, 14...♘d8 15.a4 ♗c6 16.♘fd2±) 14...♘d8 15.a4 ♗c6 and here 16.♘fd2± retains pressure.

7...cd4 8.♖d1

8.ed4 ♘d4? is examined in Chapter 11, while 8...♗e7 transposes to line B.

8...♗e7 9.♘c3

The reason behind this move is to deprive Black of the manoeuvre ♗c8-d7-c6 which would have been possible after 9.♘d4 ♘d4 10.ed4 ♗d7 11.♘c3 ♗c6, e.g. 12.d5 ed5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♗d5 ♗d5 15.♕b5 ♕d7=.

Black cannot use this move order by 9...e5, for 10.ed4 ed4 11.♗e3 ♗g4 12.♗b5 gives White a small edge, for instance, 12...0–0 13.♗c6 bc6 14.♗d4 ♕c7 15.h3 ♗f3 16.♕f3 ♖fd8±.

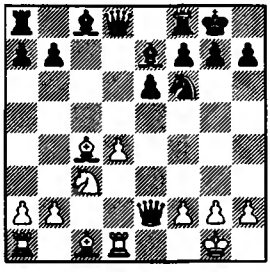
If White is planning to capture by pawn on d4, he must do it immediately: 9.ed4. In that case he could meet 9...♘a5 by 10.♗b5 ♗d7 11.♘e5 ♗c6 12.♘c3 0–0 13.♗d3 ♖c8, Bauer – Kortschnoj, Istanbul 2000 although this position is hardly better for White. On 9.ed4 0-0 White has 10.a3 with some pressure.

9...0-0 10.♘d4

White should not miss the opportunity to exchange a pair of knights. Thus he leaves the opponent with passive pieces and the queen obtains the excellent place f3.

10.ed4 ♘a5!? gives Black a solid position. (10...♘b4 11.♘e5 allows White to maintain some pressure in a typical IQP position) A model game is Kramnik – Lautier, blind, Monte Carlo 1999: 11.♗d3 b6 12.♗g5 ♗b7 13.♘e5 ♖c8 14.♖ac1 ♘d5 15.♕h5 g6 (now it is a draw, whereas 15...f5!? would keep the fight going on) 16.♘g6 fg6 17.♗g6 hg6 18.♕g6 ♔h8 19.♕h5 ♔g8 20.♕g6 ♔h8 21.♖d3 ♗g5 22.♖h3 ♗h4 23.♕h6 ♔g8 24.♕g6.

10...♘d4 11.ed4



11...♕e8

Black is running away from the d1-rook. The alternatives are perhaps worse:

11...♗d7 12.d5 ed5 13.♘d5 ♘d5 14.♖d5 ♗f6 15.♕d3 ♗e6 16.♖d8 ♖fd8, Ruck – Stevic SLO 2003, 17.♕e4 ♗c4 18.♗g5±.

11...♘d5 12.♕f3 ♘c3 13.bc3 ♕c7 14.♗b3 ♗d6 15.c4!↑ Gelfand – Adianto, Cap d'Agde 1998.

12.♘b5 ♕d8 13.♗f4 ♗d7 14.♘c7 ♖c8 15.d5

This position has been reached in the game Topalov – Kharlov, New Delhi/Teheran 2000. Black erred with 15...♖c7 to suffer after 16.d6±.

15...ed5 is the only move and White's advantage is minimal after **16.♘d5 ♖e8 17.♕d3±** (Huzman).

B. 6...cd4

This continuation is more in the spirit of the Nimzowitsch Defence (E57) where Black typically fights against an isolator on d4. Objectively it is hardly Black's best choice since White is able to develop his bishop to g5. It is well covered in another CHESS STARS publication – "Opening for White according to Kramnik" by Khalifman, vol.4, pp. 115-117. We'll confine our survey to main ideas only.

7.ed4 ♘c6 8.♘c3 ♗e7 9.♖e1 0–0 10.a3

10.♗g5 a6 11.♖c1 is also logical and offers White an easier game – 11...b5 12.d5 ♘b4 (13...♘a5 14.♗d3! b4 15.d6!⩲) 13.♗b3 ♘bd5 14.♘d5 ed5 15.♕e2 ♗b4 16.♖ed1±, Anand

– Adianto, Manila, 1992.

10...a6 11.♗a2! ♕d6 12.♗e3 b5 13.d5±.

Or 12...♖d8 13.b4!? b5 14.d5±.

C. 6...a6 7.♕e2 cd4

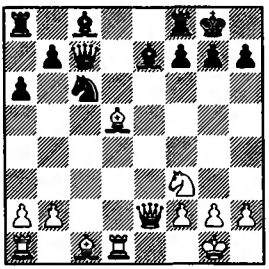
7...♘c6 offers White the choice to follow the common plan 8.♖d1 ♕c7 (8...b5 9.dc5!? ♕c7 10.♗b3 ♗c5 11.a4±) 9.♘c3 (9.a4) 9...b5 9.♗b3 ♗b7 (9...c4!? needs testing) 10.d5±, or to exploit the undetermined play of the enemy, preparing a better retreat for the bishop by 8.a3!? Of course White could also turn to the Furman variation, taking on c5.

8.ed4

Frequently seen is 8.♖d1, delaying the recapture of the d4-pawn as much as possible. We think that White should strive for another arrangement of the rooks – on d1 and e1 and only if Black's knight appears on c6, White must settle for ♖fd1.

8...♗e7

Let's see what happens after 8...♘c6 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.♘c3 0–0 (10...♘b4 11.♘e5↑) 11.d5!? ed5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 13.♗d5 ♕c7



The intuition of Smyslov and Rubinstein, who entered as White this position, hardly failed them! We think that the best order of moves now is 14.♕e4! ♗f6 15.♗g5! (15.♘g5 ♗g5 is close to the draw) 15...♗b2 16.♗f4 ♕d7 (16...♕a5 17.♖ab1 ♗f6 18.♗g5±) 17.♖ab1 ♗f6 18.♗g5±.

9.♘c3 0–0 10.♗g5! b5 11.♗b3 ♗b7 12.♖ad1! (12.♘e5 ♘bd7)

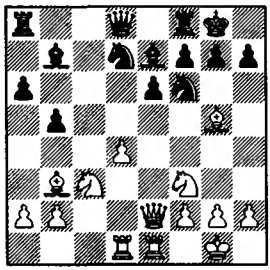
Finally Black has to resolve the dilemma what to do with the queen's knight. Bad is 12...b4?! 13.d5 bc3 14.de6 ♕c7 15.ef7 ♔h8 16.♘d4 cb2 (16...c2 17.♖c1!?±) 17.♖fe1 ♘c6 18.♘e6 ♕c8 19.♘f8 ♕f8 20.♕b2±, Graf – Giffard, Groningen 1999.

12...♘bd7

Or 12...♘c6?! 13.♖fe1 ♘d5 14.♗d5! ♗g5 15.♗e4 ♗h6 16.a4!±.

13.♖fe1

When Black's knight is on d7, the central break does not give any advantage – 13.d5 ed5 14.♘d5 ♗d5 15.♗d5 ♘d5 16.♖d5 ♗g5 17.♘g5 h6 18.♖fd1 hg5 19.♖d7 ♕f6 20.h3 ♖ae8=, J. Piket – V. Salov, Dos Hermanas 1995.



13...♖e8

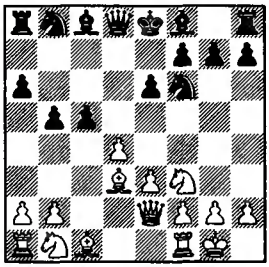
The last touch! Black prevented all tactical tricks, based on the hanging state of the e7-bishop. But is that enough for equalisation?!

It is still early for 13...b4 14.d5 e5 15.♘e4 ♘e4 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♕e4 ♕d6 18.♘e5, Lukacs – Fancsy, Zalakaros 1997, when even the best 18...♖ae8! 19.♘c4 ♕d5 20.♖d5 ♖e4 21.♖e4 ♗d5 22.♖d4 ♘f6 23.♘d2 ♗b3 24.♘b3 ♖b8 25.♖d6± leaves Black struggling.

14.♘e5 ♘e5, Hillarp Persson – Markowski, Reykjavik 2000.

Now instead of 15.♗f6 ♘f3 16.gf3 ♗f6 17.d5 ♗c3 18.bc3 ed5 19.♕e8 ♕e8 20.♖e8 ♖e8 21.♗d5∓, the acid test is 15.de5! ♘d7 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♖d6 ♘c5 18.♗c2 b4 19.♘e4 ♘e4 20.♗e4 ♗e4 21.♕e4 a5. Black should be able to hold this ending.

D. 6...a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗d3



8.♗b3 is subject of the next chapter.

8...cd4!

This position can also arise after the tricky sequence 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6!? 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.♕e2 b5 7.♗d3 cd4 8.ed4 ♘f6 and Black could consider himself as the moral winner of the first stage of the opening.

8...♘c6 and 8...♗b7 allow 9.dc5± – see Chapter 11, line B2.

Black could try to avoid entering an IQP position by **8...♘bd7** (8...♗b7?! 9.dc5 ♗c5 10.e4↑) **9.a4!? b4**

More than once we pointed out that in similar positions 9...ba4 leaves Black more chances for counterplay. However Black's knight is already on d7 which ensures a lasting initiative to White after 10.♘c3 ♗b7 11.♘a4 ♕c7 (11...cd4 12.ed4 ♗e7 13.♗g5 0–0 14.♖fc1±) 12.♗d2! cd4 (12...♘g4 13.♖fc1!±) 13.♖fc1 ♕b8 (13...♗f3 14.♕f3 ♕b8 15.ed4 ♗d6 16.h3±) 14.♘d4 ♗d6 15.h3↑.

10.♘bd2 ♗b7 11.e4 cd4 12.e5 ♘d5 13.♘b3 ♘c5 14.♗g5 ♕d7 15.♘c5!

The game Topalov – Narciso Dublan, Barcelona 2000 saw 15.♘fd4?! h6? 16.♘c5!±, but Black passed by 15...♘d3! 16.♕d3 ♘b6! 17.a5 (17.♖fd1 ♗d5 18.a5 ♘c4 19.♕e2 ♕c7) 17...♕d5 18.♕g3 ♘c4 when his pieces feel unexpectedly comfortable on the light squares.

15...♗c5 16.♖fc1 h6 17.♗d2 ♕e7, Hort – Huebner, Biel, 1987. White should have made use of the tactical device **18.♗b5!** ♔f8 19.♗c4 with a tangible initiative, e.g. 19...g6 20.♘e1 ♔g7 21.♘d3 ♗a7 22.♗d5 ♗d5 23.♘b4 ♗b7 24.♘c6 ♕d7 25.♕f3±.

9.ed4

Rarely seen is 9.♖d1!? and Black is at a crossroads. 9...♗e7 offers White some initiative after 10.♘d4 0–0 11.a4 ba4 12.♖a4 ♕b6 (12...♗b7 13.e4 ♘fd7 14.♗c2 ♗g5 15.f4 ♗e7 Torbin – Zakharchenko, St. Petersburg 2002, 16.♗e3↑) 13.♘d2 ♘c6 14.♘c4 ♕c5 15.♘c6 ♕c6, Kruppa – Torbin, St.

Petersburg 2002, 16.b3±. Probably a better response to 9.♖d1 is 9...♘bd7, intending to meet 10.♘d4 ♗b7 11.a4 with 11...ba4 12.♘c3 ♗d6 or 11.e4 by 11...♕b8.

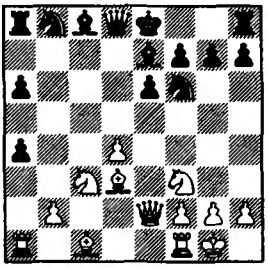
Granda Zuniga tried several times 9.♘d4 ♗b7 10.♘d2 ♘bd7 11.b3 (or 11.♘2b3), but Black obtained some initiative with the help of 11...e5!?

9...♗e7 10.a4

In contrast to positions where White's bishop occupies b3, here the plans without the a2-a4 break could lead White to a passive set-up – 10.♘c3 0–0 11.♗g5 ♗b7 12.♖ad1 ♘bd7 13.♘e5 (If White keeps on developing, Black could provoke mass exchanges: 13.♖fe1 b4 14.♘e4 ♘e4 15.♗e7 ♕e7 16.♗e4 ♗e4 17.♕e4 ♘f6=) 13...♘d5 14.♗d2 ♘c3 15.♗c3 (or 15.bc3 ♘e5 16.♕e5 ♗f6 17.♕h5 g6 18.♕g4 ♗d5 19.♗b1 ♖c8 20.♖fe1 ♖c4 21.♕h3 ♖a4∓, Fradkin – Rublevsky, Kurgan 1993) 15...♘f6 16.♗b1 ♕d5 17.f3 b4∓, Jussupow – Shirov, Prague 2002.

10...ba4 11.♘c3

11.♗g5 leads only to simplification: 11...♗b7 12.♗f6 ♗f6 13.♗e4 ♗e4 14.♕e4 ♘d7 15.♘c3 0–0=, Arencibia – Grischuk, Yerevan 2001.



11...0–0 12.♖a4

12.♘e4 ♗b7 13.♘c5?! ♗c5 14.dc5, Borisenko – Suetin, Kiev 1964 would face only White with problems after 14...♘bd7!

12.♘a4 ♘c6 13.♖d1 ♘b4=. Black can be satisfied with the results of the opening.

12...♗b7 13.♗g5 ♘c6

It is hardly a good time for wasting tempi on pawn moves like 13...a5. White has 14.♘e5 ♘a6, Pushkov – Kharlov, Vladivostok 1994, when 15.♗f6 ♗f6 16.♗e4± would have ensured some initiative.

14.♘e4

14.♖d1 offers Black the needed tempo for rearranging the pieces by 14...♘d5 or 14...a5, followed by ♘b4.

14...♘e4

Or 14...♘d5 15.♘c5 ♗g5 16.♘b7 ♕e7 17.♘c5±.

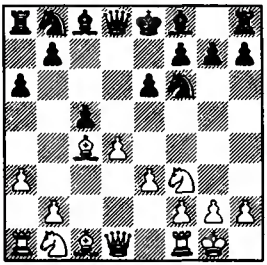
15.♕e4 g6 16.♕h4 ♖e8 17.♖e1 ♖c8 18.d5

The crucial moment in the opening. White could take the pawn 18.♗a6 ♗a6 19.♗e7 ♘e7 20.♖a6 ♘f5⇄ 21.♕e4 ♖b8, but obviously he would not be able to convert it. So he decides to gamble his own central pawn hoping to find use of his rook. In Lautier – Ivanchuk, Belgrade 1995 was 18...♕d5?! 19.♖f4↑.

The acid test of White's idea is 18...ed5! 19.♖f4 h5∞ when all white pieces, although active, are hanging. Especially sore is the first rank.

In general, Black is holding his own against this version of IQP position.

E. 6...a6 7.a3



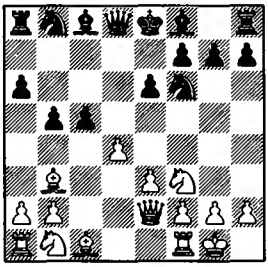
This move looks consistent at first sight. White thinks that his bishop will be safer on a2 than on b3. In fact he loses the initiative and on a2 the bishop impedes possible pressure of White's a1-rook along the a-file. That encourages Black to develop the queen to b6, without fearing a4.

7...b5 8.♗a2 ♗b7 9.♘c3 ♘bd7 10.♖e1

Common developing plans are inefficient here: 10.♕e2 ♕b6!? (Black can retreat the queen to b8 too, but the text is more active) 11.♖d1 ♖d8 12.h3 ♗e7 13.e4 cd4 14.♖d4 0–0↑ proved in Black's favour in Kozul – Stevic, Celje 2004.

10...♗e7 11.e4 cd4 12.♘d4 ♘e5 13.♗f4 ♘g6 14.♗g3 0–0 15.e5 ♘d5 16.♗d5 ♗d5 17.♕g4 ♖c8 18.♖ad1 ♖c4=,

Kozul – Stevic, Zagreb 2004.



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗b3

(D29)

8...♗b7

8...♘bd7 9.e4 ♗b7 10.d5∞ is considered in Chapter 13/B1b, while 9.♖d1 ♗b7 is covered in line A.

Now White chooses between:

A. 9.♖d1

B. 9.a4

A. 9.♖d1 ♘bd7 10.♘c3

When the rook had already gone to d1, 10.e4?! is not a sacrifice, but rather a misconception. Black can capture the pawn – 10...♗e4 11.♘g5 ♗f5 12.d5 e5! (12...c4? 13.de6!) 13.a4 (The game Mamedyarov – Palac, Clichy 03.06.2007 reached the same position, but in 13 moves, and saw further 14.♗f4 ♗d6 15.♘e6 fe6 16.de6 ef4 17.ed7 ♔d7∓) 13...c4 14.♗c2 ♗c2 15.♕c2 ♗c5∓, Ksieski – Adamski, Jachranka 1987.

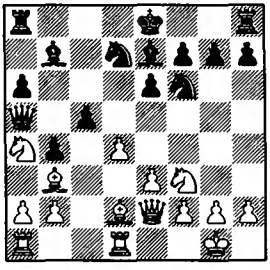
A1. 10...♕b6

A2. 10...♕b8

A3. 10...♕c7

Another good option is:

10...b4 This move should lead to a draw, although White could boast later that he had been a little better. 11.♘a4 ♕a5 12.♗d2 (12.e4?! ♕b5! 13.♕e1 ♗e4! 14.♘e5 c4 15.♘c4 ♗d5∓) 12...♗e7

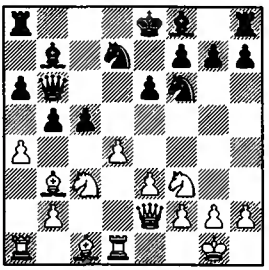


13.a3 (13.dc5 ♘c5 14.♘c5 ♗c5 15.a3 ♕b6 16.♗a4 ♔e7 17.ab4 ♗b4 18.♗b4 ♕b4. It looks that White has a strong initiative, but it is bound to evaporate quickly. e.g. 19.♖d4 ♗f3! 20.♕f3 ♕b2 21.♖ad1 ♖hd8=) 13...♕b5 14.♕b5 ab5 15.♘c5 ♘c5 16.dc5 ba3 17.♖a3 ♖a3 18.ba3 ♗c5 19.♖c1 Once again White creates concrete threats, and again a couple of precise moves dissipate the illusion – 19...♘e4! 20.♗b4 ♗b4 21.ab4 ♘d6! 22.♘e5 0–0 23.♘d7 ♖c8 24.♖d1 ♘e4 25.f3 ♘c3 26.♖d2 ♗c6 27.♘c5 ♗d5= 28.e4 ♗b3 29.♘b3 ♔f8.

Anyway, Black has better possibilities than 10...b4.

A1. 10...♕b6 11.a4!

If White wants to exploit the specifics of Black's queen being on b6, that is the right way! 11.d5 ♘d5= transposes to A2, see the game Atalik – Topalov, and 11...c4!? is also good.



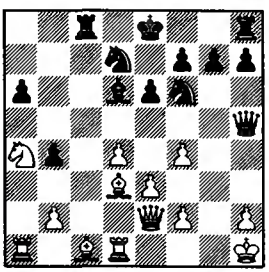
11...c4

11...b4 is safer, but White retains a lasting edge after 12.a5 ♕c7 13.♘a4 cd4 14.ed4 ♗d5 15.♗d5 ♘d5 16.♗g5 ♗d6 17.♖dc1 ♕b8 18.♘c5 ♘c5 19.dc5 ♗f4 20.♖c4±, Marin – Kaeding, Sitges 1997.

12.♗c2 b4 13.a5 ♕c7 14.♘a4 ♕a5

14...♖c8 is likely to be punished after 15.e4! b3 16.♗b1 ♕a5 17.e5 ♘d5 18.♘g5 ♗b4 19.♕h5!? g6 20.♕f3 0–0 21.♕h3 h5 22.♗g6+–.

15.♕c4 ♖c8 16.♕e2 ♗f3 17.gf3 ♕g5 18.♔h1 ♕h5 19.♗d3 ♗d6 20.f4.



Lukacs – Wells, Austria 2000 saw 20...♘g4?! 21.f3 ♘h2, when 22.♔g1± would have cost Black a piece. Besides, 20...♕e2 21.♗e2 is in White's favour, too, as the light-squared bishop has not a decent counterpart.

A2. 10...♕b8

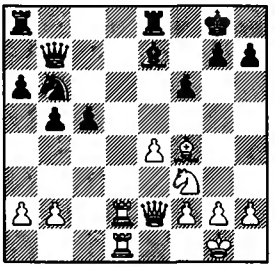
The main reason behind this move is to meet 11.e4 by 11...cd4 12.♘d4 ♗d6!

11.d5

12.♗c2 ♗d6 13.dc5 ♗c5 14.h3 0–0 15.e4 ♕c7 is roughly equal.

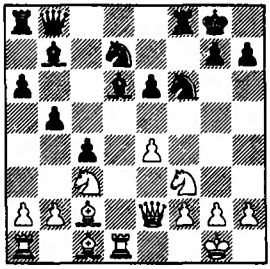
11...c4!?

11...♘d5 is sufficient for equality, but Black takes the chance to complicate play. (Let's note that Black should be careful to take on d5 only with a piece to avoid a possible e4 in case of 11...ed5 12.e4!?) 12.♗d5 ♗d5 13.♘d5 ed5 14.♖d5 ♕b7 (14...♗e7!? 15.e4 ♘b6 16.♖h5 0–0∓) 15.e4 ♗e7 16.♗g5 (16.♗f4 0–0 17.♖ad1 ♘f6 18.♖f5 ♖ad8 19.♖e1 g6 20.♖g5 ♘h5∓, G. Horvath – Zontakh, Zalakaros 1999) 16...f6 17.♖ad1 (or 18.♖e1 ♖fe8 19.♘h4 ♗f8 20.♘f5 ♕d5= Palo – San Segundo Turin ol. 2006) 17...♘b6 18.♗f4 0–0! 19.♖5d2 ♖fe8!



20.e5 ♗f8 21.♕d3 ♘c4! 22.♖e2 (22.ef6? ♘d2 23.f7 ♕f7 24.♘g5 ♘f3! 25.gf3 ♕g6–+) 22...fe5=, Atalik – Topalov, Sarajevo 2001.

12.de6 fe6 13.♗c2 ♗d6 14.e4 0-0



One does not need to be an expert on the Meran system to assess this position as promising for Black. He has a clear-cut plan for playing on the central dark squares.

15.h3

Or15.♗g5 ♘g4 16.h3 ♘ge5 17.♘e5 ♘e5 18.♗e3 ♕c7 19.♖d2 ♗c5↑, Mirzoev – Ibragimov, Ubeda 2001.

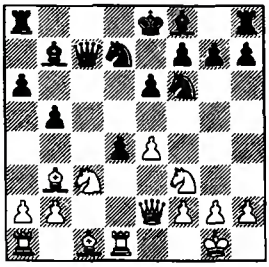
15...♕c7 16.a3 ♖ae8 17.♗e3 ♘e5 18.♘d4 ♘g6⇄

We have followed the game Sasikiran – C. Hansen, Skanderborg 2003.

A3. 10...♕c7

Recently this move has gained in popularity. Its aim is to get positions from line A2 with an extra tempo after 11.d5?! c4 12.de6 fe6 13.♗c2 ♗d6 14.h3 0–0. It is true that the queen is a bit exposed on the c-file, but that could be fixed, as in the line 12.♗d2 ♖c8! 13.♖ac1 ♕b8=. 11.a3 ♗d6 is also innocuous, so White usually plays:

12.e4 cd4



13.♘d4

Unfortunately for White, Geller's gambit 12.♘d5 is easily refuted in our computer times: 12...ed5 13.ed5 ♗e7 14.♗g5 ♔f8.

14...♗c5

12...♘c5 is less clear as White has some initiative after 13.e5 (or 13.♗g5 ♗d6 14.♖ac1 ♗h2 15.♔h1 ♗e5 16.♗f6 gf6 17.♘a4!? ba4 18.♗a4 ♔e7 19.♘b3 ♖hd8=) 13...♘fd7 14.♗f4 b4 15.♘a4 ♘b3 16.ab3 ♗d5 17.h4!? ♕b7 18.♖d3±, which is unclear how White could use it effectively.

13.♗e3

13.♗g5 0–0 14.♗f6 ♘f6 15.e5 ♘d7 16.♘e6? loses to 16...fe6 17.♗e6 ♔h8 18.♖d7 ♖f2–+.

13...0-0 14.f3=

B. 9.a4

Our main line branches here to:

B1. 9...♘bd7

B2. 9...b4.

Both moves are playable. The latter is more positional while the first one requires more concrete

knowledge.

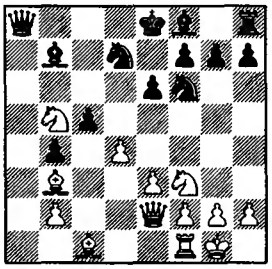
Sometimes the second player chooses 9...c4 10.♗c2 ♗b7. The natural response is certainly e4, enjoying a perfect pawn centre, but we would like to note also 11.b3!? ♘b6 [11...cb3!? 12.♗b3 b4 13.a5 ♗d6 14.♘bd2 0–0 15.e4 (15.♗b2) 15...e5∞] 12.bc4 ♘c4 13.♘c3 ♗b4 14.♘a2 ♗a5 15.♖b1↑, Korotkjevich – Kalla, Bergneustadt 2001.

B1. 9...♘bd7 10.ab5

10.e4 is ambitious, but hardly good, due to 10...cd4 11.e5 (11.ab5 ♘c5 12.♗c4 d3 13.♕e3 a5! 14.♘c3=; 11.♘d4 ♗c5 12.♖d1 ♕b6 13.♗e3 0–0!=) 11...♗f3 12.gf3 d3 13.♕d3 ♘e5 14.♕e2 ♘ed7 15.♖d1 ♗c5 16.♗g5 ♕b6∓, J. Piket – Seirawan, Monte Carlo 1994.

10.♖d1 combined with 9.a4 is a misconception – 10...♕b8 11.ab5 ab5 12.♖a8 ♗a8 13.♘c3 b4 14.♘a4 cd4 15.♖d4 ♗e7 16.e4 0–0 17.♗g5 ♗c6∓, Levitt – Baburin, IRL 2001.

11...ab5 11.♖a8 ♕a8 12.♘c3 b4 13.♘b5



B1a. 13...♕a5?; B1b. 13...♗f3?!; B1c. 13...♕b8!

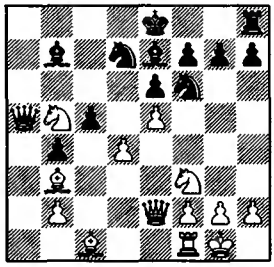
B1a. 13...♕a5?

The only "positive" side of this move is that it faces White with a "difficult" choice:

14.e4

14.♘e5!? is also appealing – 14...♘e5 15.de5 ♘d7 16.e4 ♘e5 [16...♗c6 17.♗c4 ♘b6 (17...♗e7 18.♗f4 ♘b6 19.♘d6 ♗d6 20.ed6 ♘c4 21.♕c4 0–0 22.♖c1±) 18.♘c7 ♔d7 19.♘e6 fe6 20.♗e6 ♔c7 21.♕f3 c4 22.♕f7 ♔b8 Liardet – Ovetchkin, 1998 23.♖d1!↑] 17.♗f4 ♗a6 18.♗a4!→.

14...♗e7 15.e5

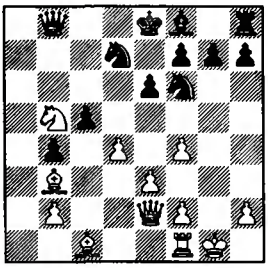


Now **15...♘d5** is bad enough: 16.♗g5 ♗c6 17.♗d5! (17.♘d6? ♗d6 18.ed6 ♗b5 19.♗c4 ♗c4 20.♕c4 0–0 21.dc5 ♕c5 22.♕c5 ♘c5 23.♖c1, Lieb – Bialas, Berlin West 1982 when 23...♘d7 offers Black a slight edge in the ending.) 17...♗b5 18.♗c4 ♗c4 19.♕c4 ♘b6 20.♕c2! c4 21.♗e7 ♔e7 22.d5 ♕d5 23.♖d1 ♕c5 24.♕e4 ♘d5 25.♕h4→, Dubinka – Meister, Pardubice 1998. Black got into a very unpleasant situation.

The big problem of Black is that **15...♘e4 16.♖d1!** is also grim – **16...0–0** (16...cd4? 17.♘fd4 0–0 18.♘e6! fe6 19.♗e6 ♔h8 20.♖d7 ♖f2 21.♖e7! ♕d8 22.♕f2! ♘f2 23.♖d7!+– or 20...♕a1 21.♕c2±) **17.d5** ed5

18.♗d5 ♗d5 19.♖d5 ♘b6 20.♖d1 c4 21.♕e4 ♕b5, Antunes – Yakovich, Oviedo 1993, when 22.e6!↑ preserves the initiative.

B1b. 13...♗f3?! 14.gf3 ♕b8 15.f4! is considered to give White a tangible initiative. (The famous game Jussupow – Anand, Las Palmas 1993 showed that Black can defends successfully after 15.♖d1 ♗e7 16.e4 cd4 17.♘d4 ♗d6 18.e5!? ♗e5 19.♘e6! fe6 20.f4 ♔e7 21.♕c4 ♘d5 22.fe5 ♕e5 23.♗d2 ♘7b6! 24.♗b4 ♔f7=. Anand's suggestion is also good: 20...♔f7!? 21.♖e1 ♗f4 22.♕e6 ♔g6 23.♗c2 ♔h6=)



15...g6 16.♖d1 ♗e7 17.e4 cd4 18.♘d4 ♘c5 19.♗c4 ♘ce4 20.♗b5 ♔f8 21.f5 ♔g7 22.fe6 ♗c5 23.ef7±, Sasikiran – Janz, Calicut 1998.

Instead of 15...g6, Black could try 15...♗e7, but it is hardly a significant improvement, for White's bishop pair, directed towards the enemy king, is powerful: 16.e4 ♘e4 (Or 16...cd4 17.♘d4 ♕b6 18.♖d1 ♘c5 19.♗c4! ♘ce4 20.f5→; 16...0–0 17.e5 ♘d5 18.f5 ♔h8 19.♖d1 ♘7b6 20.dc5 ♗c5 21.♘d4±; 16...♘b6 17.f5 e5 18.dc5 ♗c5 19.♗g5±) 17.d5 ed5 18.♗d5 ♘ef6 19.♗c6↑ ♕b6 20.♘d6 ♔f8 21.♘c8 ♕d8 22.♖e1→.

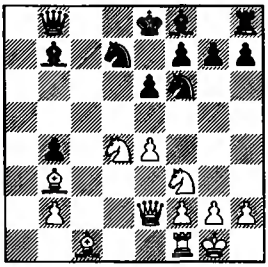
B1c. 13...♕b8! 14.e4 cd4!

Raetsky and Chetverik suggest 14...♘e4 15.♘g5 cd4, but 16.♘e4 ♗e4 17.♕e4 ♕b5 18.♕d4± would leave White with an overwhelming lead in development.

Another dubious alternative is 14...♗c6?! (14...♘e4?! 15.♘g5→) 15.♗c4 ♘b6 16.d5! ♘c4 17.dc6 ♕b5 18.c7 ♕c6 19.♕c4 ♕c7 20.♕b5 ♘d7 21.♖d1 ♗d6 22.e5 ♗e7 23.♘g5±, Dubinka – Svetushkin, Alushta, 1999.

15.♘bd4

16.♘fd4 ♗c5! 17.♗e6 encountered the unexpected 17...0–0!?∓, Ruzele – Godena, Istanbul 2000.



15...♗d6!

15...♗c5 is a worthy alternative. White can offer the bold sacrifice 16.♗e6!?, but capturing is not obligatory (we do not claim that it is losing, but White would get a dangerous initiative, and for many players initiative is advantage) – 16...0–0!? 17.♗d7 ♘d7 18.♘b3 ♗e7 19.♘fd4 ♖e8 20.♘f5 ♗f8 21.f3 ♕c8 22.♕f2 ♗a6 23.♖d1 ♘e5 24.♗e3 ♕c4 25.♘fd4∞, Nogueiras – Borges Mateos, Matanzas 1995. Another

version of the idea of counter-sacrificing presents the game Sasikiran – E. Vladimirov, Shenyang 1999 – 16.♖d1 0–0 17.♘e6 fe6 18.♗e6 ♔h8 19.♗d7 ♗e4 20.♗e6 ♗f3=.

16.♖e1

The game Kramnik – Anand, Mainz 2001 delivered a strong blow to 16.♗e6?! fe6 17.♘e6 h6! 18.♘g7 ♔f7 19.♘f5 ♗e4 20.♘h6 ♔g7∓. Even after the best 21.♕d2 White is struggling after 21...♖h7 or 21...♔f8, according to the analysis of Jussupow and Kindermann.

16...♗e4

It is risky indeed, but Black had not many alternatives. Previously 16...e5 had been tested and proved to be in White's favour – 17.♘f5 0–0 18.♘g5 ♗c5 19.♕c4↑.

17.♗e6 ♘c5

It would be difficult to find volunteers for 17...fe6 18.♘e6, for instance 17...♗f3 19.♕f3 ♘e5 20.♕f5↑. The course to quick castling looks safer.

18.♗f5 0–0 19.♗g5 ♗f5 20.♘f5 ♖e8 21.♕f1 ♖e1 22.♕e1 ♘ce4=.

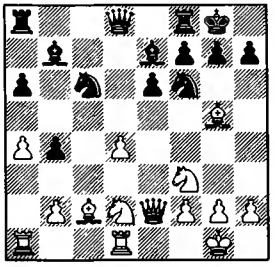
(3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗c4 c5 6.0–0 a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗b3 ♗b7 9.a4)

B2. 9...b4 10.♘bd2

In the typical case 10.♖d1 ♗e7 or 10...♘bd7 interweaves with the main line. The game Cacho Reigadas – Magem Badals, ESP 1993 took on a different course after

10.♖d1 ♘c6!? Black can implement the same idea by 10...♗e7 and only after 11.♘bd2 – ♘c6.

11.♗c2 cd4 12.ed4 ♗e7 (12...♕d5!?) 13.♗g5 0–0 14.♘bd2

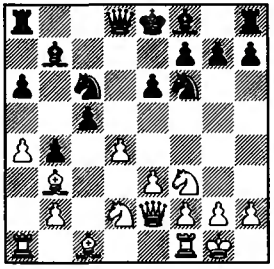


14...♘a5 Capturing the pawn is a bit risky and only forces play without bringing Black particular benefits – 14...♘d4 15.♘d4 ♕d4 16.♘e4 ♕e5 17.f4 ♕a5 18.♘f6 ♗f6 19.♕d3 (19.♗f6 gf6 20.♕g4 ♔h8 21.♗h7 ♕c5 22.♔h1 ♕f2∓) 19...♕c5 20.♔h1 ♖fc8 21.♕h7 ♔f8=.

15.♘e5 ♕d5 16.♘df3 ♖fc8=.

After 10.♘bd2 we would like to draw your attention to the practically unknown B2a. 10...♘c6!? The usual 10...♗e7 is examined in B2b.

B2a. 10...♘c6!?

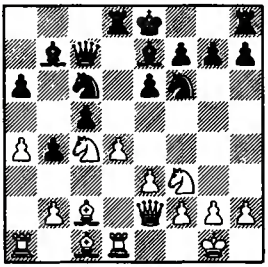


We found only three games which all went on with 11.♘c4:

Lehner – Vodep, Graz 1994, 11...♘a5 12.♘a5 (12.♗a2!?) 12...♕a5 13.♖d1 ♗e7 14.♗d2 0–0 and here

14...cd4!∓ deserved attention.

Bozic – Andric, Belgrade 1952, 11...♕c7 12.♖d1 ♖d8 13.♗c2 ♗e7



14.dc5 ♖d1 15.♕d1 0–0 16.b3 ♘a5 17.♗d3 ♖d8 18.♕c2 ♘c4 19.♗c4 ♕c5∓. Black's set-up in this game is suitable against all developing schemes of White.

The possibility of meeting ♘c4 by ♘a5 logically turns us to

11.a5 instead of 11.♘c4. Then 11...♘a5? fails to 12.♗a4 ♘c6 (12...♗c6 13.♗c6 ♘c6 14.♖a6 ♖a6 15.♕a6±) 13.♘e5 ♕c7 14.♘dc4±.

Correct is **11...cd4!** (or the method of Andric in the above game) **12.ed4 ♗e7** (12...♘a5 13.♗a4 ♗c6 14.♗c6 ♘c6 15.♖a6 ♘d4 16.♘d4 ♖a6 17.♕a6 ♕d4=) **13.♘c4 0–0** [13...♘d4? is suicidal after 14.♗a4 ♔f8 15.♘d4 ♕d4 16.♖d1 ♕h4 (16...♕e4? 17.♕e4 ♗e4 18.♘b6 ♖d8 19.♖d8 ♗d8 20.♗d2 ♗e7 21.♖c1 g5 22.♗g5±) 17.♗e3 g6 18.♘e5 ♔g7 19.♗c6 ♗c6 20.♘c6 ♘g4 21.♗f4 ♗f6 22.♖ac1±] **14.♖d1 ♕c7 15.♗e3 ♖ad8∞.**

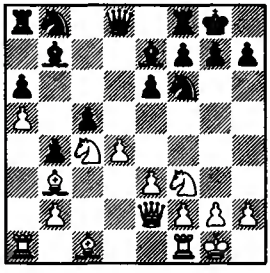
Another attempt could be **11.♖d1 ♕c7 12.♘c4**

This position can also be reached after 10.♖d1 c6 11.♘bd2 ♕c7 12.♘c4. The set-up of Andric proved good enough in the game Huss – Varga, Buekfuerdo 1995:

12...♖d8!? 13.h3 ♗e7 14.a5 0–0 15.♖d3 ♘e4 16.♗d2 cd4 17.ed4 ♘d2 18.♕d2 ♖d5 19.♖c1 ♕d8 20.♘e3 ♖d7 21.♗a4 ♖d6 22.♘c4 ♖d5 23.♘e3 ♖d6 24.♘c4 ♖d5 ½–½.

B2b. 10...♗e7 11.♘c4 0-0 12.a5

The old treatment 12.♖d1 is not very promising – 12...♕c7 (12...♘bd7 13.♘fe5 ♕c7 14.e4 cd4 15.♗f4 ♕c5 16.♖ac1 gave White the initiative in Khalifman – Sadler, Hastings 1995, but a couple of accurate moves are enough to level the play, though the next two in the game do not strike us with an extraordinary quality – 16...♕a7?! 17.♘a5 ♗c5?! 18.♘b7↑. Why not 16...♘e5! 17.♘e5 ♕b6 and it is up to White to ponder). 13.♗d2 ♘bd7 14.♘fe5 ♖fd8 15.♖ac1 a5 16.♗e1, Jussupow – Anand, Dortmund 1997, when probably 16...♗d5!? would have been the best continuation.



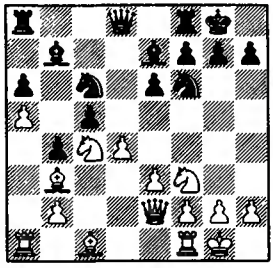
The new ideas for White include a5, ♗a4, ♖fc1 and ♘e5, pressurising the queenside. All that may sound tempting, but in fact cannot be brought to life. For instance, if White tried on his last move 12.♗d2,

then logical would be 12...cd4! when 13.ed4 would leave White in wonder what the bishop on d2 was looking for. And after 12.a5, Black can develop the knight to c6, eyeing the a5-pawn:

12...♘c6!?

12...♘bd7 is a subject of another discussion, quite popular lately. Here is the story in short:

13.♗d2 ♗d5 14.♖fc1 ♕b8 15.♗a4! ♕b7 (15...♖c8? 16.e4!) 16.♘fe5! (16.dc5 ♗c5 17.♘ce5 ♘e5! 18.♘e5 ♖ac8=) 16...♖ad8 (The rook is not on his best place here. A very complicated position arises after 16...cd4!? 17.ed4 ♗g2 18.f3 ♘e5 19.♘e5 ♗h3 20.♗c6 ♕a7 21.♗a8 ♕d4 22.♔h1 ♖a8 23.♘c6 ♕d7 24.♘e7 ♕e7 25.♖c6∞, though White has some initiative.) 17.f3 cd4∞, Krasenkow – Markowski, Warsaw 2002.



13.dc5

13.♖d1 cd4 14.ed4 ♕c7, followed by ♖d8 is good for Black.

13...♗c5 14.♖d1 ♕c7 15.e4 ♘g4 16.♗e3 ♗e3 17.♘e3 ♘e3 18.♕e3 ♘a5 19.♖dc1 ♕d8 20.♖d1 ♕c7 21.♖dc1 ♕d8 22.♖d1 ½–½, Gagarin – Krush, Moscow 2002.

Conclusion

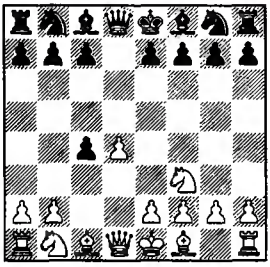
Black has good play in the Classical variation. In lines A2. 10...♕b8 and A3. 10...♕c7 he is even able to overtake the initiative in Meran-type structures.

More unclear is 9.a4, considered in line B, but even then White has not proved any advantage neither after 9...b4 nor 9...♘bd7. The somewhat better statistics in White's favour is mostly due to the fact that the path to equality is quite narrow and the order of moves might be critical.

When we analyse this system, we cannot shake off the feeling that White should look for new ideas in other directions – like the modern 7.♗b3 or perhaps the restraining 7.a4.

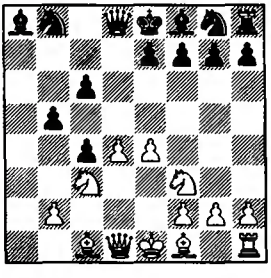
Part 3

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 Deviations from the Classical system



In the final part of the book we deal with all kinds of deviations from the Classical System.

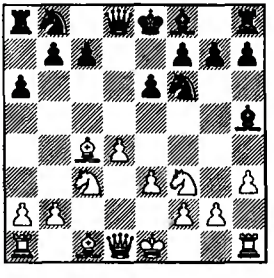
We start with a very popular move order for Black: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6. It had been initially intended against 3...♘f6 4.♘c3!? a6 5.e4 or 4.♕a4. Nowadays the gambit is not considered too dangerous, but still many players remain faithful to 3...a6. Despite being a frequent guest in tournaments, this line is poorly covered in theory books. We divided the material in two chapters. Chapter 22 examines the most testing continuation 3.e4!?. White plays a real gambit



In this critical position we consider 5 continuations. 9.e5 and 9.d5 are practically unexplored and lead to tangled positions.

Chapter 21 focuses on 3...a6 4.e3 b5. This move is not very appealing because of its strong drawish tendencies, but it requires from White very precise play. He should be happy to retain even a slight edge there.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 ♗g4 is practically nonexisting at highest level, probably because White enjoys some spatial advantage. However usually Black players are better prepared and achieve in practice satisfactory results. Line D1 (Chapter 26) is especially topical.



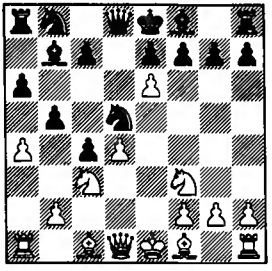
For a long time 8.g4 ♗g6 9.♘e5 ♘bd7 10.♘g6 hg6 11.♗f1 has been White's main choice. Now I propose the more refrained 8.0-0. It

is a safe option which should give White a small edge.

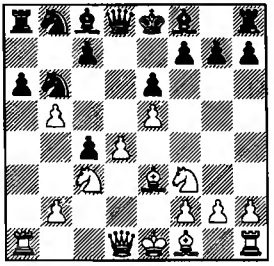
We devoted a special chapter to 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5. It is an important line because it could arise from the increasingly popular scheme which we call "Anti-everything" 1. d4 and 2.♘f3. Black could counter-attack it with 1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5, when the best answer is 3.c4. Then, in order to avoid Tarrasch, Black might prefer 3...dc4.

Chapter 27 covers 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3, which is aimed against 3...a6 and 4...♗g4. Then 3...e5 is testing, because it impedes White's plans. The arising version of the Exchange French should not be of great concern to Black.

Of course, we pay due attention to the Two Knights gambit 3...♘f6 4.♘c3!? a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4. The old line with 7...♗b7!? 8.e6 is unclear,

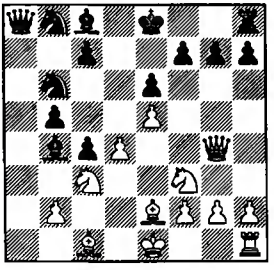


whilst 7...e6 8.ab5 ♘b6 9.♗e3 remains fashionable:

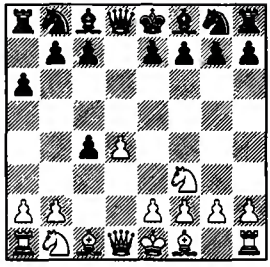


Here we prefer 9...ab5 with double-edged play. Black castles and counters White's attack with f5. (Chapter 24).

If you are looking for more adrenaline, we strongly recommend 7...e6 8.ab5 ♗b4!? 9.♕c2 ♘b6 10.♕e4 ♕d5 11.♕g4 ab5 12.♖a8 ♕a8 13.♗e2



Both 13...♖g8 and 13...♔f8 lead to sharp unbalanced game. I (S.S.) think that Black is fine in that line.



(D21)

3...a6 is the second most popular move for Black after 3...♘f6. At the same time we suspect that some players resort to it by pure habit. Some 30 years ago the main concern of Black was how to sidestep the terrible weapon in White's arsenal against QGA – the gambit 3...♘f6 4.♘c3!? a6 5.e4. There was a disheartening number of miniatures where White sacrificed a couple of pawns and went on to mate the enemy king. Hence many fans of QGA decided to smartly "trick" White with the move order. The reasoning behind 3...a6 was: since 4.♘c3 b5! was not dangerous anymore, and we would play ...a7-a6 anyway, why not "restrain" the opponent's choice and steer the game directly into the Classical variation. As a bonus, Black also averted the variation with 4.♕a4 check.

That would be a sound idea, but only if the premises were true. In fact, it all depends on the status of the 4.e4!? b5 5.a4 variation. It is currently under Black control, but nevertheless it leads to a very sharp and unbalanced game. White has many tempting plans to explore, and even if he failed to get enough compensation for the pawn, it would be difficult to tame his initiative. Especially for rapid chess, that line is a dangerous weapon. On the other hand, it is fun for both sides.

One last note – if Black intends to develop the bishop to g4, the move 3...a6 could prove superfluous.

Black can also use the move order with 3...a6 not only as a work-around for some concrete variation, but as a global weapon against the whole white strategy. In that case 4.e3 is met by 4...b5 and most probably White will end up with only a symbolic small plus, with strong drawish trends. To be sure, the half-point is Black's limit in this line, but a limit not that far away.

The main options for White in response of 3...a6 are:

A. 4.a4?!; B. 4.♘c3; C. 4.e3 b5!?. The most challenging continuation 4.e4!? is the subject of the next chapter.

A. 4.a4?!

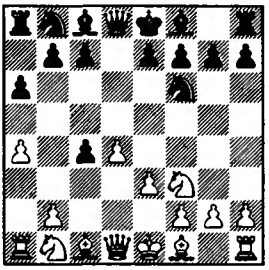
White terribly weakens the b4-square and loses a tempo at that. The results are favourable for Black and nobody seems to challenge this assessment, but nevertheless it is amazing how many people play 4.a4?! Black should take advantage of it by developing his knight to c6 and the bishop to g4.

4...♘f6 (4...♘c6!?) **5.e3**

Alternatively:

5.♘bd2 ♘c6 6.e3 ♗g4 7.♗c4 e6 8.h3 ♗h5 9.a5 ♗b4 10.g4 ♗g6 11.♕b3 0-0 12.♖a4 ♗a5 13.♕b7 ♗e4 14.0-0 ♗d2 15.♘d2 ♖b8 16.♕a6 ♖b6 17.g5 ♖a6 18.♖a6 ♗d5 19.gf6 gf6 20.♔h2 ♔h8∓, Sjoberg – Yakovich, Kecskemet 1991

5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.e4 ♗g4 7.♗e3 ♗f3 8.gf3 e5 9.de5 (9.d5? ♘a5∓, De Jonge – Baburin, Bunratty 2007) ♘e5 10.f4 ♘d3 11.♗d3 ♕d3 12.e5 ♕d1 (12...♘g8!? 13.♕f3 ♗b4 14.♕b7 ♗c3 15.bc3 ♖d8 16.♕c6 ♖d7 17.♕a8= is a draw by perpetual) 13.♖d1 ♘g4 14.♖d4 f6=.



5...♘c6

Or 5...♗g4 6.♘bd2 e6 7.♘c4 c5 8.♘ce5 ♗h5 9.♗e2 ♘bd7 10.♕b3 ♖b8 11.♘d7 ♘d7 12.0-0 ♗d6 13.♖d1 0-0 14.d5 e5 15.e4 f5= Kishnev – Yakovich, Barnaul 1988.

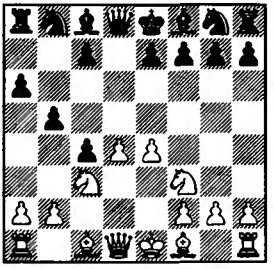
6.♗c4 ♗g4 7.0-0 e6 8.h3 ♗h5 9.♗e2

9.♘c3 ♗d6 (9...♗b4 10.g4 ♗g6 11.♘h4 ♗c3 12.bc3 ♘e4 13.♘g6 hg6 14.♔g2 ♕h4 15.♕f3 0-0-0 16.♖h1 f5 17.♗e6 ♔b8 18.gf5 ♖h5 19.♕f4 ♖g5 20.♔f3 ♕f2 21.♔e4 ♕c2 Stefansson – Baburin, Siofok 1991). 10.♗e2 0-0 11.♕b3 ♘a5 12.♕c2 c5 13.♖d1 ♕e7 14.dc5 ♗c5 15.e4 ♘d7 16.♗f4 ♘c6 17.g4 ♗g6 18.♕d2 ♖fd8 19.♗c7 ♖dc8 20.♗d6= Manor – Shvidler, Izrael 1986.

9...♗d6 10.b3 ♕e7 11.♘bd2 e5 12.♘c4 e4 13.♘fe5 ♗e2 14.♕e2 ♗e5 15.de5 ♘e5 16.♗a3 ♕e6 17.♘e5 ♕e5 18.♖fd1 ♘d5 19.♗b2 ♕e6 20.♕h5 0-0-0∓ Mikhalchishin – Donchev, Lvov 1983.

B. 4.♘c3 b5 5. e4

The alternative is 5.a4 b4 6.♘e4 (or 6.♘a2 e6!) 6...♘d7 7.♘ed2 c3 8.bc3 bc3 9.♘e4 ♘gf6 10.♘c3 e6 11.e3 ♗b4 12.♗d2 c5 13.♗e2 0-0 14.0-0 ♗b7 15.♖b1 ♖b8 16.♘a2 ♗a5 17.♕e1 ♗c7 18.dc5 ♘c5 19.♗b4 ♗d6 20.♗c5= Karpov – L. Portisch, Tilburg 1983.



Black is at a juncture. He should make a choice depending on his style and home preparation. 5...♘f6 trans-

posest to the Two Knights gambit. Line B1 leads to hazy complications where you could surprise your oponent with the new variations I (S.S.) propose in this edition of the book. Line B2 is a sound positional option which gives Black a good game with little risk.

B1. 5...♗b7
B2. 5...e6

B1. 5...♗b7

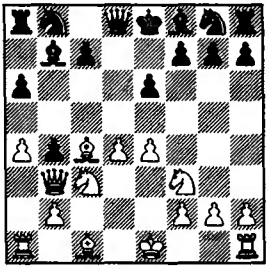
In comparison with the line 3...♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4 b5 White has no tempo for e4-e5, but the bishop on b7 is hanging in some variations.

6.a4 b4

6...e6 7.ab5 is better tested. We deal with it in the next chapter.

7.♗c4 e6 8.♕b3

8.d5 is spectacular, but ineffi-cient: 8...bc3 9.♕b3 ed5 10.♕b7 dc4 11.♕a8 cb2 12.♗b2 ♗b4 13.♔f1 c3∓ Gufeld – Bagirov, Baku 1964.



B1a. 8...♘c6; B1b. 8...♘d7!?

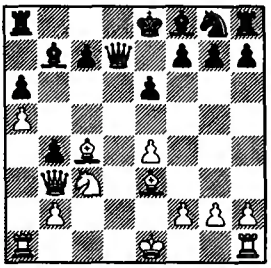
Both options lead to tangled and practically unexplored play.

B1a. 8...♘c6 9.a5 ♘d4

Black demonstrates only a moderate appetite. Going for the queen quickly turns into disaster: 9...bc3?? 10.♕b7 ♘b4 11.0-0! 11...♖b8 12.♗a6 ♖b7 13.♗b7+– Izeta Txabarri – E. Vladimirov, Ceuta 1992. Remember this trap!

10.♘d4 ♕d4 11.♗e3 ♕d7

11...♕f6?! is a weaker alternative: 12.0-0-0 13.♘b5 ♕e7 14.♘a7 c6 15.♕a4 ♕c7 16.g3 ♗e7 17.♗b6 ♗g5 18.f4 ♗f4 19.♔b1 ♕e5 20.gf4 ♕e4 21.♗d3 ♕f4 22.♖hf1 ♕h4 23.♗a6 ♕e4 24.♗d3 1-0 Farago – Skomorokhin, 1994.



12.f3!

Waiting for 12...♗d6 to castle long.

After 12.0-0 ♘f6 13.f3 ♗d6 14.♖ad1 14.♖fd1 ♕e7 White has to struggle for keeping the balance. 15.♗g5 0-0∓ is insufficient. Farago – Izsak, Budapest 1995 continued with the repetition of moves 15.♕a4 ♕d7 16.♕b3 ♕e7 17.♕a4 ♕d7 18.♕b3 ♕e7 ½-½, but 15...♘d7!?∓ favours Black.

12...♗d6 13.0-0-0!

An excellent idea. It has been introduced by the correspondence game Liljedahl – Barnsley, ICCF 1998. Instead, 13.♘a4 slows down the attack: 13...♕e7 14.e5 ♗e5 15.♘c5, Pedersen – Sadler, Cannes 1995 when 15...♗c6! would have left

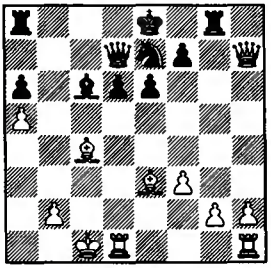
White without compensation for the pawn: 16.♗a6 ♘h6!

After the long castle Black should embark on a long forced line which is too hazy for evaluation:

13...♗c6!

The stem-game saw 13...♕e7 14.e5±.

14.e5 bc3 15.♕c3 ♘e7 16.ed6 cd6 17.♕g7 ♖g8 18.♕h7∞

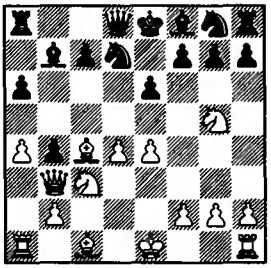


At first glance one would say that it was the Sicilian! There are two plausible follow-ups:

18...♗b5 19.♗b5 ab5 20.♗b6 ♖g2;

18...♖c8 19.♔b1 ♗f3 20.♗a6 ♗d1 21.♖d1 ♖b8 22.♗b6⩲ ♖g2. White's bishops are rather dangerous.

B1b. 8...♘d7!? 9.♘g5



9...bc3!?

This novelty deserves further investigation. 9...♕e7 10.♘e2 ♘f6 11.e5 ♘d5 is known to be double-edged: 12.0-0 h6 13.♘e4 ♕h4 14.f4 c5 15.♕f3 cd4 16.♘d4 ♖c8 17.b3 ♘c3 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.♕b7 ♖c4 20.bc4 ♗c5 21.♗e3 ♗d4 22.♗d4 ♘e2 23.♔h1 ♘g3 ½-½ Van Wely – Brenninkmeijer, 1995.

10.♘f7

White has no choice as 10.bc3 ♗c8! 11.♘f7 stumbles into 11...♘c5∓.

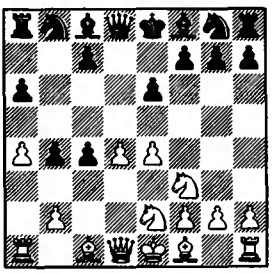
10...♕h4 11.♘g5 ♗e4 12.0–0 ♗g2

As in line B1a, we reached a very unbalanced position with mutual chances.

13.♗e6 ♗d6 14.♔g2 cb2 15.♕b2 ♕h2 16.♔f3 ♘gf6 17.♗f7 ♔d8 18.♗e3.

It would be fun to play such a position with either colour!

B2. 5...e6 6.a4 b4 7.♘e2



7...c5

Another interesting variation is 7...♘c6 8.♘g3 ♘a5 9.♗g5 ♗e7 10.♗e7 ♘e7 11.♖c1 c5 with roughly equal chances.

8.d5 ed5 9.♘f4

9.ed5 ♘f6 10.♘f4 c3 11.bc3 ♗d6∞ is also very complex.

9...de4 10.♕d8 ♔d8 11.♘g5 ♖a7

12.♗c4 ♘h6∞.

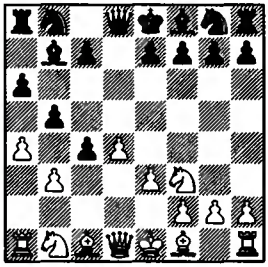
White has compensation, but the two extra pawns are not a burden to Black at all.

C. 4.e3 b5!? 5.a4 ♗b7

This line is definitely underestimated. It has a stamp "±", but nobody could really answer how to win this 'small advantage' and isn't it of the fleeting type. If we try to dig a bit deeper, it becomes clear that Black has not some serious opening problems and White's initiative gradually evaporates to none around move 20. This is yet another argument in favour of 4.e4!?

C1. 6.b3; C2. 6.ab5

C1. 6.b3



C1a. 6...cb3?; C1b. 6...e6

In the first line Black fails under a terrible attack, connected with e4, ♘g5 and a crushing sacrifice of a minor piece on e6 or f7.

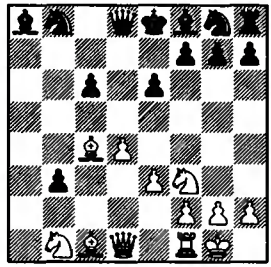
6...e6 is a better try. The a6-pawn remains on board and could be a constant source of trouble in the middlegame and endgame, but apaprently that does not bother Khenkin, who has recently employed this system.

Black might also try 6...c5, but it does not deserve any special attention. White is ahead in development and opening up the position suits his plans: 6...c5 7.bc4 bc4 8.♗c4 e6 9.0–0 ♘d7 10.♗a3 ♘gf6 11.♘bd2 ♖c8 12.♕b1 ♖c7 13.♖c1 cd4 14.♗f8 ♘f8 15.♘d4 ♘g6 16.♕b4±.

C1a. 6...cb3? 7.ab5 ab5 8.♖a8 ♗a8 9.♗b5 c6

9...♘d7 leads to the same positions as 9...c6, but sets a trap: 10.♘e5? 10...c6! 11.♘d7 (11.♗c6 ♗c6 12.♘c6 ♕b6 13.d5 ♘gf6 14.♗b2 e6 15.de6 fe6 16.♘d4 ♗b4∓) 11...cb5 12.♘f8 ♗g2 13.♘e6 fe6! Correct would be 10.♕b3 c6 11.♗c4 e6, transposing to the main line.

10.♗c4 e6 11.0-0



11...♘d7

11...♗e7 12.♕b3 ♘f6 does not help much due to 13.e4 ♘e4 (13...0–0 14.♘g5 ♘d5 15.♕g3 ♘c7 16.♖d1±) 14.♖e1 ♘f6 15.♗e6 fe6 16.♘g5±.

12.♕b3

12.♘c3 is also possible, but the text is much more destructive.

12...♗e7

12...♘gf6 immediately allows 13.♘g5 ♗e7 14.♗e6 fe6 15.♘e6.

13.e4!

An excellent idea of Kuzubov. White takes control of d5 and prepares to sacrify a piece.

White had also tried 13.♘c3 ♘f6 14.e4 c5 15.d5 ed5 16.ed5 0-0 17.♗f4 ♘b6 18.♖d1 ♗d6 19.♗g5 ♘c4 20.♕c4 h6 21.♗h4 ♖e8=, or:

13.♗a3 ♘f6 14.♘bd2 c5 15.dc5 0-0 16.♖c1 ♗c5 17.♗b2 ♕e7 18.♕d3 ♖d8 19.♕c2 ½–½ Frois – Ruefenacht, Thessaloniki 1984.

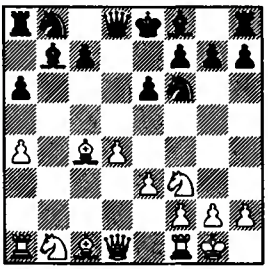
13...♘gf6 14.♘g5! ♕b8

The point is that the endgame after 14...0–0 15.♘f7 ♖f7 16.♗e6 ♕e8 17.♘c3 ♘f8 18.♗f7 ♕f7 19.♕b8 ♕e8 20.♕e8 ♘e8 21.♗e3 ♗b7 22.♖b1± is difficult for Black because of his total lack of co-ordination. After the text White could have executed his idea right away: 15.♗e6! fe6 16.♕e6 ♖f8 17.e5 ♘d5 18.♘h7 ♕b1 19.♘f8 ♘f8 20.♕c8 ♔f7 21.♕a8±.

15.♕a2 c5 16.♗e6! fe6 17.♘e6 ♗e4 18.♘c3 ♗d3 19.♘g7±, Kuzubov – Heberla, Calvia, 21.10.2007.

This game has dealt a severe blow on the move 6...cb3.

C1b. 6...e6 7.bc4 bc4 8.♗c4 ♘f6 9.0-0



Black had no problems after 9.♕b3 ♗f3 10.gf3 c5 11.dc5 ♗c5 12.♖g1 0–0 13.♗b2 ♘bd7 Vitiugov – Sakaev, Khanty-Mansiysk 26.11.2007

9...c5!

This natural move turned to be a novelty in the game Bacrot – Khenkin, Tegernsee 2007. The other options are in White's favour:

9...♗d6 10.♘c3 ♘bd7 11.♖b1 ♖b8 12.♕e2 a5 13.♗d3 0–0 14.e4 e5 15.d5 ♘c5 16.♗b5 ♗c8 17.♘d2± Pfeiffer – Pfleger, Bad Pyrmont 1961.

9...♘bd7 10.♘c3! ♗e7 11.♕e2 0–0 12.♖b1 ♕c8 13.e4!± Wedberg – Laird, Copenhagen 1982.

10.♗a3 ♘bd7 11.♘bd2 ♗e7 12.♕e2 cd4 13.♗e7 ♕e7 14.♘d4 0–0=.

It is not easy to improve White's play. It seems that Black can gradually neutralise White's lead in development.

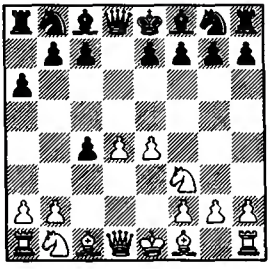
C2. 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.b3 e6 9.bc4 bc4 10.♗c4 ♘f6

This line is absolutely harmless for Black and is suitable only for a quick draw. He castles and pushes c7-c5 at his leisure. The only way for White to do something is to play 11.♕a4 now or on the next move.

11.♕a4

The careless 11.0-0 immediately levels the game owing to 11...♗e7.

♗c6 12.♗b5 ♗b5 13.♕b5 ♘bd7 14.♘c3 ♕a8 15.0-0 ♗d6 16.♗d2 c5= Estremera – Prats, 1999.

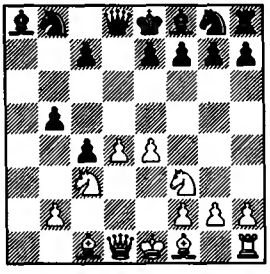


4...b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5

The only decent alternative is 6.♘c3!?, see 4.♘c3 in Chapter 21, line B.

Otherwise Black gets a comfortable position with every reasonable way of development: 6.b3 ♗e4 7.♘c3 ♗b7 8.ab5 ab5 9.♖a8 ♗a8 10.bc4 e6 11.♘b5 ♗b4 12.♗d2 ♗f3 13.gf3 (13.♕f3 b4 14.c5=) 13...♗d2 14.♕d2 c6 15.♘c3 ♘e7∓ Vaisser – Bagirov, Novosibirsk 1971.

6...ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3



By playing 4.e4, White has demonstrated a fighting spirit, but it takes two to tango. Black can take the challenge by the risky A. 8...c6!, or switch to a dull defence with high chances to draw and none to win by B. 8...e6.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 4.e4!?

(D21)

A. 8...c6!

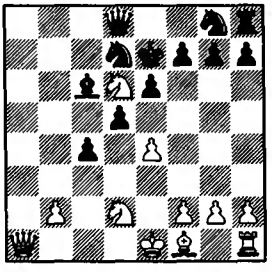
White is at a crossroads. He has five very different ways. Slow development seems inadequate in this unbalanced position. White should play actively in the centre in order to get compensation for the pawn. Therefore 9.d5 and 9.e5!? seem most promising.

A1. 9.♗f4?!; A2. 9.♗e2; A3. 9.♗g5 A4. 9.d5; A5.e5!?

Before going into details, let's see a short description of the options:

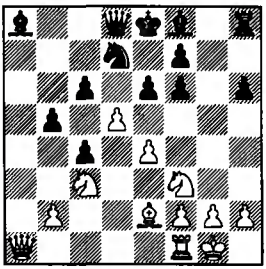
A1. White tries to use the a-file by 9.♗f4?!, but does not achieve success. Black is even slightly better.

The main line is 9...e6 10.♕a1 ♘d7 11.d5 cd5 12.♘b5 ♗b4 13.♗d2 ♗d2 14.♘d2 ♗c6 15.♘d6 ♔e7∓.



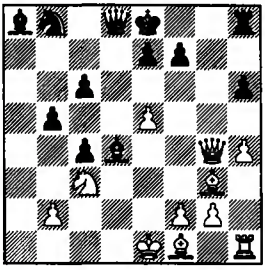
A2. The most popular move is 9.♗e2, intending first of all to castle and only then to break in the centre. The main line reaches this situation where White's attack proves to be only an optical delusion:

9.♗e2 e6 10.0-0 ♘f6 11.♗g5 h6 12.♗f6 gf6 13.♕a1 ♗b7 14.d5

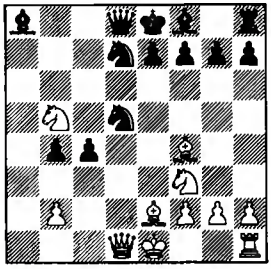


14...♗c5∓.

A3. White chooses to hinder as much as possible Black's development (9.♗g5). Then 9...♘f6 deserves consideration. We mostly analyse 9.♗g5 h6 10.♗h4 g5! 11.♗g3 ♗g7 12.h4 g4 13.♘e5 ♘f6 14.♘g4 ♘g4 15.♕g4 ♗d4 16.16.e5∞.



A4. 9.d5 It is tempting to immediately force the events. The strong point of this option is that nobody knows how to react and Black can swiftly turn into a co-author of a miniature. The threats are dangerous enough, but somehow Black is coming out of the complications, often enjoying an extra pawn against a gradually exhausting initiative of the opponent. The critical position in our opinion is:

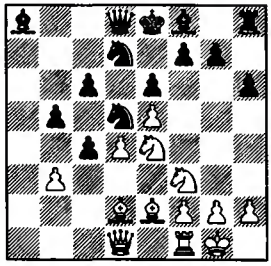


arising after 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3 c6 9.d5!? ♘f6 10.♗f4 cd5 11.ed5 ♘bd7 12.♗e2 b4 13.♘b5 ♘d5.

If you find the sight of a position with two pawns down without some imminent threats disturbing, skip this line.

A5. White fixes the centre with 9.e5!? and relies on long-lasting strategic pluses. He completes development, undermines Black's stronghold at the queenside with b3, and eventually turns right, hoping for a smashing onslaught under the cover of the powerful centre. Not recommended for people who like to recount often the number of chips on the board. Most likely White will be missing a pawn for a long time, but we'd rather take his side.

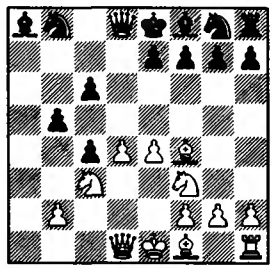
A typical set-up arises after 9.e5 e6 10.♗e2 h6 11.0-0 ♘e7 12.♘e4 ♘d5 13.♗d2! ♘d7 14.b3↑



Now let us see details.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3 c6)

A1. 9.♗f4



Looks consistent. However, if White does not obtain something substantial by force, the bishop would be useless on f4.

9...e6 10.♕a1 ♘d7 11.d5

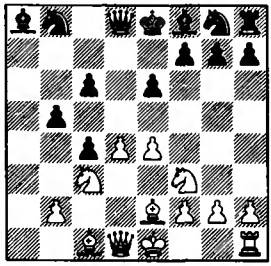
Without a pawn break in the centre, White's efforts would be inefficient: 11.♕a7 ♘gf6 12.♗e2 ♗b4 13.0-0 ♗c3 14.bc3 ♘e4 15.♕a3 f6 16.♖e1 c5∓ Petrov – Volodarsky, Novokuznetsk 1997.

11...cd5 12.♘b5

Or12.ed5 ♗b4 13.♘e5 ♘e5 14.♗e5 ♘f6 15.♗f6 gf6∓ Griego – Dlugy, USA 1988;

12...♗b4 13.♗d2 ♗d2 14.♘d2 ♗c6 15.♘d6 ♔e7∓.

A2. 9.♗e2 e6



10.0-0

It is worth mentioning 10.♗g5 ♗e7 11.♕a1 ♘d7 12.0-0 ♗g5 13.♘g5 ♘e7 14.♕a7 0-0 and White resorted to tactics to keep the fire burning: 15.♗g4 ♘f6 16.♗e6 fe6 17.♘e6 ♕d7 18.♕d7 ♘d7 19.♘f8 ♔f8 20.♖a1 ♘b6 21.f3 with a complex endgame, Pomes Marcet – Narciso Dublan 1999.

10...♘f6

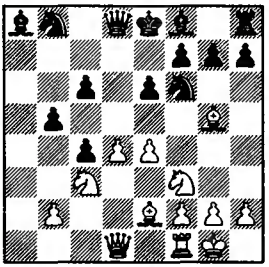
Black has other options, though not so popular:

10...♘d7 (intending to meet 11.d5 with e5!) 11.e5 ♘e7 12.♗g5 ♕b8 13.♘e4 ♘d5 14.♕c2 h6 15.♗h4 Here Black succeeded to undermine the centre without direct losses. 15...c5 16.♖a1 ♘b4 (16...cd4 17.♘d4 ♘b4 hands White additional tactical resources: 18.♖a8 ♕a8 19.♘b5 ♘e5 20.♕d1 ♘d5∞ Perhaps a computer could defend successfully, but at the moment White's initiative looks promising. H. Gruenberg, – Comp Deep Thought, Hannover 1991), 17.♕b1 ♗d5∓.

10...♗b4 The most unpleasant for Black treatment of the position would be 11.♕c2 (It is not the right time to force the game now, as in

Lehner – Varga, St Poelten 2002: 11.♗g5 ♘e7 12.♕a1 ♘d7 13.d5?! ed5 14.ed5 0-0 15.d6 ♗d6 16.♖d1 ♕c7 17.♘e4 ♘d5 18.♘d4 ♗h2 19.♔f1 ♗f4 20.♗f3 ♘e5 21.b3 ♗g5 22.bc4 ♘f3 23.gf3 ♗f4 24.cd5 cd5 0–1) 11...♘e7 12.h4 White puts the rook to d1, pushes the pawn to h5, restraining the knight, and decides at his leisure how to attack further. Black is rather passive, but a pawn up, of course.

11.♗g5



11...h6

11...♗e7 puts to the test White's plan: 12.e5. Why else White has played ♗g5, if not to conquer the dark squares?! 12...♘d5 13.♘e4 0-0 14.♗e7 ♕e7 15.b3 cb3 16.♕b3 For the pawn White has some positional compensation.

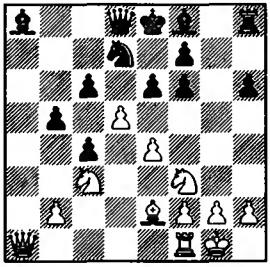
11...♘bd7 12.♕a1 ♗b4 (12...h6 seems more consistent in connection with the previous move. White should insist on the pin. Variations on the Botvinnik theme from Semi-Slav look favourable to him: 13.♗h4 (Black is not afraid of 13.♗f6 ♘f6 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘d5 cd5! 16.♕a6 ♗e7 17.♕b5 ♕d7 18.♕b8 ♕d8 19.♕a7 0-0 20.♖a1=) 13...♗b4 14.e5 g5 15.♘g5 hg5 16.♗g5 ♖g8 17.♗f6 ♘f6 18.ef6 c5 19.g3±.

After 12...♗b4 White is dominating: 13.e5 h6 14.ef6 hg5 15.fg7 ♖g8 16.♕a7 ♕c8 17.♖a1 ♗b7 18.♘e5± f5 19.g4 ♖g7 20.gf5 ef5 21.♗f3 ♗d6 22.♘b5 cb5 23.♗b7 ♕c7 24.♕a8 ♔e7 25.♗c6 ♗e5 26.♖a7 ♗h2 27.♔g2 ♖g8 28.♖c7 ♖a8 29.♖d7 ♔e6 30.d5 1–0 H. Gruenberg – S. Gross, Dresden 1985.

11...♕b6 12.♕d2 ♘bd7 13.♖a1 ♗b7 14.♕f4 ♗b4 15.♗f6 gf6 The ruined castling position of Black and the good co-ordination of his pieces makes White's game easier. He only should avoid forcing the position prematurely. A good option seems 16.♕h6.

Worse is 16.e5 in view of 16...c5! (but not 16...f5? 17.♕h6 ♗f8 18.♕h5 ♗e7 19.♖d1 h6 20.h4 ♕d8 21.d5 cd5 22.♘b5 ♕b8 23.♘g5 ♗g5 24.♘d6 ♔e7 25.♕f7 ♔d8 26.hg5 hg5 27.♕e6 ♔c7 28.♘b5 ♔d8 29.♘d6 ♔c7 30.♗c4 ♘c5 31.♘b5 ♔d8 32.♕f6 ♔d7 33.♗d5 1–0 Rotstein – Kachur, Lvov 1986) 17.♘e4 cd4 18.♘f6 ♘f6 19.ef6 (19.♕f6 ♖f8∓) 19...♗d6 (19...♗d5∞) 20.♕d4 ♕d4 21.♘d4=.

12.♗f6 gf6 13.♕a1 ♘d7 14.d5



14...♗c5

Kiss – Varga, 1994 saw 14...ed5

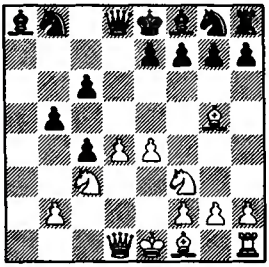
15.ed5 ♗c5 16.♖d1 0-0 with a balanced game.

After the text it is difficult for White to find enough counterplay:

15.de6 fe6 16.♘h4 ♘e5 17.♖d1 ♕b8 18.♗h5 ♔e7 19.♕c1 ♗b7 or 15.b3 cd5 16.ed5 ♗d5.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3 c6)

A3. 9.♗g5



Too sophisticated for our taste. The main virtue of White's idea is the wide choice presented to Black. He should make his mind about the future of the dark-squared bishop – on g7, or on its traditional working diagonal.

9...h6

9...♘f6 should probably be answered with 10.♗e2.

9...♕a5 delays the development – 10.♗e2 e6 11.0-0 ♗b4 12.d5!? (We do not understand the game Cruz Lopez – Garcia Palermo, Elgoibar 1991 where White chose to swap the queens instead of mating Black's king – 12.♕a1 ♗b7 13.♕a5 ♗a5 14.♖a1 ♗b6 15.e5 ♘e7 16.♘e4 ♘c8 17.♗d2 ♘d7 18.♗b4 f6 19.ef6 gf6 20.♖e1 ♖g8 21.♗d1 ♔f7 22.b3 ♗d8 ½-½). 12...cd5 13.ed5 ♗c3 14.de6! ♗b4 (14...♗f6 15.♕d6! ♕d8 16.ef7 ♔f7 17.♘e5±). White has the alternatives 15.♕d4 or ♘e5, in both cases with dangerous attack.

9...g6 was played in A. Trifunovic – Zouaghi, Glenalmond 1996, 10.e5 ♗g7, when came the inadequate 11.♘e4? ♘h6 12.h4 ♘f5 13.h5 c5 14.h6 ♗e4 15.hg7 ♘g7 16.dc5 ♕d1 17.♔d1 ♘e6-+. We have to guess what could have happened after a possible 11.h4.

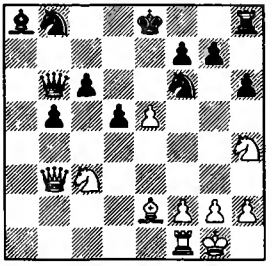
10.♗h4 g5!

Usually the best way to punish a challenge is to accept it. Anyway the alternatives are not too appealing:

10...♕b6 11.♗e2 e6 12.0-0 ♗e7 **13.b3!?** In Kohlweyer – Mainka, Dortmund 1988 has been played **13.d5** (13.e5 is good only for a draw: c5 14.♗e7 ♘e7 15.dc5 ♕c5 16.♕d4 ♕d4 17.♘d4 b4 18.♘cb5 0-0 19.♗c4 ♘bc6=) 13...cd5 14.ed5 ed5 15.♘d5 ♗d5 16.♕d5 ♘f6 17.♗f6 ♗f6 18.b3 0-0 19.bc4 b4 20.c5 ♕c7 21.♕c4± and eventually White won, but we think the central break comes a bit early, allowing Black to simplify.

13...♗h4 14.♘h4 cb3 15.♕b3 In this position you should think twice before taking the central pawn – 15...♕d4? 16.♖d1 ♕e5 (16...♕c5 17.e5!?) 17.♘f3 ♕c7 18.♕a3 ♗b7 19.♘d4!→ breaking through the enemy lines via the b5-square. **15...♘f6** Now you can exercise yourself playing for mate, for instance:

16.d5 ed5 17.e5 (17.ed5 0-0 18.♘f5 ed5 19.♘b5 ♘e4 20.♕b2 ♕f6 21.♕f6= is a dead draw)

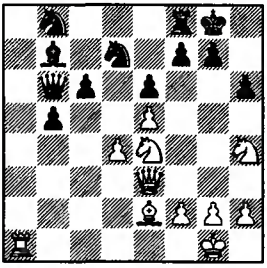


17...♘h7? 18.♖a1 ♗b7 19.♕b4 c5 (White's attack is crushing after 19...♗c8 20.♗b5! cb5 21.♘d5 ♕d8 22.♕b5 ♘d7 23.♕b4 ♘e5 24.♘f5! ♗f5 25.♖a8+–) 20.♕b5 ♕b5 21.♗b5 ♗c6 22.♗c6 ♘c6 23.♖a8 ♘d8 24.♘d5± and Black can not castle.

However the sobering 17...♘fd7! 18.e6 fe6 19.♘g6 ♖g8 leads White's attack to impasse.

Apparently the position is still not ripe for a strong medicine and we would recommend the strategical approach, based on the weak dark squares and space advantage:

16.♖a1! ♗b7 17.e5! ♘fd7 18.♘e4 0-0 (The greedy 18...♕d4 runs into 19.♘d6 ♔f8 20.♘g6!! fg6 21.♕e6!+–) 19.♕e3⩱.



We prefer White's prospects. A possible continuation could be 19...♘a6 20.♘f6 ♘f6□ 21.ef6 ♕d8 22.fg7 ♔g7 23.♘f3 ♘b4 24.♕e5 ♕f6 25.♖a7! ♕e5 26.♘e5 ♗c8 27.♔f1 and the endgame is not a dream for Black.

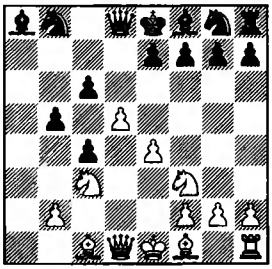
11.♗g3 ♗g7 12.h4 g4 13.♘e5 ♘f6 14.♘g4!

In Belotelov – Varga, Balatonbereny 1997 was 14.h5 0-0 15.f3 gf3 16.gf3 ♘bd7 17.♕d2 ♔h7 18.♕e3 e6 19.♗e2 ♕b6 and it became clear that White did not know what to do with his army.

14...♘g4 15.♕g4 ♗d4 16.e5∞.

White needs only two moves to complete his development. If you feel happy counting the bits on the board, you might choose the black side. However he ruined castle is also an important trait which probably balances the play. We can go a little further in the analysis with 16...c5 17.e6, but that would hardly clarify much the situation.

A4. 9.d5



Why not!? After all, this is the most logical continuation of White's previous play. He is systematically playing on elimination of Black's queenside. When Black eventually encounters this move in practice, the outcome is usually catastrophic.

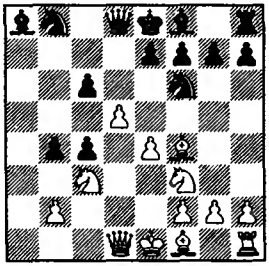
That's why I decided to offer some analysis here, in an attempt to clarify things.

9...♘f6

The game Krasenkow – Kharlov, URS-ch Moscow 1991 saw 9...e6? 10.♗f4 b4 11.de6 ♕e7 12.♘a4 and Black suddenly got sick of his position – 1–0. The same result achieves 9...b4? 10.♕a4 bc3 11.♕a8 ♕b6 12.bc3 ♕b1 13.♗c4 ♕c1 14.♔e2 ♕f4 15.♗d3+–.

10.♗f4 cd5

In tournaments no one has resisted the temptation to punish White on the spot by the over-optimistic 10...b4?



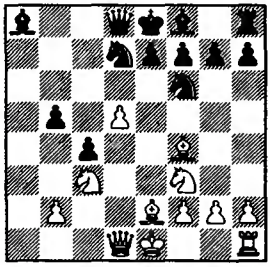
The only problem is that White has a forced win. He only has to shack in a piece and couple of pawns while evacuating his king. When done, Black's pieces are setting to drop like ripe fruits. 11.♕a4! (There is no way back – 11.dc6? ♕d1 12.♘d1 ♘c6 13.♗c4 ♘e4 14.♗b5 f6 15.♘d4 ♔d7 16.f3 ♘c5 17.♗d2 e5∓) 11...bc3 12.♗c4! (12.bc3? ♕b6 13.♕a8 ♕b1 14.♔d2 ♘e4 15.♔e2 ♕d3 16.♔e1 ♕b1 17.♔e2 ♘c3 18.♔d2 ♘e4 19.♔e2 e5 20.♘e5 ♗d6 21.♔f3 0-0 22.♗c4 ♕h1 23.♘f7 ♖f7 0–1 Elbilia – Baburin, Gifhorn 1992) 12...cb2 (or 12...♗b7 13.♕b3 ♗a6 14.dc6 ♗c4 15.♕c4 ♘c6 16.♕c6 ♕d7 17.♕c3+–) 13.0-0 ♕b6 (13...♘bd7 14.dc6 ♘c5 15.♕b5 ♕c8 16.♕c5 e6 17.♕b6 ♗c6 18.♗b5+–) 14.♖b1+– ♘e4 15.♕a8 ♕f2 16.♔h1 ♕b6 17.♕b8 ♕b8 18.♗b8 cd5 19.♗d5 ♘d6 20.♗d6 ed6 21.♖b2 f5 22.♘g5 h6 23.♘f7 ♖h7 24.♖b7 ♗e7 25.♗e6 g6 26.♘d6 ♔f8 27.♖b8 ♔g7 28.♘e8 1–0 J. Richardson – C. Hartman, 1996.

11.ed5

11.♘b5 ♕a5 12.♘c3 e5! 13.♗e5 de4 14.♗c4 ef3 15.0-0 ♗e7∓.

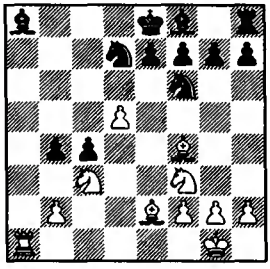
11...♘bd7 12.♗e2

White cannot spare a tempo for 12.♘b5 due to 12...♕a5 13.♘c3 ♘d5∓.



12...b4!

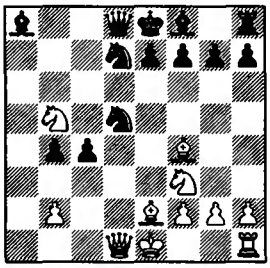
White is only one move shy of castling and Black has to do something. Analysis proves that any delay would be troublesome: 12...♕a5? 13.0-0 b4 14.♕a1! ♕a1 (14...♕d8 15.♘b5+–) 15.♖a1



15...♗b7 16.♖a7 bc3 17.♖b7 ♘d5 18.♗c4 ♘f4 19.♗b5 f6 20.bc3+−;

Or 12...♘b6? 13.♘b5 ♘fd5 14. ♕d4 f6 (It is late for advice. Black has no time to castle, for instance: 14...e6 15.0-0 ♗e7 16.♕g7 ♗f6 17.♘d6! ♕d6 18.♕h8 ♗h8 19.♗d6 ♗b2 20.♘e5+−) 15.0-0 e5 16.♘e5 fe5 17.♗e5→). Even the materialistic computer after an initial scepticism assesses this position as better for White. It means it is winning e.g. 17...♕g5 18.♗f3 ♔f7 19.h4 ♕g6 20.♖a1 ♗c6 21.♖a7 ♔g8 22.♗d6 c3 23.♗f8+−.

13.♘b5 ♘d5



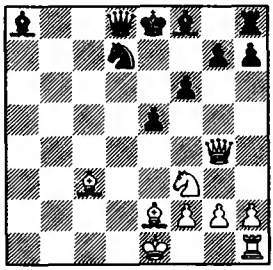
14.♗g3

Although White's position looks very promising, we could not find anything decisive. Most probably the initiative is enough for maintaining the balance, but hardly more. We'll show some instructive lines:

14.♕d4 (14.♕c1 c3 is in Black's favour) 14...c3 15.bc3 f6

This is the only way to exploit the placement of White's queen on d4. In fact, the same idea could be executed one move later – 15...bc3 16.0-0 f6! (A false trail is 16...♕a5 17.♗c4 ♗b7 18.♗d5 ♕b5 19.♗b7 ♕b7 20.♕c3±. The imminent intrusion of the white rook in the enemy camp should one way or another decide the game). 17.♗c4 e5 18.♘e5 fe5∓. 15...bc3 should be met by 16.♗c4! e5! 17.♗e5 ♗c5 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.♗d6 ♕f6 20.♕e4 ♖d8 21.♘e5=.

16.♗d2 e5 17.♕g4 bc3 18.♘c3 ♘c3 19.♗c3



19...♕b6!

Controlling the e6-square. It is not difficult to lose this position, for example with 19...♕c7 20.♕e6 (20.0-0? ♕c3 21.♗b5 ♗e7 22.♗d7 ♔f8 23.♘g5 fg5 24.♕f5 ♗f6 25.♕e6 ♗e7 26.♕f5=) 20...♗e7 21.♗b4 ♘f8 22.♗b5 ♔d8 23.♗e7 ♕e7 24.♕b3 ♗f3 25.gf3+−.

20.0-0 ♗d5 21.♖d1! ♕c6 22.♘d2 ♗e6! If White manages to exchange the bishops, he would obtain decisive attack – 22...g6? 23.♗c4!↑.

23.♕g3 g6∞. Probably White will make a draw, but Black is still a pawn up.

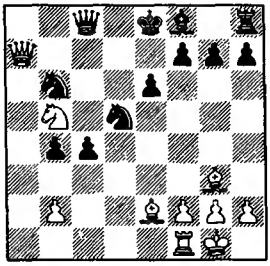
14...♕c8 15.0-0 e6 16.♕a4 ♗c6

16...♗b7 17.♖c1 ♕a8 (17...♗c5 18.♘d6 ♗d6 19.♗d6↑)18.♕a8 ♗a8 19.♖c4 ♘7b6 20.♘c7↑.

17.♘fd4 ♘7b6 18.♕a7 ♗b5

18...♗b7 19.♗f3 ♗e7 20.♗c7 ♘d7 21.♗d6↑.

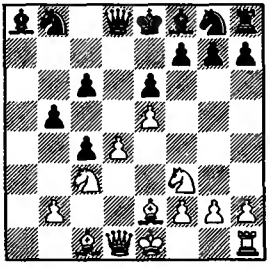
19.♘b5



19...♗e7 20.♘c7 ♘c7 21.♕b6 ♘d5 22.♕b5 ♕d7 23.♕b8=.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3 c6)

A5. 9.e5!? e6 10.♗e2

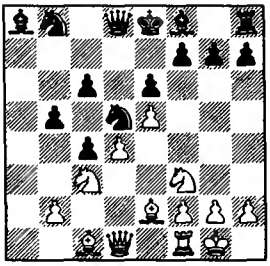


10...h6

A typical prophylactic move for this structure, though after castling the pawn will be a target. It would be interesting to try:

10...♘e7 11.0-0 White could have forced extreme complications with 11.♗g5 h6 12.♘e4 hg5 13.♘d6 ♔d7 14.♕a1 ♘f5 15.♘f7 ♗b4 16.♔f1 ♕a5 17.♕a5 ♗a5 18.♘h8 g4 19.♘g5 ♘d4∞ Lex – Kleindienst, Baden 1997. Probably he is objectively better, but the endgame is so double-edged, that the roles could easily change in one move.

11...♘d5

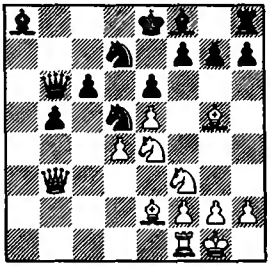


12.♗g5

In such structure White cannot get anything unless he undermines Black's pawns on the queenside. That would allow the light-squared bishop to come into play, sometimes with decisive effect. It is instructive to see how the renown adept of this line Knaak quickly reaches an impasse, trying a direct attack: 12.♘g5 ♗e7 13.f4 (or 13.♘ge4 0-0 14.f4 g6 15.g4 b4 16.♘a4 c5! 17.♘ac5 c3↑) 13...♘c3 14.bc3 c5! 15.♗e3 (The attempt to crush the black castle by 15.♗h5 0-0 16.♘f7 ♖f7 17.♗f7 ♔f7 18.f5 ef5 19.♕h5 ♔g8 20.♕f5 cd4 21.♗g5 ♘c6 22.♕f7 ♔h8 23.cd4 h6 24.♗e7 ♕e7 25.♕e7 ♘e7 26.♖f8 ♔h7 27.♖a8 c3∓ also leads nowhere.) 15...cd4 16.cd4 0-0 17.♕b1 ♗g5 18.fg5 ♗c6∓ Knaak-Gruenberg, Dresden 1985.

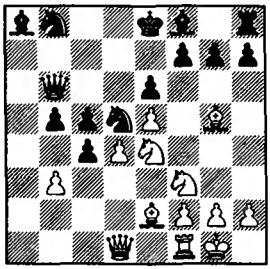
12...♕b6 13.♘e4 c5!?

Or 13...♘d7 14.b3! cb3 15.♕b3∞.



A model position for this line. It is true that Black's pawn shield around the king is still flawless, but it cannot last forever. A march of the h-pawn could provoke the needed weakness.

14.b3!

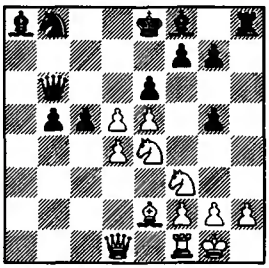


14...h6! Probably the only safe continuation. 14...c3 can be met by 15.♕a1 ♗c6 16.♘c3↑.

The attacking possibilities of White are illustrated by the following variations:

14...cd4 15.bc4 ♘b4 16.♘fd2 d3 (16...♘d7 17.cb5 d3 18.♘c4+–) 17.♗h5 ♗e4 18.♘e4 ♘d7 (18...bc4 19.♕g4 ♔d7 20.♗f7 h5 21.♕h3 ♘8a6 22.♖c1+–) 19.cb5 (19.♕f3!? ♘e5 20.♘f6 gf6 21.♕f6 ♖g8 22.♕e5→) 19...♕b5 (19...♘e5 20.♕a1+–) 20.♕f3 ♘e5 21.♘f6 gf6 22.♕f6+–.

15.bc4 hg5 16.cd5

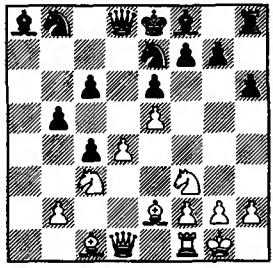


16...♗d5!

The seemingly neat 16...c4 is in fact a mistake: 17.♘fg5 ed5 (17...♗d5 18.♗h5 ♗e4 19.♗f7 ♔e7 20.♗e6 ♗d3 21.d5→) 18.♗h5 de4 (18...♕h6 19.♕g4 ♕h5 20.♕c8 ♔e7 21.h3+–) 19.♗f7 ♔e7 20.d5 ♕h6 21.d6 ♔d8 22.♘e6 ♔c8 23.h3+–

17.dc5 ♗c5 18.♕c2 ♗e4 19.♕e4↑. White still possesses the initiative, but the material is too reduced.

11.0-0 ♘e7



12.♘e4

On the ground of one unhappy game that went on 12.b3?, the whole plan with 9.e5!? was sentenced to oblivion.

We have here an example for the right idea in a wrong shaping. White not only fails to open the queenside but allows Black to consolidate it "for good": 12...♘d5 13.♘e4? (13.♕c2) 13...c3 14.♘e1 ♘d7 15.♕d3 b4 16.♕g3 g6 17.♗g4 ♕b6 18.♘f3 c5 19.♘d6 ♗d6 20.ed6 ♘5f6 21.♘e5 ♕d6 22.♘d7 ♕d7 23.♕b8 ♕d8 24.♕b5 ♔f8 25.♗h3 ♘d5 26.♕c5 ♔g7 27.♖e1 ♕f6 28.g3 ♕e7 29.♕a5 ♗c6 30.♕a2 ♖a8 31.♕e2 ♕f6 32.♕c4 ♖a2 33.♖f1 ♗b7 0–1 B. Vladimirov – Gusev Leningrad 1955.

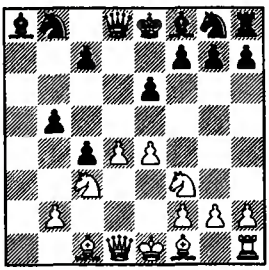
12...♘d5 13.♗d2! ♘d7 14.b3 ♘7b6

It seems suicidal to cling to the extra pawn. The following lines illustrate a straight way to Black's castle: 14...cb3 15.♕b3 ♗e7 Here Black's pawn is already on h6 and this unties White's hands for a direct assault. 16.♘e1 0-0 17.♕g3 ♔h8 18.♕h3 b4 [18...f5 19.♗h6 fe4 (19...gh6 20.♕h6 ♔g8 21.♘g3 ♘7f6 22.♘d3 ♕e8 23.ef6±) 20.♗d2 ♔g8 21.♕e6 ♔h8 22.♕h3 ♔g8 23.♗g4 ♘7b6 24.♗e6 ♖f7 25.♕f5 ♕f8 26.♕e4±] 19.♗h6 gh6 20.♕h6 ♔g8 21.♗d3 ♖e8 22.♘g3 ♗g5 23.♕h7 ♔f8 24.♘f3± with decisive attack.

15.bc4 (15.♗a5!?) **15...♘c4 16.♗c4 bc4 17.♕a4** (17.♕c2!?) **17...♗e7 18.♕c4 0-0±** Mellem – Raedisch, Kiel op 2000. Without the light-squared bishop the attack is not easy, but still White is in control.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 a6 4.e4 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3)

B. 8...e6



Black demonstrated with his last move that he is cautious. He is ready to return the gambit pawn, but to ensure fast development and a solid position without weaknesses. His chances for a full point are however minimal.

9.♘b5

9.♗g5?! This good positional idea is worthless here, since Black has not plugged yet his light-squared bishop.

9...♗e7

9...f6 is dubious. One can play such moves when there is nothing else. Nevertheless White has no straight refutation: 10.♕a1 (10.♗f4!?) 10...♘d7 11.♗f4 ♗b4 12.♗c7 ♕c7 13.♕a8 ♔f7 14.♘d2 ♕d6! (14...♘e7? 15.♕h8 ♕a7 16.♗e2 ♕a1 17.♘d1 ♘f8 18.e5 ♕c1 19.0-0 ♕d2 20.ef6 gf6 21.♗h5+– 1–0 Gofshtein – Donchenko, Belgorod 1989) 15.♗e2 ♕d4 16.0-0 ♕d2 17.♖d1 ♕b2 18.♖d7 ♗e7∓.

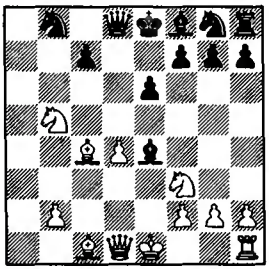
10.♗e7

Or 10.♕a1. White is trying to obtain some pluses by a direct onslaught on the queenside. It might have a sound tactical background, but at the end it all comes to a draw endgame. Probably this is the most White can hope for in this position. 10...♘d7 11.♘b5 ♗e4 12.♗f4 ♗f3 13.gf3 ♗b4 14.♔e2 e5 15.de5 ♘c5 16.♕a8 ♕a8 17.♘c7 ♔d7 18.♘a8 ♔c6 19.♗g2 ♘e7 20.♖a1 ♘d5 21.♗e3 ♘b3 22.♖d1 ♖a8 23.♖d5 ♖a2 24.f4 ♔c7 ½–½ Lazarev – Baburin, Budapest 1991.

10...♘e7 11.♕c2 c5! 12.♘b5 ♕a5 13.♘c3 cd4 14.♘d4 ♕a1 15.♘d1 0-0↑ D. Bischoff – Meister, Mengen 1990.

9...♗e4 10.♗c4

10.♗e2, intending to recapture the pawn on c4 with the knight, is against the common sense and eventually leads to the main lines, but losing a tempo – 10.♗e2 ♘f6 11.0-0 c6 12.♘c3 ♗d5 13.♘e5 ♗d6 14.♘c4 ♗c4 15.♗c4 ♕c7= Kiselev – Askarov, St. Petersburg 1999.



Black has to make up his mind here about his future plans. There are plenty of them:

1. To win the d4-pawn. It is very dubious.

2. Another plan is to part with the dark-squared bishop, keeping the other one. This way Black's castle is better protected and the c-pawn is not any more on an open file. Of course, there are no targets left for counterplay.

3. To keep his light-squared bishop, retreating it to g6. A sound idea, that promises Black good play. I found only one game, (though poorly played) but that is probably a matter of fashion.

4. Black is realistic and plays the safest way – the e4-bishop goes for the f3-knight, eliminating the potentially most dangerous attacker. The g8-knight will be heading for e7, and the centre will be reinforced by c7-c6. The arising positions leave White with very static pawn structure and some meagre hopes to mate Black's king (although he would need to produce a miracle to succeed). In fact the only approachable weakness in Black's set-up is the c-pawn, but it can be balanced with counterplay against White's pawns on b2 and d4.

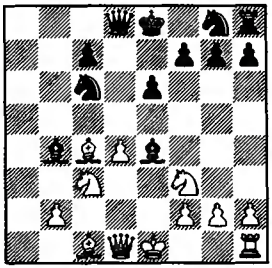
5. The same as (4), only Black's knight goes to f6. It allows a pin which is however harmless. The control of e4 is a plus.

6. None of the above! Even if Black fails to focus his mind on any plan, he can still hold the position. It is extremely difficult for White to draw some advantage of the 'sit-and-wait' tactic of the opponent.

B1. 10...♗b4 11.♘c3

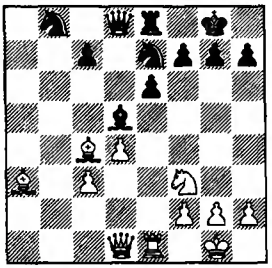
11.♔e2?! ♘e7 12.♗f4 0-0↑

11...♘c6? The shortest way to the d4-pawn and to defeat. We included it in the book for completeness sake. For 11...♘e7, see the next line.



12.0-0 ♗f3 13.♕f3 ♘d4 14.♕b7 ♗d6 15.♖d1 ♘f5 16.g4 ♘h4 17.♗b5 ♔f8 18.♗g5!+– 1–0 Krasenkow – Westerinen, Palma 1989.

B2. 10...♗b4 11.♘c3 ♘e7 12.0-0 ♗c3 13.bc3 0-0 14.♗a3 ♖e8 15.♖e1 ♗d5



16.♗b5!

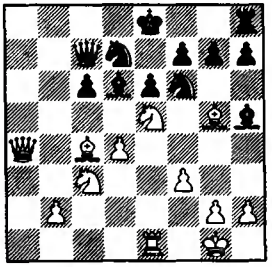
Suddenly Black encounters problems of (un)co-ordination. The innocuous 16.♗f1 levels the chances: 16...♘g6 17.♘e5 ♘e5 18.♖e5 ♘d7 19.♖e3 ♘b6 20.♖h3 ♗c4 21.♕h5 h6 22.♖g3 ♕f6 23.♖f3 ♕g6 24.♕g6 fg6=, Kohlweyer – Van der Sterren, Groningen 1989.

16...♗c6

Or 16...c6 17.♗f1 ♘g6 (17...♗f3 18.♕f3±) 18.♘d2 e5 19.c4 ♗e6 20.de5±.

17.♗e7 ♖e7 18.♗c6 ♘c6 19.♕a4 ♕d7 20.d5!↑.

B3. 10...♘f6 11.0-0 c6 12.♘c3 ♗g6 13.♖e1 ♕c7 14.♘e5 ♗d6 15.♗g5 ♗h5 16.f3 ♘bd7 17.♕a4



17...0-0=.

The game B. Jansen – T. Struik, Nijmegen 2001 saw 17...♘xe5?? which could have led to defeat. 18.de5 ♗c5 19.♔h1 ♘d7 20.♕a8! ♘b8 21.b4! ♗b4 (21...♗d4 22.♘b5 cb5 23.♗b5 ♔f8 24.♖c1+–) 22.♖b1 ♕e5 23.f4+–. Instead White erred decisively – 20.♘e4? 0-0 21.♕c2? (21.♘c5! ♘c5 22.♕b4 ♘b7 23.♖a1↑) 21...♗g6 22.♗d3 ♗b4 23.♘c3 ♘e5∓.

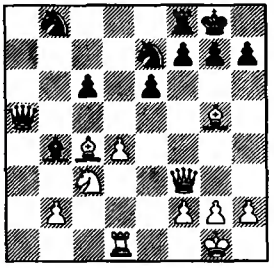
B4. 10...♗b4

Less precise is 10...♗f3 11.♕f3 ♗b4 since this move order allows also 12.♔e2!? ♘e7 13.♗f4 ♗a5 14.♖a1 ♗b6 15.♖a8 (15.♕b7 0-0 ½–½ Adler – Sulava, Budapest 1990) 15...0-0 16.♔f1±. 11...c6? would be a serious mistake: 12.0-0 ♕b6 (If Black accepts the piece, the remaining white forces exert terrible pressure: 12...cb5 13.♗b5 ♘d7 14.♗f4 ♘gf6 15.♖a1 ♘d5 16.♗d7 ♔d7 17.♖a7 ♔e8 18.♕d1±) 13.♗f4!? (This sacrifice does not leave Black any choice. He has to take the piece and suffer a crushing attack.

11.♘c3 ♘e7

The plan with 11...♗f3 12.♕f3 ♘f6 is considered in **B5**.

12.0-0 ♗f3 13.♕f3 0-0 14.♖d1 c6 15.♗g5 ♕a5



16.♘e4

16.h4 has also been tried. Not a bad move at all. White only should not forget that Black's castling position has no weaknesses, and a direct assault is most likely to fail: 16...♘d5 17.♘e4 ♗e7 18.♗d3 ♕d8 19.♕g3 ♔h8 20.h5 ♗g5 21.♘g5 h6 22.♘f7 ♖f7 23.♕g6 ♕g8 24.♕e6 ♘f4 25.♕e5 ♘d3 26.♖d3 ♕f8∓ Krutti – Izsak, 1995.

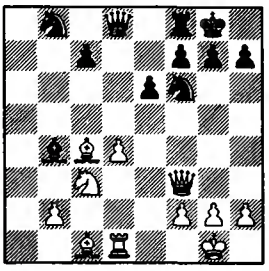
16...♘d7

It is debatable that the queen would be better placed on f5: 16...♕f5 17.♕e2 ♘d5 18.h4 ♘f4 19.♕f3 ♘h3 20.♕h3 ♕e4 21.♗d3 ♕d5 22.♕e3 ♗d6 23.♗c2 ♘d7 24.♖c1±, when White treads on the Achilles' heel in Black's set-up. The c6-pawn is not easy to defend. Gagarin – Shestakov, Moscow 1994

17.h4 ♘b6 18.♗d3 ♘bd5 19.♘g3 ♗d6 20.♕e4 g6 21.♕f3 ♖b8 22.♘e4 ♗c7 23.♗e7 ♘e7 24.♘f6 ♔g7 25.♘d7 ♖e8 26.♕f6 ♔g8

White's initiative is temporary and soon will evaporate. It is time for White to look for equalisation. Gagarin – Kachur, Katowice 1995.

B5. 10...♗b4 11.♘c3 ♘f6 13.0-0 0-0 14.♖d1



14...♘bd7

14...c6 looks too passive, but that could be proved only by a kingside attack. An appropriate manoeuvre would be 15.♗d3! and probably some drastic measures would have to be applied after 15...♕c7, like 16.♕h3 ♘bd7 17.g4∞.

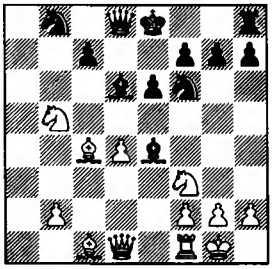
15.♗b5!?

In Inkiov – Raetsky, 1998, Black built a comfortable position after 15.♗g5 ♕a8 16.♕e2 ♕a5 17.♗d2 ♘b6 18.♖c1 ♖d8 19.♗e3 c5 20.dc5 ♗c5 21.♗d3 ½–½. White is trying to hinder this set-up.

15...♕a8 16.♗c6 ♕a5 17.♗f4 though 17...e5 18.♗g3 ed4 19.♘b5 ♗d6 does not promise him much.

B6. 10...♘f6 11.0-0 ♗d6

Black chooses the most natural way of developing his pieces. It is difficult to give White a sensible advice how to use his initiative. The pin is not very efficient.



12.♘c3 ♗b7 13.♕e2 0-0 14.♗g5 ♘bd7 15.♘e5 ♕a8 16.f4 ♗b4 17.♗d3 ♕a7 18.♔h1 ♕a8 19.♘d7 ♘d7 20.f5 ef5 21.♗f5 ♖e8 22.♕f2 ♘f8 23.♗d3 ♔h8 24.♗d2 ♖e6 25.♖g1 ½-½ Marszalek – Raszka, 1987.

Chapter 22

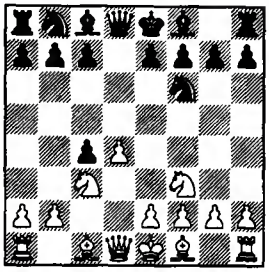
Conclusion

The 3...a6 system is a double-edged weapon in Black's repertoire. It sidesteps some White options, as the gambit 3...♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4, and 4.♕a4. If White tries to transpose to the Classical system by 4.e3, Black could switch to relatively unexplored lines by 4...b5, with a slightly inferior, but solid position.

White's most testing response is 4.e4!?. This is a real gambit, which leads to very sharp play. The price of every move increases and both players must demonstrate a good erudition and ingenuity.

The critical position arises after 4.e4 b5 5.a4 ♗b7 6.ab5 ab5 7.♖a8 ♗a8 8.♘c3 c6 when 9.e5 and 9.d5 are most dangerous for Black, although currently he appears to be in control.

8...e6 is quite dull, but White is still failing to find the keys to the black castle.



(D24)

A few decades ago, when the QGA was in the category of the second rate openings, this move was the number one candidate against Black's set-up. Nowadays its popularity has faded considerably. Not only has Black found new ideas, but he also possesses pleasant transpositions to other systems like the Slav Defence (4...c6) and Vienna Variation (4...e6 5.e4♗b4) where White's advantage is quite problematic. Even the Chigorin option 4...♘c6 raises a lot of complex questions. If Black dislikes all these possibilities, he could still play 3.♘f3 a6 which is intended directly against the 4.♘c3 system.

The Slav Defence and Vienna Variation lay beyond the scope of this book. They are covered in other volumes of CHESS STARS Openings series.

A. 4...c5;
B. 4...♘d5;
C. 4...a6

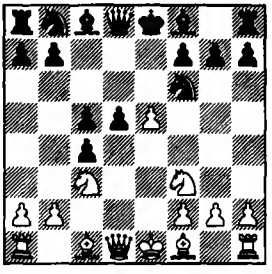
4...♗f5 leaves a lot of room for creativity. It leads to structures that resemble the Slav Defence. The absence of a4 and the resulting hole on b4 suggests somewhat better prospects for White, who can try 5.e3 or 5.♘e5, followed by f3.

A. 4...c5 5.d5 e6 (5...a6 6.e4!) **6.e4 ed5**

6...♘e4?! 7.♘e4 ed5 8.♘c3 ♗e6 9.♘g5 ♗e7 10.♘e6 fe6 11.g3±.

7.e5

7.ed5 a6 8.a4 ♗d6 is good for Black, e.g. 9.♕e2 ♗e7 or 9.♗c4 0–0 10.0–0 ♗g4.



A1. 7...♘e4
A2. 7...♘fd7

A1. 7...♘e4

This move is very popular lately. although in our opinion it is not entirely satisfactory. However, in practice White does not achieve much, probably because his effort is not applied in the right direction.

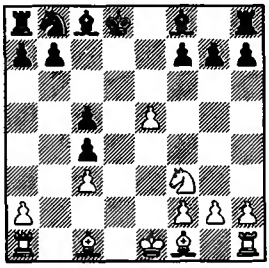
A1a. 8.♘e4?!; A1b. 8.♕d5; A1c. 8.♘d5!?

A1a.8.♘e4?! de4 9.♕d8 ♔d8 10.♘g5 ♗e6 11.♘e6 fe6 12.♗c4 ♘c6 13.♗f4 ♘d4

13...♔c7 offers White some practical chances with 14.♗e6 ♘d4 15.♗d5 ♘c2 16.♔e2 ♘a1 17.♖a1±. (Sulava)

14.0–0–0 ♔c7 15.♖he1 b5 16.♗f1 ♗e7 17.♖e4=, Stefanova – P. Cramling, Istanbul 2003.

A1b. 8.♕d5 ♘c3 9.♕d8 ♔d8 10.bc3



White has a small edge here, but it is very difficult to convert it. He advances on the kingside, trying to fix a target there.

10...♘c6

Black has also tried:

10...♗e6 11.♘g5 ♘d7 12.♘e6! (Inaccurate is 12.f4?! ♗d5 13.♗e3 ♘b6 14.0–0–0 ♔e8 15.f5 h6 16.♘f3 ♖d8 17.♗e2 ♗e4 18.e6 fe6 19.♘e5 ♖d1 20.♖d1 ♗f5 21.♗h5 g6 22.♘g6 ♗g6 23.♗g6 ♔e7∓) 12...fe6 13.f4 ♘b6 14.a4 a5, Mensch – Z. Nemeth, Budapest, 2001. White's further play is linked with g3, ♗h3, maybe h4-h5. He should watch out for Black's counterplay with ...♖d8-d3. As a whole, the initiative is on White's side.

10...h6, besides losing a tempo, is also a severe positional concession – 11.♗c4 ♗e6 12.♗e6 fe6 13.♘h4 ♗e7 14.♘g6 ♖e8 15.♗e3 b6 16.h4 ♘d7 17.h5±, Najer – Bezgodov, 56th Russian Championship 2003.

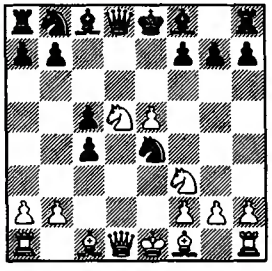
11.♗c4

11.♘g5 ♔e8 12.e6 turned bad for White after 12...f6!? 13.♘f7 ♗e6 14.♘h8 ♗d6↑ Bareev – Azmaiparashvili, Plovdiv 2003.

11...♗e6 12.♗e6 fe6 13.♘g5 ♔d7 (13...♔e7!?) **14.♗e3 ♘e5 15.0-0-0 ♔c6 16.♗f4 ♘g6 17.♗g3 e5 18.♘f7 ♖g8.**

The ending is easier for White, who is able to develop his initiative by 19.h4! h5 20.♖he1 ♗e7 21.♔c2 ♗f6 22.♗e5 ♘e5 23.♘e5 ♗e5 24.♖e5 ♖af8 25.f3 g6 26.♖e6 ♔c7 27.♖e7 ♔c6 28.♖e6 ♔c7 29.♖d5 ♖f5 30.♖ee5, Dreev – Azmaiparashvili, Dos Hermanas, 2001, when according to Dreev, 30.♖g6! ♖g6 31.♖f5 ♖g2 32.♔b3 ♔c6 (32...c4!? 33.♔c4 ♖a2 34.♖h5±) 33.♖h5 b5 34.a4± would have highlighted White's advantage.

A1c. 8.♘d5!?



This move is seldom seen, but it has more venom than the other alternatives. Despite the lenghty article of Sulava in New in Chess Yearbook, the truth for this line is still unclear. However Black's task seems quite complicated.

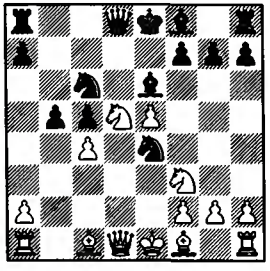
8...b5

Or 8...♘c6 9.♗c4 ♗e6 10.♕d3±, Malakhatko – Kamber, Zurich 2002.

8...♕a5 gives White some positional edge after 9.♗d2 (Sulava prefers 9.♘d2 ♘c6 10.♗c4 ♗e6 11.0-0 ♘d2 12.♗d2 ♕d8 13.♕b3±) ♘d2 10.♕d2 ♕d2 11.♔d2!? (White leads his king into the battle. The more conservative 11.♘d2 ♘a6 12.♗c4 ♗e6 13.0–0–0 is also in his favour, e.g. 13...0–0–0 14.♘e4 ♘b4 15.♘b4 ♖d1 16.♖d1 ♗c4 17.b3 ♗e6 18.♘d5±. White rules over 2/3 of the board.) 11...♘a6 12.♗c4 ♗e6 13.♔c3 0–0–0 14.♖hd1! (14.♖ad1 allows 14...b5! 15.♗b5 ♘b4 16.♘b4 cb4 17.♔c2 ♗c5=) After 14.♖hd1! 14...b5 already fails to 15.♗b5 ♘b4 16.♘f4! ♘a2 17.♖a2→.

9.b3 ♕a5

The game Malakhatko – Sulava, San Marino 2006 saw the novelty 9...♗e6 (or 9...♘c6 10.bc4 ♗e6) 10.bc4 ♘c6 (Sulava recommends to meet 10...bc4 11.♕a4 ♗d7 12.♕c4 ♗c6 with 13.♘e3±)



Here Malakhatko went astray with 11.♗d3? when 11...♕a5 gave Black at least equal chances. A sterner test of Sulava's idea is 11.♕c2! with two possible replies:

a) 11...bc4 12.♘e3 ♕a5 13.♘d2 f5 14.ef6 ♘f6. Sulava assesses this position as unclear, but White's pawn formation is much better. He only needs a few moves to consolidate: 15.♗c4 ♘d4 16.♕d1 ♗e7 (the fine point is that 16...♕c3 17.♗e6 ♕a1 fails to 18.♘b3 ♘b3 19.♗b3→) 17.0–0 ♗c4 18.♘ec4 ♕c7 19.♖e1±.

b) 11...♕a5 12.♘d2 f5 13.ef6 ♘d6 14.♗b2 Black's initiative is likely to disappear soon, leaving him without a pawn.

10.♗d2

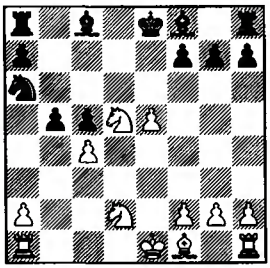
10.♘d2 encounters 10...♘c3! (10...♗b7 11.bc4 ♗d5 12.cd5±) 11.♘c4 bc4 12.♕d2! (Sulava. 12.♗d2 ♘d1 13.♗a5 ♘b2 14.♘c7 ♔d7 15.♘a8 ♘c6∓ favours Black) 12...♗e6 13.♗c4 ♘c6 14.♘c3 ♖d8 15.♕b2 with a tangled position.

10...♘d2

Unfortunately for Black, 10...c3 loses to 11.♗b5 (Sulava).

11.♕d2 ♕d2 12.♘d2 ♘a6 13.bc4±

Pein – Garcia Palermo, 1986.



White can meet 13...♗e6 with

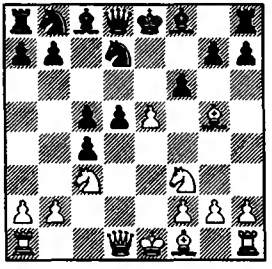
14.a3. His pieces are better co-ordinated.

A2. 7...♘fd7 8.♗g5

8.♕d5!? is less popular, but it is worth attention. After 8...♘b6 9.♕d8 ♔d8 10.♗e3 (10.♗g5 ♔e8) 10...♗e6 (or 10...h6 11.0–0–0 ♔e8 12.♘d2 ♗e6 13.♘de4 ♘a6 14.f4 with initiative) 11.0–0–0 ♔e8 the game Wojtaszek – Warakomski, Krakow, 2006 improved on Kasparov – Spangenberg, simul. Buenos Aires 1992 (12.♘g5 ♘c6 13.♘b5 ♖c8 14.♗e2, when 14...♘e5!? would have been the real test of White's plan – 15.♗f4 ♘d3 16.♗d3 cd3 17.♘c7 ♖c7∞) with 12.♘b5! ♘a6 13.♘g5 ♗d7 14.♘a3 and Black failed to solve the opening problems: 14...♗c6 15.♘c4 h6 16.♘a5 with a solid advantage. Black should have eaten a pawn, but 14...♘b4 15.♘c4 ♘a2 16.♔b1 ♘b4 17.♘e4 ♗f5 18.f3 ensures fair compensation: 18...♘c4 (18...♘c6 19.♘cd6 ♗d6 20.ed6 ♗e4 21.fe4 ♔d7 22.♗c5±) 19.♗c4 a6 20.g4 ♗e4 21.fe4 b5 22.♗d5 ♘d5 23.ed5.

8...♗e7

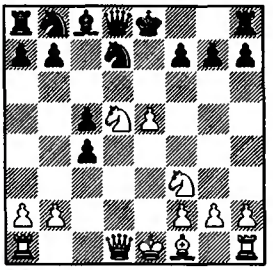
The exotic 8...f6 was killed by the idea of Ljubojevic:



9.♕d5!! fg5 10.0–0–0 (the same aim achieves 10.♗c4 ♕e7 11.♗b5 g4 12.e6 gf3 13.0–0–0 ♔d8 14.♖he1 ♕d6 15.♕g5 ♗e7 16.♕g4 h5 17.♕e4 ♘f6 18.♖d6 ♗d6 19.e7 ♔c7 20.♘d5 ♘d5 21.♕d5 ♗d7 22.♖d1 ♗f4 23.♔b1 fg2 24.♗d7 g1♕ 25.♕c5 ♘c6 26.♖g1 ♔d7 27.♕f5 1–0 Ljubojevic – Van Wely, Monte Carlo 1997) 10...♕e7 11.♘b5 ♘b6 12.♕e4 ♕f7 13.♘g5 ♕f5 14.♘c7 ♔e7 15.♕e3 ♘8d7 16.♘a8 ♘a8 17.g4 ♕g6 18.♖d6 ♘f6 19.♗c4 h6 20.♕c5 ♕g5 21.♖d2 1–0, Mamedyarov – Gouliev, Baku 2001.

9.♗e7 ♕e7 10.♘d5 ♕d8

If you ask somebody about this variation, he undoubtedly will inform you that it is notoriously bad for Black. In fact, no one can tell why. After its peak in the early 90-ies, it had nearly disappeared from tournaments, to come back again recently. White must really sweat out in order to obtain even the slightest advantage.



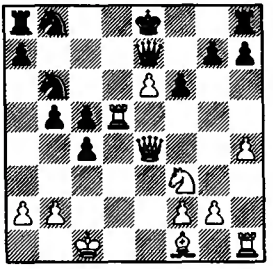
A2a. 11.♕c2; A2b. 11.♗c4

A2a. 11.♕c2 ♘b6!?

11...♕a5!?, which hampers the normal development of White, needs further inspection.

11...b5 12.0–0–0 ♗b7 appears

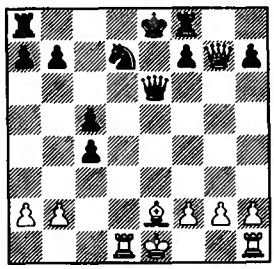
attractive. Indeed after 13.h4?! ♗d5 14.♖d5 ♕e7 15.♕e4 ♘b6 16.e6 f6□ White has to look for equalisation.



For instance, 17.♖h5 ♘a6 18.♕c6 ♔f8 19.♘e5 ♔g8□ 20.♘f7 g6□ 21.♖h3, Rychagov – Vaulin, St. Petersburg 1995, when 21...gh5!∓ would have held down White's attack. Also perspective is 17...h6!? or even 17...g6. More logical is to proceed in the diagram position with 17.h5 0–0 18.♘h4 ♘d5 19.♘f5 ♕c7 20.♕d5 ♘c6 and now White has to concede to perpetual check after 21.♕c6 ♕f4 22.♘e3 ♕f2, Jussupow – Seirawan, 1989, since 21.e7 ♖f7 22.♖h4 ♖e8 23.♖g4 ♖ee7 24.♖g7 ♔h8! 25.♘e7 ♖g7 26.♘c6 ♖d7∓ is outright dubious.

However the simple developing move 13.♗e2! casts a thick shadow over this line: 13...♗d5 14.♖d5 ♕c7 15.♕e4 ♘b6 16.♖d6 ♘8d7 17.♖hd1 0–0 18.♘g5 g6 19.♕h4 h5 20.♗h5 ♘e5 21.♗f3 f6 22.♖d7 ♘d3 23.♖1d3 1–0, Majer – Falk, Hessen 1991.

In spite of the rich practical material on 11...♘e5 12.♕e4 ♗e6 13.♕e5 ♕d5 14.♕g7 ♖f8 15.♖d1 ♕e4 16.♗e2 ♘d7 17.♘g5 ♕g6 18.♘e6 ♕e6, the most fair assessment of this position should be "unclear".

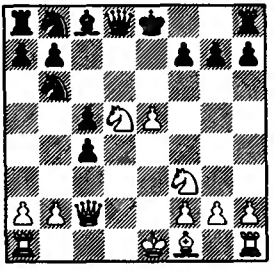


Still, White has a bigger choice, while Black is walking a tight rope. 19.0-0

The alternative is 19.♕g5 f6 20.♕h5 ♖f7 21.0–0 0–0–0 22.♖d6 ♕d6 23.♕f7 ♘e5 24.♕h7 ♕e6! 25.♕e4 ♖d4 26.♕e3 ♕f5 27.h4 b6 28.h5∞ J. Piket – E. Vladimirov, Rotterdam 1988.

19...0–0–0 20.♗g4 f5□ 21.♗h3! (21.♗f3?! ♕f6! 22.♗b7 ♔c7 23.♕f6 ♖f6⇄) 21...♘f6 22.♖de1!? ♕d5 23.♖e7 ♔b8 (23...♘h5 24.♕g5!) 24.g3 f4 25.♗e6 ♕f3 26.♗c4 h5 27.♕g5!, Levin – Bouton, Dortmund 1992. Black had to continue 27...fg3 28.fg3 ♖d1 29.♕e5 ♔a8 30.♕e2 ♖f1 31.♕f1 ♕f1 32.♗f1±, but pawns on both flanks considerably enhance the potential of White's bishop.

Let's return to 11...♘b6!

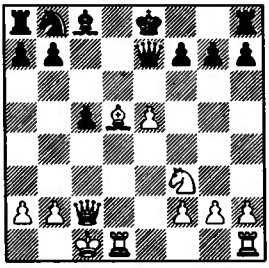


White's problem in this position

is that his main idea for crushing attack on Black's king is easily deflected. Other tries in the centre allow Black to sacrifice the c5-pawn, gaining a strong initiative. We believe, that in future we'll be seeing a gradually decreasing number of candidates to stay at White's side.

12.0–0–0 ♘d5 13.♗c4 ♕e7 14.♖d5?! 0–0 15.h4 (15.♗d3!?) ♘c6 16.♕e4 ♗e6 17.♘g5 g6 18.♘e6 fe6 19.♖d6 ♘d4 20.♖d1 ♖f2∓ (20...♔h8) 21.♔b1, Van Wely – Overeem, Haarlem 1995.

14.♗d5 is more realistic.



Black can overtake the initiative at the cost of two pawns: 14...♘c6 15.♗c6 bc6 16.♖d6 ♗e6 17.♕c5 0–0 18.♖c6 ♕b7 19.♔b1 ♖ab8 20.♕c3 ♖fd8⩲, Hynes – Ryan, Kilkenny 1997. Instead of blundering with 21.♖c7 ♕a6 22.a3 ♖d3 23.♖a7 ♕b6 –+ White could have eliminated all direct threats by 21.♔a1! ♖d3 (21...♗d5? 22.♖d6 ♖d6 23.ed6 ♕a6 24.♕a3±) 22.♕c2 ♗f5 23.♕c1∞, but still his play is far from easy.

Black could also look for improvements, for instance 20...♗d5!? 21.♖c5 (21.♖d6∞) ♖fc8 22.♖c8 ♖c8 23.♕e3 ♕a6 24.b3 ♕g6 25.♔a1 ♕g2 26.♖c1 ♖c1 27.♕c1 g6∓.

If you feel better with equal material, you could gamble with 14...0–0 15.h4 ♘a6 16.♘g5 g6 17.♕c3 ♘b4 18.a3 ♘d5 19.♖d5 ♗f5 20.g4 ♗d7 21.♘e4 ♗c6 22.♘f6 ♔h8 23.♕e3 ♔g7∞, Cramling – Blauert, Bern 1995, but here the chances to get mated are too real, though Cramling failed to materialise them.

A2b. 11.♗c4 ♘c6 12.♕e2!

The only way to aspire for an opening advantage. The other options are quite harmless:

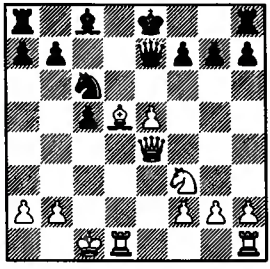
12.♕a4 ♘b6 13.♘b6 ♕b6 14.0-0-0 0-0 15.♖he1 (15.♖d6 ♕c7 16.♖hd1 ♕e7 17.♖e1 ♗f5=) ♗f5 16.e6 fe6 17.♗e6 ♗e6 18.♖e6=, P. Kiss – Vaulin, Zalakaros 1992.

12.0–0 0–0 (12...♘b6 13.♘b6 ab6 14.h3 ♕d1 15.♖fd1 ♗e6 16.♗e6 fe6 17.a3 ♔e7 18.♖d3 ½–½, Ricardi – Spangenberg, Buenos Aires 2000.) 13.♖e1 ♘b6 14.♘b6 ab6 15.♕d8 ♘d8 16.♘g5 ♘e6 17.♘e4 ♘d4 18.♖ac1 ♗e6 19.♗e6 fe6=, Pliasunov – Batsanin, Rybinsk 2001.

12...♘b6

12...♕a5?! encounters 13.b4! ♘b4 14.0–0 with a smashing attack.

13.0–0–0 ♘d5 14.♗d5 ♕e7 15.♕e4



15...♗d7

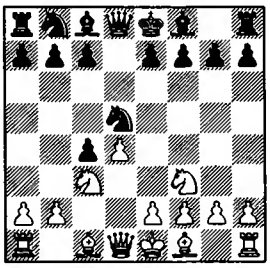
This is a rare, but natural plan. Black is preparing to evacuate the king on the queenside. The game Sulava – Arnold, Paks 2000 is a good example of the perils that are awaiting Black after short castling: 15...♘b4 16.♗c4 0–0?! 17.h4 ♖b8 18.♖d6! (It is important that White includes his rook into play before jumping with the knight. Another reason behind this move is to block the way of Black's queen to the queenside after a possible exchange of the bishops by ♗e6, followed by c5-c4.) 18...♔h8 19.♘g5 f5 20.♕f3 g6 21.♕f4 b5 22.h5 bc4 23.hg6+–.

16.h4 h6 17.♖he1 0–0–0 18.♘d2 (18.a3=)

The game is balanced, e.g. 18...♘a5 19.♖e3 ♗e6 20.♗e6 ♕e6 21.♕a4 ♘c6=, Gupta – Naumann, Niedersachsen, 1993.

B. 4...♘d5

The only reason to play such a move could be a wish to confuse the opponent and to escape from long forced lines in the main variation. Although such an approach could bring a good harvest of points, it cannot claim a praise. White's most reasonable response is to quickly regain the pawn, stake out his perimeter in the centre and place his pieces on good squares, cutting off any provocation. That puts Black in a cramped position without much hope for activity. Nowadays few players are ready to accept such a role in a good will.



5.e4!

White could also transpose to the 4.♕a4 system by 5.♕a4 ♘c6 6.♕c4, but 5.e4 is certainly more natural. Another point in its favour is the fact that Black could have chosen 4...♘d7 on the fourth move, practically forcing 5.e4 ♘b6.

5...♘b6 6.♗c4

6.♘e5 ♘c6! 7.♘c6 bc6 8.♗e3 g6 leads to double-edged play. White kept his two bishops, but exchanged one pair of knights, thus ensuring to his opponent more breathing space. Now White should have placed a rook to c1 and regain the pawn. Instead he ventured into a dubious attack:

9.h4?! h5 10.♗e2 ♗g7 11.♕d2?! e5 12.0–0–0 ed4 13.♗d4 ♗d4 14.♕d4 ♕d4 15.♖d4 ♗e6=, Praszak – Szymczak, Gdynia 1989.

6...♘c4 7.♕a4

7...♘d7 8.♕c4 ♘b6 9.♕d3 c6 10.0–0 g6 11.h3 ♗g7 12.♗f4 0–0 13.♖ad1 ♗e6 14.♖fe1 ♕d7 15.♕e3 f6 16.b3 ♖ad8±, Thomson – E. Shvidler, Thessaloniki 1988.

Here is another example where Black is trying to get counterplay: 7...c6 8.♕c4 b5 9.♕b3 a5 10.0–0 a4 11.♕c2 ♕a5 12.♗f4 ♗d7 13.♖ac1±,

Lin Weiguo – Ye Rongguang, Beijing 1992

It is not so important what exactly White will play. More vital is what he should not do:

7...c6 8.♕c4 g6 9.♘g5?! (9.h3) 9...e6 10.e5 ♗e7 11.♘ge4 b5 12.♕d3 b4 13.♘e2 ♗a6∞, W. Arencibia – Velikov, Cienfuegos 1989. Here White prematurely decided to redeploy his pieces before completing development.

7...♘d7 8.♕c4 ♘b6 9.♕b3 e6 10.0–0 ♗e7 11.a4?! 0–0 12.♗f4 f5 13.♖fe1 fe4 14.♖e4 ♘d5 15.♗g3 (15.♘d5! ed5 16.♖ae1 ♗f6 17.♗e5 c6 18.♖4e3±) 15...♗f6 16.♘e5 b6 17.♘g4 ♗b7 18.♖e6 ♗d4 19.♘e3 ♗c3 20.bc3 ♘e3 21.♖e3 ♔h8=, Pomar – Huebner, Buesum 1968. The same sin as in the previous example – White started an early operation (11.a4), but stopped on time. Later he tried to trade his knight for the black bishop, instead of aiming for a clearly better position with a knight vs. light-squared bishop.

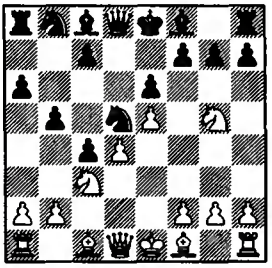
C. 4...a6 5.e4

Sometimes, when White is not confident in his home preparation, he chooses the bad move 5.a4. Black obtains good play by placing the knight to c6 and the bishop to g4.

5...b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4

Without a second front on the queenside White's attack is sterile: 7.♘g5 e6

More options to White offers 7...f6 8.♘ge4 (Alternatively: 8.♕f3 e6 9.ef6 ♕f6 10.♘d5 ed5 11.♕d5 ♗b4 12.♔d1 ♘c6 13.♗e3∞; 8.♘h3 ♗h3 9.♕h5 g6 10.♕h3 ♘b4∓, Edel – Bathke, Germany 1990; 8.♘d5 ♕d5 9.♗e2 c6 10.♗f3 ♕d8 11.ef6 ef6 12.♕e2 ♗e7 13.♘e6 ♗e6 14.♕e6 ♕d7 15.♕e2 0–0 16.0–0 ♖a7 17.a4∓ Rogers – Garcia Palermo, Dortmund 1985, 17...♗b4! intending ♖e8, ♕d8.) 8...♘c6! 9.♗e2 ♘db4 10.a3 ♘d3 11.♗d3 cd3 12.0–0 f5! 13.♘g5 ♘d4 14.♕d3 e6 15.♘e2 c5 16.♖d1 ♗e7 17.♘d4 cd4 18.♕f3∞, Manor – Zilberman, Ramat Aviv 2000.



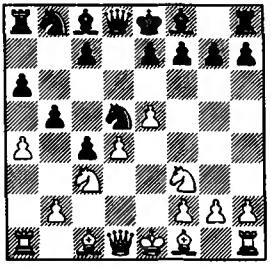
8.♕h5 ♕d7 9.♗e2

Bad is 9.♘d5 ed5 10.♘h7 ♗b4 11.♗d2 ♗d2 12.♔d2 ♕d8! 13.♗e2 ♘c6 14.♔e3 ♗e6 15.f4 g6 16.♕h6 ♕e7–+.

9...♗b7 (Black has good play anyway, so why to plunge into unnecessary complications of the sort of 9...♘b4 10.0–0! ♗b7 11.♘h7 ♘8c6 12.♘f6 gf6 13.♕h8 0–0–0 14.♕f6 ♘d4 15.♗h5 ♗e7⩱)

10.♗f3 g6 11.♕g4 b4 12.♘ce4 ♘c6 13.♗e3 h6 14.♘h3 0–0–0 15.0–0∞ Petursson – Zaltsman, Reykjavik 1984.

After 7.a4 Black has eight (!) main options. We shall examine five of them:



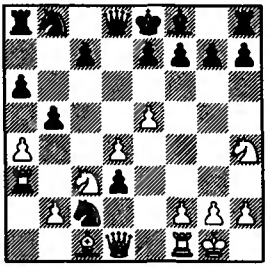
C1. 7...♘b4?!
C2. 7...c6
C3. 7...♗b7!?
C4. 7...♘c3

The most fashionable 7...e6 is the subject of Chapter 24.

C1. 7...♘b4?!

There has always been some mystification about this variation. Tournament testing is definitely in White's favour, while commentators quite elusively use terms like "with wild complications" and similar non-committing evaluations. Indicative is the game Ehlvest – Sadler, FIDE World ch. Groningen 1997 which quickly finished with a repetition of moves. However the last word was for White.

8.♗e2 ♗f5 9.0-0 ♘c2 10.♖a2 ♘b4 11.♖a3 ♘c2 12.♘h4 ♗d3 13.♗d3 cd3



In Sitnik – Glavas, Opatija 2002 White unexpectedly presented Black with very bad news:

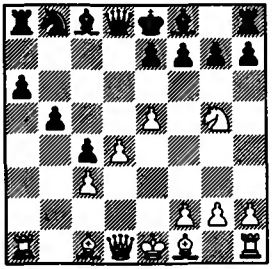
14.♕f3!! which took the opponent unawares. The old line was 14.e6 fe6 15.♕h5 ♔d7!? (15...g6 16.♘g6 hg6 17.♕h8 b4 18.♕g8!) 16.♖a2 (16.♘e4↑) 16...b4 17.♘e4 ♔c8 18.b3 ♘c6 19.♘g5∞, Kahn – Naes, Budapest 2000.

14...♘d7 15.♘d5 c6 16.e6+–.

Apparently 14...♖a7 15.e6 fe6 16.♕h5 g6 17.♘g6 hg6 18.♕h8 b4 19.♖b3 bc3 20.♗h6+– is also grim, so 14...c6 looks like the only move. White could follow 15.ab5 ♘a3 16.e6 fe6 17.bc6 ♕c7 18.♕h5 g6 19.♘g6 hg6 20.♕h8 ♘c6 21.ba3 forcing Black into a ruined pawn structure without any material consolation.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4)

C2. 7...c6 8.ab5 ♘c3 9.bc3 cb5 10.♘g5



Black has several ways to avoid the double attack ♕f3. In all cases White obtains good compensation for the sacrificed pawns after 11.e6. It is often good to throw in also the d-pawn (by d5) in order to open

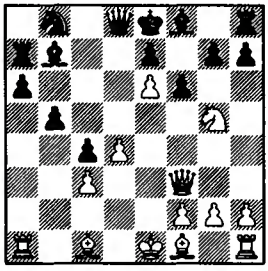
central files. Another attacking possibility is ♕h5, followed by ♘g5-h7-f6 and ♕h8. Beware of it! In this case White loses the initiative which could be lethal.

The novelty of Naes 10...♕c7?! 11.♕f3 e6 12.♘f7 ♗b7 13.♘d6 ♗d6 14.ed6 ♕f7 15.♕g3 0–0 16.♗e2 ♗d5↑, Gerstner – Naes, Ubeda 2000 is not worth much in view of the standard 11.e6! ♗e6 12.♘e6 fe6 13.♗e2↑ – the most dangerous threats are awaiting Black after White castles and brings the rooks to the centre.

To a similar pattern leads 10...♖a7 11.e6! ♗e6 12.♘e6 fe6 13.♕h5 ♔d7 14.♗e2 ♕e8 15.♕h3 g6 16.d5 ♔d8 17.♗e3 ♖b7 18.♗d4 ♖g8 19.♕e6 ♗g7 20.♗b6 ♖b6 21.♕b6 1–0, Knaak – Efimov, Berlin 1989.

C2a. 10...f6; C2b. 10...♗b7

C2a. 10...f6 11.♕f3 ♖a7 12.e6 ♗b7



12...♕b6?! 13.d5 fg5 14.♗e3 (14.♕f7 ♔d8 15.♗g5 ♖d7!! 16.ed7 ♘d7 17.♗e2 h6 18.♗e3 ♕f6 19.♕f6 ef6 20.♗g4 ♗b7∓ Sosonko-Rivas, Amsterdam 1978) 14...♕c7 15.♗e2 ♖b7 (15...♘d7 16.♕f7 ♔d8 17.ed7 ♗d7 18.0–0 ♖a8 19.♗f3 ♕d6 20.♗g5± Knaak – Thormann, DDR 1980) 16.g3 ♖b6 17.h4 g4 18.♕f7 ♔d8 19.h5 h6 20.0–0 ♗b7 21.♗b6+– Langeweg – Witt, Holland 1982.

13.♕f4

Unclear is 13.d5 ♕d5 (13...♗d5 14.♕e3 ♘c6 15.♘f7 ♕c8 16.♘h8 ♕e6 17.♕e6 ♗e6 18.♗e3 ♖a8 19.h4±, Vaiser) 14.♕d5 ♗d5 15.♗e3 fg5! (15...♖b7? 16.0–0–0+– Vaiser-Vera, Berlin 1982) 16.♗a7 ♘c6 17.♖a6 ♘a7 18.♖a7 ♗e6± Vaiser. White could try 19.h4! joining his second rook to the battle.

13...♕c8

Or 13...♕d6 14.♘f7 ♕e6 15.♗e3 ♔f7 16.♕b8 ♕b6 17.d5 ♖a8 18.♕f8 ♖hf8 19.♗b6 ♗d5 20.♗a5± Sulava – Ne. Nikolic, Yugoslavia 1990.

14.d5 ♗d5 15.♗e3

15.♕d4 fg5 (15...♕b7!?) 16.♕d5!?∞ is worth consideration, but not 16.♕a7? g6 17.♗g5 ♕e6 18.♗e3 ♘c6 19.♕a6 ♗g7 20.♖c1 0–0 21.♕b5 ♘e5∓ Kir. Georgiev – Murshed, Novi Sad 1990.

15...♖b7

15...♖a8? 16.♕f5 ♕c6 17.0–0–0 +– Webb – Bernard, Polonia 1978.

16.♕f5 ♕c6 17.0–0–0 g6 18.♕d5 ♕d5 19.♖d5 fg5 20.♗d4

It is never late for going astray: 20.♖c5? ♔d8 21.♗e2 ♖c7 22.♖d5 ♔c8 23.♗b6 ♖c6, Hoerstmann – Schlaeger, Germany 1997, 23...♗g7!∞.

20...♖g8 21.♗e2 ♘c6 22.♖c5 ♖c7 23.♗f3 ♘d4 24.♖c7 ♘e6 25.♖c8 ♔d7 26.♗g4±, Timoshchenko – Haritonov, Irkutsk 1983.

C2b. 10...♗b7 11.e6 f6 12.♘f7 ♕c8 13.♘h8 ♕e6 14.♗e2

Se. Ivanov suggests 14.♗e3 g6 15.h4 ♗g7 16.♘g6 hg6 17.h5±.

14...♗g2 15.♖g1 ♗e4, Se. Ivanov – Tyrtania, Berlin 1992. The position is not easy for evaluation. The game went **16.♗e3?!** g6 17.♗f3 ♘d7 18.♘g6 hg6 19.♖g6 ♘b6 20.♗e4 ♕e4∞.

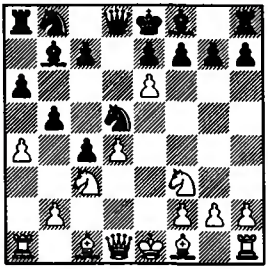
We think that White can be more precise: **16.♗g4!** ♕c6 17.f3 ♗d3 (17...♗d5 18.♕c2 g6 19.♘g6±) 18.♔f2 g6 19.f4 f5 20.♗f3 ♗e4 21.♗e4 ♕e4 22.♘g6 hg6 23.♖g6 ♘d7 24.♖ga6 ♖a6 25.♖a6 ♘f6 26.♖f6 ef6 27.♕e2±.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4)

C3. 7...♗b7!?

This option is undeservedly out of fashion. White is still to determine his best path amongst the jungle of variations. Indicative is the fact that in the last ten years Black scored 6 out of 9, according to our database.

8.e6



C3a. 8...f6, C3b. 8...fe6!

C3a. 8...f6

This frequently seen move looks like a misunderstanding, but also faces White with important decisions to make.

9.♘e4!?

Slower, but consistent is 9.♗e2 g6 (9...♘c3 10.bc3 ♕d5 11.0–0 ♕e6 12.♖e1 g6 13.♘h4 ♕d7 14.♗g4 f5 15.♗f3 ♘c6 16.♗a3 e6 17.d5±, Lin Weiguo – Adianto, Beijing 1992) 10.0–0 ♗g7 11.♘e4 ♘b6 12.♘c5 ♗d5 13.♖e1 0–0 14.♗f4 ♘c6 15.a5 ♘c8=, Nemet – Adianto, New York 1994. Probably White should think about including fresh forces in the attack. That could be accomplished by ramming Black's kingside by h4-h5. Also useful would be to open the a-file. In that case Black's king would not be able to castle long. Here is a concrete example: 9.♗e2 ♘c3 10.bc3 g6 11.h4!? ♕d5 12.h5 ♖g8 13.hg6 hg6 14.♘h4, Dreev – Galliamova, Rostov na Donu 1993, 14...g5!∞ – Dreev.

9...♘e3

9...♘b4 does not solve all the problems – 10.♘c5 ♗f3 11.gf3 ♘8c6 12.♗e3 ♘d4 13.♗d4 ♕d4 14.♕d4 ♘c2 15.♔d2 ♘d4 16.♔c3±, B. Vladimirov – Matulovic, Sochi 1966.

It would be interesting to try 9...♘b6. Then 10.♘c5 could be followed by 10...♗f3 11.gf3∞ or 10...♗d5, similar to the game Nemet – Adianto – see below.

10.♗e3 ♗e4 11.♘d2 ♗d5 12.ab5

Or 12...e6 13.ba6 ♘a6 14.♖a6! ♖a6 15.♕h5+–.

12...ab5 13.♖a8 ♗a8 14.♕h5 g6 15.♕b5±, Vaisser – Romanishin, Kiev 1973.

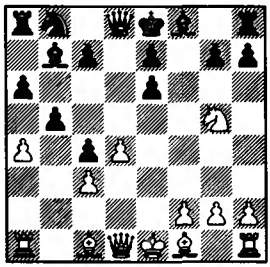
C3b. 8...fe6! 9.♘g5

White has no time for 9.♘e4. In P. Cramling – Karpatchev, Os-

terskars 1995 was 9...♘b6 10.♘c5 ♗d5 11.♘e5 g6 12.♕g4 and White had the upper hand, but 10...♗f3! 11.♕f3 ♕d4 12.♘e6 ♕e5 13.♕e2 ♕e2 14.♗e2 ♔f7 15.♘c7 ♖a7= would have equalised. Even stronger is 9...♘b4! 10.♘c5 (or 10.♘eg5 ♕d5 11.♗e2 ♘8c6 12.♗d2 h6∓) 10...♗f3 11.gf3 ♘8c6 12.♘e6 ♘d4 13.♘d4 ♕d4 14.♕d4 ♘c2 15.♔d1 ♘d4 16.ab5 a5∓.

9.♗e2!? ♘c3 10.bc3, when probably the only move is 10...g6∞, may prove to be unpleasant for Black.

9...♘c3 10.bc3



10...♕d6

Black has also tried 10...♕d5 11.♗e2! (11.0–0 ♘c6! 12.ab5 ab5 13.♖a8 ♗a8 14.♖e1 g6∓, Mamedyarov – Zhang Pengxiang, Dubai 2005) 11...♕g2 12.♖f1, when 12...♗d5 13.ab5 g6!? (13...ab5 14.♖a8 ♗a8 15.♗g4 ♗d5 16.♗f4±) 14.ba6 ♗h6 (14...♗g7 15.♘e6 ♗e6 16.♗f3 ♕h3 17.♗a8 ♕c3 18.♗d2 ♕d4 19.a7±) 15.♘e6 ♗c1 16.♘c7 ♔d8 17.♘d5 ♕d5 18.♕c1 ♖a6 19.♖a6 ♘a6 20.♕a3 ♘c7 21.♕b4 was in White's favour in, Vranesic – Clarke, Havana 1966, but 12...♘d7! defends successfully.

11.♕g4 ♘d7 12.♗f4 ♘f6 13.♗d6 ♘g4 14.♗c7 h6 (14...♘f6 15.f3 ♗d5=) **15.♘e6 ♔d7 16.♘f8 ♖hf8**=, Lehmann – Van Scheltinga, Beverwijk 1966.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4)

C4. 7...♘c3 8.bc3

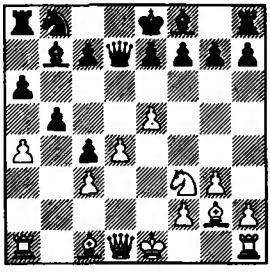
Lately Black has been avoiding this position, although we are unable to show a clear advantage for White.

C4a. 8...♕d5; C4b. 8...♗b7!?

C4a. 8...♕d5 9.g3 ♗b7

We'll note for the record only the old variation 9...♗e6 10.♗g2 ♕b7 11.0–0 ♗d5 12.e6! ♗e6 (12...fe6 13.♘h4 g6 14.♖e1 ♗g7 15.♕g4 0–0 16.♕e6 ♗e6 17.♗b7 ♖a7 18.♗g2 ♗d7□ 19.ab5 ♗b5 20.♗a3±) 13.♘e5! ♗d5 (13...c6 14.♕h5! g6 15.♘g6 fg6 16.♕e5+–) 14.♗d5 ♕d5 15.ab5 f6 16.♘g4! ♕b5 (16...ab5 17.♘e3 ♕b7 18.♖a8 ♕a8 19.♕h5+–) 17.♕f3 c6 18.♘e3!+–, Chernin – A. Mikhalchishin, Lvov, 1987.

10.♗g2 ♕d7



11.♗a3

The typical sacrifice 11.e6!? might soon become White's weapon of choice. It is employed by such a theoretician as Beliavsky. Current

practice is definitely alarming for Black. He must probably look for early improvements after 11...♕e6 12.♗e3. Perhaps 12...h6!? 13.0–0 (13.♘g5 ♕c8 14.♗h3 ♘d7) 13...♘d7 14.♖e1∞, trying to stay with the queen in the centre, is a plausible alternative to 12...♕c8?! 13.d5 ♘d7 (13...c6 14.♘e5!) 14.0–0 ♘f6 15.♘e5 e6 16.de6 fe6 17.♗g5 ♗d6!□ (Illescas' suggestion 17...♗g2?! 18.♗f6 h5 is quite dubious due to 19.♗g5! ♗d6 20.♘g6 ♗f1 21.♘h8 ♔d7 22.♘f7 ♗d3 23.♕f3 with a strong attack) 18.♗f6 0–0! 19.♗g7 ♔g7 20.♕g4 ♔h8 21.♗b7 ♕b7±, Beliavsky – Illescas Cordoba, Linares 1995.

Instead of the second sac, 11.0-0?! e6 should be fine for Black.

In practice White has also tried 11.♘h4?! ♗g2 12.♘g2, when 12...b4 takes over the initiative.

11...g6

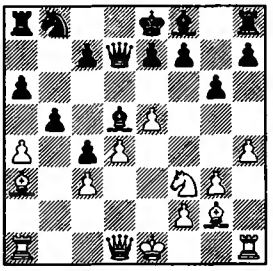
There is no doubt that 11...e6?! 12.♗f8 ♔f8 13.0–0 g6 14.♘g5 or 14.♘h4 gives White an excellent compensation. In a number of games Black sufferd after 11...♗d5 12.0–0 ♘c6 13.♖e1 g6 14.e6→.

12.0–0

Apparently 12.h4 ♗d5 allows Black to maintain the balance. His idea is to keep the king in the centre as long as possible, where it is better placed in an eventual ending. Meanwhile Black is redeploying his queenside following the scheme ♗d5, ♘c6-a5-b3.

The common move 12...♗g7 is also unclear. In this case the discussion is turning around whether White should exchange early on g6, offering the enemy chances along the f-file, or must wait for the best moment, having in mind also h5-h6: 12...♗g7 13.h5 0–0 14.♔f1 ♗d5 15.hg6 fg6 16.♘g5 ♗g2 17.♔g2 ♕d5 18.♔g1 h6 19.♕c2 hg5 20.♕g6=.

Now back to 12...♗d5:



13.h5 ♘c6 14.hg6

Or 14.♔f1!? ♘a5 15.hg6 fg6 16.♘g5 ♗g2 17.♔g2 ♕d5 18.♕f3 ♕f3 19.♔f3 ♘b3 20.♖a2 h5 21.♘e6 ♔d7 22.♘f4 ♖h6 23.♗c1⩲.

14...fg6 15.0–0! ♗h6, Filippov – G. Flear, Reykjavik 1999. Now White should not hesitate to open files by 16.e6 ♕e6 (17.♘h2 ♕e6 18.♖e1 ♕f7 19.♗d5 ♕d5 20.♘g4 ♗g7 21.♘e3 ♕f7 22.f4 0–0 23.♕f3↑) 17.♖e1, but 17...♕f6! 18.♘e5 ♗g2 19.♔g2 ♘e5 20.♖e5 0–0 21.f4 (Rizzitano) is enough only to compensate for the missing pawns.

12...♗g7 13.♖e1

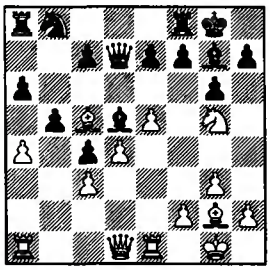
Here 13.e6 is one move either too late or early! 13...fe6 14.♘e5 ♕c8! 15.♗b7 ♕b7 16.♕g4 ♗e5 17.de5 ♕c6 18.ab5 ab5 19.♕h4 0–0 20.♗e7 ♘d7↑.

13...0–0 14.♗c5

14.e6 is insufficient for an advantage: 14...fe6 15.♘e5 ♕c8 16.♗h3 ♗d5 17.♗e7 (17.♕d2 ♕e8! 18.♘g4∞

– Ibragimov) 17...♖e8 18.♗g5 ♘d7 (Perhaps 18...c5!? is better) 19.♘g4 ♕b7 20.♘h6 Here Black can choose to repeat moves by 20...♔h8 or to accept the risk of playing a very complex position with some initiative with White after 20...♗h6 21.♗h6 b4 22.cb4 ♕b4 23.♖b1 ♕d6 24.♕d2 ♖ab8∞, Arbakov – Mchedlishvili, Ohrid 2000.

14...♗d5 15.♘g5



Black is at a juncture.

Zakharstov – Ibragimov, Smolensk 1991 went on with 15...♘c6 16.e6 fe6 17.♕g4 ♗g2 18.♔g2 ♕d5, when instead of 19.f3? e5 20.♘e6 ed4 21.cd4 b4 22.♘c7 h5∓ (Rizzitano suggests 23.♕g6, but the reason behind this move evades us as 23...♕f3 24.♔g1 ♖f6 25.♕c2 ♖c8 obviously favours Black), White should have swapped queens with an excellent compensation: 19.♕e4 ♕e4 20.♖e4 e5 21.d5 ♘a5 22.♗e7 ♖fe8 23.ab5 ab5 24.♗b4±. All white pieces are very active. It is better first to trade bishops:

15...♗g2 16.♔g2 ♘c6

In the game Zakhartsov – Tenikashvili, Moscow 2006, Black opted for 16...h6? which turned badly after 17.♕f3 c6 18.♘h3 g5 19.♕e4 ba4 20.f4 g4 21.♘f2 h5 22.f5↑.

16...♕d5 17.♘e4 ♘c6 18.♕f3 underlines the shaky state of the d5-queen. On the central square it is running the risk to be captured or even swapped! Without queens White's initiative develops easier: 18...♔h8 19.♘g5! ♕f3 20.♘f3 with overwhelming spatial advantage. 18...♕d7 is somewhat better try, but 19.♖eb1 ♖ab8 20.ab5 ♖b5 21.♗a3 retains unpleasant pressure.

17.e6!

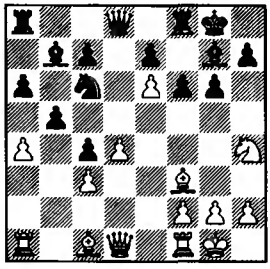
17.♕f3 allows 17...b4 with sufficient counter-chances.

17...♕d5 18.♕f3 ♕f3 19.♘f3 ♗f6 20.♘d2⩱.

The e7-point is difficult to defend.

C4b. 8...♗b7!? 9.e6 fe6

9...f6 10.♗e2 (10.g3 ♕d5 11.♗g2 ♕e6 12.♗e3 has been always assessed as promising for White, but computer analysis suggests good counter-chances after 12...b4∞) 10...g6!? is also playable (Black is best off when developing as fast as possible. 10...♕d5 is dubious due to 11.0–0 ♕e6 12.♖e1↑ intending ♘h4, ♗g4) 11.0–0 ♗g7 (11...♗d5 12.ab5 ab5 13.♖a8 ♗a8 14.♗f4 ♗g7 15.♕a1⩱) 12.♘h4 0–0 13.♗f3 ♘c6



We see a typical for this line position with mutual chances. White has sufficient compensation for the pawn, but if he decides to regain it, Black gets a respite. Perhaps the best tactic is to keep tension with 14.♗a3↑. Instead in Magerramov – Savon Moscow 1991 was 14.♖b1 ♘a5 15.♗b7 ♘b7 16.ab5 ♘d6 17.ba6 ♖a6=. The proud e6-pawn is already more of a weakness than an asset.

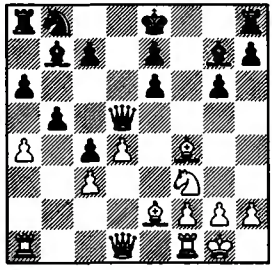
10.♗e2

10.♘e5 is well met with both 10...♕d5 or 10...g6=. 10.♗f4 is parried by 10...♕d5 11.♗c7 ♘d7 12.h4 g6 13.h5 ♗g7 14.♗e2 0–0 15.hg6 hg6 16.♘h4 e5 17.♗f3 ♕f7∓, Lazarev – B. Kogan, Kiev 1963. About 10.♘g5= – see the diagram in C3b.

10...g6 (if 10...♕d5 11.♘g5= – see C3b.) **11.0–0**

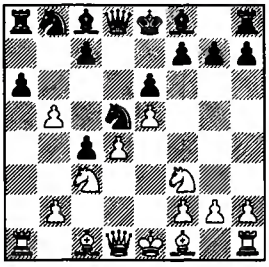
11.♘g5 ruins White's kingside without obtaining any benefits in exchange – ♗g2 12.♖g1 ♗d5 13.ab5 (13.♗g4 ♕d6 14.♕e2 ♗h6 15.♗e6 ♗g5 16.♗d5 ♕d5 17.♗g5 0–0∓) 13...♕d6∞

11...♕d5 12.♗f4 ♗g7=/∞.



White has some compensation, but apparently nothing substantial.

Chapter 24



In the diagram position Black has two good options: 8...♗b4 and the fashionable 8...♘b6. The latter is quite reassuring for Black, if he would like to avoid possible traps or home preparation. He only must remember to take on b5 as early as possible, as suggested in B4b and B5b. Afterwards, even if he loses the c4-pawn, White's advantage is seldom enough for a full point.

A. 8...♗b4!?
B. 8...♘b6

A. 8...♗b4 9.♕c2

9.♗d2 ♘b6 is fine for Black. We'll note here the main options of White:

Ward – Ganguly, Torquay 2002: 10.b3 ♗b7! 11.ba6 (11.bc4 ♗f3) 11...♗f3 12.♕f3 ♕d4.

Lobron – Sasikiran, Blitz 2004: 10.ba6 ♖a6 11.♖c1 (11.♖a6 ♗a6 12.♗e2 0-0) 11...♗b7 12.♗e3, when 12...♘a4 13.♗c4 ♘b2 14.♕b3 ♗c3 15.♕c3 ♘c4 16.♕c4 ♗f3= would have been good for Black.

Hillarp Persson – Svensson, Malmo 2004: 10.h4 ♗b7 11.ba6 ♖a6 12.♖a6 ♘a6 13.♗e3 0–0 14.♖h3 c5↑.

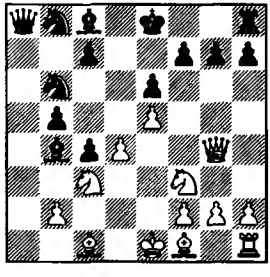
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4 e6 8.ab5

(D24)

9...♘b6 10.♕e4

The current status of this line is fine for Black, so White is looking for new ideas. However 10.ba6 ♖a6 11.♖a6 ♘a6 12.♗e3 is not too impressive. Black has comfortable places for all his pieces after 12...♗b7 13.♗e2 ♗e7! when 14.♗c4 would stumble into 14...♘c4 15.♕a4 ♕d7 16.♕c4 ♘b4, whereas 14.0–0 0–0 15.♘e4 ♘b4 16.♕b1 is met by 16...♕a8 17.♘c5 ♗d5. Note that 13...c5? is premature in view of: 14.dc5 ♗c5 15.♗c4 ♘c4 16.♕a4±, Vallejo Pons – Yakovich, Moscow 19.02.2007.

10...♕d5 11.♕g4 ab5 12.♖a8 ♕a8



13.♗e2

This variation is a patent of the GM from Novosibirsk Alexander Fominyh. Its tactical foundation is

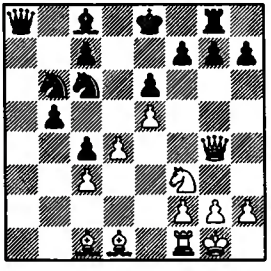
the fascinating rook sacrifice 13.♕g7 ♕a1!! Let's draw straight from the source: 14.♕h8 ♔d7 15.♔d1 ♗c3 16.bc3 ♘d5 17.♕h7 ♘c3 18.♔d2 ♘c6 19.♕c2 ♘a4 20.♗c4 (20.d5?! ♘b4! 21.de6 ♔e7!–+, Semenov – Fominyh, USSR 1988). 20...bc4 21.♕c4 ♘b6! 22.♕c3 ♕a2 23.♕c2 ♕a5 24.♕c3 ♘c4=. Komarov – Fominyh, Cairo 2001. White had a chance to force a draw by perpetual check after 25.♔d3 ♕b5. Instead, he succumbed to a mating attack – 25.♔c2? ♘b4.

13...♖g8

Kasparov grants an exclamation mark to this move. The newer idea 13...♔f8!? is also worth consideration. It aims to defend the g7-pawn without failing under a crushing attack in case of castling. 14.0–0 ♗c3 15.bc3 h6 16.♕h4 ♘c6 17.♘g5 ♘e7 18.♗f3 ♘bd5 19.♕h5, Najer – Torbin, Togliatti 2001. Now Black could have entrenched himself by 19...g6! 20.♕h3 ♔g7 21.♘e4 ♗b7∞, and White still has to sweat his way up to Black's king.

13...♘d5?! 14.♕g7 ♖f8 15.0–0 was disastrous for Black in Sakaev – Kharlov, Budapest 1996.

14.0–0 ♗c3 15.bc3 ♘c6! 16.♗d1!



16.♘g5 h6 17.♘h7 ♘e7 18.♗h6 gh6 19.♘f6 ♔f8 20.♘h7= leads to a draw, while stepping back could lose the initiative – 17.♘e4 ♘e7 18.♘c5 ♘bd5 19.♗f3 ♕a5 20.♗e4 ♔f8 21.♗d2 ♕a2∞, Zakharevich – Stjazhkina, St Petersburg 1999.

16...♘e7

In Sakaev – Yakovich, Krasnoyarsk 2003, Black attempted 16...♘d5, when 17.♗c2!? would have been most testing. Since 17...g6 18.♘g5↑ cannot make Black happy, he must play 17...♘c3, exposing himself to a (possibly!) crushing attack after 18.♗h7 ♘e2 (18...♖f8 19.♗d2 ♕a3 20.♕g7± ♘e2 21.♔h1 ♘cd4 22.♘d4 ♘d4 23.♖d1!+–) 19.♔h1 ♖f8 20.♗d2!± g6 (20...c3 21.♗d3±) 21.♗g6! fg6 22.♕g6 ♔d7 23.d5!→ (23.♕g7 ♘e7! 24.♕f8 ♗b7!∞).

17.♗c2 ♗b7!

Suggested by Kasparov.

17...♘f5?! 18.♘g5 h6 19.♘e4 ♔f8 was seen in Kasparov – Timman, Prague 1998 where instead of 20.♘c5? Kasparov proposes the forced variation 20.♘g3! ♘e7 (20...♕c6 21.♘f5 ef5 22.♗f5 ♗f5 23.♕f5±; 20...♘d5 21.♘f5 ef5 22.♗f5 ♔e7 23.♖e1→) 21.♘h5 ♘f5 22.d5! ♘d5 23.♗f5 ef5 24.♕d4 ♖h8 (24...♕c6 25.♖d1 ♗e6 26.♘f4+–; 24...♔e8 25.♕c5!) 25.e6 ♖h7 26.♕c5 ♔g8 27.ef7 ♔f7 28.♕b5→.

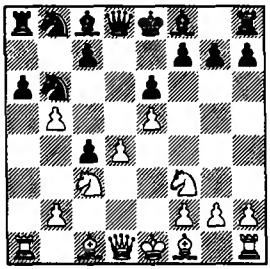
After the text Black is out of danger:

18.♗h7 ♗f3 19.gf3 ♖h8! 20.♕g7 ♖h7 21.♕h7 ♕f3↑

It is not so easy for White to make a draw. Black's knights combine their power with the queen to

ensure a long term compensation for the exchange.

B. 8...♘b6!?



B1. 9.♘g5?!
B2. 9.b3
B3. 9.ba6
B4. 9.♗e2
B5. 9.♗e3

B1. 9.♘g5?! h6! 10.♘ge4

Kramnik has won a game with 10.♕h5? hg5?, but 10...g6! 11.♕h3 ♕d4 12.♘f3 ♕d8 13.♗g5 ♗e7 14.♖d1 ♘8d7∓ fixes things in Black's favour.

10...♗b4 11.♕g4 ♔f8 12.♗e3 ♗b7 13.ba6 h5 14.♕g5 ♕g5 15.♘g5 ♖a6 16.♖a6 ♘a6‡, Deak – Schrancz, HUN 2000.

B2. 9.b3 ♗b4 10.♗d2 ♗b7 11.ba6?!

11.♗c4 might be a little better, but not enough to make the line attractive to White: 11...♗f3 12.♕f3 ♕d4.

11...♗f3 12.♕f3 ♕d4 13.♗c4 0-0 14.♕e3 ♕e3 15.fe3 ♘c4 16.bc4 ♖a6‡ Ward – Ganguly, Great Britain 2002.

B3. 9.ba6 ♖a6 10.♖a6 ♗a6!

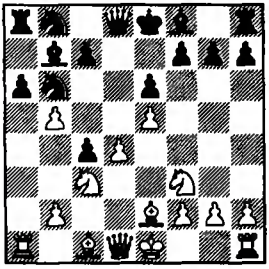
The b8-knight is better off on c6. 10...♘a6 11.♗g5 ♕d7 12.♗e2 ♗b7 13.0–0 h6 14.♗e3 ♗e7 15.♘d2 0–0 16.♗f3 ♗f3 17.♕f3 c5 18.dc5 ♘c5 19.♕g4 ♕c7, P. Nikolic – Van Wely, Wijk aan Zee 1997 leaves the initiative to White – 20.♗h6! ♕e5 21.♘f3 ♕f6 22.♗e3±. Black's king is more exposed than his rival.

11.♗e2 ♗e7 12.0-0 0-0 13.♗e3 ♘c6 14.b3 ♘b4 15.♗c4 ♗c4 16.bc4 ♘c4 17.♗f4 c5 ½-½, Ernst – Rytshagov, Stockholm 2002.

B4. 9.♗e2 ♗b7.

B4a. 10.ba6; B4b. 10.0–0

The plot in this line is how and when to trade off the b5-pawn. Black should take on b5 himself, anticipating the move ba6. It could be done at any moment, leading often to the same position at the end.



White's problem is that if he plays B4a. 10.ba6 before vacating the c1-square, Black will reply 10...♖a6 and after the swap of rooks the game would be about level.

On the other hand, after B4b. 10.0–0 Black will take on b5 on

his turn, also solving the opening problems.

B4a. 10.ba6 ♖a6 11.♖a6 ♘a6 12.0–0 ♗e7 13.♗e3

Alternatively:

13.♗c4 ♘c4 14.♕a4 ♕d7 15.♕c4 offers Black full compensation for the pawn: 15...♘b4⩲ 16.♖d1 0–0 17.♗g5 ♗f3 18.♗e7 ♕e7 19.gf3 ♖d8 20.♔f1 h6 21.♔e2 ♘d5 22.♘d5 ♖d5 23.♖d3 ♕d8 24.b4 ♕b8=, Bacrot – Zilberman, Havana 1998.

13.♘a4 ♕d5! 14.♘e1 ♕c6=.

13.♘d2 ♕d4 14.♘c4 ♕d1 15.♖d1 ♘c4 16.♗c4 0–0! Tyomkin – Lesiege, Montreal 2000. Here computers claim a clear edge for White, obviously mislead by his big spatial advantage. However the humans agreed to a draw because 17.♖d7 ♗c5 18.♘a4 (18.♗a6 ♗a6 19.♖c7 ♗d4=) 18...♗a7 19.b3 ♖c8 20.♗a3 ♗c6 21.♖d1 ♘b8 leaves White without a reasonable plan.

13...0–0 14.♘d2 ♕a8!

A very good idea! Black wins a tempo for redeployment. It is still early for counter-attacking by 14...c5?! 15.♘c4 ♘c4 16.♗c4 cd4 17.♕d4 ♕d4 18.♗d4 ♘b4 19.♗b6 ♖c8 20.♗e2 ♗c5 21.♗c5 ♖c5 22.f4±, Van Wely – Miles, London 1995.

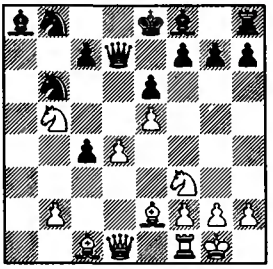
14...♕d7 gave White time for 15.♖e1!, enabling a retreat-square on f1 for the bishop: 14...♘b4 16.♘c4 ♘c4 17.♗c4±, Khalifman – Ganguly, Moscow (1.3), 2001;

15.f3 ♖d8 16.♕c1 c5! 17.dc5 ♘c5 18.♘c4 ♘c4 19.♗c4 ♘d7 20.♗d4 ♕c8=, Orsag – Jackova, 2000.

B4b. 10.0–0 ab5!

Not so precise is 10...♗e7 11.♗e3 0–0 12.ba6 ♖a6 13.♖c1! and White preserved some pressure in Landa – Sulava, Oberwart 1996 13...♘c6 14.b3 cb3 15.♕b3 ♖a3 16.♕b1 ♘b4 17.♘b5 ♖a2 18.♖fe1 ♖e2 19.♖e2 ♗a6↑.

11.♖a8 ♗a8 12.♘b5 ♕d7



This position cannot be appealing to White – 13.♘a3 ♗d5 14.♕c2 ♗a3 15.ba3 ♘c6 16.♖d1 ♗f3 17.♗f3 ♘d4 18.♕e4 ♘f3 19.♕f3 ♕a4∓, P. Nielsen – Kumaran, Copenhagen 1996.

B5. 9.♗e3

This is the trendy line now.

B5a. 9...♗b7; B5b. 9...ab5

9...♗b4 10.♘d2 ♗c3 11.bc3 ab5 12.♖a8 ♘a8 13.♘c4 is in White's favour, Grischuk – Teske, Rapid Canada de Calatrava 06.04.2007.

In Nikolaidis – Karpatchev, Corfu, 08.10.2007 was 9...♗e7 10.♘d2 ♗b7 11.♕g4 ♔f8 12.♘c4 ♘d5 13.ba6 ♘a6 14.♗e2 h5∞, but what was Black's plan against 11.♘c4 ♘c4 12.♗c4.

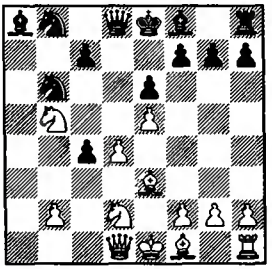
B5a. 9...♗b7

We had explained that Black

must try to exchange a pair of rooks. The text does not help much to achieve this goal, but recently Black has patched his defence and has no theoretical problems.

10.ba6

Perhaps White should test more extensively 10.♘d2!? ab5 11.♖a8 ♗a8 12.♘b5



Here 12...♗b4!? 13.♕g4 ♔f8 is very interesting.

Other options are:

12...♘c6 13.♘c4 ♗b4 14.♗d2 0–0 15.♘b6 cb6 16.♗b4 ♘b4 17.♕d2 ♘c6 18.♗c4. Draw agreed. Black still has to tame the opponent's initiative, although the ending after 18...♘a5 19.♗e2 ♕d5 20.f3 ♗c6 21.♘d6 ♘b3 22.♗c4 ♕d4 23.♕d4 ♘d4 24.♔f2± does not seem too dangerous.

12...♕d7 13.♘c3 ♕c6 14.h4 ♘8d7 15.♖h3 f6 16.ef6 ♘f6 17.♖g3+–, Kinsman – Shaw, Edinburgh, 1996.

10...♖a6

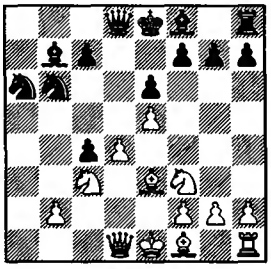
Beliavsky suggests to meet 10...♘a6 with 11.♘d2 ♘b4 12.♖a8 ♕a8 13.♘c4 ♗g2 14.♘b6 cb6 15.♗b5±.

11.♖a6

According to our conception, White could preserve the rook by 11.♖c1!? ♘c6 (11...♗b4 12.♘d2 ♕h4 13.♘c4 ♗g2 14.♗g2 leads to the same pattern as seen in the game.) 12.♘d2 ♘b4 (Or 12...♘d4 13.♘c4 ♘c4 14.♗c4 ♖c6 15.♕a4!±) 13.♘c4! ♗g2 14.♗g2 ♘c4 15.0–0 ♘e3 16.fe3 ♗e7 17.♘e4↑, J. Piket – Tkachiev, 2000. However, professionals prefer to snatch a pawn in an endgame.

11...♘a6

White had the initiative after 11...♗a6 12.♗e2 ♗e7 13.0–0 0–0 14.♕b1 ♘c6 15.♕e4 ♘b4 16.♕g4 ♔h8 17.♕h5±, Fressinet – Guliyev, Paris 2006.



12.♘d2

The old main line 12.♗c4 ♘c4 13.♕a4 was well neutralised in the game Peralta – Edouard, Andorra, 02.07.2007: 13...c6! 14.♕c4 ♘b4 15.♕b3 ♗a6 16.♔d2 ♗e7 17.♘e1 0–0 18.♘c2 ♘c2 19.♔c2 ♕a8⇄.

In the game Fressinet – Renet, Paris, 09.07.2007 White chose 12.♗e2 and had the upper hand after 12...♗e7 13.♘d2 ♘b4 14.♘c4 ♘6d5 15.0–0±. Black should better play 12...♘b4 13.0–0 ♗e7 14.♘d2 ♕a8, activating the queen. Then 15.♘b5 0–0 16.♘c7 ♕c8 17.♘b5 ♕c6 18.♗f3 ♕b5 19.♗b7 ♘6d5 20.♗d5 ♘d5= is a typical for this line drawish position.

12...♘b4 13.♘c4 ♘c4 14.♗c4

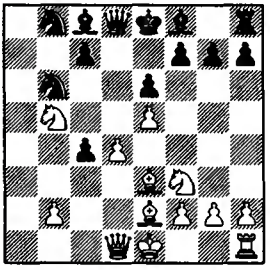
♗g2 15.♕a4 ♕d7 16.♗b5 c6 17.♕a8 ♕d8 18.♕d8 ♔d8 19.♖g1

The ending is equal, Halkias – Kozhuharov, Kavala, 10.08.2007. Now simplest would have been 19...♗h3 20.♗e2 ♔c7=.

B5b. 9...ab5 10.♖a8 ♘a8 11.♘b5 ♘b6 12.♗e2

The plan of capturing the c4-pawn does not work with this move order because of 12.♘d2 ♗a6 13.♘c3 ♘c6∓ (Beliavsky).

White has also tested early activation of the queen, but that costs him the right of castling, without earning obvious benefits: 12.♘c3 ♘c6 13.♘g5 ♘b4 14.♕h5 g6 (perhaps 14...♕e7 first is more precise) 15.♕f3 ♕e7 16.♘ge4 ♘c2 17.♔d2 ♘e3 18.♘f6 ♔d8∞ Eljanov – Karjakin, Warsaw 2005.



12...♗e7

In Timoscenko – Meins, Rethymnon, 2003 Black hurried to "develop" the other bishop. In fact it is better placed on c8, defending e6 after the obligatory f7-f5. The game continued 12...♗a6 13.♘c3 ♗e7 14.0-0 (14.♕g4 runs into 14...♘b4! 15.♗e2 ♘c2 16.♔d1 ♘b4 Kogan – Mannion, Port Erin 2005. The king on d1 is strange looking, to say the least) 14...0–0 15.♕c2 ♘c6 16.♕e4 ♘b4 17.♕g4 ♔h8 18.♕h5 f6 19.ef6± when White retains some initiative thanks to the target on e6.

13.0–0 0–0 14.♕c2 ♘c6 15.♕e4!

White's queen belongs to the kingside. Assault of the c4-pawn hands the initiative to the opponent. 15.♘a3?! ♘b4 16.♕c1 ♘d3 17.♕a1 ♗a6 18.♖d1 ♘b2 19.♕b2 c3 20.♕c2 ♗e2 21.♕e2 ♗a3 22.♕d3 ♘d5 23.♘g5 g6 24.♘e4 ♗b2∓, Campos Moreno – Magem, Barcelona 2000.

15...♘b4 16.♕g4

16.♘c3 gives Black a tempo for 16...♘4d5. Then 17.♕g4 meets 17...♘e3 18.fe3 c5! So in Porper – Mannion, Triesen 2004 White tried 17.♗d2 ♗b7 18.♕g4 ♔h8 19.h4 (19.♘g5 fails to 19...h6 20.♘ge4 f5 21.ef6 ♘f6 22.♕e6 ♗e4 23.♘e4 ♖e8∓). Perhaps Black should have prepared f5 with the help of 19...♕d7!?∞. Instead he gambled with 19...f5. It is unclear what he had in mind in case of 20.ef6 ♘f6 21.♕e6 c5 22.dc5 ♗c5 23.♕e5 with an extra pawn.

16...f5!

Remember this defensive resource! We see the bishop very useful on c8, defending the weak e6-pawn. Black would not survive without this break-through.

17.ef6 ♗f6=.

We have followed the game Najer – Sulskis, Linares 2001.

Huzman's proposition 18.♘e5 is well countered by 18...♘c2! 19.♘c4 e5 20.♕e4 ♘d4=.

Chapter 24

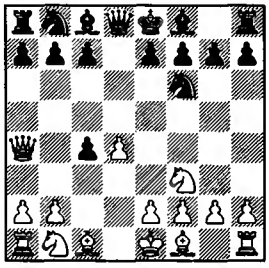
Conclusion

The Two Knights Gambit 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 is not any more the weapon of choice against the QGA as it used to be. Besides possible transitions to the Slav and other defences, Black has found some good ideas after 4...c5 5.d5 e6 6.e4 ed5 7.e5 when the tricky 7...♘e4 runs into 8.♘d5!? b5 9.b3 with some pull, but 7...♘fd7 8.♗g5 ♗e7 9.♗e7 ♕e7 10.♘d5 ♕d8 looks safe against both 11.♕c2 or 11.♗c4.

The gambit line 4...a6 5.e4 b5 6.e5 ♘d5 7.a4 is complicated and still unclear. Then 7...♗b7!? is out of fashion, but White has not shown yet a clear path to an advantage. It might be Black's best attempt to play for a win.

Lately 7...e6 deserved the reputation of the most reliable equaliser. It has a sound positional foundation and does not incur a learning overhead. After 8.ab5 8.ab5 Black has two good options. 8...♘b6 9.♗e3 is already well tested. 8...♗b4 is more straightforward and natural. The flip side is that play is forced, with several lines that lead to a draw by repetition.

Chapter 25



1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♕a4

(D23)

This move is unambitious and in most cases is motivated by insufficient home preparation. White seldom surprises the opponent with new ideas. Black has a wide choice, but we'll limit the survey to the lines which are closer to the spirit of the QGA – 4...♘c6!

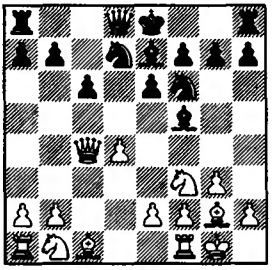
For completeness sake we'll add some notes on 4...c6, only because it is frequently seen in tournaments after the move order 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♕c2 dc4.

Another popular position arises after 4...♘bd7, although it is reached most often when White wants to avoid the Vienna variation – 1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 dc4 4.♕a4 ♘d7. We'll follow this move order when the most testing is 5.e4 c5.

A. 4...c6
B. 4...♘d7
C. 4...♘c6!?

A. 4...c6 ♗f5 6.g3 e6 7.♗g2 ♘bd7 8.0–0 ♗e7

This is a purely strategic line. It allows plenty of different plans for both sides. White tries to build up an ideal pawn centre while Black can vary between pawn expansion on the queenside with b5-b4 or the more restrained ♘e4, aiming to trade a couple of minor pieces in the centre. In the latter case even if White succeeds to achieve his goal and lines up the pawns on d4 and e4, it would not be of some benefit to him. In the meanwhile Black can prepare the break c6-c5. It is no wonder that amazing quantity of games are drawn before the 25th move.



9.e3

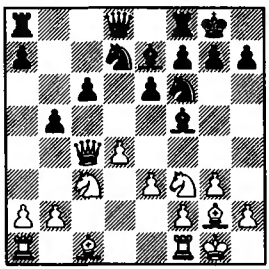
Black can meet 9.♘bd2 with the same plan as against ♘c3 – 9...♘e4, maintaining blockade on e4.

9...0–0 10.♕e2

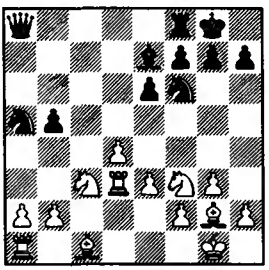
We recommend to meet **10.♘c3** with **10...♘e4**, intending to trade

knights and later the light-squared bishops via e4. White can avoid then the unloading manoeuvre of the opponent ♘e4xc3 followed by ♗e4 with **11.♘d2**, but without success – 11...♘d2 12.♗d2 e5 13.e4 ed4 14.♕d4 ♗e6 15.♗e3 ♗c5 ½–½, U. Andersson – Erenburg, Istanbul 2003.

Besides the above-mentioned plan, an early expansion on the queenside by b5-b4 is also quite popular – **10.♘c3 b5**



Usually White retreats to e2 or b3 and Black has good counterplay with b4, followed by c5. It would be interesting to test more thoroughly 11.♕c6!? ♗d3 12.♖d1 ♖c8 13.♕a6 ♘b8 14.♕a7 ♘c6 15.♕b7 ♘a5 and now 16.♕a6!? (The game Torbin – Skorchenko, Essentuki 2003 saw 16.♕c8 ♕c8 17.♖d3 b4 18.♘e2 ♕c2 19.♖d2 ♕a4 20.♖d3 ♕c2 21.♖d2 ♕a4=) 16...♖a8 17.♕a8 ♕a8 18.♖d3



18...b4 19.♘e1 ♕a6 20.♘e4 ♘e4 21.♗e4±.

10.♖d1 is not of independent significance in view of 10...♘e4 11.♘c3 ♘c3 12.bc3 ♗e4 13.♕e2=, Z. Franco – Filgueira, Buenos Aires 2003.

10.a4 seems interesting. Unfortunately the game Kharlov – Kir. Georgiev, Istanbul 2003 finished abruptly after 10...a5 11.e3 ♕b6 12.♕e2 ♕a6, ½–½.

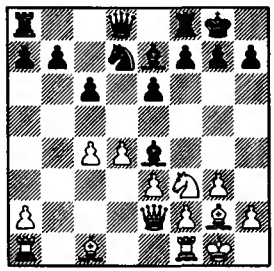
10...♘e4 11.♘c3

With 11.♘e1 White would gain control over e4, but then c4 and a4 become weak – 11...c5 12.♘c3 ♘df6 13.f3 ♘c3 14.bc3 ♗g6 15.♗b2 ♘d5 16.e4 ♘b6 17.♘d3=, Ehlvest – Dreev, Tallinn 2003.

11...♘c3 12.bc3 ♗e4 13.c4

13.♘e1 ♗g2 14.♘g2 a5 15.♗d2 c5=;

A little more tension would retain 13.♗h3 c5 14.♘d2 ♗c6 15.e4 ♘b6 16.♘b3 ♘a4 17.♗d2 b5 18.♖fe1 ♖e8 19.♖ab1 ½–½, Tkachiev – Savchenko, Cannes 2000.



13...c5

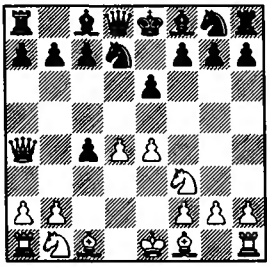
13...♕a5 14.♗b2 ♕a6 15.♖fc1 ♘b6 16.a4 ♘a4∞ is more complicated, Raetsky – Ulibin, Biel 2002.

14.♗b2 ♕c7 15.♖ac1=, Yu-

dasin – Akopian, Haifa 1995. Black has deployed all his pieces on good places, the c4-pawn is an obvious target.

B. 4...♘bd7

The most popular path to this position is the Anti-Vienna variation 1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 dc4 4.♕a4 (4.♘c3 ♘f6 5.e4 ♗b4 6.♗g5 c5 leads to the Vienna variation which is currently considered as acceptable for Black) 4...♘bd7 **5.e4**



Now Black can transpose to the main line by **5...♘f6** 6.♘c3 since Huzman's recommendation 6.♗g5 is quite dubious – 6...c6 7.♕c4 h6! Less accurate is 5...a6 6.♗c4 ♖b8 7.♕c2 and in future White can develop the knight to d2, instead of c3. However Black could keep open the option of placing the knight on e7. A recent novelty of Rublevsky rehabilitated this line:

5...c5!?

Black immediately undermines the centre. White can ignore this break, exploiting the fact that his knight is still on b1 and eventual cd4 will not be threatening anything.

6.♗c4 cd4 7.0–0 ♗c5

After the game Sakaev – Khalifman, St. Petersburg 1997 there are no volunteers for 7...♕b6 8.♘a3! ♘e7 9.♘b5 ♘g6 10.♘fd4 ♗c5 11.♘f3, when 11.♗e3!± (threatening 12.b4) would have led to an overwhelming advantage in activity of White's pieces.

8.b4 ♗d6

8...♗b6 is risky. White has a choice between 9.♗b2!? intending to regain quickly the sacrificed pawn, e.g. 9...♘f6 10.e5 ♘g4 11.h3 ♕c7 12.hg4 ♕c4 13.♘a3 ♕d5 14.♖fd1 d3 15.♕b3 ♕b3 16.ab3± or 9.♘a3!? ♘e7! 10.♗b2 0–0 11.♘d4 ♗d4 12.♗d4 ♘c6 13.♗e3±. White's edge is minimal after a possible 13...♘b6 14.♕b3 ♘c4 15.♕c4.

9.e5 ♗b8 10.♗b2 ♘e7!

This move apparently equalises. 10...♘h6? turned bad in Kuzmin – Kharlov, Dubai 2003: 11.♗d4 ♘f5 12.♗b2 0–0 13.♕c2 ♘b6 14.♗d3 ♘d5 15.a3 ♗d7 16.♖d1±.

11.♗d4 0–0

In case of 12.♕c2 ♘c6 is a double attack on d4 and e5. 12.♖d1 ♘c6!? 13.♗c3 ♕c7 wins the e5-pawn.

The stem-game Khenkin – Rublevsky, Moscow 2004 continued 12.♖e1 ♘f5 13.♗b2 ♘b6 14.♕b3 ♘c4 15.♕c4 ♗d7 16.♘c3 (16.♘bd2) ♗c6=.

5.♘c3 e6 6.e4

We shal examine:

B1. 6...a6

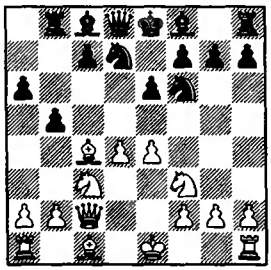
B2. 6...c5!?

The third option 6...♗e7 is too passive – 7.♗c4 0–0 8.♕c2 c5 9.dc5 ♗c5 (9...♘c5 10.0–0 ♕c7 11.♗g5 a6? 12.e5 ♘g4 13.b4+–, Van der Ster-

ren – A. Fernandes, Linares 1995) 10.0-0 ♕c7 11.♕e2± with typical for the Furman variation position, Malaniuk – Lau, Dortmund 1993.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♕a4 ♘bd7 5.♘c3 e6 6.e4)

B1. 6...a6 7.♗c4 ♖b8 8.♕c2 b5



9.♗d3

9.♗e2 leaves the e4-pawn underprotected, forcing White to push it forward: 9...♗b7 10.e5 ♘d5 11.0–0 (11.♗g5 ♗e7! 12.♗e7 ♕e7 13.♘d5 ♗d5 14.♕c7 0–0∞) 11...c5 12.♗g5 ♕b6 13.♘d5 ♗d5 14.♖ac1 h6 15.♗h4 c4=, Zsinka – Kallai, HUN, 1999. Black convincingly sealed the centre and can afford some pawn advances on the kingside like g5-h5.

9...♗b7 10.♗f4 ♖c8 11.d5!

11.0–0 c5 12.d5 c4 puts under big question the retreat of the white bishop to d3 on move 9. After 13.♗e2 ed5 14.♖ad1 ♘c5!? Black achieved a comfortable game in L. Portisch – Atalik, Halkidiki 2002.

11...♘h5

11...ed5 runs into 12.0–0–0→. Van Wely preferred against Dreev 11...♘c5 120-0-0 ed5, when critical is 13.e5 ♘h5 14.♗e3 g6 15.♗c5 ♗c5 16.♘d5 ♗d5 17.♕c5 ♘f4 18.♗c2 with an initiative.

12.♗e3

Gelfand suggests 12.♗g5 ♗e7 13.de6 fe6 14.h4↑, but 14...c5 15.0-0-0 c4 leads to double-edged play.

12...e5 13.a4

White has to decide two things – when to get in a4 and where to retreat the knight – to e2 or a2. We like the knight in the middle, so 13.0–0!? ♗d6 14.a4 b4 15.♘e2± deserved attention.

13...b4 14.♘a2

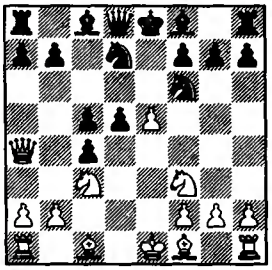
Gelfand suggests also 14.♘e2 c6 15.dc6 ♖c6 16.♕b3±.

14...c6.

Black has good prospects to equalise, Gelfand – Psakhis, Polanica Zdroj 1997.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♕a4 ♘bd7 5.♘c3 e6 6.e4)

B2. 6...c5!? 7.d5! ed5 8.e5



8...b5!

This variation is seldom seen in tournaments, probably because of the unforgettable impression of the line 8...d4? 9.♗c4 dc3 10.ef6 ♕f6 11.♗g5 ♕c6 12.0–0–0! (you do not see every day a queen sac on move

12, do you!) 12...cb2 13.♔b2 ♗e7 14.♕c6 bc6 15.♗e7 ♔e7 16.♖he1±. Certainly we'll not recommend such a nightmare for your repertoire. We are not in the times when accepting sacrifices (and getting mated) was a matter of honour. Instead Black counter-attacks and temporarily overtakes the initiative.

9.♕b5 ♖b8 10.♕a4 d4 11.ef6 dc3 12.♗c4 ♖b4!

12...cb2? 13.♗f7! ♔f7 14.♘g5 is crushing.

13.♕c2

We are following the game Miles – Karpov, Biel 1990. The Encyclopaedia of Chess Openings (Second edition – 1987!) recommended 13.♕d1. Then 13...♘f6 14.♗f7 ♔e7 15.♕d8 ♔d8 16.bc3 ♖e4 17.♗e3 ♔e7 18.♗b3 ♘g4 19.♘g5+– or 13...♕f6 14.♗g5 ♕d6 15.♕e2 ♗e7 16.♖d1 ♖b2 17.♕e3+– are hopeless.

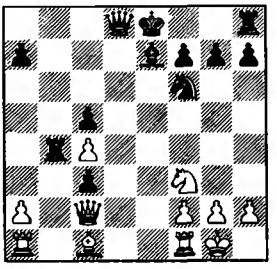
So 13...gf6! 14.b3 and now:

14...♗g7∞ – ECO 4th edition 2004;

14...♘e5 15.♕d8 ♔d8 16.♘e5 fe5 17.♗g5 (17.♗f7 ♖g4, followed by 17...♗f5 and the passed c-pawn could be very powerful) 17...♗e7 18.0-0-0 ♔e8 19.♗e7 ♔e7 20.♖he1 f6, Alburt – Z. Polgar, Exhib. New York 2004. Here 21.a3 ♖b8 22.♔c2 would have been slightly better for White.

14...♕e7! Played in the little known correspondence game Wendehake – Cordoba, corr, 1979 which saw 15.♗e3 ♗g7∞. Instead 15...♘b6 16.0–0 ♘c4 17.bc4 ♗g7 would have favoured Black.

13...♘f6 14.b3! ♗e6 15.0-0 ♗c4 16.bc4 ♗e7



17.♘e5?! 0-0! 18.♕c3 (18.♘c6 ♕c7 19.♘b4 cb4∞) **18...♗d6 19.♘d3 ♖b6 20.♖e1**=, ½–½. Miles – Karpov, Biel 1990.

Perhaps 17.♕c3 is better, but still Black has excellent prospects for equalising.

C. 4...♘c6!? 5.♘c3

White has many other possibilities:

5.♘e5 ♗d7 6.♘d7 ♕d7 7.e3 e5∓.

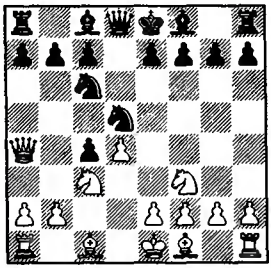
5.g3?! ♘d5! 6.♕c4 ♘b6 7.♕d3 e5!↑.

5.e3 ♘d7 6.♕c4 e5 7.de5 ♘de5 8.♘e5 ♘e5 9.♕e4 ♗d6 10.♗e2 0–0∓, Zietlow – Raetsky, GER 1999.

5.♕c4 is very popular. Black can experiment with the double-edged 5...♘d7 6.e4! e5 7.d5 ♘e7 8.♘c3 a6 9.♗e3 ♘g6 10.h4, Tunik – Rublevsky, Elista 1995, or 5...♗g4 6.e3 e6, but I like more Brynell's idea 5...e5!? Then the natural 6.de5?! ♗e6 7.♕a4 ♘d7 8.♘c3 ♘c5↑, Ahlander – Brynell, Skara 2002 turns nice for Black. More testing is 6.♘e5 ♘e5 7.de5 ♘g4 8.♗f4, but appart from the other sharper options, Black can play to equalise by 8...c6 9.e3 ♕a5 10.♘c3 ♘e5 11.♕d4 ♘g6 with an easy game.

5...♘d5!

An original idea of Tigran Petrosian which provides Black with rich piece play.



6.♕c4

Alternatively:

6.e4 ♘b6 7.♕d1 ♗g4 8.d5 ♘e5 9.♗f4 (9.♕d4 ♘g6 10.♘d2 e5= is a safe line, whereas 9...♘f3 10.gf3 ♗f3 11.♖g1 ♕d6∞ is more ambitious, but also risky.) 9...♘g6 10.♗g3 e5 11.de6 ♕d1 12.♖d1 fe6 13.♗e2∓, Dreev – Krush, Gausdal, 19.04.2007.

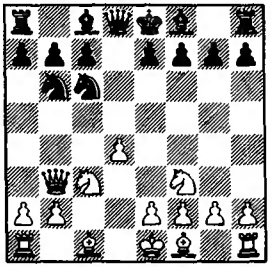
6.♘e5 ♘b6 7.♘c6 ♕d6 8.♕c2 ♕c6 (8...bc6 is ugly, but might be the better option as White must either defend the d4-pawn, or sacrifice it without immediate benefits.) 9.e4 e5 10.de5 ♗c5 11.♗e2 0–0, Nakamura – Sarkar, Philadelphia 2006. Black will win the e5-pawn, but the still remaining pawn majority on the kingside gives White some compensation.

6...♘b6

6...♘db4 7.♕b3 e5 is dubious. Then 8.d5 ♘d4 9.♘d4 ed4 10.a3 gave White the initiative in Palatnik – Caposciutti, Rome 1990. On the seventh move in U. Andersson – Kortschnoj Johannesburg 1981 Black chose 7...♘d4?! 8.♘d4 ♕d4 9.♗e3 ♗e6 10.♕a4 ♗d7 11.♕b3 ♗e6 12.♕a4 ½–½, but White has a strong improvement on the ninth move: 9.a3!? with good compensation for the pawn.

7.♕b3

The old move 7.♕d3 puts White on the defensive after 7...e5! 8.♘e5 ♘b4 9.♕b1 ♕d4 10.♘f3 ♕d6 11.e4 ♗g4 12.a3 ♗f3 13.gf3 ♘c6 14.♘b5 ♕e7=, Conquest – Dlugy, 1984.



7...e5!

7...♗g4?! 8.d5 ♗f3 9.gf3 ♘d4 10.♕d1 e5 11.e3 ♘f5 looks very interesting.

The attempt to open up play with 12.f4 ef4! turns well for Black. However White has important long-term advantages in his favour – the better centre, bishop pair and some lead in development. The solution is simple: 12.♕c2! followed up by ♗d2 and 0-0-0 seizes the initiative, e.g. 12...g6 13.♗b5 ♘d7 14.♗d2.

8.de5

8.de5 ♗e6 9.♕c2 ♕d4 10.♕e4 ♕e4 11.♘e4 0–0–0 12.a3 ♘c4 has also given Black adequate compensation in Rotstein – Ernst, Germany, 2002, when best would have been 12...♗e7∞.

8...♗e6 9.♕c2 ♗b4!?

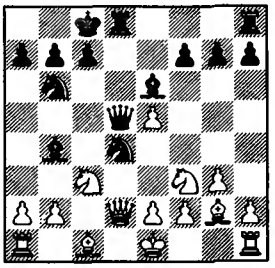
The game Ivanchuk – Ponomariov, Linares 2002 showed that Black's counterplay is based on the weak queenside pawns. It is important to kill their defender – the c3-knight. Ponomariov preferred 9...♘d4 10.♕d3 (10.♕e4 ♗c5∞) 11...♘f3 12.gf3 ♕d3 13.♗d3 0–0–0 14.♗e2 ♗b4 15.♗d2 ♘a4 16.a3 ♗c3 17.♗c3 ♘c3 18.bc3 ♖d5 19.f4 ♖c5 20.♖c1 ♖a5, ½–½. The text is still more persistent.

10.g3

Or 10.a3 ♗c3 11.♕c3 ♕d5

10...♕d5 11.♗g2 ♘d4 12.♕d2 0–0–0

Black is fully mobilised and his pieces are very active. I think that he has sufficient compensation for the pawn (S.S.).



13.♘d5 ♗d2 14.♗d2 ♗d5 15.♘d4 ♗g2 16.♖g1 ♖d4 17.♖g2 ♖hd8 18.♗c3 ♖c4=.

The game Rause – Soltau, Wch18 Final 2003-5 corr ICCF, 2003 soon ended in a draw.

Conclusion

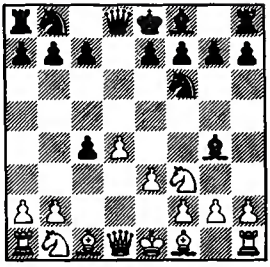
The 4.♕a4 variation is not a source of concern for Black, but still has some blank spots in its theory. We recommend line C. 4...♘c6! because it leads to a lively game with mutual chances. Black's thematic break-through e7-e5 gives good counterplay in many lines. It allows him to quickly develop and even aim for exchange of queens to leave White's queenside pawns without defenders. The line 6...♘db4 7.♕b3 ♘d4 8.♘d4 ♕d4 9.a3!? needs practical tests, but its current status appears to be in White's favour.

In line B we consider also a way to avoid with White the problematic Vienna variation. In that case Black has a good game with minimal risk (line B2).

Chapter 26

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 ♗g4

(D25)



This system is passive, but very solid. Black ensures a swift development to his pieces at the cost of concession of the centre. If White does not make use of his space advantage at an early stage of the game, play is likely to be levelled.

White has to decide first when to play h2-h3. We have no unequivocal recommendation. The differences are too subtle and sometimes are a matter of taste. In some variations White would prefer to have the enemy bishop on g4. Then a possible ♘e5 would be with tempo. Another case is when Black has to transfer the bishop to the b1-h7 diagonal in order to prevent e4. Then g6 would be a safer place.

The minuses of delaying h3 are only in the possibility of Black to part with his bishop instead of retreating it to h5 at a later stage of the game. However, we believe that White should have a comfortable small edge in that case.

5.♗c4

5.h3 ♗h5 (5...♗f3 6.♕f3 ♘c6 7.♗c4 e5?! 8.de5±) 6.g4 ♗g6 7.♘e5 is not popular. The game Lputian – Fominyh, Rimavska Sobota 1991 went on 7...♘bd7 8.♘c4 ♘b6 9.♘c3 ♘c4 10.♗c4 e6 11.f3 a6 12.e4 c5 13.♗e3 cd4 14.♕d4∞.

5.♘bd2 ♘bd7 6.♘c4 e6 7.♗e2 ♗e7= is not very consistent either.

5...e6

A. 6.♕b3?!
B. 6.h3
C. 6.♘bd2
D. 6.♘c3

We examine first the dubious continuation 6.♕b3?! If White is so tempted by the b7-pawn, it is wiser to insert first 6.h3 ♗h5, although even then Black has sufficient compensation. 6.h3 ♗h5 7.g4 is an attempt to take over the initiative immediately. It leads to non-standard, tactically rich positions.

6.♘bd2 is a modern treatment and especially line C2. 7.a4!? ♗d6 8.a5 is worth attention.

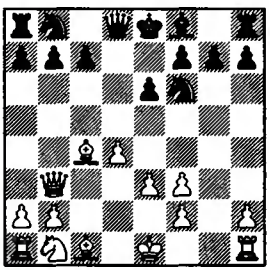
Finally 6.♘c3 is the most analysed line. Both plans with 6...a6, followed by ♘c6 (D1) or 6...♘bd7 and

♗b4 deserve attention. I think that it is time for White to reconsider his play, base on the old game Kasparov – Petrosian. A more restrained central plan should give him a small, but safe advantage.

The effect of surprise works in Black's favour, as the whole system is a little underestimated, and White usually spends less time on it in his home preparation.

Note that White could sidestep the ♗g4 system by playing 3.e3. Of course, he should be ready then for 3...e5, which might be a preferable option to the plan with ...♗g4.

A. 6.♕b3?! ♗f3 7.gf3



7...c5

More frequent is 7...♘bd7 If White takes on b7 we'll have a simple transposition to the main line with c5. More interesting is the case when White builds his play on the bishop pair and pawn cluster in the centre. The game Chiburdanidze – Romanishin, Lippstadt 2003 offers an active plan for Black: 8.♘c3 ♘b6 9.♗e2 ♗e7 10.f4 0–0 11.♗f3 c5 12.dc5 ♗c5 13.♗d2 (13.♗b7? ♖b8 14.♗f3 ♘bd5 15.♕d1 ♗b4 16.♗d2 ♕a5∓ 17.♘d5 ♘d5∓) 13...a5!↑. Of course, if Black will play c7-c5 anyway, why not to do it right away?!

8.♕b7 (8.dc5=) **♘bd7 9.♘c3**

An alternative is 9.dc5 ♗c5 10.♘c3 0–0 11.f4 ♘b6.

In the famous game Foguelman – D. Bronstein, Amsterdam 1964 Black opened the way to his queen without losing a tempo by 11...♘d5, and got a crushing attack after 12.♖d1? ♖b8 13.♕c6 ♕h4! 14.♘c3, when 14...♘e5!! 15.fe5 ♘c3∓ would have scored on the spot. However 12.♗d5!? ♖b8 13.♕c6 ♖b6 14.♖d1!!∞ allows White to complicate things.

12.♗e2 ♘fd5 13.0–0 ♕h4, Quinteros – A. Miles Amsterdam 1977 and here 13...♘c3 14.bc3 ♘d5⩱ would have created a target to attack.

9...cd4 10.ed4 ♗d6!? 11.f4

The otherwise tempting move 11.♘e4 encounters 11...♘e4 12.fe4 ♖b8! 13.♕a6 ♕h4! 14.♗d3 ♗b4 and White's king is in the draught.

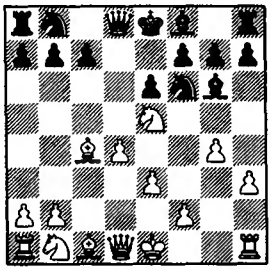
11...0–0 12.♗b3 ♕a5 13.♖g1 ♖ab8 14.♕g2 g6 15.♖b1 ♖fc8 16.♗d2 ♕b6 17.♘e2 ♗b4∓, Kiselev – Fominyh, St. Petersburg 2002.

B. 6.h3 ♗h5 7.g4

By 6.h3 White provided more room to his king in case of eventual castling. That makes 7.♕b3 more reliable, compared to line A: 7...♗f3 8.gf3 ♘bd7 9.♕b7 c5 10.dc5 ♗c5 11.f4 0–0 12.♕f3. Still, considerable lead in development gives Black good prospects, e.g. 12...♘b6 13.♗e2 ♗b4

14.♗d2 ♗d2 15.♘d2 ♕d6, Xu Yuanyuan – Pina,Wch U20 Girls Yerevan 2000, when 15...♖c8⩱ would have retained the initiative.

7...♗g6 8.♘e5



White scores a terrific percentage in this variation. We guess that it is mostly due to a bad preparation of the second players. The game Bocharov – Fominyh, Tomsk 2001 shows a good way for Black to fight for the initiative:

8...♗e4!?

8...♘bd7 is also playable, e.g. 9.♘g6 hg6 10.♕f3 c5! 11.0–0 cd4 12.ed4 ♗e7, Hort – A. Miles, Amsterdam 1978, when 12...♖c8∞ seems promising for Black.

9.f3 ♗b1 10.♖b1 ♘fd7! 11.♕b3

Or 11.f4 ♕h4 12.♔e2 ♘e5 13.fe5 ♘d7↑.

11...♘b6

Now instead of 11...♘b6 12.♗d3 h5?? 13.♗g6+– Black had:

11...♘e5 12.de5 ♘d7 13.♕b7 ♖b8 14.♕c6 ♖b6 15.♕a4 ♕h4 16.♔f1 ♕g3↑.

C. 6.♘bd2

This line is "optically" not very aesthetic. Apparently White's idea is to relieve the queen of the necessity to keep an eye on the f3-knight. However that is not a plan, and despite the sufficient amount of games, we suspect that White players have not a clear idea for their future actions. Otherwise we cannot explain the fact that virtually all games feature different set-up. We'll note one of them which attracted our attention:

6...♘bd7

The plan with ...c5 is also interesting and should equalise.

The line branches here to:
C1. 7.♕b3
C2. 7.a4!?

C1. 7.♕b3 ♖b8

Unclear is 7...♘b6 8.♘e5 ♗h5 9.0–0 ♗e7 10.♗b5 c6 11.♘c6 bc6 12.♗c6 ♘bd7 13.♗a8 ♕a8 14.f3 0–0 15.♘c4∞ Beach – Small, Auckland 1979.

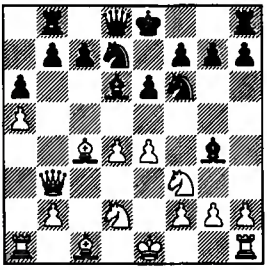
8.h3 ♗h5 9.g4 ♗g6 10.h4

So far so good. 10...h5 11.g5 ♘e4 12.♗e6 ♘dc5 13.dc5 ♘c5 14.♗f7 ♗f7 15.♕c3∞ although double-edged, is at least a pawn up for White.

Aleksandrov – Fominyh, 2002 saw 10...b5?! 11.♗e2 h5 (11...h6!?) 12.g5 ♘e4 13.a4!↑ and White's game is a bit easier. We have no idea what is going to do White in case of normal **10...h6!?** Perhaps we should wait for the next game in this line.

C2. 7.a4!? ♗d6 8.a5 a6 9.♕b3 ♖b8 10.e4

A sound approach. The a5-pawn is cramping Black's wing. The downside is the obvious weakness of the advanced pawn. The next step in White's plan is to gain space in the centre. All this turned well in Sulskis – Ilczuk, Koszalin 1999:



10...♗f3 11.♕f3 e5 12.d5 0-0 13.0-0 ♖c8 14.♖d1 c6 15.♘f1±.

D. 6.♘c3

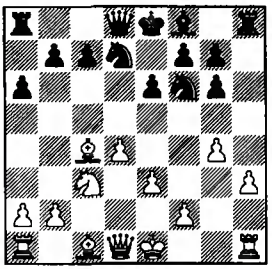
Main options are:
D1. 6...a6
D2. 6...♘bd7

D1. 6...a6 7.h3 ♗h5

The exchange 7...♗f3 cannot ensure full equality. White should play on the queenside, refraining from e4, which would enhance the effect of respective e6-e5. 8.♕f3 ♘c6 9.0–0 ♗d6 10.♖d1 0–0 11.a3 e5 12.♘d5 ♘d5 (12...♘d7 13.b4) 13.♗d5 ♕e8 14.♗d2 (14.de5!? ♕e5 15.g3 ♖ad8 16.♖b1±) 14...ed4 15.♗c6 ♕c6 16.♕c6 bc6 17.ed4 a5 18.♖ac1 ♖fb8 19.♖c2 ♖b3 20.♗c1±, E. Geller – Sajtar, Helsinki, 1952.

8.0–0!?

A whole generation of chess players was strongly influenced by the famous game Kasparov – Petrosian, Tilburg 1981, which went 8.g4 ♗g6 9.♘e5 ♘bd7 10.♘g6 hg6

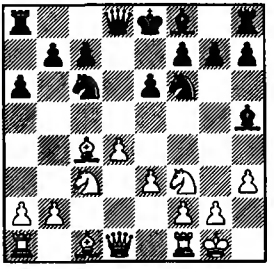


11.♗f1 c6 12.♗g2 ♕c7?! 13.0–0 ♗e7 14.f4 ♘b6 15.g5 ♘fd7 16.♕g4± Kasparov – Petrosian, Tilburg 1981. Recently Kunin has shown a better set-up for Black and won a lot of games against strong opposition. I'll note only one of them, to illustrate that White's task is quite difficult:

12...♗d6! 13.0–0 ♕e7 14.g5 ♘d5 15.♕g4 ♗c7 16.f4 ♗b6 17.♗d2 0–0–0 18.♖ac1 ♔b8 19.a3 f6 20.h4 ♖h7 21.♖f3 c5∓ Jussupow – Kunin, Osterburg 2006.

I propose another, much safer approach for White.

8...♘c6



8...c5!? is a bit unusual for the ♗g4 system, but perhaps this move

is not worse than the other Black options. It has only one drawback, but a major one. After 9.dc5! ♕d1 10.♖d1 ♗f3 (10...♗c5 11.g4 ♗g6 12.♘e5 ♘bd7 13.♘g6 hg6 14.♗f1 is clearly better for White) 11.gf3 ♗c5 12.b3 ♘bd7 13.f4 ♔e7 14.♗f1 ♖ac8 15.♗g2± Black has to struggle for the draw. The bishop pair gives White a small, but lasting edge in the endgame, for instance: 15...♗b4 16.♘e2 ♖c7 17.♔f1 ♖hc8 18.♗b2 b5 19.a4 ba4 20.♖a4 a5 21.♗a3± and White went on to win in Beliavsky – Romanishin, Tbilisi 1978. If White attempts to keep on queens, he does not get anything:

9.d5?! b5 and White does not have enough compensation for the material deficit, although the engines are initially very optimistic about 10.♗e2 ♘d5 11.♘d5 ed5 12.a4 b4 13.b3;

9.♖e1 or 9.♗e2: 9...♘c6!;

9.♕e2 ♕c7! with a fine game.

9.♗e2

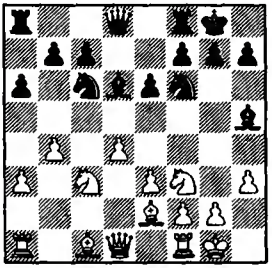
White's main positional aim is to gain space by e3-e4. However, that is not easy to achieve by straightforward means as 9.♕e2. Then 9...♗d6? 10.g4 ♗g6 11.e4 would be very nice, but 9...♗b4! underlines the drawback of White's play – the pin of the f3-knight is rather awkward: 10.a3 (10.♗d2 ♗c3 11.♗c3 ♘e4 12.g4∞) 10...♗c3 11.bc3 ♘e4 12.♕c2 ♗f3 13.gf3 ♘d6 14.♗d3 ♕f6 15.♕e2∞.

Similar is 9.♖e1 ♗b4 10.a3 ♗c3 11.bc3 ♘e4 12.♗b2 ♗f3 13.♕f3 ♘d2 14.♕e2 ♘c4 15.♕c4 ♕d5!=.

9...♗d6 10.a3!?

White is planning to expand in the centre with e4. However, 10.♘d2 now is about equal after 10...♗g6! 11.♘c4 0–0 12.♗f3 ♕e7 13.b3 ♖fd8 14.♗b2 e5=, so White gains space first on the queenside.

10...0-0 11.b4



11...♗g6

Black can also exchange some pieces, but that would not solve his problems: 11...♘d5 12.♗b2 ♗g6 13.♕b3 ♘ce7 (13...♘c3 14.♕c3 f6 15.♗c4±) 14.♘a4 b6 15.♘e5±.

12.♗d3!

This novelty allows White to take control of e4. It is positionally good for him to trade the light-squared bishops, as e4 will then leave him with the "good" bishop vs. the "big pawn" on d6.

12...♗d3

Or 12...♘d5 13.♗g6 hg6 14.♗d2± ♘b6 15.e4.

13.♕d3 ♘d5 14.e4 ♘c3 15.♕c3±

D2. 6...♘bd7 7.0-0 ♗d6

The Slav structures are pleasant for White who can build up a pawn centre and squeeze the opponent: 7...c6 8.♗e2 ♗e7 9.e4 0–0 10.♗e3 ♗b4 11.♕c2 (11.e5 ♘d5 12.♘d5 cd5 is more static, although White maintains the initiative with 13.♖c1 ♘b8

14.♘g5 ♗f5 15.♗d3 ♗e7 16.♗f5± E. Vladimirov – Fominyh, Mumbai 2003. We have here a typical example when an insertion of h3 would have made White's play impossible.) 11...c5 12.♖fd1 cd4 13.♗d4 ♗f3 14.♗f3± Bareev – Fominyh, Sochi 2004.

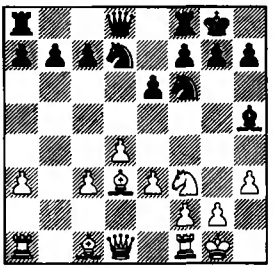
7...♗b4

The old 7...♗d6 is too passive and puts Black on the defensive: 8.h3! ♗h5 (8...♗f3 10.♕f3 c6 is solid, but grim) 9.e4! e5? (9...♗f3 10.♕f3 e5 11.d5±) 10.g4! ♗g6 11.de5 ♘e5 (11...♗e5 12.♘e5 ♘e5 13.♗e2 ♘ed7 14.f4 ♗e4 15.g5± Lukacs – Sapi, Budapest 1980) 12.♘e5 ♗e5 13.f4! ♕d4 (13...♗d4 14.♔h2± Zhu. Polgar – Dueckstein, Vienna 1993) 14.♕d4 ♗d4 15.♔h2 ♗c3 16.bc3 ♗e4 17.g5 ♗d5 (17...♘d7 18.♖e1 f5 19.gf6 ♘f6 20.♗d3 0–0 21.♗e4 ♖ae8 22.♗a3!± Littlewood – Muir, Chester 1979) 18.♖e1! ♔f8 19.♗b5! This killing move has been first played in the correspondence game Stulrajte – Kuchyna, Slovakia corr, 2001. 19...a6 20.♗a4 b5 21.gf6 ba4 22.♗a3 ♔g8 23.♖e5+–.

8.h3 ♗h5 9.a3!

Anticipating 9...c5.

9...♗c3 10.bc3 0-0 11.♗d3



11...♗g6

If White achieves e4 he would be clearly better, for instance, 11...c5 12.♖b1 ♘b6 13.e4 cd4 14.cd4 ♗f3 15.♕f3 ♕d4 16.♗b2 ♕d8 17.a4⩲.

12.♗g6 hg6 13.♕b3!?

In the game Lugovoi – Sulava, Saint Vincent 1999 White played the consistent 13.♖e1 c5 14.e4 ♕a5 15.♗d2 ♕a6 16.♗g5 cd4 17.cd4 ♖ac8, when 18.♕d2± would have retained a small edge.

13...b6 14.♘g5±.

Black is unable to stop e4.

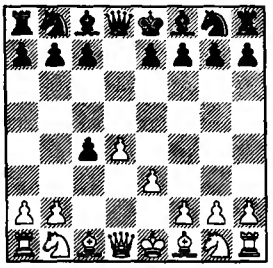
Conclusion

The 4...♗g4 system is enjoying a splash of popularity. The games of the recent years have introduced new ideas which have significantly widen the range of topical variations. While ten years ago theoretical discussions were concentrated on one or two positions of line D, now the focus is shifting to other unexplored possibilities, which often bring better results than the old "main" lines. However Black players should first decide is it worth to study a system, which could be sidestepped with 3.e3.

Chapter 27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3

(D20)



The e3-system has always been aside from the main theoretical discussions in the QGA. Nevertheless many players use this move order to avoid variations with ♗g4 or 3.♘f3 a6 4.e3 b5. This reasoning seems very tempting indeed, but it relies on the presumption that Black has nothing better than transposing to the Classical system after 3...e6.

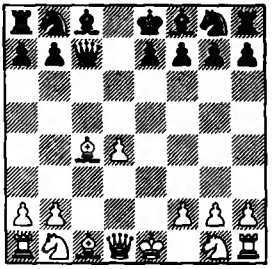
The response 3...e5 is supposed to be inferior, drawing on the theory of the French Defence. It claims that after 1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.ed5 ed5 4.c4 the move 4...dc4?! is worse than 4...c6. That may be true, but still the arising positions are perfectly acceptable and Black's play is quite intuitive, with good chances for equalising. The same applies to 3...c5, although White has slightly better prospects there. All in all, it is not easy to say which is the best choice after 3.e3, but certainly 3...e5 is the most testing.

We examine:
A. 3...c5
B. 3...e5
3...♗e6?! is a low-grade move. White obtains a comfortable edge after 5.♘c3 c6 6.♘g5 ♗d5 (6...♕d7 7.e4 h6 8.♘e6 ♕e6 9.e5 ♘d5 10.♗c4±) 7.e4 h6 8.ed5 hg5 9.dc6 ♘c6 10.d5 ♘e5 11.♕d4 ♘fd7 12. ♗g5±, Akopian – Kirov, Palma de Mallorca 1989.

A. 3...c5 4.♗c4 cd4 5.ed4

For 5.♘f3 see the next chapter.

5...♕c7



A1. 6.♕d3
A2. 6.♗e2
A3. 6.♗b3

A1. 6.♕d3

A popular move lately, but probably not sufficient for advantage. Black should try to develop his light-squared bishop on g4. Oth-

erwise White can hope for a small edge – 6...♘c6 7.♘f3 e6 8.0–0 ♘f6 9.♘c3 ♗e7 10.♗g5 0–0 11.a3 ♖d8 12.♖fd1 h6 13.♗h4 ♘h5 14.♗e7 ♕e7 (14...♘e7 15.♘e5 ♘f6 16.♖ac1±) 15.♕e3 ♘f6 16.♘e5! ♗d7 17.♘c6 bc6± (17...♗c6? 18.d5 ♘g4 19.♕e1!±), Lautier – Kallai, France 2001. We see that the d7-bishop is a cause of constant concern for Black.

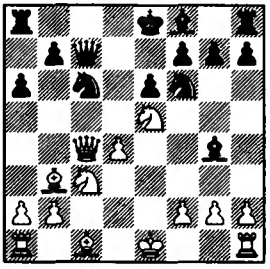
6...♘f6 7.♘c3 a6!

7...♘c6 fails to the typical blow 8.♘b5! ♕b8 9.♘e2 a6 10.♗f4±.

8.♘f3 ♘c6 9.♗b3

An improvement on 9.0–0 ♗g4! 10.♗f7 ♔f7 11.♕c4 ♔e8 12.d5 ♗f3 13.gf3 ♖c8 14.dc6 ♕c6∓, C. Horvath – Varga, Lillafured 1999. Now White is ready to counter the "sortie" of the bishop with

9...♗g4 10.♕c4 e6 11.♘e5



11...♗f5

In Avrukh – Sulava, Bled 2002 was 11...0–0–0 12.♘c6 ♕c6 13.♕c6 bc6 14.♗e3 ♘d5 15.0–0 ♗b4 16.♖ac1 ♔b7 and Black faced tactical problems, caused by the unsafe placement of the king. We believe that the bishop pair and lead in development are more than sufficient compensation for one pawn.

12.♗a4 ♗d6 13.♗c6

13.♘c6 0–0 14.♗g5 bc6 15.♗f6 gf6 16.♕c6 ♕c6 17.♗c6 ♖ab8⩲.

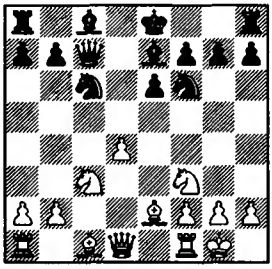
13...bc6 14.♕c6 ♕c6 15.♘c6 ♖c8 16.♘e5 ♘d5 17.♘d5 ed5 18.0-0 f6 19.♘f3 ♖c2⩱.

Perhaps we would have used here a sign for "more than sufficient compensation" if there was one.

A2. 6.♗e2 ♘f6 7.♘c3 e6 8.♘f3 ♘c6!

Black should not let the opponent to plant a knight on e5. In the game Sundararajan – Sermek, Calcutta 2002 White obtained the edge after 8...♗e7 9.0-0 0-0 10.♘e5! ♖d8 11.♘b5! ♕b6 12.a4 ♖e8□. Huzman suggests here 13.♗e3!? ♘d5 (13...♕d8 14.♖c1 ♘d5 15.♗f3↑) 14.♗d3 g6 15.♕f3↑.

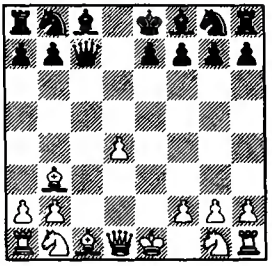
9.0–0 ♗e7



This is a typical IQP position with mutual chances. 10.♘b5 ♕d8 transposes to a frequently seen line from the 2.c3 Sicilian (B22). White can also play 10.a3 0–0 11.♗d3 b6 12.♕e2 ♗b7=.

A3. 6.♗b3

It seems that White can fight for advantage only with this move.



6...♗g4 7.f3 ♗d7 8.♘c3 ♘f6 9.♘ge2 e6

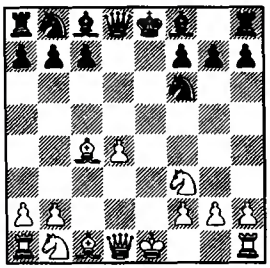
9...g6 10.♗g5 ♗g7 11.♖c1 ♕d8 12.0–0 0–0 13.d5 ♘a6 14.♔h1±, Jussupow – Miles, Horgen 1994.

10.♗e3!? ♗e7 11.♖c1 ♗c6 12.d5 ed5 13.♘f4

White's lead in development ensures him of the initiative, for instance: 13...♕e5 14.♘cd5 ♘d5 15.♘d5 0–0 16.♕d4±.

B. 3...e5 4.♗c4 ed4 5.ed4 ♘f6 6.♘f3

Rarely seen is 6.♕b3 ♕e7 7.♘e2 which turns well for White if queens stay on board, but 7...♕b4! 8.♘bc3 ♕b3 9.♗b3 ♗d6!? probably equalises. For instance 10.♘b5?! ♗e6 11.♗f4, Janosevic – Matulovic, Birmingham 1975, could even tip the balance in Black's favour – 11...♗b3 12.ab3 ♗f4 13.♘f4 ♔d7 14.♘d3 ♘c6 15.0–0–0 ♔c8∓.

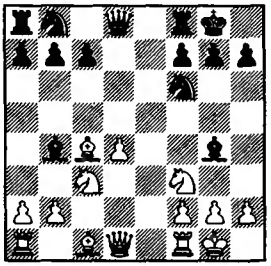


B1. 6...♗b4
B2. 6...♗e7
B3. 6...♗d6!

Black has three main options. One of them is passive – to block the d4-pawn by ♘bd7-b6-d5, c6, ♗e6, (see line B2) and one is active – to attack the pawn by ...♘c6, provoking it to move forward. (6...♗d6!) 6...♗b4 has similar aims.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3 e5 4.♗c4 ed4 5.ed4 ♘f6 6.♘f3)

B1. 6...♗b4 7.♘c3 0-0 8.0-0 ♗g4



9.♗g5

Sharper is 9.h3 ♗h5 10.g4 ♗g6 11.♘e5 ♘c6 12.f4 ♗e4 13.♘e4 ♘e4, Leitao – Matsuura, 1998.

9.a3 ♗c3 10.bc3 c5 is unclear.

9...♘c6 10.♘d5 ♗e7 11.♘e7 ♕e7 12.h3 ♗f3 13.♕f3 ♕e4

13...♘d4 leads to further simplification with White retaining slightly better prospects due to his mighty bishop – 14.♕b7 ♖fb8 15.♗f6 ♕f6 16.♕c7 ♖b2 17.♖ad1 ♘e6 (17...a5) 18.♕c6 ♖f8 19.♖d7±.

14.♕e4 ♘e4 15.♗e3 ♘d6 16.b3 ♖ad8 17.d5±.

This has been seen in Lputian – Romanishin, Manila 1992.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3 e5 4.♗c4 ed4 5.ed4 ♘f6 6.♘f3)

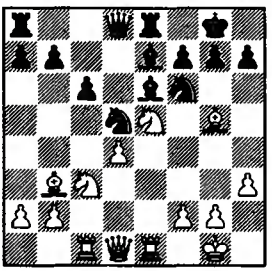
B2. 6...♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3!

This move order is more precise than 8.h3 because 8...♗g4 is not a grave threat in view of 9.h3. It also eliminates the option 8.h3 c5 9.d5 b5 10.♗b5 ♗b7 with some compensation.

8...♘bd7 9.♖e1

White side-stepped all possible tricks of the opponent, for instance to play ♘bd5 or ♘fd5 without c6 first. Not that it would have changed the character of position, but it is usually good to restrict the enemy's choice. Otherwise 8.h3 ♘bd7 9.♘c3 ♘b6 10.♗b3 c6 11.♖e1 ♘fd5 12.♘e4 ♗f5 13.♘e5 ♘d7 14.♕f3±, Karpov – Timman, Amsterdam 1991 also led to some edge for White.

9...♘b6 10.♗b3 c6 11.♘e5 ♘bd5 12.♗g5 ♗e6 13.♖c1 ♖e8 14.h3



14...♖c8

This is supposed to improve on 14...♘d7 15.♗e7 ♖e7 16.♘e4 f6 17.♘d3 ♘f8 18.♕f3 ♕c7 19.♘g3 ♖d8 20.♘c5 ♗f7 21.♖e7 ♕e7 22.♘f5 ♕c7 23.♕g3!±, I. Sokolov – Huebner, Wijk aan Zee 1996. The dark squares in Black's camp are hopelessly weak. We propose **14...♘c7!?** 15.♗c2 ♘d5 16.♗e7 ♕e7 17.♘e4 ♘b4∞ when 18.♗b3 ♘a2 19.♗a2 ♗a2 20.b3 is probably sufficient only for maintaining the balance.

15.♖c2 (15.♕f3 ♘c7=) **15...♘d7 16.♗e7 ♖e7 17.♘d5**

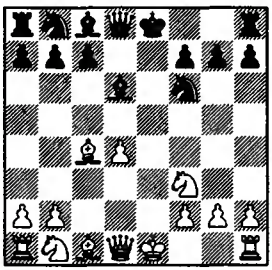
Now White obtains only a smal edge in the ending. More ambitious is 17.♘e4.

17...♗d5 18.♗d5 cd5 19.♖ce2 ♘e5 20.de5 h6 21.♕d3±, Kir. Georgiev – Huebner, Batumi 1999.

A similar position arises after 21.♖d2!? ♖d7 (21...♕b6 22.b3 ♖d7 ...23.♖d5 ♖d5 24.♕d5 ♖c2⇄ 25.♕f3 ♖a2 26.♖d1) 22.e6 fe6 23.♖e6 ♖c6 24.♖e5 d4 25.♖de2↑. Black has good prospects for a draw.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.e3 e5 4.♗c4 ed4 5.ed4 ♘f6 6.♘f3)

B3. 6...♗d6



7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3

8.♗g5 has been popular for a while, but it seems that Black finally found a satisfactory defence – 8...h6 9.♗h4 ♘c6! 10.h3 (10.♘bd2 ♗g4= and 10.♘c3 ♗g4 11.h3 ♗f3 12.♕f3 ♘d4 13.♕b7 ♖b8= have been tried too) 10...g5 11.♗g3 ♗g3 12.fg3 ♘a5 13.♗d3 ♘c6 14.♗c4 ♘a5 15.♗d3 ♘c6 16.♕d2 ♘h5 17.g4 ♘f4 18.♗e4 ♘d4=

19.♘d4 ♕d4 20.♕d4 ♘e2 21.♔h2 ♘d4 22.♘c3 ♗e6 23.♖ad1 ♘c6 24.♘d5 ♗d5 25.♗d5 ♖ad8 26.♗c6 ½–½, Lautier – Anand, Monte Carlo 1999.

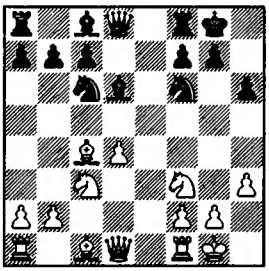
8...♘c6

The pin 8...♗g4?! is good only if Black can meet 9.h3 with ♗f3, followed by capturing the d4-pawn. Otherwise White gets tempi to expand on the kingside – 9.h3 ♗h5 10.g4 ♗g6 11.♘e5 c5 12.♘g6 hg6 13.dc5 ♗c5 14.♗f7! ♔f7 15.♕b3 ♔e8 16.♖e1 ♗e7 17.♕b7 ♘bd7 18.g5 ♖b8 19.♕c6→, Ulibin – Lautier, Sochi 1989.

9.h3

After 9.♗g5 h6 10.♗h4 ♗g4 11.h3 ♗f3 12.♕f3 Black can choose between 12...♘d4 13.♕b7 ♖b8 14.♕a7 ♖a8= or 12...g5 13.♗g3 ♗g3 14.♕g3 ♕d4∞.

9...h6



This position is supposed to be slightly better for White. It can be true if Black fails to activate the light-squared bishop, but practice proves that White cannot impede it from reaching f5 or e6.

9.♕c2

The only way to prevent 9...♗f5. Alternatives are:

10.a3 ♗f5 11.♖e1 a6 12.♘e5?! (12.d5 ♘e7=; 12.b4 ♕d7 13.d5 ♘e7 14.♘e5 ♗e5 15.♖e5 ♘g6 16.♖e1 ♖fe8=) 12...♗e5 13.de5 ♕d1 14.♘d1 ♘d7 and Black had a good game in Legky – Lautier, France 1996.

10.♖e1 ♗f5 11.d5 ♘e7 12.♘d4 ♗h7 Despite White's space advantage, the game is balanced, because Black's knights have good operating places. 13.♘db5 (13.♕f3 ♘g6 14.♗d3 ♘d7 15.♗c2 a6=, Ilczuk – Kaminski, Koszalin 1996) 13...a6 14.♘d6 ♕d6 15.a4, Kachiani – Brynell, Germany 1999. Here Black should have chosen 15...♘f5 16.b3 ♖fe8=, since after 15...♖ad8 16.b3 ♘ed5?!± play opened up in White's favour.

10.♗e3 ♗f5 11.♘h4 ♗h7 12.♕f3 ♘d4 13.♗d4 ♗h2 14.♔h2 ♕d4 15.♗b3 ♕h4 16.♕b7 ♗d3 17.g3 ♕h5 18.♖fe1 c5=, Barsov – Skripchenko, Moscow 2006.

10...♘b4

Or 10...♘a5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.♘e5 c5 13.♗e3 cd4 14.♗d4 ♗e5 15.♗e5 ♘c6=, I. Rajlich – Kosic, Budapest 2007.

11.♕b1 ♗e6!

It is important to destroy the most dangerous white piece. The opened f-file compensates for the weakness on e6.

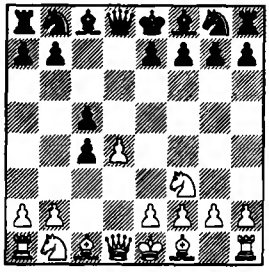
12.♗e6 fe6 13.♖e1 ♕e8 14.♗d2=.

Conclusion

Lately Black has good results against 3.e3. In line B3 he can even boast with a positive score. This system is especially good for players who have not time for home preparation. In most cases the play is positional with no strict move order to follow. Black must memorize only a couple of diagrams for a model and one rule – to avoid hurrying with the bishop to g4.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5

(D21)



This variation is becoming quite popular. A possible explanation is that in practice White fails to achieve something substantial in the line 4.d5 e6 5.♘c3 ed5 6.♕d5 ♕d5 7.♘d5 ♗d6 8.♘d2. Previously it had been assessed as better for White, but latest results do not provide enough evidence on that. However in line C2b we show that life (and the endgame in particular!) is not that easy for Black.

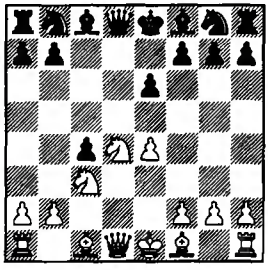
Most games nowadays continue with 4.e3. Then Black can transpose to the usual lines with 4...e6, but he often prefers to test 4...cd4 5.♗c4 ♕c7, aiming at IQP positions, but allowing the dangerous sacrifice 6.♗b3!?

We examine:
A. 4.♘c3
B. 4.e3
C. 4.d5

4.e4 does not deserve much attention as Black easily completes development, obtaining comfortable play, e.g. 4...cd4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4 ♗d7 7.♗c4 ♘c6=.

A. 4.♘c3

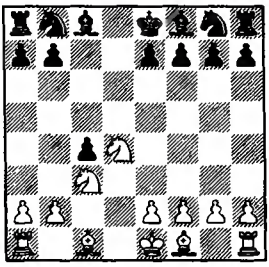
We do not see much sense in this move. It only gives Black additional options in the form of 4...e6. Then 5.d5 would transpose to line B, which White apparently wanted to avoid, so he plays 5.e4 cd4 6.♘d4!?



With queens White enjoys some pull due to his better development: 6...♗d7?! 7.♗xc4 ♘c6 8.0–0 ♘f6 9.♘f3 ♕b8 10.g3±. However 6...e5!? 7.♘f3 (7.♘b5?! meets 7...a6!) 7...♕d1 ♕d1 8.♔d1 ♘c6 gives Black fair chances to equalise: 9.♘b5 ♖b8 10.♗c4 ♗g4 11.♗e3 ♖c8, Ikonnikov – Jonkman, Soest 2001 or 9.♗xc4 ♗g4 10.♗e3 f5 11.exf5 ♘ge7.

Still the most testing answer to 4.♘c3 is:

4...cd4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4



The fine point is that Black is not able to cover both d5 and b5 so White gets some initiative for the pawn.

A1. 6...♗d7

A2. 6...♘f6

A3. 6...e5!?

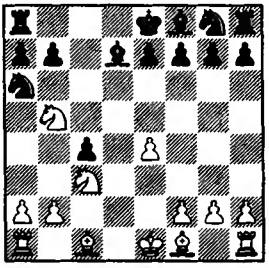
A1. 6...♗d7

This move is unanimously assessed by written theory as leading to a slightly inferior position, but with a dubious argumentation. In practice Black usually equalises easily. Lately White does not even try to embark on a theoretical dispute with 7.♘db5!. Instead he plays 7.e4 ♘c6 8.♘c6 ♗c6 9.♗c4 which is drawish after 9...e6 followed by 10...♗b4. We'll focus on the most testing continuation:

7.♘db5! ♘a6

7...♔d8 8.♗e3 ♘c6 9.0-0-0↑ transposes to line A2.

8.e4



8...♘f6

8...e6 is passive. White regained the pawn with 9.♗c4 ♖c8 10.♗e2 ♘b4 and emerged with the upper hand from the complications after 11.♘a7 ♖c3 12.bc3 ♘c2 13.♔d2 ♘a1 14.♗b2 ♗c5 15.♘b5±, Magerramov – Psakhis, Groningen 1993.

9.♗c4!

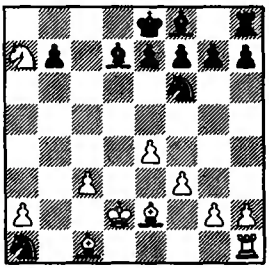
No one dared to repeat this natural move. It was tested in Yuferov – Maljutin, Moscow, 1989 and White got the edge. Maljutin kept playing this variation and his opponents stubbornly deviated first by choosing the humble 9.f3?! e5 10.♗e3 ♗e6 11.♗a7 ♗b4 12.♗e3 ♔e7 13.♔f2=. It is still a mystery what improvement Black has in mind. The following play is quite forced:

9...♖c8

Otherwise Black is doomed to stay in binds.

10.♗e2 ♘b4 11.♘a7 ♖c3 12.bc3 ♘c2 13.♔d2 ♘a1 14.f3

A critical position. White will regain the piece whilst the opponent seems unable to generate some counterplay. The stem-game continued:



14...g6,

when 15.♔d3! (15...♗a4 16.♗f4±) makes way to the c1-bishop. White is

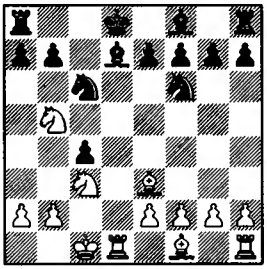
better. Other tries like 14...e5 15.♗b2 are not much better either.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.♘c3 cd4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4)

A2. 6...♘f6 7.♘db5 ♔d8 8.♗e3!

8.♗f4 ♘c6 or even 8...a6 seem enough to equalise.

8...♘c6 9.0-0-0 ♗d7



10.g4!

An excellent resource! White underlines the vulnerable state of Black's king. 10...♘g4 11.♗h3 h5 12.f3 ♘ge5 13.♗d7 ♘d7 14.♖d2 is murky. 10.g3 is less enterprising since 10...e6! gives Black a respite because of the threat 11...♘g4.

10...e6 11.h3!

In the source game Krasenkow – Bus, Pardubice 1994 was the unaesthetic 11.♗h3, when 11...♘b4! would have turned the tables as 12.a3 ♘bd5 13.♗a7 runs into 13...♖a7! 14.♘a7 ♘c3 15.bc3 ♔e8∓.

11...h6

In Khalifman – Greenfeld, Pardubice Black practically lost a tempo after 11...♗e7 12.♗g2 a6 13.♘d6 ♗d6 14.♖d6 ♔c7 15.♖hd1 h6 16.♘a4+–.

12.♗g2 ♔c8 13.♖d2 a6 14.♘a4⩱ or 14.♘d6⩱.

White maintains the initiative.

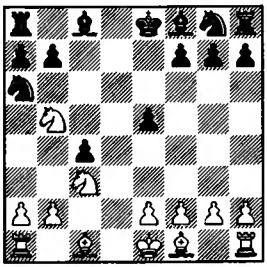
(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.♘c3 cd4 5.♕d4 ♕d4 6.♘d4)

A3. 6...e5!?

Black prepares the e6-square for his light-squared bishop. The c4-pawn is more valuable than the a7-one, because it provides an excellent outpost on d3 for a knight. White seems unable to oppose anything against the opponent's plan.

7.♘db5 ♘a6

7...♔d8 does not fit to the general plan. White gets the initiative after 8.♗g5 f6 9.0–0–0 ♗d7 10.♗e3 ♘c6 11.g3⩲, Pushkarjov – Szakolczai, Stockerau, 1992.



8.♘d5

Magerramov tried agains Vaisser, Groningen 1993 8.♗e3 ♗d7 9.0–0–0 ♘f6 10.g3, but 10...♘g4∓ would have been awkward. Next year he improved with 8.e4 ♗e6 9.♗e3 ♘f6 10.f3 (Magerramov – Sermek, Tilburg 1994), when 10...♖d8 or 10...♗e7 equalise. Now Black elliminates a couple of light pieces and all opening problems as well.

9...♔d8

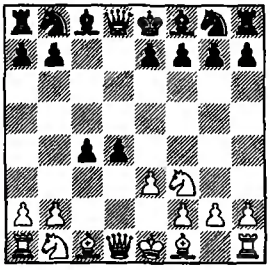
The comp proposes 9...♔d7!?

9.e4 ♗d7 10.♗xc4 ♖c8 11.b3 ♘b4= Sosonko – Cifuentes Parada, Netherlands 1994.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5)

B. 4.e3 cd4

We think that objectively 4...e6, which transposes to the main lines of the QGA, is better. However the text is the most testing continuation and demands specific knowledge from White.



5.♗c4

We see the first results of Black's third move – White is forced to resort to tactics in order to even the pawns. 5.ed4 is not yelding success to White, although he gets some initial initiative:

5...♗e6 6.♘c3 ♘f6 7.♗e2!? (7.♘e5 ♘c6 8.♘c6 bc6 9.♕a4 ♕d7 10.♗c4 ♗c4 11.♕c4 is about equal. Black can continue with safer 11...e6 or more risky 11...g6, intending to sac the c6-pawn, but obtaining play on both flanks) 7...♘c6 8.0–0 g6 9.♗e3. Here Lugovoi suggests 9...♘d5 10.♘g5 ♘c3 11.bc3 ♗d5=. In practice we see 11...♗g7 10.♘g5 ♗d5 11.♘d5 ♘d5 12.♗c4 0–0 13.♕f3 ♘f6 14.♖fd1 ♕d7 with some space advantage for White, which could be underlined by 15.♘e4 ♘e4 16.♕e4 ♖fd8 17.d5±.

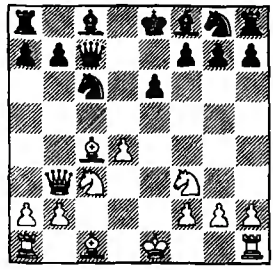
5...♕c7

5...e6 leads to an IQP position in the best possible version for White.

B1. 6.♕b3

B2. 6.♗b3!?

B1. 6.♕b3 e6 7.ed4 ♘c6 8.♘c3



We see on the diagram an IQP position. The move order is not of primary importance. Black's queen is clumsy on c7, but so is White's one on b3. If Black makes a few precise moves and manages to avoid the central break-trough d4-d5, he will have a solid position. Perhaps his main concern should be to drive back the opponent's queen. We'll show first what Black should avoid:

Graf – Vaulin, St Petersburg 1995: 7...♘f6 8.0–0 ♗e7 9.♘c3 ♘c6 10.d5 ed5 11.♘d5 ♘d5 12.♗d5 0–0 13.♗d2 ♗f6 14.♖ac1 ♗f5 15.♗c3±. We see from this example that Black cannot just develop. Firstly he should create the threat of ...♘a5, but without forgetting about his kingside, like in:

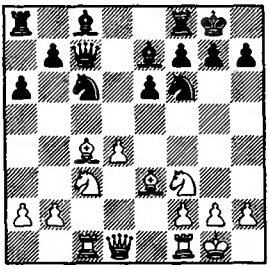
Graf – Azmaiparashvili Bali 2003: 7...♘c6 8.♘c3 a6 9.♕d1 b5 10.♗b3 ♘a5 11.0–0 ♗b7?! (11...♘f6) 12.d5! ♘b3 13.♕b3 e5 14.♗e3 ♘f6 15.♖ac1 ♕b8 16.♖fe1 ♗d6 17.♗d4±.

Probably Black can minimise risks with:

8...a6 9.♕d1

9.♗d3 is also playable. It is linked with a kingside attack. Lately Black holds firm against such a plan so White prefers another setup. He tries to keep d5 under control. His main attention is focused on the c-file, where he is dominant.

9...♘f6 10.0–0 ♗e7 11.♗e3 0-0 12.♖c1



White developed his pieces and his next actions depend on the opponent's setup. If Black pushes b5, White could attack it later by a4 or plant a knight on c5. The game Kozul – Thorhallsson, Plovdiv 2003 went on with:

12...♖d8∞ 13.♗b3 ♕d6 14.♖e1 ♘a5 15.♗c2 b5 16.♘e4 ♘e4 17.♗e4 ♗b7 18.♗b7 ♘b7 19.♘e5 ♕d5 20.♕h5 ♘d6 21.♖c7.

White is in a delicate situation. He still keeps the initiative, but Black has no weaknesses. After 21...♖e8 or 21...♗f8 play would be double-edged.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 cd4 5.♗c4 ♕c7)

B2. 6.♗b3!? de3

After having struggled in several games, the loyal servant of the 3...c5-varition Afek finally chose to decline the pawn sacrifice by **6...♘f6 7.ed4** ♘c6 8.0–0 ♗g4 9.♘c3 ♖d8 10.h3 ♗h5, but 11.d5± proved awkward for him, Piceu – Afek, Belgium 2004. Safer is **7...e6** 8.♘c3 ♗e7 9.0–0 0–0. We have a typical IQP position with a "non-standard" queen on c7. A normal development would be 10.♗e3 with some pull for White. In Haik – Z. Polgar, Cannes, 1987 was 10.♗g5 ♘c6 11.♖c1 ♖d8 12.♕e2, when Black played 12...♕a5 missing 13.d5! ed5 14.♗f6 ♗f6 15.♘d5 ♗f5 16.♘f6±. It is better to make a luft by 12...h6!? Then 13.♗h4 ♕a5 14.d5 (14.♖fd1 g5!? 15.♗g3 g4) 14...ed5 16.♘d5 ♖d5 17.♕e8 ♔h7 is in Black's favour, so White should retreat: 13.♗e3! ♕a5 14.♖fd1, returning to the usual plan with an extra h6 for Black.

7.♗e3 e6

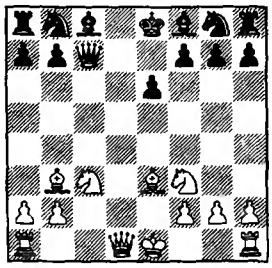
In Pujos – Afek, France 2003 Black chose to develop his bishop to g4: 7...♘f6 8.0–0 ♘c6 9.♘c3 ♗g4, but simple 10.h3 turned very unpleasant. In the game was 10...♖d8? 11.♗f7 ♔f7 12.♕b3±, but 10...♗h5 11.♘b5 ♕a5 (11...♕b8 12.♘bd4±) 12.♗a4, intending to push b4 on almost any Black's move, is not attractive either.

8.♘c3

After the text Black has tested without glory two defensive plans:

B2a. To play ♗d7 without ...a6 and:

B2b. To put in ...a6, refraining from ♗d7.

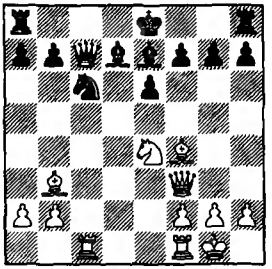


B2a. 8...♗d7 9.♖c1 ♕a5 10.0-0 ♘f6 11.♘g5! ♘c6

This move allows White to step on Black's sore point – d6. However the logical 11...♗c6 has a downside too. The e6-point is left defenseless: 12.♖e1 ♗e7 (12...♗b4 13.♘f7! ♔f7 14.♗e6 ♔f8 15.♗f4+–) 13.♗d2 ♕d8 14.♕e2 0–0 15.♘e6+–.

12.♘ce4 ♘e4 13.♘e4 ♕c7 14.♕f3 ♗e7

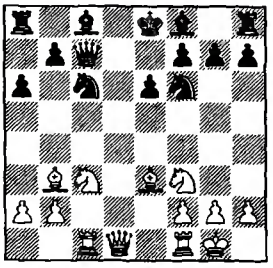
This position has been reached in Bosboom – Muhren, Wijk aan Zee 2005. Now 15.♗f4⩲ maintains a strong initiative. Both d6 and d7 squares are weak.



15...♕a5 16.♖fd1±.

B2b. Tregubov – Afek, Vlissingen 2002 saw:

8.0–0 (instead of 8.♘c3) **♘f6 9.♘c3 a6 10.♖c1 ♘c6**



In the current position White shifts his attention to the weak queenside of the opponent:

11.♘a4 ♗e7 12.♘b6 ♖b8 13.♘d4 0–0

White is clearly better. He can regain the pawn by:

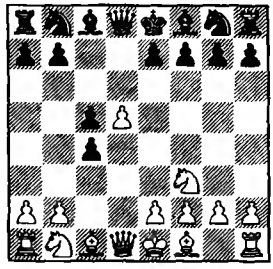
14.♕f3 ♗d7 15.♘xd7 ♕xd7 16.♘xc6 bxc6, Markus – Kallai, Hungary 2006, 17.♕xc6± or opt for the more risky:

14.♗a4 ♖d8 15.♕e2 (15.♕f3?! is met by 15...♗d6! 16.♗c6 ♕b6!) 15...♖d4 (The stem-game went with 15...e5?! 16.♘c6 bc6 17.♖c6±) 16.♗d4 ♘d4 17.♖c7 ♘e2 18.♔h1

White's pieces are quite discoordinated, but still he has the extra exchange. Play could continue 18...♗d6 19.♖c8 ♖c8 20.♘c8 ♗c5 21.g3±.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5)

C. 4.d5!

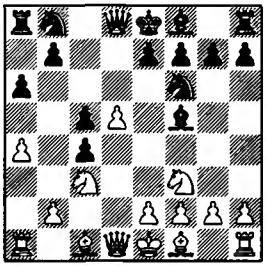


4...e6

4...♘f6 is another plausible alternative. After 5.♘c3 e6 (5...a6?! 6.e4! e6 7.♗g5↑) 6.e4 ed5 7.e5! Black experiences some opening problems, as shown in Chapter 23, line A.

More entertaining is 4...a6, but we think that Black should lure the knight to c3 first by 4...e6 5.♘c3 a6!? – see line C1. After 4...a6 White could fight for the initiative with 5.e4!

In practice White tried only 5.a4 ♘f6 6.♘c3, when 6...♗f5 annoyingly hinders White's plans.



Here 7.e3 e6 8.♗c4 ed5 9.♘d5 ♗d6 (or 9...♗e6) is harmless whilst 7.♘h4 ♗e4! 8.♗g5 ♘bd7 9.f3, M. Horvath – Misanovic, Germany, 2000, could have stumbled into 9...h6 10.♗f6 ♗h7! 11.e4 ♕b6!? 12.♗c4 ♕f6 13.g3 g5 14.♘g2 ♗g7↑.

Let's return to 5.e4. Then 5...b5 6.a4 ♗b7 7.ab5 ab5 8.♖a8 ♗a8 9.b3 ♘f6 10.♕c2↑ gives White active play.

5.♘c3

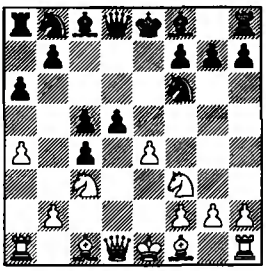
For 5.e4 ed5= see Chapter 23.

C1. 5...a6!?
C2. 5...ed5
Or 5...♘f6 6.e4 – see Chapter 23.

C1. 5...a6!? 6.e4!

6.a4 ♘f6 7.e4 is still underexplored. In most lines the inclusion of ...a6 and a4 is in Black's favour, but it is hard to say how signifficant is the difference. For instance, 7...♘e4!? 8.♘e4 ed5 is unclear while without a4 White gets the upper hand by ♘c3! In the current situation however 9.♘c3 is hardly the best since White has a hole on b3 and the a6-pawn restricts an otherwise dangerous jump of White's knight to b5. This is decisive in the variation 9.♘c3 ♗e6 10.♘g5 ♘c6! 11.♗e2 ♘d4 12.♘e6 fe6 13.♗e3 ♕f6 with mutual chances. The other retreats of the knight are not much better, while 9.♗g5 ♕a5 10.♗d2 ♕d8 11.♘c3 ♗e7 is not too impressive for White.

We should note however that most players prefer 7...ed5

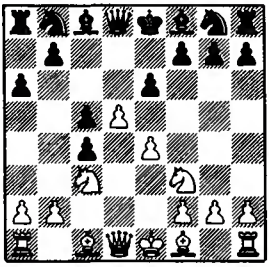


8.ed5?! In our opinion this move is absolutely harmless. White should choose 8.e5! with some advantage. The piece sacrifice 8...♗e6? 9.ef6 gf6 is insufficient due to weakness of the f5-square.

8...♗d6 9.♗c4 0–0 10.0–0 ♗g4 11.h3 ♗f3 12.♕f3 ♘bd7 13.♕d1 ♕c7 14.♕b3 ♖ae8. Black has an excellent game, Anand – Ivanchuk, Amber-

blind, Monte Carlo 2000.

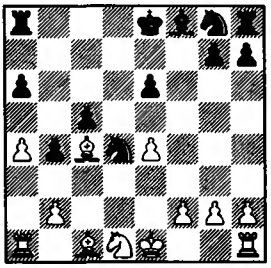
Let's return to 6.e4:



6...b5

6...ed5 7.♘d5 b5 is possible, e.g. 8.♗f4 ♗d6 9.e5 ♗c7 10.♘c7 ♕c7 11.♘g5 ♕a5 12.♗d2 ♕c7∞.

7.a4 b4 8.de6 ♕d1 9.♘d1 ♗e6 10.♘g5 ♘c6 11.♘e6 fe6 12.♗c4 ♘d4



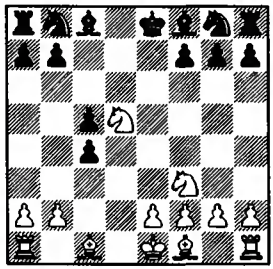
The knight on d4 compensates for the bishop pair, but still White has the better pawn formation. Perhaps he should set up his pieces in the following way:

13.0-0 ♘e7 14.♗f4, intending ♘e3.

(1.d4 d5 2.c4 dc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.d5 e6 5.♘c3)

C2. 5...ed5 6.♕d5 ♕d5 7.♘d5

This position has always been assessed to be in White's favour, but lately a lot of games have been drawn. This fact accounts for the current popularity of the variation 3...c5 in general and the response 4.e3 in particular. In our opinion 4.d5 is more testing and faces Black with some problems.

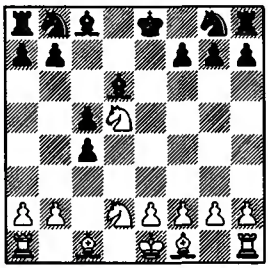


7...♗d6

7...♘a6 8.e4♘e7 is inferior. White can play on restriction of Black's minor pieces. In order to activate them, Black will have to weaken his pawn structure, which will provide the opponent with targets. 9.♗f4!? (9.♘e3 ♘c7 10.♘c4 is also somewhat better for White, e.g. 10...♘g6 11.♗e3 b6 12.h4 h5 13.0–0–0 ♗b7 14.♘fe5 ♗xe4 15.♘xg6 ♗xg6 16.♘e5 ♗f5 17.g4!↑ E. Atalik – Afek, Wijk aan Zee 2006) 9...♘d5 10.ed5 ♗f5 (10...b5 was refuted in the game Sakaev – Vaulin, Kstovo 1997 which saw 11.0–0–0! f6 12.a4 ♘b4 13.ab5 ♘d3 14.♗d3 cd3 15.♖d3 ♗d7 16.♖e1 ♔f7 17.♖de3! ♗b5 18.♗c7 ♖e8 19.♖e8 ♗e8 20.♘d2±) 11.♗c4 f6 12.0-0-0 0-0-0 13.♖he1±. Black has to drive back the nasty bishop on f4, but then in Janssen – Afek, Hoogeveen 2003, f6 became a target: 13...g5 14.♗d2 ♗d6 15.♗c3 ♖hf8 16.♗a6 ba6 17.♘d2 ♗g4 18.f3 ♗f5 19.g3±.

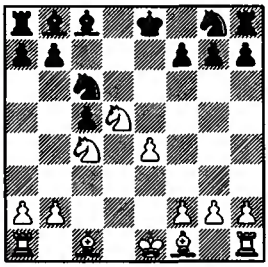
8.♘d2

8.e4 ♘e7 9.♗c4 ♘d5 10.♗d5 ♘a6 11.0–0 ♘c7 12.♗b3 ♗e6= is equal.



C2a. 8...♘c6
C2b. 8...♘e7

C2a. 8...♘c6 9.♘c4 ♗b8 10.e4



Black's knight on c6 is very strong. White's only chance is quick development in order to create concrete threats before Black manages to consolidate. 10.g3 is too slow : 10...♘ge7 11.♘e7 ♔e7 12.♗e3 (12.♗g2 ♘d4!=) 12...b6 13.♗g2 ♗b7=. White fails to exploit the pin along the main diagonal. 14.a3 meets 14...♘a5 15.♗b7 ♘b7= while 14.0–0 provides a tempo for 14...♗c7 15.a3 a5=.

10...♘d4!?

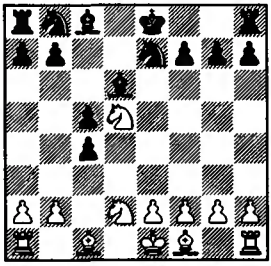
To 10...♘f6 White has found 11.♗e3! ♘d5 (11...♘e4?! 12.f3 ♘d6 13.♗c5 ♗e6 14.0–0–0 ♘c8 15.g3± is even worse, Epishin – Lalic, Manresa 1995) 12.ed5 ♘b4 13.0–0–0 ♘a2 14.♔b1 ♘b4 15.♗c5 ♗f5 16.♔a1 ♘c2 17.♔a2 ♔d7 18.♘a5± Sadler – Sermek, Cannes, 1996.

11.♗d3 ♘e7 12.♗e3 ♗e6 13.♘e7 ♗c4

13...♔e7 14.♘a5 b6 15.♗d4 cd4 16.♘c6 ♔f6 17.♔e2 is in White's favour too – 17...♗e5 18.g3 g5 19.♖hf1 ♗h3 20.f4±.

14.♗d4 ♗d3 15.♗c5 ♗e5 16.♖d1± Khenkin – Mainka, 2003.

C2b. 8...♘e7



9.e4!?

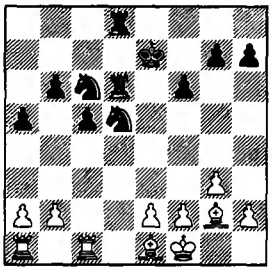
It is difficult to resist the temptation to get the bishop pair advantage in an open position. The hypnotising effect is so strong, that all the games but one continued in the digaram position with:

9.♘c4 ♘d5 10.♘d6 ♔e7 11.♘c8 ♖c8 12.g3 This move allows White to finish development, but that is not enough. Black is concentrating his forces in the centre.

12...♘c6! (12...♘b4 fails to 13.♗h3 and White completes development successfully).

13.♗g2 (Or 13.♗h3 ♖d8 14.0–0 ♖d6 15.e4 ♘db4 16.♗f4 ♖dd8=, Bar-

on Rodriguez – Cifuentes Parada, Zaragoza 1999.) 13...♖d8 14.♗g5 f6 15.♗d2 ♖d6 16.0–0 ♖ad8 17.♖fc1 b6 18.♔f1 a5 19.♗e1



Theory modestly omits to clarify what should White do in order to activate his bishops. In our opinion, Black has no problems. He could stay compactly in the centre and push kingside pawns. 9.e4 is considerably more unpleasant.

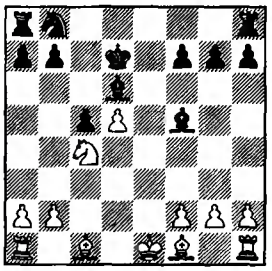
9...♘d5

In the game K. Georgiev – Velikov, Corfu 1991 Black tried to refrain from taking on d5, without much success – 9...♘c6 (with different move order) 10.♘c4 ♗b8 11.♗e3 b6 12.0–0–0 ♗b7 13.♗e2±. Here Black opted for 13...♘e5 when 14.♘e5 ♗e5 15.♗b5± would have fixed White's advantage.

10.ed5 ♗f5

10...b5?! 11.a4 ♗b7 (11...♘a6 12.ab5 ♘b4 13.♘c4 ♘c2 14.♔d1 ♘a1 15.♘d6 ♔e7 16.♘c8+–) 12.ab5 is in White's favour. Perhaps 10...♘d7 11.♘xc4 ♔e7 12.♗e3± is the lesser evil.

11.♘c4 ♔d7



The stem-game Pert – Estrada Nieto, Oakham 2001 went on 12.♗e3 ♘a6 13.♖c1 ♖ac8 14.♘d6 ♔d6 15.♗c4 ♘b4 16.♗f4 ♔d7 17.♔d2 ♗e4 18.♗b5±. White has also:

12.♘d6 ♔d6 13.♗f4 ♔d5 14.0–0–0±.

Conclusion

The variation 3...c5 has been initially designed for sidestepping sharp lines with 3...♘f6 4.♘c3. We have a rare case when on move three Black is in a position to impose his opening choice. If White insist on playing the Classical lines with 4.e3, besides 4...e6 Black has also 4...cd4 5.♗c4 ♕c7. We think that White can try to punish the opponent with the promising pawn sacrifice 6.♗b3!? The IQP positions after 6.♕b3 are not well explored.

The best policy for White is to accept the challenge and go for 4.d5! – line C. His space advantage after 4...e6 5.♘c3 ed5 6.♕d5 ♕d5 7.♘d5 ♗d6 8.♘d2 ♘e7 9.e4!? faces Black with certain problems.